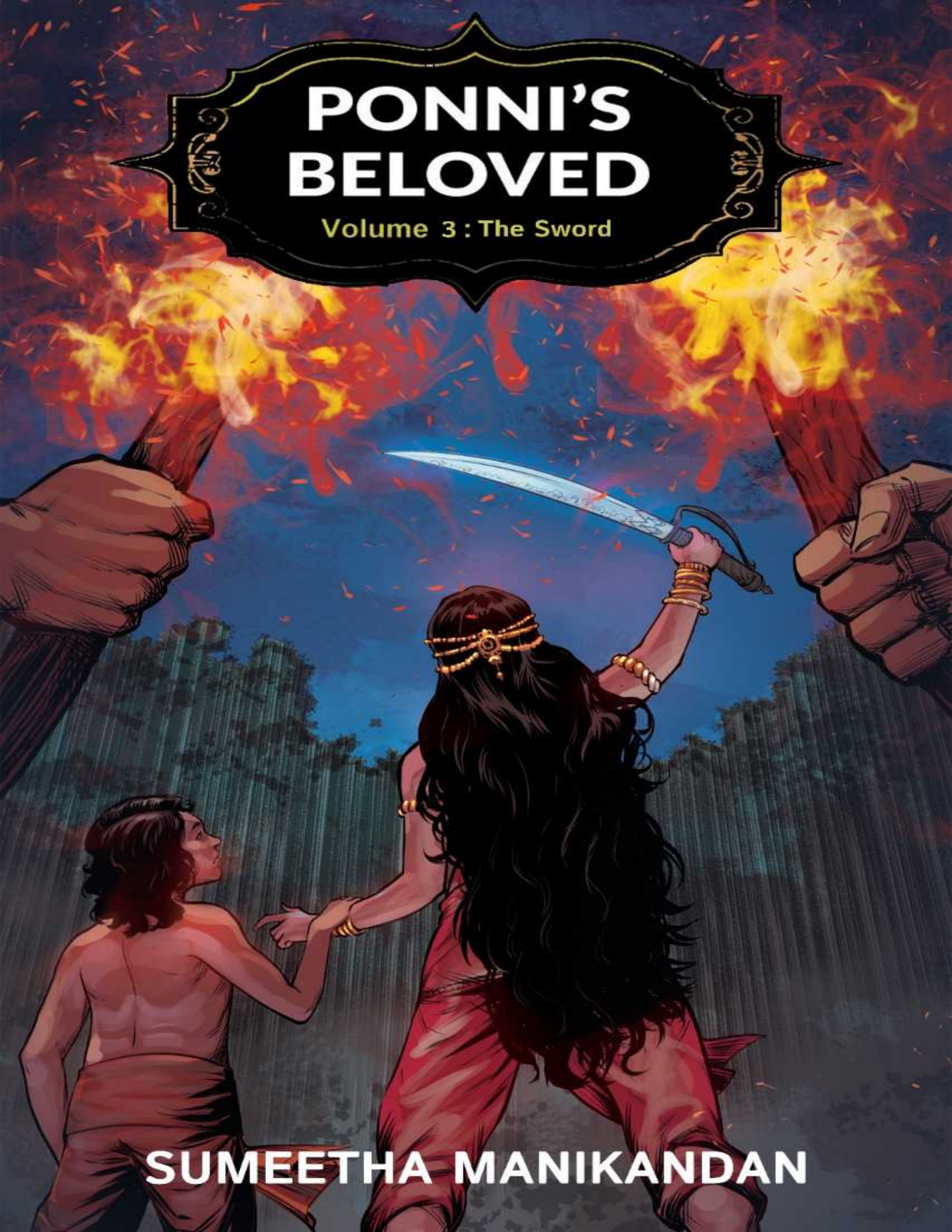


PONNI'S BELOVED

Volume 3 : The Sword



SUMEETHA MANIKANDAN

Ponni's Beloved

AN ENGLISH TRANSLATION OF
KALKI KRISHNAMURTHY'S PONNIYIN
SELVAN

by

Sumeetha Manikandan

Part 3 of 5 - The Sword

Version 2.0
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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Sumeetha Manikandan is a top bestselling romance author whose novellas 'Perfect Groom' and 'These Lines of Mehendi' (which was published as a paperback novel called 'Love Again') have been on the top of Amazon India charts ever since their publication. A bookaholic, thinker, feminist and a daydreamer, she reads across genres and is a crazy fan of history, romance and science fiction novels.

An avid reader of historical novels, she has been translating Kalki Krishnamurthy's classic Tamil novel Ponnaiyin Selvan for the past ten years and hopes to translate more of his novels into English.

Sumeetha is married to filmmaker K.S. Manikandan and lives with her twelve-year-old daughter in Chennai.



Acknowledgement

I would like to acknowledge my father, S. Vijayaraghavan who used to tell me the story of Ponniyin Selvan every evening during dinner and fueled my interest to read the book.

My Aunt Ranganayaki who lent me her Ponniyin Selvan books all those years ago when I was in school. I still treasure them to this day.

Navin and Vidya Sigamany for publishing the first drafts of Ponni's Beloved on their website Zine 5.com almost ten years ago. I would like to thank Inderpreet Kaur Uppal for her stellar efforts in editing the initial draft copy.

Author Venkatesh Ramakrishnan who encouraged me to resume the translation again. Writer and Journalist, Dhivakar Venkataraman for providing valuable historical guidance for the cover page artwork.

Meenakshi Devaraj, an avid fan of Ponniyin Selvan series and rendered great help in translating Poonguzhali's song and Devaram poems in this volume.

Friends like Raja King, Fowzia Iqbal, Abirami Baskaran, Sastha Prakash, Ramanujam Jaganathan, Thirukambigai Devi and countless others, who followed the translation avidly and promoted it among numerous groups.

I would also like to dedicate this book to all those fans who have been asking me for years to publish my translation and to my

husband who claims to be the first among them.

A special dedication is due to Abirami Baskaran whose encouraging words were invaluable. She was one of many who left us all too soon. May her soul rest in peace.



AUTHOR'S NOTE

Kalki Krishnamurthy's *Ponniyin Selvan* was the first Tamil novel that I read. To tell you the truth, I learnt to read Tamil using elementary school books, just so that I could read this story.

They say that good books and great authors can transform lives. I have found it to be true in my case. I started translating this book ten years ago, as a hobby and realized that I could write. Today, I am a freelance writer who makes a living out of writing, and I owe my profession to this novel!

Many authors have written phenomenal books in Tamil literature after Kalki Krishnamurthy, but *Ponniyin Selvan* still remains the most popular book, widely read by many. *Ponniyin Selvan* has the right mixture of all things that makes an epic – political intrigue, conspiracy, betrayal, huge dollops of romance, infidelity, seduction, passion, alluring women, unrequited love, sacrifice and pure love.

Ponni's Beloved is an English translation, and as many readers have pointed out, no translation can do justice to the original. I have tried to capture the essence and soul of Kalki's writing in my translation.

I recently visited all the places (in India) that are mentioned in this novel. We started on Aadi 18 (Aug 3, 2019) for this trail trip almost on the footsteps of Vandiya Devan and saw all the fascinating places that he mentions in the journey. I have included some of the photos in this volume.

Thank you,
Sumeetha Manikandan

PS. For those who wish to sign up for this tour trail, do contact Tour Bee (7299646588). The tour trail was well organized and at the curator had many interesting stories about each place that we visited.



FOREWORD

Kalki Krishnamurthy's *Ponniyin Selvan* was serialized in the post-independence era and it ran for four long years. Talking about a golden era in Tamil history, it ensnared the imagination of huge swathe of the Tamil population with people queuing in railway stations long before dawn to lay their hands on that week's edition of the Kalki magazine.

An entire generation dwelt upon the freshness of the novel and surprisingly it was not condemned to the recesses of the mind as a childhood fancy but continued to entice readers of subsequent generations as they were born and introduced to the Tamil language. The novel still has a colossal following but bounded by the hedges of a language that is not easy to learn, it strictly remained out of the mainstream and well within the realms of the Tamil speaking world.

Tamil people have been habitual migrants and the diaspora is spread over numerous countries. In today's generation, though many of them can speak fluent Tamil they lack the patience to read the Tamil script that is spread over 1000 pages of a novel. And that's when the need arises a need for a good translation.

When I read the novel late in my thirties, the social media was just

picking up and I was introduced to the yahoo group of Ponniyin Selvan fans around the year 2001. For the first time, readers from different age groups, settled in different lands were congregating online.

It was there that I came across a translation of Ponniyin Selvan into English. (There had been one earlier in print but that left much to be desired for those who had read the original. In fact, at one point the earlier translator mentioned 'Maize' for the Tamil word Cholam. But it was pointed out in the group that Maize entered India 500 years after the storyline period.)

The online translation was a bold bid by a youngster. As much as the substance within, the attempt bedazzled a lot of us because for 40 years or more it was almost sacrilege to deal with Kalki's works. The one sequel in the market at that time had been mauled by the copyright owners!

Over the next decade many of the members of the Yahoo group became novelists, biographers, bloggers, heritage activists and a host of history and literature connected personalities. And I would like to list Sumeetha's translation of Kalki's work as a starting point for all this.

A translated work should remind us of the original and it should have the author's imprint on the words. I think Sumeetha comes out in flying colours on both fronts. I am sure her work would open up the genius of Kalki to many who were deprived of it all these days.

Biography of Venkatesh Ramakrishnan:

Author Venkatesh Ramakrishnan is a Chennai based bilingual novelist from India. South Indian historical fiction is his forte. He has published 3 novels in Tamil, 2 of them are sequels to the famous Kalki Krishnamurthy novels Ponniyin Selvan and Sivagamiyin Sabatham respectively, with the titles Kaviri Mainthan and Kanji Tharagai. One of his other fictional work in Tamil is Thillayil Oru

Kollaikaran. Gods, Kings & Slaves. The Siege of Madurai is his first novel in English.

Character List

CHOLA ROYAL FAMILY

Paranthaka II – Emperor of the Chola and Pandya kingdoms from 957 to 970 CE, when this story happens. His handsomeness earned him the popular epithet of Sundara Chola, meaning Handsome Chola.

Vanamadevi - Consort of Paranthaka II and empress of the Cholas, she is the mother of Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan, Princess Kundavai and Prince Arulmozhivarman. Her father is the nobleman Thirukovallur Malayaman.

Aditya Karikalan - Eldest son of Sundara Chola and Vanamadevi and crown prince to the Chola throne, Aditya Karikalan is a peerless warrior who defeated and killed the Pandya king and established Chola suzerainty over his kingdom.

Kundavai - Younger sister of Aditya Karikalan and the daughter of Sundara Chola and Vanamadevi. Kundavai is cherished throughout the kingdom for her wit, wisdom, grace and intelligence. She lives in Pazhaiaarai along with her companions and friends.

Arulmozhivarman - The youngest son of Sundara Chola and Vanamadevi, Arulmozhivarman is known throughout the kingdom as 'Ponniyin Selvan'. At the time of the story, he is in Ilangai (Sri Lanka) on a campaign against King Mahindan and had captured many parts of the island. He later ascended the Chola throne as Raja Raja Cholan (985 - 1014 CE).

Gandaradithan - Son of Paranthaka I and Sundara Chola's uncle. He was the Chola king from 950 to 957 CE. Gandaradithan was known for his piety.

Sembiyanmadevi - King Gandaradithan's queen who was equally virtuous and spiritual. She belongs to the clan of Mazhavarayar and married the king despite his advanced age.

Madhuranthakan - Son of King Gandaradhithan and Sembiyanmadevi and the first cousin of Sundara Chola.

Arinjaya Chola - Son of Paranthaka I and the father of Sundara Chola. He reigned for a very short period from 956 to 957 CE.

Kalyani - Wife of King Arinjaya Chola and the mother of Sundara Chola. She belongs to Vaithumbarayar clan.

Rajadhithan - Eldest son and heir apparent of Paranthaka I. Prince Rajadhithan died in the Thakkolam war (950 CE) after which the crown passed on to his younger brother.

Paranthaka I - Grandfather of Sundara Chola, Paranthaka I ruled from 907 to 955 CE.

Noble Clans

PAZHUVUR CLAN

Periya Pazhuvetarayar - Lord Treasurer of the Chola kingdom and a peerless warrior who carried 64 battle scars on his body. He is the patriarch and the petty king of the powerful Pazhuvur clan and is an influential courtier and nobleman at the Chola court.

Nandini Devi - Queen and wife of Periya Pazhuvetarayar, Nandini is a young woman renowned for her beauty. Nandini's antecedents are a mystery and her past life is shrouded in secrecy.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar - Also known as Kalanthaka Kanda, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar is the younger brother of Periya Pazhuvetarayar and is the commander of the Thanjavur fort. A powerful man with a strong physique, he is also the father-in-law of Prince Madhuranthakan.

KODUMBALUR CLAN

Budhivikrama Kesari - The commander of troops in Ilangai, he is also known as Kodumbalur Periya Vellar. He is the patriarch of the Kodumbalur Clan.

Vanathi - A Kodumbalur princess and the niece of Budhivikrama Kesari, Vanathi is also the cherished companion and friend of Princess Kundavai, who hopes to wed her to Prince Arulmozhivarman.

Kodumbalur Siriya Vellar - Father of Vanathi and the younger brother of Budhivikrama Kesari, he died valiantly in Ilangai after leading a campaign across the sea.

SAMBUVERAYAR CLAN

Singannar Sambuvarayar - A powerful lord who ruled over Kadambur.

Kandanmaran - Son of Sambuvarayar who also fought along with Aditya Karikalan in many wars.

Manimegalai - Daughter of Sambuvarayar and the sister of Kandanmaran.

MALAYAMAN CLAN

Thirukkovalur Malayaman - Patriarch of the Malayaman clan and the father-in-law of Sundara Chola. He is close to his oldest grandson Aditya Karikalan.

VANAR CLAN

Vandiya Devan - Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan is Aditya Karikalan's bodyguard, friend and confidante.

PANDYA KING'S BODYGUARDS

Ravidasan - The ringleader of the conspirators who wish to avenge the death of their king. He is also known as 'Mandiravadi'.

Soman Sambavan - One of the conspirators and a member of Ravidasan's gang.

Edupankari - One of the Pandya conspirators who works in the Kadambur palace and overhears the noblemen's plots about the Chola succession.

Devaralan - One of the Pandya conspirators who works in the Kadambur palace.

OTHER IMPORTANT CHARACTERS

Azhwarkadiyan Nambi - A Vaishnavite and a spy who is also known as Thirumalai or Thirumalaiappan. He also claims to be Nandini Devi's brother.

Parthibendra Pallavan - Close confidante and friend of Aditya Karikalan.

Kudanthai Jodhidar - An astrologer in Kudanthai (present-day Kumbakonam) who is patronized by Kundavai.

Senthan Amuthan - A devout man who would offer the flowers of his garden to Thallikullathar Temple in Thanjavur. Vandiya Devan

stays in his house while visiting Thanjavur.

Poonguzhali - Senthana Amuthan's cousin who lives in Kodi Karai.

Glossary of Terms

Abathudavigal – The army of bodyguards that guarded the Pandya King

Adey – An expression used to refer someone with derision and disrespect

Adigaley – A respectful term used to address a monk

Amma – Mother

Ammavasai – New Moon

Anna - Elder brother

Anni - Elder brother's wife

Anthapuram - Women's quarters in a palace, usually located in an interior and protected part

Akka - Elder sister

Appa - Father

Ayya – A respectful term in Tamil used to address men

Ayyo / Ayyayo – An exclamation of distress

Battar – Term used to refer to the priest

Bikshu – A Buddhist Monk

Chi Chi – An expression of disgust

Dalapathy - Army Commander

Devi – Used to address royal or noble women

Dhanadhigari – Treasurer

Dhoomketu – A comet

Gurunatha – Teacher

Jodhidar – An Astrologer

Kalapathy – Ship's Captain or Commander

Maha Mandiri – Prime Minister

Maharaja – My King

Maha Guru – Chief among teachers

Mandapam – A canopy, usually built of stone with four or more pillars.

Mandiravadi – Magician

Malai – A Mountain

Natha – My beloved

Olai – Palm leaf used to write messages

Padai - Army

Paatti – Grandmother

Pujari – A priest

Prabhu – A respectful term to address a lord, prince or the king

Rani – Queen

Raja Drogam – Treason against the king

Rakshashi - Demoness

Senapathy – Army Commander

Samudra Rajan – The Sea God

Sangu sakkaram – Conch and discus

Thambi – Younger brother

Thatha – Grandfather

Theevu – An Island

Vajrayudham – Thunderbolt

Vaikuntam – The abode of Lord Vishnu

Vihara – A Monastery

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An excerpt from The Crown (Ponni's Beloved Volume 4)

The story so far...

In the 10th century AD, Southern India was ruled by the mighty Cholas who expanded their Kingdom from Ilangai (Sri Lanka) to River Krishna. Our story begins during the reign of Emperor Sundara Chola (Paranthakan II) who was sick abed with paralysis. His son, the Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan was gathering forces in Kanchipuram to expand their empire, while his second son, Prince Arulmozhiarman had conquered Ilangai and was setting up Chola suzerainty in the island kingdom.

Worried about his father's health and security at the hands of Pazhuvur brothers (prominent noblemen in the Chola court) Aditya Karikalan sends his friend and trusted bodyguard, Vandiya Devan with a message to the Emperor, inviting him to Kanchipuram. On his way to Thanjavur, Vandiya Devan halts his journey at Kadambur and stays at his friend Kandanmaran's palace for a night. There, he inadvertently, discovers that the Pazhuvur brothers were plotting a conspiracy. They plan to crown Prince Madhuranthakan (who is the Emperor's cousin) as the next Emperor and thereby denying the throne to the Crown Prince Karikalan.

While on his journey, Vandiya Devan meets Azhwarkadiyan, a spy who works for the Chola Prime Minister Anirudha Bhramarayar. Azhwarkadiyan tells him about Nandini, the young beautiful wife of Periya Pazhuvetarayar. Nandini happens to be the secret leader of the late Pandya King's loyalists who have vowed avenge their king's death.

They conspire to kill Aditya Karikalan (who had beheaded their king ingloriously) and wipe out his family in vengeance. Vandiya Devan meets Nandini and procures a signet ring from her, citing

Azhwarkadiyan's name (who was her foster brother), which he uses to enter the fort.

At the fort, he meets the Emperor and tries to warn him about the plot but is interrupted by Chinna Pazhuvetarayar who suspects him to be a spy. He also meets Nandini at her palace garden whose attempt to seduce him fails. While escaping from Nandini, he encounters his friend Kandan Maran in the dungeon passage and saves his life from a murderous guard but his friend mistakenly concludes that he was a killer. He then escapes from the fort and leaves for Pazhaiaarai with the help of his friend Senthana Amuthan.

At Pazhaiaarai, he meets Princess Kundavai and finds out that she is the same woman with whom he had fallen in love in Kudanthai. He tells Kundavai about the conspiracy that the noblemen are hatching. She writes a message to her brother Prince Arulmozhi and asks Vandiya Devan to bring him back home from Illangai. Vandiya Devan immediately leaves for Kodi Karai.

Prince Aditya Karikalan is furious that his friend has been branded a spy and wants to march his army to Thanjavur to crush the power of the Pazhuvur brothers. His grandfather Malayaman advises him against it and asks him to bring back Prince Arulmozhi home. They decide to send Karikalan's friend Parthibendra Pallavan for this task. Before he left, Karikalan tells Parthibendran about his unrequited love for Nandini and how she had betrayed him by sheltering and pleading for Veera Pandyan's life, which led him to behead the king in rage.

Kundavai leaves for Thanjavur along with her companion Vanathi, the Kodumbalur Princess. Vanathi is in love with Prince Arulmozhi varmar but she is also very faint-hearted. One night Vanathi sees the Emperor moaning in pain and shouting at someone who resembled Nandini. Next day, the Emperor calls Kundavai for a private audience and reveals his past to her.

When he was a young Prince, Sundara Chola gets stranded in an island near Ilangai and there he falls in love with a deaf and mute fisher girl named Mandakini. One day, the King's men find Sundara Chola and he goes back to the Kingdom after promising her his hand. After his return, circumstances force him to take the mantle of responsibility for his empire and he becomes the crown prince. Heartbroken by the turn of events, Mandakini commits suicide by jumping from the Kodi Karai lighthouse. Sundara Chola believes that Mandakini's ghost is haunting him since then and is asking him to give up the kingdom to his cousin Maduranthakan.

Vandiya Devan, in the meanwhile, meets Poonguzhali, a boat girl in Kodi Karai and goes to Ilangai with her help. At Ilangai, he meets Azhwarkadiyan again, who escorts him to the Prince. Prince Arulmozhivarmar is taken in by Vandiya Devan's personality and they become fast friends. Arulmozhi also reveals to them that a deaf and mute woman has been saving his life and helping him in Ilangai. He also tells them that she had saved his life when he was young and calls her 'Kaveri Amman'. Kaveri Amman (Mandakini) saves them once again from the murderous gang led by Ravidasan - the leader of Veera Pandya's erstwhile bodyguards. Vandiya Devan is taken aback by her resemblance to Nandini and guesses that she might be her mother.

Poonguzhali meets them again and gives a message that two warships have come to arrest the Prince on the Emperor's orders. Kodumbalur Periya Vellar and Parthibendran try to counsel the Prince against surrendering but in vain. The Prince decides to meet the ships and give himself up. He leaves their army in an elephant along with Poonguzhali but the warships had by then met a bad end. One of the warships is broken after running aground, while the other is captured by Arab pirates. Vandiya Devan who sees the Arab Pirates going along with Ravidasan assumes that the Prince is held a prisoner in the ship. He swims towards them and gets into the ship, only to find that he is gravely mistaken.

Prince takes Parthibendran's ship and goes in search of Vandiya Devan. During a fierce storm, Vandiya Devan kills the Arab Pirates and then Ravidasan (Mandiravadi) and his companion abandon the ship leaving him alone in it. When the storm intensifies, a bolt of lightning strikes the ship and its sails catch fire. The prince rescues him from the burning ship, but they fail to reach Parthibendran's ship and end up floating in the sea. They are later rescued by Poonguzhali.



Chapter 1: At Kodi Karai

The storm that began in Ilangai crossed the sea and made its way through the coastal cities of Chola Kingdom leaving behind destruction and death in its wake. From Kodi Karai to Kaveri Pattinam^[1], the cyclone rendered many people homeless, uprooted trees and destroyed many a property. The backwaters of Kodi Karai were flooded and the quicksands became more deadly and dangerous than ever, capable of swallowing large elephants.

Two days after the storm, Periya Pazhuvetarayar and his entourage came to Kodi Karai. A veiled palanquin followed the entourage but this time, it was indeed Nandini who travelled in it. There was no reason to take Prince Madhuranthakan with them and Lord Treasurer felt that it was important that Nandini travelled with him sometimes. It might be necessary to take Madhuranthakan again in the same veiled palanquin and if the Pazhuvur queen were to travel genuinely with her husband on some trips, no one would suspect otherwise. This was one of Nandini's arguments, but it didn't take long to convince her husband. Pazhuvetarayar readily accepted her suggestion and gleefully anticipated a romantic trip by the coast, along with his beautiful wife.

Just before the storm struck Kodi Karai, they were in Nagapattinam for a day, where Pazhuvetarayar met people on affairs of the Kingdom.

Nagapattinam was a busy trade route for many merchant ships, in those days. Ships laden with goods would often anchor at the port and boats would ply their way to the coast to unload and ferry them

back to the mainland. Trade merchants and officers of the guild would be at hand to levy taxes on the goods that are brought by the ships and the merchant ships would trade for items that they wish to take back to their respective kingdoms. There were many royal officials at the Port to conduct this business and as the Treasurer of Chola Kingdom, it was his duty to oversee their records.

After meeting the guild of merchants, Pazhuvetarayar headed to Chudamani Viharam^[2] where he was accorded respect and courtesy due to his status.

A few days ago, two Buddha Bikshus from this Viharam visited Thanjavur and requested permission to meet the Emperor. The Pazhuvur lord allowed them to meet Sundara Chola and they blessed him with good health and showered praises about his benevolence towards them. They had many praiseworthy things to say about Ponniyin Selvar who was helping the Buddha Sangam in Ilangai by renovating their monasteries and temples. They also imparted a piece of important information to the Emperor...

“Chakravarthy! The Buddha Sangams in Ilangai are delighted with the Prince’s benevolence that they have decided to offer the crown of Ilangai to him. This news has not only made us proud but also happy! There is no higher praise for the Chola Kingdom than this!”

Periya Pazhuvetarayar who was present there had an unusual idea that he voiced to Sundara Chola after the Bikshus left.

“My Lord! While there is no doubt that you rule over this vast kingdom, unfortunately, your sons rarely listen to you and nor do they respect your wishes. The reason for this is the ill advice given to them by certain people who have coveted important positions in our royal court. Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan refuses to come to Thanjavur and is instead asking you to travel to Kanchipuram. He is being taught by your noble father-in-law Malayaman to disrespect your wishes. In the case of your younger son, I have sent messengers one after another, across the sea asking him to return

home but in vain. These messengers find it difficult to meet the Prince, thanks to the schemes of Commander Kodumbalur Vellar. If Prince Arulmozhi knew that you wished to see him, he would immediately set out from Ilangai, I am sure of it. I would like to propose a plan that would make it hard for the Prince and the Commander to ignore your commands. If you permit, I can elaborate...”

When the Emperor nodded his ascent he said, “Let us send a warship with the Emperor’s royal commands to imprison the Prince, on charges of trying to usurp the throne of Ilangai. Kodumbalur Vellar cannot ignore a direct command from you and our men will have to meet the Prince directly. The Prince will never disrespect your orders, he will return immediately,”

When Sundara Chola heard this, he smiled. It was a strange idea and it might even work. The Emperor wished to see Arulmozhi, as soon as possible because he knew he was nearing his death. He wanted to speak to the young prince about the giving up their claim on the throne to Prince Maduranthakan. He hoped that the Prince would aid him in this plan and help change his older brother’s mind.

Thinking thus, Sundara Chola acceded to the Pazhuvetarayar’s idea of sending warships to Ilangai to imprison the Prince. Periya Pazhuvetarayar arranged for the warships and sent his own soldiers along with the sailors to Ilangai. The Captain of the ships had strict instructions not to cause any bodily harm to the Prince and to treat him with the utmost respect.

After the ships departed to Ilangai, Periya Pazhuvetarayar started worrying. He was concerned about his reputation. If something untoward were to happen to the Prince, whilst on his journey home, he would be blamed for the same. He, therefore, decided to go to Nagapattinam to welcome and receive the Prince ceremoniously and to bring him back to Thanjavur, under his protection.

There were a few other reasons for this decision. He didn't want the Prince to meet the Dowager Queen Sembiyanmadevi or Princess Kundavai before he spoke to his father, the Emperor. Both women had a lot of influence with the Prince and they hated the Pazhuvur brothers. He feared that they might change his mind.

Periya Pazhuvetarayar had many other worries too. The soldier who guarded the treasure chamber and the dungeon pathway was found dead and it had given rise to many suspicions in his mind.

Was someone hiding in the treasury? Could it be that spy from Karikalan, who his brother had foolishly lost sight of? If that were so, then he would have learned many other secrets!

Could Nandini be involved in this?

His brother had warned him about the Mandiravadi who came to meet his wife. He decided that he needed to find more about the Mandiravadi. When he learned that Princess Kundavai had sent Vandiya Devan to Ilangai with a message for her brother, he was more than worried.

What message did she send to her brother? Did she warn him about the conspiracy that they had planned?

Be that as it may, he had decided that once the Prince reached the shores of Chola Kingdom, he would be taken into his custody and protection. He had also asked the Captain of the warships to imprison Vandiya Devan if he was found in the company of the Prince. He wished to interrogate him personally and find out what he knew.

Thinking thus, the Pazhuvur lord travelled to Nagapattinam to await the Prince's arrival. Nandini had more reasons than her husband to travel to Nagapattinam. She was eager to meet Vandiya Devan and to know what message Kundavai had sent with him to the Prince. She also wanted to know how far Mandiravadi's mission in Ilangai

had been successful. Hence, she insisted that she too would travel along with Pazhuvetarayar. The Pazhuvur Lord agreed to take her along without much argument. He had long wanted to go on a romantic trip by the boat along with his beautiful wife and had hoped that this might quench his desires to some extent, but sadly, it didn't come to pass.

While they were in Nagapattinam, the storm hit the city and it was impossible to go anywhere on a boat. However, Nandini enjoyed the high winds and huge waves that rose in the sea from the safe confines of her palace balcony, while her husband brooded about his crushed dreams.

After the storm passed, Pazhuvetarayar was busy with the city officials to check the damages that have been caused. The destruction of property and life was minimal within the city since they had largely anticipated the storm. However, he heard many disturbing rumours from ships and boats that returned from the sea. One of them was a ship burning in the middle of the sea while another ship was trying to rescue.

What if this was one of the ships that he had sent? What if the Prince had been in one of these ships?

He knew that if some mishap were to befall the Prince, he and his clan would be blamed for it. The Prince was popular among the people and they would never forgive him if any danger befell him. Desperate for more news, he decided to travel to Kodi Karai. There might be fishermen who probably saw those ships and they might be able to tell him what happened.

When he told Nandini about his decision she immediately acceded to his plan. "I have never seen Kodi Karai. I have heard that it is beautiful."

There were two ways to reach Kodi Karai, through the canals that lead them to the backwaters or through the roads. Since their

entourage was large, they decided to go by road. Moreover, Nandini didn't want to travel by boat since she feared that it might encourage Pazhuvetarayar's romantic overtures. She told him that if they travel by road, they might get a chance to speak to the fisherfolk who might have come back from the sea.

Though they met some fishermen on the way, they didn't get any new information about the ships. When they reached Kodi Karai, the guardian of the lighthouse Thyaga Vidagar offered his humble home for the Pazhuvur couple, as there was no palace or mansion for them to stay.

However, Nandini refused his offer and opted to camp in tents near the lighthouse. They noticed a large ship on the horizon, and it came as close as possible to the sea. Periya Pazhuvetarayar got excited to see the ship. It looked careworn and its sails were ripped and torn.

Who could be in this ship? Could it be the Prince?

The fact that it didn't have a flag atop the sail was not surprising since the stormy winds might have torn it away.

Pazhuvetarayar sent a boat full of men to learn more about the ship. The ship seemed to be waiting for the boat, as two men immediately got into it and came ashore. One of them was Parthibendra Pallavan.

Prince Arulmozhivarmar who left his ship to save Vandiya Devan didn't come back that night. Parthibendran and his crew searched for them fruitlessly in the sea. They rescued one of the sailors who had gone with the Prince and learned that after saving Vandiya Devan, their boat was broken into two, by a sail mast.

Parthibendran searched for the Prince in despair for few more hours and then decided to go to Kodi Karai with a faint hope that he might have come ashore here.

When he learned that Periya Pazhuvetarayar had come to Kodi Karai along with Nandini he got irritated. He remembered everything that Karikalan had told about her. At the same time, he was also curious to see the woman who had stolen the Crown Prince's heart and his sleep. As he neared the shore, this curiosity grew so much that he feared whether he would be allowed to meet her!

He needn't have worried so much because as soon as they came ashore, the soldiers took him to Pazhuvur Lord's tent. Pazhuvetarayar was standing at the entrance of his tent watching Parthibendran. When the Pallava Lord saw him, he realized that he was doing Pazhuvetarayar a huge injustice by calling him an 'old man'. It would indeed be a difficult prospect to find a young man who would match his stature, build and stamina indeed!

While he was thinking thus, a beautiful maiden came out of the tent. To Parthibendran, it seemed as though the clouds had parted to reveal a peal of lightning. Like a beautiful flower creeper, she came around Pazhuvetarayar's gnarled old form. Her beauty had astonished Parthibendran so much that it robbed him of speech.

"My Lord! Who is this warrior? I have never met him before," she asked, her voice dripping with honey that was as intoxicating as nectar.



Chapter 2: The seductive net

Men who get married to younger women dwell in a world where suspicion reigns supreme. They often regard strangers with distaste. Pazhuvetarayar felt the same when he saw Parthibendran outside his tent and added to that he didn't like the way Nandini had come forward to talk to the Pallava lord, but he was helpless because he couldn't chide her for doing so!

He, therefore, replied to Nandini with a frosty smile, "Devi, there are many in this world whom we do not know and we have nothing to lose if we don't."

Parthibendran who had by then recovered his speech said, "Ayya! If your beloved queen doesn't know my person then it is indeed a loss for me. Allow me to introduce myself to your wife. Devi, people call me Parthibendra Pallavan."

"Oh! I have heard about you," said Nandini.

"Parthibendra! Why did you omit all those titles that decorate your name? Since when did you turn so humble? Nandini! He isn't just Parthibendra Pallavan, he is the warrior who won Vengai^[3] and Kalingam^[4]! He is the warrior who beheaded Veera Pandyan!" said Pazhuvetarayar with a derisive laugh.

Nandini's face darkened for a few seconds just as sudden clouds crowd on a clear blue sky. She regained her composure soon

enough and laughed.

“Ayya! These days so many people are claiming the honour of beheading Veera Pandyan that it is difficult to count,”

“Devi! The Pazhuvur lord added those titles to my name out of respect but in truth, the honour of slaying Veera Pandyan rests only with Prince Aditya Karikalar!”

“Now, I wonder, why you say that? Don’t you want, your share of glory in killing a dead snake?” asked Pazhuvetarayar sarcastically.

“No, My Lord! Aditya Karikalar did not kill a dead snake. When he drew his sword, a beautiful woman came in front to beg for the King’s life. If it had been me, I would have thrown that sword away and Veera Pandyan might have escaped with his life,” said Parthibendran in reply to Pazhuvetarayar though his eyes were directed towards his wife.

Nandini, who realized the dangerous route the conversation was taking, immediately turned towards her husband.

“Nadha^[5]! Why are we talking about these old stories? Kindly enquire about his business hereabouts!”

Pazhuvetarayar immediately acceded and asked, “She is right. Let’s not discuss old stories. What are you doing here? When did you leave Kanchipuram? Where are you bound?”

Parthibendran who had forgotten the purpose of his visit soon remembered it.

“Ayya! Forgive me. I have come with the distressing news that would drown the Chola Kingdom in sorrow. Prince Arulmozhivarmar came in my ship and when the storm struck us he jumped into the sea and has gone missing. We searched for him fruitlessly for an entire day. I came here hoping that he might have come ashore...”

Even before he could finish his account, Pazhuvetarayar exclaimed, "What? What did you say?" and fell down in a dead faint.

Parthibendran sprang forward to hold him but Nandini pushed his hands away and sat down near her husband. Cradling his head on her lap, she shouted, "Water! Water!"

A handmaiden came running from the tent bearing a pitcher of water, while soldiers and onlookers crowded them around. Nandini with a regal glance bid them to move away and sprinkled some water on her husband's face and crooned lovingly, "Nadha! Nadha!"

After a few minutes, Pazhuvetarayar opened his eyes and sat up immediately.

"Nandini! Did my ears deceive me? What did this Pallavan say? Did he say that Ponniyin Selvan was lost in the sea? Could that be true? That child, with whom I used to play, who used to ride my shoulders! Could he be gone? I held him in these very hands right from the time he was a babe, and these were the hands that put the seal on the royal decree to imprison him! Woe to me! What will the people of Chola Kingdom say about me and my clan?" wailed Pazhuvetarayar and beat his hands on his head. No one had seen the old man ever so distressed in their life, not even Nandini!

"Natha! Don't distress yourself! The Pallava lord did not complete his message. Let us hear him out and decide what needs to be done,"

"Yes. You are right! Parthibendra! You said that the Prince drowned in the sea. Is that true? Or are you perhaps telling these tales out of some malicious intent? Do not play with me!" growled the old man.

"Ayya! Forgive me! I did not say that the Prince drowned and died. I cannot accept the fact that a storm can steal this Kingdom of its most beloved Prince. When the storm was at its worst, the Prince jumped from my ship into the sea. He might have escaped if God willed it!

That's why I came here hoping against hope that he might be alive by some miracle come ashore..."

"He jumped from the sea during the storm! Why? What possessed him to do such a thing? Why did he come in your ship in the first place? What were you doing when he did such an insane act?" questioned Pazhuvetarayar one after another.

Nandini interjected saying, "Ask him to explain as to why he went to Ilangai in the first place?"

"Yes. Tell me the truth or else you will never leave this place alive,"

"My Lord! I am not in the habit of telling lies. If for some reason, lies are called for, even then, my tongue betrays me by telling the truth. We have been hearing disturbing rumours about the Emperor in Kanchipuram. We also heard that the noble lords have come together to conspire against the Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan's right to succession,"

"Lies! Absolute lies!"

"I too wish that they were but mere lies nonetheless this is what we heard! This prompted noble Malayaman to send me to Ilangai so that I could bring back Prince Arulmozhi to the Kingdom..."

Starting thus, Parthibendran recollected all the events that had occurred ever since he boarded the ship to Ilangai. After listening to him, Pazhuvetarayar wailed, "Oh God! A great calamity has struck the Chola Kingdom! And it came because of me. It was 'I' who sent those ships to Ilangai to imprison the Prince!"

"My Lord! None of this is your fault. Even if you hadn't sent those ships, the Prince would have travelled in the Pallava Lord's ship to Kanchi and would have become prey to the storm. Pray, do not blame yourself for something that God had destined!" said Nandini

wisely and then suddenly leaned towards her husband and whispered something in his ears.

Pazhuvetarayar's face gained some colour after he heard her words and said, "Yes! Yes, you are right! It didn't occur to me at all!"

Next, he turned to Parthibendran and said, "Pallava! I am going to go to your ship and inspect it. You will remain here under guard, until then. Don't try to escape or else my soldiers will hunt you down. You belong to the brave clan of mighty Pallavas and it would tarnish their fame if you were found wounded in your back!"

"My Lord! I have no intention of escaping from here. If I do decide to escape, none of your soldiers can hope to wound me and certainly not in the back."

"My lord! Don't worry. I will take care of him. If he tries to escape, this dagger of mine will find its mark. You go to his ship and inspect it carefully. Speak to his sailors to verify his story." Said Nandini with her hand clutching the dagger that she had taken out of her waist.

"Devi, I don't want to burden you with this responsibility. You go inside the tent and take rest or else go to Thyaga Vidakaraiyar's house. Our soldiers can keep him under watch until I return or else I could take him along with me to inspect the ship..."

"I have no intention of accompanying you, My Lord. If I come along, you might think that I am influencing my sailors. I will not budge from here until you return,"

"My Lord! I have no intention of going anywhere too. I will be here waiting for you..." said Nandini and then leaned towards him to whisper in his ears again, "This Pallava lord might have come here to spy on you, who knows? I will stay here to prevent such mischief. Moreover, no one hereabouts must know the truth about the Prince's fate until you return from the ship..."

Pazhuvetarayar nodded and then took a boat to inspect Parthibendran's ship that was anchored at some distance. Nandini stood looking at the boat until it moved away from the range of her eyes. She was also aware of the fact that Parthibendran was unabashedly staring at her face. She turned towards him expecting him to look away with embarrassment but the honeybee that has smelt the nectar will seldom turn away!

Nandini took the dagger back from her waist and said, "Don't try to escape! You have been warned!"

"Devi, why are you trying to scare me off with that dagger? How could a fish that has been ensnared in the fisherwoman's net escape? Where would it go? I am truly caught in the net that you had cast..."

"What are you saying? Are you comparing me with a fisherwoman? If my lord were to hear this..."

"I am not worried about what he would think. But I did not mean to call you a fisherwoman. I was referring to your beautiful eyes that cast an alluring seductive net..."

"Chi! Chi! How dare you? Even if you had called me a fisherwoman it was excusable but now you dare to call me, a woman of loose morals!"

"Forgive me! That's not what I meant when I spoke about your beautiful eyes. There is nary a guile in them. The spider painstakingly makes a beautiful web as its home. When the flies fly into it, one can hardly blame the spider for enticing it inside..."

"So, now you are comparing me to a nasty spider. Do I look so horrible to you?"

"No! No! I should have compared you to the lamp. We light a lamp so that it relieves us from the darkness, but the house flies and other

pests are attracted to its beauty and they sacrifice their life at its altar...”

“A small wind can take care of this lamp’s light. That’s all the power that it holds.”

“The lamp might be extinguished but is there any power in this world to dim a full moon’s light! The moon rises over the sea because of the natural order of things in this world but why does the sea try to reach it with its endless waves?”

“I have heard that the Pallava kings appreciated true art and had great imagination to build splendid structures... today I have learned it to be true!”

“I never believed it when I read about it in the Puranic^[6] tales and old stories but today I am willing to believe it,”

“What are you referring to?”

“I have heard about those who possess such unearthly beauty that they are able to enslave all beings in the three worlds. Didn’t Mohini^[7] enchant the Asuras^[8], just when they were about to partake the nectar? Didn’t the Apsara Menaka^[9] entice Sage Vishwamitra^[10] away from his austerities? Didn’t Kovalan^[11] fall prey to the beauty of courtesan Madhavi^[12]? Didn’t King Dasaratha^[13] banish Rama^[14] to the forest to please Kaikeyi^[15]? Didn’t the glorious Kingdom of Rome lose its fame and glory when it bowed its head before the beauty of Egypt’s queen^[16]...”

“Enough! May I ask, why you are quoting these examples to me?”

“Devi! Can’t you guess?”

“If you are quoting to compare them with me then, you are making a huge mistake,”

“I doubt that. The women that I quoted as an example had as much power as you have,”

“I can prove that it is a lie with the help of your own words!”

“How so?”

“I sent my lord husband to the ship deliberately, so that I could speak to you privately,”

“I guessed your intent. That’s why I didn’t go with him,”

“A little while ago, you said that a woman tried to save Veera Pandyan and that Aditya Karikalar didn’t accede to her request,”

“Yes, I did,”

“Do you know who that woman was?”

“Yes. She is right now the beloved wife of Periya Pazhuvetarayar!”

“If I indeed were so enticing, wouldn’t I have saved the life of Veera Pandyan? Why did I fail there?”

“It is true that Prince Aditya Karikalar didn’t accede to your request. His fury in war is legendary. But it is also true that for the past three years, he has been regretting his actions and torturing himself for not granting your wish,”

“How is it that you know about this? Did he speak to you about it?”

“For three years, he had locked this sorrow in the deepest recess of his heart. I knew that he was troubled by something and begged him to reveal it to me. He opened his heart ten days ago, just before I journeyed to Ilangai. Since then...”

“Since then...”

“Since then, I have been wanting to meet the *Pazhuvur* Queen,”

“You said that if you had been in Aditya Karikalar’s position, you would have acceded to my request and granted Veera Pandyan his life,”

“Yes, I did,”

“Is that true?”

“Absolutely! You can test me if you so wish,”

“Ayya! I have a doubt. Can I tell you about it?”

“My ears are fortunate to hear anything that you care to say with your honeyed voice,”

“I think that you are testing me with your words. While you speak of the net that I am casting around, you are trying to trap me in your net! You are trying to gain my confidence so that you could learn all my secrets!”

Parthibendran was flabbergasted to hear Nandini’s words. He had indeed begun the conversation with the intention of trapping her in a web of lies and to make her believe that he was smitten by her beauty. But what began with a deceitful intent soon became true for him and he became truly enamoured by her beauty. He was startled by the fact that Nandini was perceptive enough to glean the truth out of his lies. Nonetheless, he tried to hide the fact from her and said, “Devi! If you truly believe that I have come here to spy on you, let the Gods unleash thunder and lightning upon my head!”

“Ayyo! Do not say that!” wailed Nandini. “That messenger who came from your Prince, what was his name?”

“You mean Vandiya Devan?”

“Yes. He tried to spy on me very cleverly and if your account is true, it looks as if the lightning did indeed fall upon his head,”

“Alas, Devi! The lightning fell upon the ship and not on his head and that finally led to the Prince leaving the ship in the heart of the storm!”

“Poor Kundavai! Two people who were most dear to her heart are lost to her forever. How unfortunate for her?”

“Devi! Who are these two people?”

“Didn’t you know that Prince Arulmozhivarmar was most dear to Kundavai?”

“Yes, I do. But who is this other person who was dear to her?”

“Who but that messenger that your Prince sent along,”

“You mean Vandiya Devan?”

“Yes!”

“Chi! Chi^[17]! How could Princess Kundavai, who is powerful enough to rule this kingdom spare a glance to that upstart and vainglorious Vandiya Devan?”

“Nonetheless, it is true. She was attracted to him and that’s why she sought to save him from my husband’s soldiers, by sending him away to Ilangai to fetch her brother. My husband is berating himself for sending those ships to imprison the Prince, but it is Kundavai who is responsible for the brother’s death. If she had not sent Vandiya Devan to the Prince...”

“...then the Prince wouldn’t have jumped into the sea during the storm.”

“When my Lord husband comes back from the ship, I would be grateful if you could point this out to him,”

“*Devil!* Is there anything else that I could do for you, and earn your gratitude?”

“Ayya! I am but a helpless woman and there are a hundred ways to earn my gratitude,”

“If you could tell me, I would be much beholden to you. Aditya Karikalar got a golden opportunity to earn your gratitude, but he let it slip away and regretted his actions for three years. I do not wish to make such a blunder.”

“Is that true, ayya? Would you go to any lengths to do the bidding of a woman?”

“No! Yesterday, if someone had told me this, I would have laughed. But today, after I saw you, I can’t help myself. Tell me something... anything! If I had a hundred lives, I would sacrifice them for you, just to do your bidding. I would give up a thousand kingdoms just to please you. Ask me to forgive my deadly enemy and I would do it for you. Ask me to behead my dearest friend, and it shall be done forthwith...”

As Parthibendran went on listing the things that he was prepared to do just to gain Nandini’s gratitude, his body shook and his speech slurred, his lips trembled, and his breath became heated!

Parthibendran’s transformation will be a source of great surprise for all the readers. But if someone had gone to him and said, “You will become thus!” he wouldn’t have believed it. Later, after many years, he would think back to this day and wonder how he could have acted thus!

This kind of transformation is not limited to a person like Parthibendran. It happens all the time, all around us. We haven’t

unravelling the mysteries of the human body yet and it would take many years before we unravel the mysteries of the mind.

People who commit acts of unspeakable evil, one day become devout and renounce their old life. There are others who spend their lives immersed in devotion but irrevocably commit evil acts.

Nandini who heard Parthibendran's declaration with a smug smile interjected him and said, "Enough Ayya! I would never ask you to do anything so terrible as you just described. I would only request you to do something that would make us both happy,"



Chapter 3: The Owl's Call

Nandini looked at the sea and saw the boat nearing Parthibendran's ship. She sighed deeply and it flared Parthibendran's protective instincts.

"Devi! Tell me what you want me to do? Whatever makes you happy will make me very happy!"

Many strange thoughts were coursing through Parthibendran's mind at that instant. He wanted to rescue this beautiful woman from that old wild cat!

Why can't I take her away from this old brute? If only she could tell me her heart's desire, I would imprison that old man in the ship and banish him to some uninhabited island. How dare he marry a beautiful young woman who is younger than his grandchildren?

But Nandini was still watching the sea intently even as Pazhuvetarayar climbed on the rope ladder to get into the ship.

"Thank the Gods! He got into the ship! Though he is a great warrior he keeps forgetting that he is quite old. I was worried that he might slip and fall into the water while climbing aboard the ship,"

Parthibendran was disappointed when he heard her speak thus.

Why is she so concerned about the old man? Would it be so bad if he were to die? This kingdom would surely benefit from it and this woman would be 'free'.

"Today, I learned how loyal the old man is towards the Chola Kings. I was astonished to see him wail thus. Ayya! Is there any chance that the Prince might have escaped the ravages of the storm?"

"I can't say anything for sure. The storm was intense when he jumped into the sea. It was fate!"

"Don't blame it all on fate. It was Kundavai's greed that brought about this calamity. Do you know that she has great belief in astrology and palmistry? She would constantly look at her brother's horoscope and declare that he would one day become an Emperor! Poor woman, what would she do if she learns that her dear brother died in the storm? I wish I could offer some consolation in her grief!"

"Devi! Why do you wish to console her? She brought this upon herself thanks to her own 'greed'"

"She is the Emperor's daughter and if she were to shed even a single tear, the people of this kingdom would fall upon their feet to wipe it away. Such is the legendary beauty of this Princess,"

"At one time, I thought the same but after I met you..."

"After you met me?"

"After I met you, I realized that Kundavai can't match the beauty of your little toe!"

"Your eloquence is fine, but I wouldn't believe it. If you were to meet Kundavai tomorrow I am sure you will forget me!"

"Never! That will never happen! Devi! Why don't you test my devotion to you? You will know the extent of my affection for you,"

“Who am I to command you, my lord? I can merely request you. Ever since, I married Periya Pazhuvetarayar, many in the Kingdom have been berating me for causing confusion and chaos. I request your help to disprove it,”

Parthibendran was fiercely disappointed by her request. He had hoped that Nandini would bid him to do something impossible and that he would accomplish it forthwith and gain her favour but she was talking about the kingdom’s affairs instead!

“Tell me, Devi! What do you wish me to do?”

“Ayya! Kundavai is responsible for the present difficulties of the Kingdom. Her vain and headstrong behaviour has alienated all the noble lords from the Emperor’s camp. She has decided to place her brother Arulmozhi in the Chola throne. That’s why she never encouraged any peace talks among the noble lords. But now that she has suffered an irreparable loss and we can strive to make peace. Ayya! Most of the noble lords wish to see Prince Madhuranthakan ascend the throne after Sundara Cholar and the Emperor too wishes the same,”

“Is that so?”

“That’s right Ayya! Why else would the Emperor approve a royal order that decrees the imprisonment of Arulmozhi? But I didn’t think this was the right way to proceed with peace talks. I have instead proposed that we split the kingdom from the South of Vellattru for Aditya Karikalar and the Northern region to Prince Madhuranthakar. Didn’t the old Pallava Kings rule the Thondaimandalam region and remain happy? Didn’t Cheras and Pandyas rule within their small kingdoms and remain contented?”

“Devi! Why are you telling me about this? How does it matter to me if Chola Kingdom is split into two?”

“Ayya! I thought you were the trusted friend of Prince Aditya Karikalar!”

“I have spent years toiling loyally for the fame and glory of others and living under their shadow. But I wish to live for myself now. Devi! Listen to me. I have often wondered why I was born in this world. My forefathers ruled the Pallava Kingdom for many years. They built Mammalapuram^[18] to resemble heaven on earth! I often wondered whether I was born to re-establish the Pallava rule again, but my heart wasn't in it. Instead I fought for the Cholas and earned their patronage. I became the trusted friend of Prince Aditya Karikalar and was happy to earn glory with him. I thought I would spend the rest of my life in this manner but today I have realized the purpose of my birth! There! The sea lord too is acknowledging it.

Devi! Do not talk to me about dividing the kingdom. Let's talk something else, instead. Command me to get precious stones and corals from far away island kingdoms. Ask me to bring precious white pearls from the deepest of the seas in this world. Ask me to get Sanjeevini^[19] herb from the lofty mountains of Meru^[20]. Let me travel to the skies and make a necklace of those stars for you. Let me bring that full moon for you so that you can use it as a mere mirror...”

“Enough! Ayya! Enough! Kundavai has declared me ‘mad’ on many occasions and looks like I might become one, if I hear one more word from you!”

Parthibendran looked a bit abashed and said, “I think it is ‘me’ who is going mad. Forgive me. Tell me, what you wish for?”

“I wish to clean the taint to my name. People are saying that the calamity and disaster has come to the Cholas ever since I married Periya Pazhuvetarayar. They say that, because of my influence, Prince Madhuranthakar desires the Kingdom that he had earlier refused! They say that the entire conspiracy hatched by the noble lords is my doing! I do not wish to die without, trying to clear my name,”

“Why do you talk about dying? Do you wish to torment me?”

“Pallava Kumara! Are you familiar with the ancient art of Palmistry^[21]? Do you believe in it?” asked Nandini changing the subject abruptly.

Instead of answering her directly, Parthibendran said, “Show me your hands,”

Nandini showed him her left hand and Parthibendran looked at it intently and said, “You have many interesting lines. It is quite astonishing to see these in anyone! Show me the other hand!”

Nandini showed him both her hands and Parthibendran looked at them carefully and said, “Devi, has anyone ever seen your hands to predict your future?”

“Yes. Princess Kundavai saw these lines and told me once...”

“What did she say?”

“She said that I would die young,”

“That is true!”

“Ayyo! You too are saying the same thing!”

“It looks like her knowledge about palmistry is incomplete. One of your lines does indicate a short life, while the other foretells that you might survive the danger and live a long life. After that you will travel across the seas... to far away kingdoms and live a happy contented life that even the Kings and Queens would envy. You will gain this happiness through a young man whom you met near the sea and he will move the earth and the sky to fulfil even the smallest of your wishes. These lines indicate it very clearly...” said Parthibendran and then suddenly took her hands and reverently held them to his eyes.

Nandini shook his hands from hers and said, “Chi! How dare you touch me?”

“Forgive me! For an instant I forgot that they were your hands. I thought they were a pair of blooming lotuses!”

“If my lord husband had seen this, he would put you to death immediately!”

“Devi! I regret the fact that I have just one life to give up for you,”

“Then why do you wish to squander it like this? Use it to aid me instead,”

“Tell me what I should do,”

“I wish to save the Chola Kingdom from fratricidal strife. I need your help,”

“How can I help?”

“Bring your friend, Prince Aditya Karikalar to Kadambur Sambuverayar’s palace. Lord Sambuverayar has a daughter. If we could get her married to the Prince, my wish will be fulfilled,”

“This is an easy task for me. I can surely bring the Prince to Kadambur, what else?”

“If we get the Prince married to Sambuverayar’s daughter, the troubles that have plagued this realm will lessen by half. Then we will need to convince him about dividing the Kingdom into two...”

“and then...”

“If I could bring peace in this Kingdom, the taint of my bad reputation will be gone. I will then embrace my fate and end my life in the deep

sea,”

“Then I will follow you and save your life. We will be reborn in this world again. I will take you to an island far away from here and establish a kingdom for you,”

“Ayya! I beseech you, don’t talk in this manner. I am a woman born and bred in this kingdom and I am bound by the dictates of society. I am the lawful wife of Periya Pazhuvetarayar,”

“Devi! Tell me the truth! Why did you marry this old man? Do you truly love him, or did he force you to submit to his desires?”

“Please don’t blame my husband. I married him willingly,”

“Why? What for? What did you see in him?”

“I didn’t see anything in him. But he did offer me a life in the palace, troop of servants and maids for me to command and a gracious life of a queen,”

“I can’t believe this!”

“It might be difficult to believe but that’s the truth. When I was young, there was someone who abused me for being poor and orphan. She told me that I had no right to play with Prince and Princesses of the realm. I wished to prove her wrong and that’s how I ended being married to the old man,”

“Devi! Who is this woman that insulted you thus?”

“Can’t you guess?”

“It was Princess Kundavai, wasn’t it?”

“Yes,”

“I will teach her a lesson one day,”

“God has taken care of it. With one stroke of his hand, she has been deprived of her brother and lover. I feel pity for her,”

“I think she deserves a much harsher punishment than this,”

“If you fulfil my wish by bringing the Prince to Kadambur, it will be a just punishment for Kundavai. Her wish to rule over the Chola Kingdom will turn to dust,”

“If I fulfil your wish, what will you give me in return?”

“Whatever you wish will be yours, provided you do not demand anything that would besmirch my honour and the sanctity of my marriage to my Lord Husband,”

“Rani! In the desert kingdoms of Arabia, they follow a new religion where married couples can separate and remarry whomsoever they desire...”

“I have heard about it,”

“Let us go to this Kingdom and join their faith...”

“I have had daydreams about doing something like that, but it is not possible,”

“Devi! Why do you say thus? It is possible. If you could only say ‘yes’ I will make it possible for you. I will take you across the seven seas and conquer rich islands. I will carve out a new empire for you. I will seat you beside me on a golden throne studded with precious gems. I will place upon your beautiful head, a sparkling crown and make the people pay homage to you. It is our fate to be together, that’s why I survived deadly wars just so that I could rescue you...”

“Ayya! My lord husband is coming back. His boat has almost reached the shores. Calm yourself, we can talk about these things, later.”

“Later, when Devi?”

“Come along with us to Thanjavur. If my husband doesn’t invite you as a guest, then come with us as our prisoner,”

“Your invitation alone is enough for me,”

Pazhuvetarayar’s boat came ashore and he stomped furiously through the beach to reach the tent. Nandini and Parthibendran stood up when they saw him approaching. Poor old man! His anger knew no bounds when he realized that Nandini and Parthibendran had been talking all the while he was away.

“Nadha! Did you inspect the ship properly? Did you speak to the sailors? Is he telling the truth about the Prince?” asked Nandini with a loving voice. Her voice calmed the storm that was blowing in her husband’s heart.

“Yes. Whatever he said was true. The beloved Prince of this realm, that lovely boy is indeed dead, thanks to this scoundrel!” said Pazhuvetarayar grounding his teeth.

“Ayya! I am not responsible for his death. Don’t lay the blame on my head. This tragedy is not of my doing but of that vile woman who rules the Chola Kingdom!”

The old man’s anger was frightening to behold. He thought that the Pallavan was talking about his wife!

“What did you say?” he shouted and took out a spear that was struck on the ground and aimed at him in anger.

Nandini sprang forward and clutched his hand tightly, “Nadha! What are you doing? How could a great warrior like yourself smear your hands and reputation by killing a guest under your roof?”

“Rani! Is he a guest? Didn’t you hear what he just said about you?”

“My lord! Are you sure that he was talking about me? If he were indeed talking about me, I wouldn’t wait for you to take revenge. I would kill him myself,”

“Ayya! Am I mad to talk about the Pazhuvur queen? I was referring to the headstrong princess of Pazhaiaarai. Kundavai sent a message to Prince Arulmozhi with Vandiya Devan and signed his death warrant. The Prince jumped into the stormy sea to save him, despite my objections. That’s why, I said Kundavai was responsible for the Prince’s death,”

Pazhuvetarayar felt a bit ashamed for jumping to conclusions but instead of accepting his mistake he said, “Don’t try to hide your mistakes by blaming others. What were you doing when the Prince jumped into the sea? How could you allow him to do such an insane act? Go! Get lost! I don’t wish to see you anymore!”

Nandini interjected and said, “Nadha! Wouldn’t it be prudent to take him to Thanjavur along with us? Let him narrate whatever happened to the prince in the Emperor’s royal court or else we will be blamed for the Prince’s death,”

“Let people talk whatever they want, I will chop their heads off. I am not afraid of idle talk. But yes, it is better to take him along with us to Thanjavur. Parthibendra! Why are you looking hither and thither? Do you plan to escape?” he said and signalled his soldiers to come near.

“Bind him with ropes!” shouted Pazhuvetarayar and the soldiers surrounded Parthibendran. The Pallava scion stood silently for a

while and then showed his prowess in arms. Soon the soldiers lay on the ground moaning and groaning in pain!

“Ayya! If you wish to bind me then don’t send mere soldiers. I would submit only to that warrior who has won 64 glorious scars in the service of Chola kingdom,”

Despite his anger, Pazhuvetarayar found himself smiling. “You are indeed the scion of brave Pallava kings, there is no doubt about that. If you agree to come along with us to Thanjavur willingly then there is no need to bind you,”

“I wish to come with you to Thanjavur. I will speak to the Emperor and tell him everything that occurred. I too, do not want to be blamed for the Prince’s death,”

“Fine. Let us leave this instant!”

At that moment an owl hooted at a distant in the woods. *Nandini* looked immediately in that direction.

“The woods of Kodi Karai are very strange indeed! How could an owl hoot in the broad daylight?”

Nandini immediately looked at her husband and said, “Do we leave immediately? Shouldn’t we wait for two or three days here? What if the Prince had survived the storm by clutching a wooden log or something? He might come ashore here,”

“Parthibendra! Do you see how wise the queen is? Yes, let’s tarry here for two more days. We can search the shore...”

“I have no objection Ayya! But I don’t think that the Prince would be found. If you had seen the storm that raged that night, you too would be discouraged thus.”

But the old man didn't listen. He stationed his men in boats all along the coast watching for signs of survivors.



Chapter 4: In the woods

In the middle of the sea, the boat was drifting along the placid sea. It seemed rather inconceivable that this gentle sea could throw up huge waves big enough to swallow a war ship!

On the boat, the Prince and Vandiya Devan were arguing vociferously while Poonguzhali with an oar in hand, was watching them silently. The subject of the argument was what they ought to do once they reach Kodi Karai? Vandiya Devan wanted the Prince to come with him to Pazhaiaarai. He eloquently listed many reasons for this.

“Your sister wishes to see you most urgently to discuss the affairs of the Kingdom. I swore to her that I would bring you along with me. You will need to heed this request of mine,”

“I can’t refuse to obey my father’s commands just so that you could honour your word!”

“Those are not your father’s commands. They are Pazhuvetarayar’s commands!”

He further added, “Moreover, do you wish to meet your father as a ‘free man’ or as a ‘prisoner’. Listen to me! If the people of this Kingdom learn that the Pazhuvur lords have imprisoned you, they will take up arms to free you at a heavy cost of blood. Do you want that to happen? God in his benevolence sent that storm to aid us. Do you wish to go against the God’s will and surrender yourself to Pazhuvetarayar?”

Vandiya Devan’s argument slowly changed the Prince’s intention to go to Thanjavur. He knew the love and devotion that the people had for him and if people knew that he had been imprisoned they might rise and revolt on his behalf. After thinking about it for a while he said, “Even if I were to agree to your idea, how do we avoid the Pazhuvur soldiers who would be waiting for me at Kodi Karai?”

“We have Poonguzhali to help us. She will take us through the Kodi Karai backwaters away from these soldiers. Poonguzhali are you listening?”

Poonguzhali was in the seventh heaven! Saving the Prince's life in the sea had given her more happiness than she could imagine but she was also pained by the fact that she would have to part with him, once they reached Kodi Karai. When Vandiya Devan proposed that she help them hide away from the Pazhuvur soldiers, she was elated!

“If we go towards the west of Kodi Karai there is a narrow canal that would take us through the dense woods. I could take the boat through there. It is a very dense wooded place and very secluded,”

“You could leave us there and go back to Kodi Karai to learn the news, couldn't you?”

“Yes. There are many places where the boat can be hidden,”

“Prince! Did you hear that?”

“I heard her! You are asking me to enter my kingdom like a thief. Samudra Kumari! Why have you stopped the boat?”

Poonguzhali immediately started plying the oars.

“Poor woman! How long will she ply the oars alone? Let me help you. Here, give me the other oar,”

The Prince smiled at his friend and said, “My friend! All your schemes will go waste. I don't think I will reach Pazhaiaarai or Thanjavur. In all probability, I will die here and reach Kailasam soon!”

Vandiya Devan turned towards him worriedly and said, “Ayya! What has happened to you? Why is your body shivering uncontrollably?”

“This is the shivering fever, my friend! Don’t you remember I told you how this fever had claimed many lives in Ilangai. Only a lucky few have escaped the ravages of this fever,”

Vandiya Devan who didn’t panic even when the sails of his ship caught fire, looked at him with alarm. Poonguzhali who looked up to see the Prince, dropped her oar in shock and stared at him silently.

The Prince’s body started shivering uncontrollably and Vandiya Devan cried, “Ayya! What do I do? Where do we take the boat? Poonguzhali! Is there a physician in Kodi Karai?”

But Poonguzhali was in great shock and wouldn’t respond. The Prince stood up and started shouting, “Take me to my sister immediately. Take me to Princess Kundavai”

Vandiya Devan’s confusion vanished when he heard this but the Prince in the grip of his fever shouted, “Akka! I am coming to you. I will not heed those who try to stop me,” and tried to jump out of the boat.

The Prince became uncontrollable and Vandiya Devan found it impossible to restrain him. He shouted for help, “Poonguzhali! Come here fast,”

Poonguzhali sprang forward and held the Prince’s hand in hers after which he became a docile child.

“Akka! Don’t be angry with me. I will listen to you. I will lie down now,”

After this, Ponniyin Selvar lay down shivering. His eyes looked around blankly without recognizing anything or anyone. His mouth churned out gibberish and long-forgotten conversation that largely didn’t make any sense!

Vandiya Devan had by then realized that it was pointless to ask the Prince's advice. It was his responsibility to save the Prince's life but thankfully he had the aid of this intelligent boat girl who was not only resourceful but also loyal to the Prince.

"Poonguzhali! Let us not tarry anymore. We need to reach Kodi Karai as soon as possible,"

Poonguzhali immediately started plying the oars fast. The boat veered through the waves, intent upon its destination.

Vandiya Devan sat next to the Prince. He was alarmed by the fact that the Prince tried to jump into the sea. *What if he tried the same again?* He also tried to chart out the next course of action.

"Poonguzhali! What do you think we should do? Shall we dare our way to Kodi Karai? Will your family help the Prince?"

"Ayya! It is difficult to know whom we can trust these days. My brother's wife is a greedy woman and our family is employed by Pazhuvetarayar to guard the lighthouse. Moreover, the soldiers who had come chasing you, might still be waiting to catch you. And the number of Pazhuvur soldiers might have increased as well, anticipating the Prince's arrival,"

Vandiya Devan was glad that he took her advice and thanked his lucky stars that sent her to aid him.

"So, it is best that we do not go to Kodi Karai immediately,"

"Look there!" said Poonguzhali suddenly pointing at a distance.

There was a large ship standing in the direction that she pointed out and beyond the ship the lighthouse of Kodi Karai was visible.

"*Aha!* That's a big ship. I wonder if it could Pallava Parthibendran's. If that were so, wouldn't it be better to take the Prince to

Kanchipuram,”

“It could be Pazhuvetarayar’s ship as well. Did you notice anything beyond the ship?”

“I could see the lighthouse,”

“Did you notice anything strange about it?”

“No.”

“I did. There were some people atop the lighthouse looking at the sea,”

“Will they be able to see us from there?”

“No. But if we go near the beach, we will be visible,”

“Then it is best to be careful, let us go through the canal that you mentioned earlier,”

“Let us go there when the dusk begins. Ayya! Do you remember I made you stay in that dark mandapam for a whole day? This canal flows near that place. If you could take the Prince there for a while, I could go and find out who has come,”

“Does that canal stop there, Poonguzhali?”

“No. It goes all the way to Nagapattinam,”

At that moment, the Prince started his fevered talk again, “Yes, Akka! You had mentioned about Buddha Bikshus of Nagapattinam Choodamani Viharam. Everything happened just as you anticipated. The Maha Boddhi Sangam of Anuradhapuram came forward to crown me as the next king of Ilangai but I refused it. Akka! I have no interest in ruling the kingdom. I will listen to any other advice that you give but please do not make a ruler of me. I would prefer to sail in

the sea in a small boat. Nothing gives me more happiness than that. Akka! Do you know, I met this boat girl in Kodi Karai....”

Poonguzhali blushed when she heard the Prince talk about her in his fevered state. Vandiya Devan listened to all this curiously and waited eagerly for him to continue but the Prince regained consciousness. He got up and looked around asking faintly, “Have we reached Kodi Karai yet?”

Vandiya Devan said, “There! We can see the beach,”

Even when Vandiya Devan was thinking about whether to consult the Prince, the latter lost consciousness yet again!

Poonguzhali found it difficult to meet Vandiya Devan’s eyes or to look at the Prince after that fevered speech. She looked ahead instead and mechanically plied the oars. She deftly set the boat in the western direction and they soon moved away from the beach towards the backwaters of Kodi Karai.

Even while the sun was setting, they reached the canal that she spoke of. The dense woods and the thicket that surrounded the forest shielded the canal from many prying eyes that were roaming in the beach.

Poonguzhali stopped the boat near a dense thicket and said, “Ayya! If you could mind the boat for a while,” and then got down near the bank and nimbly climbed the nearest tree. “Thank the Gods we came here. Over a hundred men are watching the sea near the beach. Near the lighthouse a huge tent has been pitched and there are many soldiers there too!”

“Who do you think it could be?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“I can’t tell but it must be Pazhuvetarayar. Who else could it be? Let us go to the place where I hid you. And then I will go home once it darkens well enough and find out all the information,”

“Poonguzhali! If something were to happen to you, our fate is sealed,”

“Ayya! I have never worried about my life before but I am now. Do not fret. I will take care of myself and nothing will happen to me,”

Poonguzhali got into the boat and slowly plied the oars so that no one hears them approaching. After rowing thus for about an hour, she stopped near a dense thicket of shrubs and got down. She bid a silent farewell to Vandiya Devan and went through the woods. Walking swiftly through the woods, she made her way to Kuzhagar temple. She reached it just on time to watch the priest close the temple gates.

“Oh! It’s you Poonguzhali! I wondered who it could be. There are too many people in Kodi Karai today. Where did you go, I haven’t seen you in a while?”

“I had gone out in the sea, Ayya! You said there are too many people in Kodi Karai, who are they? Who are those people standing near the beach?”

“Didn’t you go home Poonguzhali?”

“I did, but I turned away when I saw many strangers. You do know that I hate meeting new people. Who are they?”

“Periya Pazhuvetarayar has come along with his younger queen and a huge entourage. Parthibendra Pallavan from Kanchi too has come and he didn’t come empty handed. He has brought bad tidings that will soon engulf this kingdom in sorrow.”

“What bad tidings? I know nothing about this,”

“Prince Arulmozhivarmar had come in this scoundrel Pallavan’s ship it seems and on the way a fierce storm hit their ship and the Prince

jumped into the sea to save somebody. They searched everywhere for him and then came back ashore. That's why Pazhuvetarayar has stationed his men all through the beach, hoping that the Prince might have survived the storm somehow. He is roaming around the beach restlessly and so does his queen! Poonguzhali! All those people who talk about the Pazhuvur Queen are woefully wrong. I have never seen anybody else so concerned about the Prince's fate than her,"

"Is that so ayya? Thanks for telling about the good nature of Pazhuvur queen but why did she come here?"

"She came here to pray for the Prince and to beseech the Kuzhagar [22] to spare his life. Not everyone is stone hearted like you are. I don't see you mourning the Prince's fate,"

"I don't think mourning his death is going to help him in any way. Who can overcome fate indeed? I don't wish to go home when so many important people have come there. If you could give me that Prasadam [23] in your hand, I would be grateful. I will eat and sleep in the temple tonight,"

"You are a strange creature indeed, Poonguzhali! When important people come to our home, one would want to make their acquaintance but you shy away from them. What do you think they would do to you? Why do you wish to stay alone in this forest tonight?"

"Ayya! If you do not wish to give that Prasadam, it's fine. Please don't scold me thus,"

"Shiva Shiva! Now why would I scold you? I am worried that this Prasadam might not be enough for your hunger. Here, take it," said the Priest and handed over the cloth bundle that held the prasadam.

Poonguzhali opened the bundle and said, "You are right, this is not enough to fill my belly. What do you have in that jar, swami? Is that water?"

“No. It is the anointed milk^[24]. I was taking it home for my child.”

“For today, let me be your child. Please be kind enough to give it to me,”

“Well. Here take it. At least, return the jar later,”

As the priest exited the temple, Poonguzhali heard an owl hoot near the temple.

“Ayya! What’s that sound?”

“Don’t you know? That’s the owl hooting. There is no dearth of owls in Kodi Karai woods but they won’t harm you,” said the priest and left.

After he disappeared, Poonguzhali went in the direction of the owl’s hoot. Weaving her way through the thicket of shrubs and wild plants, she reached the dense part of the woods and waited. And there she heard them talking. A man and a woman!

“Mandiravadi! Everybody believes that the Prince is dead. Pazhuvetarayar is distressed by the news but I don’t believe it,”



Chapter 5: Rakkammal

After Pazhuvetarayar and Parthibendran left to oversee the search for the lost Prince, Nandini stood by the beach watching the sea in silent contemplation.

“Rani Amma!” called out a voice and she turned back to find the daughter-in-law of Thyaga Vida Karayar standing there.

“Who are you?” asked Nandini

“I am Rakkammal,”

“What do you want?”

Instead of replying to Nandini, Rakkammal stared at her face with a strange expression.

“What are you looking at? Is something wrong with my face?”

“Forgive me amma! I was reminded of somebody else when I see your face. But that can’t be so,”

“What are you saying?”

“No, that’s not possible. There can be no relation between that mad mute woman and yourself,”

“Who is that mad mute woman?”

“There is a woman in Ilangai. She is my father-in-law’s uncle’s daughter. Sometimes she would come here too,”

“Why are you reminded of her when you see me?”

“There can be no relation as far as I can see but you do resemble her,”

“Rakkammal! Where is that woman now?”

“In Ilangai, I suppose. She comes rarely here but like I said there can be no relation,”

“Why are you so sure?”

“Rani! You are from Pandya Kingdom, aren’t you?”

“Yes, and you?”

“I too am from Pandya Kingdom. But the mute woman is from Chola Kingdom, therefore...”

“No matter; there are many others who have told me about her. If you happen to see her again, bring her to me. If you do, I will reward you amply,”

“Rani! It would be impossible to bring her anywhere. She is like a ‘storm’. She will not listen to anybody and nor stay in one place. She has lost her senses and is mad...”

“Fine. Be that as it may. Why are you here now?”

“Rani! A few days ago, some people came here on a royal errand from you,”

“Did they say my name?”

“Yes. They said that you had sent them on an important task and that they have to go to Illangai. I sent my husband along with them to ferry them across the sea,”

“Is he back?”

“No. That’s why I am worried. What if he was caught in the storm...”

“Don’t worry. Nothing would have happened to him. If at all something unfortunate has occurred, I will look after you. What about the people who went with your husband? Do you know anything?”

“They have come back. Didn’t you hear that owl’s call a little while ago?”

“I heard but what of it?”

“Didn’t you recognize it as Mandiravadi’s voice?”

“How do you know about him? Are you one of them?”

“Yes Rani!” she said and bent down to draw a secret symbol on the sand.

Nandini looked at her in surprise and asked, “Where is Mandiravadi? Do you know?”

“He is waiting to meet you.”

“Then why didn’t he come? Why wait?”

“He doesn’t wish to meet the Pallavan who was here a little while ago. He has met him in Illangai it seems. And he doesn’t wish to meet your husband either,”

“Did you meet him?”

“Yes. I heard the owl’s call and went into the woods. He sent me here to bring you to him. He is waiting near Kuzhagar temple,”

“But how could I go? What will I tell my husband?”

“Tell him that you are visiting the temple,”

“That’s a good idea. Should I bring an escort?”

“Not necessary but if you wish I will send Senthana Amuthan along with you,”

“Who is he?”

“He is the son of Thanjavur mute woman,”

“Shiva Shiva! How many mute women are around here?”

“Our family is cursed. Some are born mute, while some remain mute despite the gift of speech, like my husband,”

“Does that Ilangai mute woman have children?”

“I heard that she had once given birth to twin children but no one knows what happened to them. I tried to find out the secret but in vain,”

“Why is Senthana Amuthan here?”

“He has come in search of Poonguzhali, his uncle’s daughter. She is not here, so he is waiting for her,”

“Where has she gone?”

“I meant to tell you about her. Two people came here right after my husband left with Mandiravadi. One of them wanted to go to Ilangai but some Pazhuvur soldiers came here to capture him but

Poonguzhali helped him to escape and she took him in her boat to Ilangai,”

“Does she know to ply a boat?”

“That’s how she makes her living. When she is not in the sea, she is normally found roaming around the beach or the woods. There isn’t a nook in the woods that she hasn’t explored,”

“If she hasn’t come back so long, what do you think could have happened to her?”

“The whole of Kodi Karai is searching for someone who is lost at sea but I am not so sure about it, not until Poonguzhali comes back,”

“What if Poonguzhali too had drowned in that storm?”

“She will not drown. The sea is but a cradle for her. Moreover...”

“Moreover what?”

“I was atop the lighthouse a little while ago, and I saw a small boat approaching the beach...”

“And then?”

“But it didn’t come,”

“What do you think happened to it?”

“I think the boat might not have approached the beach because of the crowd. They might have taken it towards the backwaters...”

“Is that possible?”

“Nothing is impossible for Poonguzhali. Senthana Amuthan was with me in the lighthouse and he too thought the same,”

“Fine. Let’s then go to Kuzhagar temple,”

“Shall I call Senthana Amuthan?”

“No. Let him search for his uncle’s daughter,”

Both walked through the beach and entered the woods. Rakkammal too was very familiar with the quicksands that abound the woods *of* Kodi Karai and she guided Nandini around them carefully.

When they reach the Kuzhagar temple, the priest was very surprised. “Rani! What’s this? How could you come alone so far? Where are the guards? If you had only told me earlier, I would have made arrangements to welcome you in a more befitting manner!”

“I fear that wouldn’t be appropriate battarey^[25]! A great mishap has befallen the Chola Kingdom. The most beloved Prince of the Cholas is lost in the sea. I came here to pray for his safety,”

“Do not worry Rani! The Samudra Rajan will not harm the Prince, I am sure of it,”

“How are you so sure about this?”

“The Prince’s horoscope has many favourable planets and stars. He was born to rule this world and not even the Samudra Rajan can dare to drown him. He would come back safe,”

Saying thus, the priest showed the Aarathi to Kuzhagar and brought out the holy flame for Nandini.

“Amma! I am very pleased to see you living such a noble life with your Lord Husband,”

“Did you know me, before I got married battarey?”

“Yes, Amma! I have seen you many times in Pazhaiaarai and later near the Vaigai river island temple. Your brother Thirumalai, how is he faring these days?”

“He goes around from one place to around singing the divine verses of Azhwars. I haven’t seen him in a long while,”

“He too is pained by the fact that you haven’t met him since your marriage. The last time I saw him, he spoke about it with great sorrow,”

“What can I do ayya? My lord husband’s family are staunch Saivars. Thirumalai is a Veera Vaishnavan who bears the name ‘Azhwarkadiyan’. He goes around challenging the Saivars for debates and indulges in skirmishes. How can I claim him as my brother when he acts thus? My Lord Husband’s noble family name will be shamed by his actions,”

“Very true Amma! It is your duty to act in a manner that pleases your husband’s family. Azhwarkadiyan can go to hell,”

Nandini then took her leave after brushing aside his concerns for her safety.

“Amma! You are leaving alone. If you could tarry for a while, I can escort you back,”

“That wouldn’t be necessary Ayya! You need not hurry through your daily chores just for our sake. I will be quite safe. This woman knows her way through the woods and will guide me safely. Moreover, today Kodikarai is overrun by Pazhuvur soldiers who are guarding the beach. I have no fear. I will take your leave now,”

They both then came out of the temple and then headed towards the woods again. Rakkammal led Nandini through the dense forest by holding her hand carefully and soon they were near the canal.



Chapter 6: Poonguzhali's panic

Hidden behind the bushes, Poonguzhali could hear most of the conversation between Nandini and Mandiravadi. Nandini told Mandiravadi that she didn't believe his assertion that the Prince was lost to the sea.

"Rani! You have never really believed me completely and nor do you have any faith in my powers! What makes you doubt my words?"

"Have you not heard about the Prince's wonderful horoscope? The Kuzhagar temple priest too mentioned it a little while ago,"

"That's utter rubbish! My magic holds more power than all the stars and planets put together. Don't you know that it was 'I' who conjured the fierce storm on a placid sea? That spy from Kanchi didn't believe it at first but when he sank in the sea, he must have believed it,"

"Did you see him sinking?"

"I saw his ship catch fire from the lightning. Isn't that enough?"

"But the Prince jumped into the sea to save him..."

"Did he return?"

"No, he didn't return to the Pallavan's ship,"

"Then why fear? We have given the blood sacrifice of two enemies at the same time. I left Vandiya Devan alive on the ship just so that

Prince could risk his life saving him,”

“No matter what you tell me, I still can’t believe it. My intuition tells me that they are still alive. Do you know Poonguzhali?”

“I know her very well. She was a hindrance to us at Ilangai. She too might have perished in the storm,”

“I don’t believe so. A few hours ago, Rakkammal spotted a boat approaching the shores but it disappeared suddenly. She thought that there were two or three people in the boat,”

“If that is so, then you leave this place immediately along with the old man. I will take care of this matter,”

“How would it matter if we were there?”

“If the old man lingers here, he would want to welcome the Prince and take him safely to Thanjavur and all over plans would turn to dust,”

“Mandiravadi! Is there any necessity for the Prince to die? Now that everybody has agreed to crown Madhuranthakan...”

“Rani! Don’t be fickle-minded like other ordinary women. That Kanchi spy knows all our secrets. If he had survived the storm along with the Prince, he would have told him about us. Before the dawn breaks, you leave this place with the old man. Rakkammal! If Poonguzhali brings the Prince and the spy, where do you think she would hide them?”

“There is a hidden mandapam in the middle of the forest. That’s her secret home. That’s where she hid the Kanchi spy for a whole day before rowing him to Ilangai in the dead of the night. I found about it later,”

“That’s good. I know where this hidden mandapam is. I will await them there. Rani! How is Chakravarthy^[26]? Have you had any news?”

“Which Chakravarthy are you referring to?”

“I will never call that sick old man Sundara Chozhan as ‘Chakravarthy’. I am asking about our ‘Chakravarthy’.

“I heard that he is well about ten days ago. Aha! It’s been so long since I saw him!”

“Fine. I think it’s best you leave now. What are you going to do with that foolish Pallavan?”

“We are taking him to Thanjavur along with us,”

“Be very careful with him,”

“There is nothing to worry about. He would move the earth and the sky to satisfy my merest whim!”

“Even then, it would be wise to be careful. Remember how that Kanchi spy fooled you,”

“That’s true. That’s why I wish to see him again, alive...”

“There is no point in wishing for something that’s not possible, Rani!”

Talking thus, they began to move away. Poonguzhali hid behind the bushes with bated breath. Thankfully, they didn’t turn in her direction and left.

After hearing the secret conversation between Nandini and Mandiravadi, Poonguzhali’s heart panicked. Her limbs trembled when she realized the dangers that her beloved Prince was facing. With her throat dry from fear, she wanted to leave her hiding place

immediately and warn Vandiya Devan. She immediately started walking in the direction of the boat.

With the Prince lying senseless in the grips of a shivering fever she felt danger closing in from all directions. On one side, Pazhuvetarayar's men were waiting to arrest him and on the other assassins are at hand to kill him. If that were not enough that beautiful enchantress Pazhuvur Rani is at hand helping them! Parthibendra Pallavan who was against her too has turned into her puppet and the one hiding place that she had considered safe for the Prince, has been discovered by the enemies.

Poonguzhali realized that it was up to her to save the Prince and Vandiya Devan from the Pazhuvur soldiers and the murderous assassins that Nandini had unleashed upon them. Confused and claustrophobic in the woods that she had known since her childhood she felt an unusual fear of losing her way through the forest. She felt as though she was walking in circles in the forest.

What if this Mandiravadi reaches the hidden mandapam before she could get there? No! No! I am going in the right direction. There is a canal where I had left my boat.

When she reached the canal, her heart stopped beating for a second because the boat wasn't there and neither was the Prince nor his friend!

Did the Pazhuvur soldiers come here during her absence and take them, prisoners? Even if they imprisoned the Prince it wouldn't be so bad but what if the Mandiravadi had found and killed them! What if Vandiya Devan had taken the Prince to the hidden mandapam only to encounter that magician?

She immediately turned on her heels and ran in the direction of the mandapam. Yet again she was plagued by the same old fear - of losing her way through the woods.

Aha! What's that sound? It sounds as if someone was following her. Who could that be? Could it be that Mandiravadi? If that were so, why should I fear until I have my dagger here?

But her legs refused to stop and she ran through the woods. This wasn't the time to engage in idle fights. Not when her beloved Prince's life was at stake. If something were to happen to her, what would happen to the Prince! Vandiya Devan too had warned her about it.

I need to save my life so that I can save the Prince's...

As Poonguzhali ran through the woods, her pursuer didn't stop. He came after her relentlessly. As she ran, the flock of birds returned to their nests rose up in alarm at the unusual disturbance. Wolves and deer too ran away from her path, sensing danger.

Soon Poonguzhali's alarm and panic subsided and gave way to a temper. She took out her dagger and resolved to confront the danger that was following her!



Chapter 7: A song in the woods!

When Poonguzhali stopped running and turned around, a song was heard in the woods, “*Ponnaar Meniyaane! Puli Thol araikasithu....*”

Startled, Poonguzhali realized that the voice belonged to Senthana Amuthan and laughed out loud at her unfounded fears. She also forgot that her pursuer was coming from a different direction.

“Athaan^[27]! Is that you?”

“Yes. Poonguzhali!”

“Where are you? Come hither!”

“Here I am,” said Senthana Amuthan and came out of the woods to the clearing.

“You frightened me out of my wits! Why did you follow me?”

“Poonguzhali! I came all the way from Thanjavur just to hear that divine voice of yours. It’s been many days since I have been here but there was no sign of you, so I waited. Today, I saw you in the woods and started following you but you kept running away. Why did you run? Now that you are here, why don’t you sing a song...”

“You have picked a nice place to request a song and a perfect moment too!”

“If you do not sing then I will. It will be a song that would rouse all the sleeping animals in these woods...”

“Pitha! Piraichudi...”

“Athaan! Please stop...”

“Will you sing then?” he asked in a loud voice and then whispered, “Poonguzhali! It wasn’t ‘I’ but a stranger who was following you and I came behind you to warn you and that’s why I sang aloud. This stranger and your sister-in-law had some secret conversation in the evening. Do you perchance know who he is?”

Then in a loud voice, he said, “What do you say? Will you sing at all or shall I sing? Lord Shiva danced on the graveyard of skulls and you hesitate to sing in the woods!”

“I will sing Athaan! Don’t be angry with me,” said Poonguzhali and sang a song.

Parakkum em killaikaal! Paadum em Puvaikaal!

After singing the song, Poonguzhali whispered to Senthan Amuthan, “Amutha! How did you know that I had come back?”

“I saw your boat from the lighthouse and guessed that it might be you so I came to the woods hoping to meet you. I also saw a few Pazhuvur soldiers coming this way but thankfully they left and I met my friend Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan and the Prince. I warned him about the Pazhuvur soldiers and then we both carried the Prince to the hidden mandapam,”

“Ayyo! Why did you do that? What happened to my boat?”

“We didn’t want the soldiers to wonder whose it was if they came back so we drowned it in the canal water.” And then in a loud voice,

he said, “Poonguzhali! Why have you stopped singing? Sing that song again!”

“I have forgotten the rest of the song, Athaan! But isn’t there a song about the woods of Kodikarai. Do you know that song?”

“Yes. I remember it,” he said and sang a song loudly...

*Kadithai Kattru Vaduthetru Karaimel
Kudithanaile erunthal Kutramamo?*

After Senthana Amuthan finished the song, Poonguzhali whispered to him, “*Athaan!* Did that stranger who was following me leave or is he hidden close by?”

“I haven’t heard any footsteps after we came here. I assume that he is hidden somewhere close by and is watching us. Do you know who he is?”

Poonguzhali loudly said, “Of course I do. You are asking about the song where Sundarar [\[28\]](#) describes the owls that live in Kodikarai woods,”

“Kaatin Migavaal edhu Karikaiyanchangu!

After the song, she said, “Isn’t it strange Amutha? The owls of the Kodikarai are still the same after so many years. But do you know what is even more strange? Sometimes human beings hoot like an owl in these woods. I heard it a little while ago. Would you perchance know who that might be? Let us see if I can hoot like an owl!” said Poonguzhali and hooted thrice.

“I can’t believe this. That sound was just like an owl’s. Your honeyed voice was meant for beautiful divine songs of Appar, Sambandar... Where did you learn to hoot like this?”

“I learnt it from a ‘Mandiravadi’ Amutha! He told me once that if a magic spell needs to work, one needs to hoot like an owl.”

“So, you know how to work magic spells?”

“I know a few things. Would you care to test them?”

“How do I test it?”

“I will tell you. Thanks to my magical skills, I now know that there is someone hiding in these woods watching us. Why don’t you search around and you will know that I am telling the truth?”

Right after Poonguzhali said that a man stood up from behind the thick bushes and came towards them laughing uproariously.

“Girl! I knew that you were very intelligent but never knew that you were good at magical arts,”

“You scoundrel! So, it is you?”

“Girl! Do you truly know who I am?”

“It was ‘you’ who tried to kill the Prince in Ilangai. When you failed at that you invoked a terrible storm in the middle of the sea and drowned my dear prince and his friend,”

“How do you know that they died? Did you see?”

“I saw their bodies washed ashore. I buried them in Boodha Theevu and came back here. May a thunder fall upon your cursed magic!”

“Girl! Don’t try to fool me. Didn’t you save them from the raging sea with your counter magical spell?”

“Ayyo! How did you know that?”

“This Ravidasan can scent a lie within a hundred yards. I have eyes behind every little tree and shrub in this kingdom and I can sniff out a secret with the strength of my magic,”

As he spoke, Ravidasan stepped forward towards them and his red-rimmed eyes were brimming with hate and anger.

“You girl! Tell the truth or I will invoke evil spirits upon you. *Om! Hreem! Hreem! Hasht!*”

Shivering with fear Poonguzhali tightly clutched Senthana Amuthan’s hands and whispered, “I am going to run now. Try to stop him from following me,” and then she said loudly, “I beg you, don’t do anything to me. I will show you where they are hiding,”

And then she started walking in a direction that would take them away from the hidden mandapam.

When the Mandiravadi tried to follow her Senthana Amuthan tried to stop him from behind. Poonguzhali started running and Mandiravadi pushed Senthana Amuthan down and ran after her. Poonguzhali ran fast enough and soon it became evident to the *Mandiravadi* that it would be impossible to catch her. Just when he was about to give up, she would wait for him to catch up and then start running again.

While Poonguzhali lured the *Mandiravadi* away from the hidden mandapam, Senthana Amuthan ran after them stumbling all the way. He wanted to go to the hidden mandapam and warn his friend but he couldn’t leave Poonguzhali alone with the Mandiravadi.

Soon Mandiravadi spotted Poonguzhali standing on a large rocky platform. As *Mandiravadi* ran towards her she turned around and beckoned him near. Huffing and puffing with rasping breath the Mandiravadi climbed on the rock with a rage that would only be satisfied if he got hold of her and delivered a few stinging slaps on her face.

“Mandiravadi! Look at my lovers!”

Mandiravadi looked at her lovers and saw the same scene that *Vandiya Devan* once saw – the swirling fire bubbles that appeared out of nowhere! Ravidasan who had seen many terrible things in life felt uneasy and a chill ran through his spine.

“Mandiravadi! You boast of knowing all about magic. Why don’t try and drive away these fire bubbles with your spells?” Poonguzhali’s words roused Ravidasan’s anger uncontrollably.

“You girl! Are you trying to fool me?”

“Why should I fool you?”

“Then why are you running away instead of showing me where the Prince is?”

“I told you that they are dead but you wouldn’t believe me. What else could I do?”

“Is the Prince truly dead? Will you swear to it?”

“See there. Do you see the comet? Don’t you know that whenever a comet appears in the sky, it claims a royal life?”

“Girl! Give me that jar. Is there any water in it? I have a thirst...”

Poonguzhali started running again and Mandiravadi lost his head in his anger and pursued her madly intent on catching and squeezing the life out of her. Poonguzhali who ran for a while looked back to see whether the Mandiravadi was pursuing her and then she abruptly stopped and moved away four paces. Mandiravadi who was close behind her didn’t stop running. He tried to turn and run after her again but it was not possible. Something was wrong with his legs. He couldn’t move them!

He looked down to see what had happened to him and found himself in a muddy sinkhole and the mud was rising over his legs. No! No! He was sinking!

Realizing his precarious position, in his panic he tried to extricate himself from the mud but it resulted in him sinking in the quicksand more!

Poonguzhali laughed at his paltry efforts and that fuelled his anger even more.

“Mandiravadi! What are you looking at? Have you got stuck in the hands of the ghost that inhabits this quicksand? Why don’t try your magic spells and free yourself?”

Trembling in fear and anger Mandiravadi shouted at her, “You scoundrel! Wretched woman! This is your work!”

“You wanted to choke me to death, didn’t you? It’s too bad that my neck won’t be available anymore,”

Ravidasan took a deep breath controlled his anger and then tried to pacify her, “Girl! I swear on the God I will not hurt you. Please help me. Give me your hand,”

Poonguzhali laughed again and said, “I can’t give you a hand here. Why don’t you call those evil spirits that you wished to unleash on me?”

The mud had reached Ravidasan’s thighs by now and he was fast sinking within the unfathomable depths of the quicksand. He tried to catch a shrub that grew near the edge of the quicksand and tried to hoist himself up but he couldn’t move his legs.

“Girl! I beg you. Please save me,”

Just then Senthan Amuthan reached the place and saw Ravidasan's predicament.

Poonguzhali turned towards him and said, "Come, let's go."

"Ayyo! What about him? Do we just leave him here?"

"Why? Do you wish to wait until he drowns in the quicksand?"

"No! No! If I leave him here, I will dream about this all my life. Let us save him and then be on our way,"

"Athaan! He tried to kill me,"

"God will punish him for his sins but let us save him,"

"If you feel that way, give me your upper garment,"

Amuthan removed his upper garment and Poonguzhali tied it to a shrub nearby and gave the other end to the Mandiravadi.

"Mandiravadi! Hold the other end of this garment tightly but don't try to pull yourself out. You will only uproot this shrub if you do that. Wait until someone passes by this way and they will save you,"

"Ayyo! You are leaving me here in this quicksand for the night. You might as well kill me instead,"

Poonguzhali turned around ignoring his pleas and took Senthan Amuthan's hand and walked away dragging him. They could hear his cries and shouts until they reached the other end of the forest.

"Athaan! You came here at the right time. How did you do it?"

"After the dungeon prison experience, I didn't want to stay in Thanjavur. Every other day Pazhuvur soldiers and spies came to my doorstep. I, therefore, went to Pazhaiaarai and met Princess

Kundavai and she sent me here. She wants the Prince to go to Nagapattinam Choodamani Viharam as there are many dangers lurking here. She sent me here with this message for Vandiya Devan. Moreover, I too wished to see you and hear your beautiful voice, so I offered to come here...”

“You couldn’t have found a better time to listen to my song. But the Princess is right. The Prince is surrounded by dangerous assassins and if that were not enough, he is suffering from the shivering fever as well,”

“Yes. I saw. We found it very difficult to take him from the boat to the hidden mandapam. But don’t worry about him. The Buddha Bikshus of Choodamani Viharam are well known for their skills in medicine. They will soon cure the Prince,”

“How do we take him to Nagapattinam?”

“We can take him in the boat through the canal,”

“But you have drowned the boat in the canal,”

“We can always take it out of the water,”

“Then it is better if we start right away but all of us can’t travel in that small boat,”

“Not all of us will be going by boat. My friend and I have discussed this. Vandiya Devan will be going to Pazhaiaarai from here while you and I can take the Prince to Nagapattinam on the boat,”

Poonguzhali was thrilled. She would be with the Prince until they reached Nagapattinam!

When they reached the hidden mandapam, Senthana Amuthan clapped his hands loudly.

“Who is it?” asked Vandiya Devan loudly.

“It’s me, Senthana.”

“Who else?”

“And my uncle’s daughter,”

Vandiya Devan looked over the dilapidated wall and asked, “Are you sure you are alone?”

“Why do you ask?”

“Speak softly. The Prince is sleeping. There was someone here some time ago and I looked over the wall thinking that it was ‘you’. But it seemed like Mandiravadi”

“And then?”

“And then you both started singing in the woods and I thought that you had picked a great moment to sing! Thankfully, mandiravadi too thought the same and left. Did you see him?”

“Yes, we did,”

“What did you do him?”

“I didn’t do anything but she sank him up to his thighs in the quicksand and came away,”

“I heard her song too,”

“Yes. Even Poonguzhali sang a song,”

“The Prince woke up to her song and asked, ‘Who is singing?’ and I said, ‘The boat girl’ and then he slept again listening to it,”

“She didn’t merely sing a song, she also hooted like an owl. Didn’t you hear?”

“I heard that too and I thought that something wonderful was happening. I thought that you lovebirds were celebrating the spring festival in the woods,”

“Why are we talking uselessly here?”

“What else to do? We have to somehow while away the hours until dawn,”

“No. Let us leave right away. If we stay here until dawn, we will not survive,”

Just then they heard the howl of wolves and a lone owl hooting in the midst. Senthana Amuthan shivered with fear as the scene unfolded in his mind’s eyes. Mandiravadi buried up to his neck and the menacing wolves nearing him from all directions while he tried to drive them away with the owl’s hoot.

Vandiyā Devan and Senthana Amuthan lifted the Prince carefully and took him out of the hidden mandapam while Poonguzhali followed them. When they reached the canal banks the moon had risen in the woods. They laid the Prince under a tree and Poonguzhali sat down near him while Vandiyā Devan and Senthana Amuthan dived in the water to retrieve the sunken boat.

The Prince opened his eyes and said, “I am thirsty...”

Poonguzhali opened the vessel that she had brought from the temple priest and fed the Prince some milk.

After drinking the milk, the Prince said, “Poonguzhali! Is that really you? I thought that you were some *apsara* feeding me nectar in the heavens!”



Chapter 8: Oh God! Ghost!

Night-blooming flowers fell upon Poonguzhali's beautiful face from atop while the divine music played in heaven. Poonguzhali's veins hummed with music when she heard the Prince's words!

"My Prince! I am not an apsara or a heavenly damsel. I am a poor boat girl and I didn't give you nectar. I gave you the milk that I got from the temple priest of Kuzhagar temple,"

"I will not believe that you are not a heavenly damsel. Aren't you the daughter of Lord Varuna himself? Samudra Kumari! How many times are you going to save my life? How will repay this debt?"

"Ayya! If you would allow this poor boat girl to be with you for one more day and night..."

"How is that possible? I have to leave for Pazhaiaarai immediately?"

"No. We have received word to take you to Nagapattinam,"

"From whom?"

"From Princess Kundavai"

"Who is that other man along with Vandiya Devan, dragging the boat?"

“My cousin Senthana Amuthan. Princess Kundavai sent him here. It was ‘he’ who had brought her message asking us to take you to Nagapattinam Choodamani Buddha Viharam,”

“*Aha!* Has my sister changed her mind about crowning me? I have always wanted to visit Nagapattinam Choodamani Viharam. I will join their Sangam and become a Buddha Bikshu. I will travel around the world and go all the way to China. *Aha!* My fortunes have changed indeed. Poonguzhali! Come let’s go,” said the Prince and tried to stand.

Poonguzhali then knew that the Prince had not regained his full consciousness and was still in the grip of the fever. Just then, they faintly heard the wail of a man.

The Prince immediately turned around, “Poonguzhali! What was that?”

“It’s an owl, My Prince!”

“No! That’s a man’s voice and he is in some danger. Let us go save him right away. I want to do a good deed before joining the Buddha Sangam,” shouted the Prince and tried to run and fainted while attempting it. Poonguzhali who was right behind him held him in her arms.

Senthana Amuthan and Vandiya Devan came running and helped her carry the Prince back to the boat. Poonguzhali started to ply the overloaded boat through the canal.

“Poonguzhali! It would be difficult to row this small boat with four of us sitting inside. I think it would be better if I take my leave now. It is up to you two to take the Prince to Nagapattinam safely. I don’t have to tell you anything more as you do know the gravity of the situation,”

As he spoke, his voice was tinged with emotion and worry and his eyes were filled with tears.

“Why don’t you leave after we are past the woods of Kodi Karai? I left my horse there for you,” said Senthana Amuthan

“No. I would rather get down here myself. I will sleep in Kuzhagar temple for a while and find my way out of the woods before dawn breaks. It would be tough to travel all the way to Pazhaiaarai otherwise. God knows, how many obstacles are there on the way!”

Poonguzhali took out the bundle of food that she had taken from the temple priest and held it to him, “Here! Take this. Kuzhagar temple prasadam,”

“You both haven’t eaten anything you should keep the food.”

“Once we are past these woods, there are many villages on our way. Either Senthana or I can go there and get some food for us. But you have to travel without being spotted by anyone. Take the food,”

“Don’t forget that you have the Prince in your boat!”

“Who will believe that this small boat would carry the Prince of the realm? Don’t worry about us. We will take care of him. It’s our responsibility now,”

“Alright! I will get down here,”

Just then, they heard the wail of the man yet again. The Prince opened his eyes and exclaimed, “Who was that?” and then slept off again.

Poonguzhali stood up and said, “No. I can’t do this. If the Prince comes to know he would never forgive me. Take care of the boat for a little while. I will pull that Mandiravadi out of that quicksand and come back. It is close by, I should be back soon,”

“If you are going, I will come along with you. I will not leave you alone with that scoundrel,” said Senthana Amuthan

“No Amutha, you stay in the boat and take care of the Prince. I will go with Poonguzhali. I have some unfinished business with that Mandiravadi!” said Vandiya Devan and ran after Poonguzhali.

Poonguzhali could imagine the horrific scene that would unfold at the quicksand. Mandiravadi buried to his chest in the mud trying to fend off the wolves that would surround him. She could almost hear the Prince’s angry voice berating her, “Woman! You are a vile murderess!” These thoughts gave much speed to her legs and she literally ran through the woods to the quicksand.

But Mandiravadi was not there! Vandiya Devan who came behind her was equally shocked.

“Maybe, it was a different quicksand. I remember you telling me that there are many quicksands in this region,”

Poonguzhali silently pointed to the shrub nearby, where Senthana’s upper cloth was still tied.

“You think he might have drowned in this. Impossible! It is very difficult to kill Ravidasan. He has a hundred lives. He would have escaped somehow!” said Vandiya Devan and removed Senthana’s upper cloth from the shrub. Though he had tried to console Poonguzhali, he was sure that the Mandiravadi was dead and felt that he deserved a nasty horrific end such as this.

They both had realized that there was nothing more to do but to make their way back to the canal. As they walked back, they spotted two figures behind a tree near the canal path. One of them was a female and the other, a male.

Poonguzhali pointed them to Vandiya Devan.

“Who do you think it is?” whispered Vandiya Devan

“The woman is my sister-in-law and the man is Mandiravadi! Looks like she came here and rescued him from the quicksand!”

“That’s fine then,”

“That’s not fine. They are looking at the canal and might spot our boat,”

As they spoke softly the figures turned towards them and then immediately hid behind the bushes.

“It looks like they have spotted us!”

“Come with me. I have an idea and don’t be surprised by anything that I say,” said Vandiya Devan and dragged Poonguzhali near the place where Mandiravadi and Rakkammal were hiding.

“Poonguzhali! Listen to me. Mandiravadi is dead, which is a very good thing for us,”

“Ayyo! What a horrible death?”

“Why this sudden compassion after committing the murder?”

“Ayyo! Are you saying that I am responsible for his death?”

“Who else? Who tricked him into that quicksand in the first place? Suddenly you found some compassion in your heart and came here to rescue him but by then Mandiravadi succumbed to his fate. Now God alone knows whether you came to rescue him or to check whether he has drowned in the quicksand.”

“Who asked you to come after me?”

“If I hadn’t, I wouldn’t have known about the murder that you have committed. You are a vile murderess!”

“Am I a ‘murderess’ now?”

“Yes. You are. But I am not saying that I am completely innocent either. I killed the Prince by drowning him in the sea and you killed the Mandiravadi in these woods. If you keep mum about the murder that I committed, I will do the same for you,”

“It was ‘you’ who killed the Prince. Just a moment ago, you swore that you haven’t seen him!”

“I lied deliberately. There is no need to lie anymore. Do you agree to what I have to say?”

“If I refuse?”

“If you refuse, I will immediately go to Nandini Devi and tell her about the murder that you committed. There is no witness for the Prince’s murder but I witnessed the murder that you committed,”

“What will Nandini do to me?”

“Nothing much. She would just order you to be buried until neck in the ground and command an elephant to step on your pretty little head...”

“Ayyo! How horrible?”

“If you don’t care for such a fate, then do as I say,”

“What should I do?”

“There, your cousin is coming along with a boat. Get on it and go to Ilangai and stay there. You can mourn your dear dead Prince on that island,”

“Why should I go to Ilangai? Why can’t I stay here?”

“Ah! I am not a fool to allow you to stay here. You might go to Periya Pazhuvetarayar and reveal my secrets to him. The dead prince was dear to him and he might try to hunt me down for his murder. I have other errands to complete and wish to live a little while longer,”

“You scoundrel! Why did you kill the Prince? Tell me!”

“I have no shame in telling you the truth. The Prince and his sister had conspired against my master Aditya Karikalan. They tried to snatch the throne away from him. I am beholden to my master and his enemies are mine to slay. That’s why I killed the Prince,”

“You will receive just punishment for this traitorous act!”

“You don’t worry about that. Worry about yourself instead. Will you do as I say or should I...”

“Alright. Not that I have a choice in this matter anyway. The boat is coming near, I will go in that,”

“Listen to me, you should turn the boat towards the sea and go straight to Ilangai. I will be watching you from here. If you try to turn it back towards the shore again, I will know. I won’t budge from here until you leave,”

“Alright. May a hundred wolves descend upon you,” cursed Poonguzhali and got on the boat. Vandiya Devan waited at the canal banks until the boat disappeared from his line of sight.

Just then he heard the Mandiravadi’s signature horrible laugh behind him and he pretended to be frightened and ran away from the spot screaming, “Oh God! Ghost! Ghost!”



Chapter 9: Three in a boat

As the day dawned, the night flew away from the world like a reluctant lover who was withdrawing from the arms of the woman she loved. The goddess of night and darkness withdrew from the world with the same reluctance and hesitancy. As she kissed the world goodbye for one more time, one might even imagine the conversation they had. “Just a few more hours, my love and we shall meet again, tonight!” and then she moved away from her lover with many a hesitant step.

After released from the tenacious love of Goddess of night, the world cheered happily with thousand chirping birds that herald the dawn of yet another beautiful day.

The boat sailed on smoothly through the narrow canal while the flower-bearing plants that grew along the banks bloomed in the morning sun. When Poonguzhali opened her eyes, she first laid it on the handsome face of the Prince who was still asleep. She wondered

whether he was still asleep or unconscious due to the raging fever. Yet his face was radiant and peaceful, as he lay wrapped in a deep sleep.

Next to the Prince, Senthana Amuthan was plying the boat mechanically.

“Poonguzhali! Why did you wake up so early? Sleep for some more time.”

Poonguzhali smiled beautifully at her cousin and her happiness radiated through her body. Though she was born in the wild woods, the raw beauty of nature and the wilderness never failed to amaze her.

“Athaan! Will you sing a song in a ragam^[29] that signifies dawn?

“I cannot sing when a much superior singer is in front of me. You should sing.”

“But you sang in the woods yesterday!”

“I sang then to save you from that Mandiravadi but now only should sing,”

“I would love to sing but what if the Prince got disturbed?”

“I won’t get disturbed. You both can sing,” said Arulmozhi varmar and opened his eyes.

Poonguzhali bent her head shyly and smiled.

“Where is the boat going?

“We are going to Nagapattinam Choodamani Viharam,”

“Then whatever I saw and heard last night was true?”

“Yes, Ayya! This is my cousin who got the message from Princess Kundavai.”

“Tell me Amutha, what did my sister bid you to do? Did she ask the Viharam to make a Budha Bikshu out of me?”

Senthan Amuthan who was dismayed by the Prince’s question didn’t know what to answer but the Prince looked around distracted by the sudden sound of horse hooves.

“Where is my friend? Where did the warrior from the Vanar clan go?” he asked and then closed his eyes again.

Right after that Vandiya Devan appeared on the banks on a horse and Senthan Amuthan stopped the boat. Vandiya Devan alighted and came near the boat.

“No need to worry, I just came by to check whether you are fine. There is no more danger,”

“What about Mandiravadi?” asked Poonguzhali

“He doesn’t know that you are taking the Prince on this boat. He seems to have believed every word that I told,”

“Did you see him?”

“Yes, but I pretended as if I saw his ghost,”

“I have never seen anyone who could lie so much,”

“I don’t lie. I just give a free rein to my powers of imagination. How is the Prince?”

“He wakes up in the middle and speaks two words and then goes back to sleep again,”

“That is typical of this shivering fever,”

“How long will it affect him?”

“Sometimes it might ravage him for a month but thankfully the Buddha Bikshus of Choodamani Viharam are well-known for their skills in medicine. They should be able to cure him within two weeks. Poonguzhali! Be careful! I leave the Prince in your care. I don’t have much confidence in your cousin. He just needs to see a temple gopuram and he would start singing devaram and go for darshan!”

“Ever since I made your acquaintance, I have lost the desire to serve my Lord Shiva,”

“Did you lose that desire because of me or because of this girl? Tell the truth!”

Senthan Amuthan didn’t answer his question and instead asked, “Did you find the horse without any trouble?”

“The horse found me instead. This is the same horse that I left with you at Thanjavur isn’t it?”

“Yes.”

“It saw me in the dark and neighed. During my captivity with the Arab pirates, I learnt one thing Amutha! They said that every horse should be fitted with an iron shoe, like an armour. I am going to get this horse fitted with it in the first ironsmith that I see today. Anyway, I had best be on my way. I may not see you again and if the Prince asks about me, tell him that I am on my way to Pazhaiaarai and that I will send word as soon as I reach,”

The small boat resumed its journey through the canal and as they neared Nagapattinam their path became more scenic with lovely

flowers blooming on either side of the banks. Poonguzhali thought that the path towards heaven would probably look thus.

When they neared a village, Senthana Amuthan would go there to get them some food and milk for the Prince.

Whenever the Prince regained consciousness, she would stay away from him not able to meet his eyes but when he was asleep, she would sit beside him touch his forehead and muss his hair. She also enjoyed conversing with her cousin as they took turns to ply the boat and sometimes, they both would sing beautiful songs to while away the time.

Poonguzhali felt that she had spent many years in the Prince's company when she had served him. A hundred memories flitted through her mind giving way to a thousand unspoken dreams.

They journeyed through the canal for one day and night and the next day they were in Nagapattinam. One of the waterways through the canal went all the way up to Nagapattinam Choodamani Viharam. Poonguzhali took the boat through that route and they reached the rear entrance of the Viharam.

They could hear some unusual activity at the Viharam. A huge crowd of people had gathered in the front entrance and many Bikshus were seen roaming around here and there in an agitated manner. Senthana Amuthan got down from the boat saying that he would go inside to check what has happened.



Chapter 10: Choodamani Viharam

After Poompugar^[30] went under the sea, Nagapattinam became the most important seaport for the Cholas. Many merchant ships came to the beautiful land of the Cholas through the Nagapattinam port bearing precious gems and fast horses of Arabia, seeking to barter goods.

Years ago, when Sundaramurthy Nayanar came to Nagapattinam he saw rich ships helmed by the prosperous merchants bringing in their goods to the port. He described the scene in a song where he hails Nagapattinam as a port city of beautiful palaces. Nambi Aroor, yet another poet-saint too described Nagapattinam as a port, where one can procure a rare breed of a fastest Arabian horse. That's probably why Sundaramurthy Nayanar too got himself a horse instead of buying the rich wares that the merchants were peddling.

Many historical plaques have hailed this port city as the most prosperous city where merchants traded and bartered their goods. They also describe it as a city with many palaces and mandapams and the famous Choodamani Viharam.

Malay peninsula of today was known as Sri Vijaya Nadu in the olden days. Kadaram was an important city of this Kingdom and the Kings of Shailendra Vamsam ruled over Sri Vijaya Nadu for many years. Among all the kings in this lineage, Magaradwajan Choodamani Varman was well-known as a political strategist of great intelligence and his knowledge about worldly affairs was equated to the wisdom of Guru Bhagawan^[31]. The plaques of Anaimangalam^[32] compared his intelligence and acumen to the brilliance of the sun!

The son of this great king, Mara Vijayathunga Varman wanted history to remember his father's name in posterity, therefore, he built a huge Buddha Viharam at Nagapattinam and called it Choodamani Viharam. One may wonder why the Kings of Kadaram, came all the way to Nagapattinam to build a Buddha Viharam.

In those days, Nagapattinam and Sri Vijaya Nadu were engaged in trade for many long years. People who hailed from Sri Vijaya Nadu had come to Nagapattinam to trade and had subsequently settled in the port city. The Kings of Kadaram and his citizens belonged to the faith of Buddha and since a large number of his citizenry were settled in Nagapattinam he built the Choodamani Viharam for their benefit. The Chola Kings who were benevolent towards the followers of Buddha allowed the Kadaram king to build a Viharam in their land. Apart from giving them the land, the Chola Kings also gifted many grants and bestowed tax-free lands and income on the Viharam.

Later after many years when Arulmozhivarmar (Raja Raja Cholan) was crowned the king, he would bestow the entire village of Annaimangalam as a tax-free gift to the Choodamani Viharam and would inscribe this royal decree as a copper plaque for posterity. Today, these edicts can be seen at Leiden Museum in Holland and therefore they are also known as Leiden Plates.

Right from the time of Vijayalaya Chola, the kings who came after him were great devotees of Lord Shiva. King Aditya, Paranthaka Chola, Gandaradithar and others were extremely devout and built many temples and bestowed many lands and riches to their beloved God. But they were also very tolerant of people who followed other faiths and religion.

In this regard, King Sundara Chola was more benevolent than his ancestors, as he bestowed many rich grants for Buddha Viharams. Pleased by his actions, many Buddha Viharams and their principle Bikshus praised Sundara Chola's grace and magnanimity. Added to this, when they heard about Prince Arulmozhivarmar's actions in Ilangai where he had ordered his army to rebuild the dilapidated Buddha Viharams, their joy knew no bounds.

Now that we know this, we wonder what had happened at Choodamani Viharam that has agitated the peaceful Buddha Bikshus. One can hear a lot of confused gabble of voices at the

entrance of Viharam. Let us go along with Senthana Amudhan to see what is happening there.

When Senthana Amudhan entered the Viharam through the rear entrance, there was no one about, so he made his way through to the main entrance. At the public entrance of the Viharam there was a main temple of Buddha. Many devotees had gathered there holding offerings of lotus flowers, camphor and pooja plates laden with flowers of Shenbagam^[33]. But the devotees had not gone inside the temple and were instead listening intently to someone who was narrating something. Many Buddha Bikshus too had gathered around them listening to the man with their eyes filled with tears. The crowd gathered there exclaimed 'Ayyo!' even as the man continued his story.

Senthana Amudhan understood what had happened after he reached closer. The man narrating the story was one of the crew members from Pallava Parthibendran's ship. Their ship had reached Nagapattinam, a day earlier and soon after their arrival, rumours about the Prince's death had spread around the city. The head of the Viharam bid one of the crew from the ship to come so that they could learn the truth of the matter. Narrating the incidents that happened during the storm, the man completed his story with the news that the Prince had jumped into the sea to save someone.

When they heard it, everybody in the crowd started crying and shouting in anguish. The head of the Viharam, an old Bikshu started crying and streams of tears wet his ochre clothes. Anguished and in despair, the old Bikshu climbed the steps to the temple and the other Bikshus followed him. Senthana Amudhan too followed them behind but no one noticed him.

"I can't believe that this is the will of Lord Buddha. How many castles did we build in the air? Recently, when I went to Thanjavur and met the Emperor, I told him about the great deeds that his young son was doing for us in Ilangai. Princess Kundavai too was right next to them. She called me again for a private audience and told me that she

wished to open a medical clinic next to this Viharam and that she would bestow grants from her own income for the same. That was not all. She also made an important request to me. She said that there would come a time when her brother might need shelter from his enemies and that she looked upon us to provide it. She asked me whether I would be able to protect him! And I told her that I would be honoured to host the Prince as my guest and that I would protect him from any harm. What a calamity has visited upon us? The prince drowns in the sea and along with him, all our dreams have shattered. How did the Sea God dare to take away the beloved son of Cholas?”

Listening to the anguish of their leader the other Bikshus silently shed tears and silence descended upon them. Senthana Amuthan moved towards the leader thinking that now would be a good time to speak to him.

When he came forward the other Bikshus noticed him for the first time and wondered aloud as to who he was?

Senthana Amuthan addressed the leader saying, “Ayya! My name is Senthana Amuthan. I have come from Thanjavur. I wish to speak to your leader privately,”

“I keep no secrets at my Viharam. You can tell whatever you want to, in front of them,” said the old Bikshu.

“Ayya! I have come here with someone who is very unwell,”

“Who is he? What ails him? Where have you left him?”

“He is at the rear entrance,”

“How did you get there?”

“We came by the boat through the canal. He is suffering from shivering fever. I request you to...”

“Oh God! The shivering fever spreads in the air. Why did you bring him here, that too now, of all times?”

“Acharyarey! So long, I was under the impression that King Ashoka [34] belonged to the faith of Buddha. Now I know that I was not,”

“Why do you say that?”

“I once saw Ashoka stupa near Kanchi [35] and in that it was written that it is one’s prime duty to take care of the sick and infirm but here you are driving me away,”

The old Bikshu looked at his disciples and said, “Wait here, I will go with him to see this person,”

As they neared the rear entrance, the Bikshu got agitated when he saw a young woman was standing with a young man.

“How could you do this? How dare you bring a woman here? Women are prohibited from entering our Viharam, don’t you know that? That’s why we keep a separate monastery for women monks!”

After raging thus, he neared them and saw who the young man was and he stood transfixed in shock and surprise. He couldn’t speak for a while and when he did, he looked at Senthana Amuthan for confirmation, “Is it Prince Arulmozhi Varman?”

But the Prince heard him and answered instead, “Acharyarey! No! I am not a Prince. This woman and this man are trying to drive me mad. I am an ordinary man who plies the boat for a living and I asked this woman, “Will you marry me? Let us get on a boat and go far away from here,” but she is babbling something odd. She says that I was born to rule this world and that she wouldn’t marry me because she is but a mere fisher girl. She just wants me to be happy and see me succeed in life. How is this story? Now tell me who is truly mad? Me or her?”

Senthan Amuthan whispered something in the ears of the old Bikshu. He had by then realized that the Prince was in the grip of the fever and was incoherent. He remembered Kundavai Devi's request and was glad that he got the opportunity to repay the benevolence showed by the Cholas.

He turned towards the other Bikshus and said, "This boy is indeed afflicted with 'shivering fever'. If we turn him away, he would infect other people. In Ilangai, thousands of people died thanks to this fever. Take him to my personal chamber and I will oversee his treatment. If he says something inappropriate in the meanwhile, ignore it. He is not in his senses,"

Saying thus, the old Bikshu took the Prince's hand and Senthan Amuthan held his other hand and together they took him inside the Viharam.

As they took step after step, towards the Viharam door, Poonguzhali felt that the door of her desires would soon shut, never to be opened again. She would never see the Prince again in this birth.



Chapter 11: At the Ironsmith's...

Vandiya Devan rode steadily towards Pazhaiaarai without halting anywhere. He remembered the path that he had taken days ago when he was on his way to Kodi Karai, therefore, there was no need to stop anywhere. At first, he travelled through the woods but the path was arduous and his horse found it difficult to gallop through the stones and thrones that lay along.

Vallavareyan was exhausted. It had been many days since he had slept. Many a time, he found himself sliding off the horse due to weariness and lack of sleep. Despite his discomfort, he was determined to reach Pazhaiaarai with all the haste. His first duty was to inform Princess Kundavai everything and then he could give in to his weariness and sleep for hours and days...

He imagined his conversation with the Princess and the way her face would flush with happiness when he said, "I have successfully completed my mission!" Secretly smiling in anticipation, he sped his horse through the woods, intent upon the journey's conclusion.

One thought was nagging his mind for some time now. Right from the time he left Kanchi he realized that he had uttered many lies. Though he told them only when the occasion demanded it, they were nonetheless 'lies' and he felt ashamed of himself. Though he had spent very less time in the company of the Prince, he found himself much influenced by him. Until he met the Prince, he was convinced that those who worked in the political arena must know how to

handle the intrigues and the troublemakers who came along with it. He was also very sure of the fact that he ought to use any trick or lie to complete his mission successfully and thereby please the Princes who might later grant his Kingdom back. But the Prince's honesty, integrity and truthfulness had influenced him so much that he almost hated his old self and the pride that he had felt in his own ingenious tricks! He remembered the lies that he told the previous night for the Mandiravadi's benefit and worried about it.

What if somebody had heard them and repeated it to the Prince or the Princess? Princess Kundavai might not believe but nevertheless, it was a risk that horrified him in retrospect.

He made a resolution not to resort to his imagination while escaping from enemies. He resolved to tell the truth no matter what the situation demanded and handle whatever came of it, like a true warrior that the Prince would be proud of. Let that Veera Vaishnavan and Ravidasan spy for their masters.

He was sick of spying and he vowed to make his way in the world with the might of his sword. Whatever victory comes his way through his sword would be sweet enough to savour rather than indulge in spying, lying and trickery. No more lying, even if it resulted in his death!

It took him a while to notice that his horse was meandering slowly and he too had dozed off for a while. He woke with a start when the horse started limping. The horse neighed piteously unable to rest its front hoof on the ground. Vandiya Devan rubbed its neck soothingly and then got on the ground to check its hoof. A small pebble had pierced itself inside the hoof that he removed slowly. Thankfully, there was no lasting wound. He rubbed down the horse, muttering encouraging sweet words and then got on its back again. That's when he remembered yet another snippet of conversation that he heard when he was held captive in the Arab pirate ship.

“Tamil people of the south are merciless towards their horse and nor do they have any brain to speak of. They use their horses without fitting its hoof with an iron shoe. How long do they imagine that horse would survive, running barefoot?”

He thought back to this conversation and wondered at it. Soldiers wear armour while going to the battlefield to save themselves from deadly wounds but he had never heard of iron armour for the hoof of the horse! But he had heard of this practice in many other kingdoms as well. He felt that it would be worth a try to check in the next ironsmith's if they can fit his horse with an iron shoe. It might delay his journey towards Pazhaiaarai but if his horse were to become lame on the way, he had no means to reach the place, unless he stole a horse from somewhere. *Chi!* He couldn't imagine himself stooping to that level.

He turned the horse towards the king's road and came out of the woods. He resolved to avoid the woods henceforth and moreover, he doubted whether he would find anyone who knew him in these parts. If he stuck to the king's road, it would be easy to find an ironsmith too.

His surmise proved to be right. He soon sighted a village on his way through the road. What was surprising to behold was that all the homes in the village were decorated with garlands and flowers. He wondered whether Pazhuvetarayar and his entourage were expected through this way. If that was so, he thought it would be safe to pass through it fast enough before they arrive.

He spotted many villagers, womenfolk and men standing in groups and talking worriedly amongst themselves. Vandiya Devan couldn't guess what they were discussing but many of them tried to stop his horse but he galloped on...

He found an ironsmith working right outside the village. Despite his misgiving about Pazhuvetarayar's entourage on its way there, he wanted his horse to get the iron shoe. He tied his horse outside and went inside the ironsmith's house.

The ironsmith was working intently along with a small boy who minded the forge. When Vandiya Devan entered the house, he felt as though someone had hidden in the backyard but his attention was captured by the sword that the ironsmith held in his hands. It was a magnificent weapon – dangerous, sharp and beautiful. One side of it glowed like a sliver and the other side was hot fresh out of the forge glowing red with heat. The fiery beauty of the sword entranced Vandiya Devan and he thought, “This is how a sword should be!”



Chapter 12: Throw him in the fire!

The Ironsmith was intent on his work and didn't notice Vandiya Devan standing inside his house right away.

"Ayya! Who are you? What do you need? Are you in need of a sword, or perhaps a spear? Nowadays, not many come here for weapons and so I doubt if you would want any,"

"Your actions belie your words Ayya! You are asking this question, even while you are working on a sword?"

"You mean this? This was an unusual work. Someone got this old sword and wanted me to sharpen and repair it. A few years ago, when we were at war with Pandya Kingdom, I sold piles and piles of swords and spears. When our army left for Ilangai, many came here asking me to forge weapons and armours. But now, people are coming here to sell their old weapons. Did you perchance come here to sell yours?"

"No. I need my weapons for a few more years until I finish my work. After that, I would probably go from one place to another singing the divine devaram songs. I will probably sell my weapons to you then!"

"If that's so, what do you need from me now?"

"I have travelled a long way on my horse through the woods and then the King's road. I have a long way ahead before I reach my destination. I have heard that people fix an iron shoe on the horse's hoofs to protect it from going lame. Do you know how to do that?"

“Yes. I have heard that people in the Kingdom of Arabia practice such things and many people here are doing the same. I know how to do it,”

“Can you do it for my horse now?”

“I can start the work only after I finish the work in hand,”

Vandiya Devan thought for a while debating within himself the merits of waiting but ultimately his exhaustion won. He decided to rest awhile while he waited for the ironsmith to finish the work. His horse too could use some rest before they set off again.

“I will wait until you finish the work in hand,”

“Alright.”

Vandiya Devan watched the Ironsmith’s work for a while and then commented, “This sword looks magnificent and is fit to be borne and wielded by a royal prince no less. Whose sword is this, truly?”

“Appaney! At a short distance from here, there is a small lake called ‘Harishandra’”

“I have heard about it. But what of it?”

“I go to that lake very often and dunk myself in the waters,”

“Very good practice. It will surely weigh in your favour when you finally make your journey towards heaven,”

“Therefore, I have always tried not to utter falsehood and lies,”

“I have no objection to your resolution. I am not asking you to lie at all,”

“If you don’t ask me about this sword, then I wouldn’t have to lie,”

“Is that so?” thought Vandiya Devan and then said, “Ayya! I will not ask you any questions and you need not break your pledge to utter only the truth. Please start on my work fast and I will be grateful,”

The Ironsmith went back to his work silently while Vandiya Devan scrutinized him intently. He noted that the sword had a fish emblem engraved in the hilt and wondered about its significance.

Was it a mere decoration or is there a much deeper meaning attached to it?

Even while he was wondering thus, the Ironsmith kept the hilt of the sword inside the furnace and banged on the fish emblem with a hammer. Vandiya Devan realized that his intent was to hide the identity of the emblem so that no one recognizes it. He wondered why anyone would want to do that. But before he could reach any conclusion about it, he was accosted by Nidradevi (Goddess of Sleep) who started weaving her hypnotic magic over him. After escaping her clutches for many days, Vandiya Devan found himself too weak to resist and he succumbed to her allure. He fell asleep sitting down and soon stretched himself near the Ironsmith’s furnace and slept deeply.

But sadly, his sleep was not peaceful and he had many dreams. One of them was about a sword. A man comes up to the Ironsmith to get the magnificent fish emblem sword. As he handed it over, the man asks him, “What’s your price for this work?” and the Ironsmith replied, “I don’t need a fee. Let this be my gift to the Pazhuvur queen.”

“Be warned! No one should know about this. You should never take the name of Pazhuvur Elaya Rani, ever. You do know what we do to those who betray us, don’t you?”

“Why would I take her name Ayya? I will never talk about it.”

“You are talking so loudly here and this man is sleeping here. What if he hears you?”

“He is sleeping. He won’t hear it even if it thunders in here,”

“If you suspect that he knows something, throw him into your furnace and kill him,”

At the end of this conversation, Vandiya Devan dreamed that the Ironsmith and the stranger dragged him to the furnace and threw him inside the fire. After that, his dreams changed...

Vandiya Devan found himself being escorted to hell by two messengers of death sent by Yama^[36], who looked remarkably like the Pazhuvur brothers! When they arrived at Yama’s court Lord Yama’s assistant Chitragupta^[37] scrutinized Vandiya Devan’s life on earth and said, “This man is an expert in lying. I can’t count the number of lies that he has told during his lifetime!”

“No! Please! I told all those lies in royal service to serve the Prince and my Emperor. I told them to complete my mission!”

“It doesn’t matter why you told lies but the fact remains that you did. Guards! Throw him in the biggest pit of fire in hell!” said Lord Yama pronouncing his sentence.

All around him Vandiya Devan could hear voices wailing piteously. The guards dragged him near the biggest pit of fire that he had ever seen and just before he was thrown into it, Princess Kundavai arrived and said, “He told lies to complete the task that I had given him. Throw me into the fire instead of him,”

Nandini Devi too made an appearance suddenly and gave a wonderful suggestion to the guards, “Why don’t you throw both of them in the fire?”

While the guards acted on Nandini Devi's suggestion, Vandiya Devan shook himself shouting "No! Don't please!" and woke up. That's when he realized that he had been dreaming and shook his head. His dream was so vivid that he found his limbs trembling!

He shook himself awake and renewed his resolution - never to lie, no matter what the situation demands.

"Did I sleep for long?" he asked the Ironsmith

"No. Just a few hours! Do you belong to the race of Kumbhakarna [\[38\]](#) by any chance? If you sleep thus in the broad daylight, I wonder how you sleep during the night?"

"God! I have slept for long then. Have you fixed the iron shoe for my horse?"

"I am yet to do it but I wonder how useful it would be for the likes of you. You sleep so soundly! You won't even know if someone were to take your horse away,"

Irritated by his words Vandiya Devan went outside to check whether his horse was still there but it wasn't. He immediately came inside shouting, "Where is my horse?" and his hand went automatically to the hilt of his sword.

The Ironsmith calmly asked him to go to the backside where he found his horse with a small boy who was feeding it hay. "Ayya! Can you be here for a while? I need to measure the horse's hoof for the shoes,"

Vandiya Devan stood near the horse holding its rein while the boy went about his work.

"Who brought the horse here?"

"I did,"

“Why?”

“My father bid me tie it here,”

“Why did he do that?”

“Some time ago, the entourage of Periya Pazhuvetarayar passed through this road. If they had seen your horse, they would have surely taken it along with them,”

Vandiya Devan remembered the time when the Pazhuvur soldiers had mocked his horse at Thiru Narayanapuram. He felt gratitude towards the Ironsmith and his son. After the boy had measured the horse’s hoof they returned to the house.

The Ironsmith was banging on a hoof-shaped iron shoe with a hammer.

“Thank you for saving my horse from Pazhuvur soldiers,”

“It is my duty to safeguard the belongings of those who come seeking me,”

“How long has it been since the Pazhuvur entourage passed this way?”

“More than two hours. Surprisingly, you slept through the whole thing...”

“I agree that I slept through it but you still wasted so much time. You could have started my work at the very least!”

“How is that possible? Who would want to work after hearing the news that they brought? I had to harden my heart to do your work now. Where are you coming from?”

Wondering about what sort of news that could be, Vandiya Devan, said, “I am coming from Ilangai?”

The Ironsmith looked at his face for a while and then lowered his voice and said, “Did you meet Prince Arulmozhivarmar when you were there?”

Determined to stick to his resolution, Vandiya Devan answered, “Yes. I met him there.”

“When was the last time you saw him?”

“This morning,”

The Ironsmith stared back angrily at him and said, “Are you playing games with me?”

“No Ayya! I am telling the truth,”

“If that is so, then tell me, where is the Prince is right now?”

“At Nagapattinam Choodamani Viharam,”

“I have seen many liars in my life, but not the likes of you,”

Vandiya Devan could only laugh in his mind. It was indeed ironical that people believed his lies readily without any question and when he told the ‘truth’ they denounced it as a ‘lie’.

“Thambi! When did you leave Ilangai?”

“Four days ago,”

“Ah! That’s why you didn’t hear the news!”

“What news Ayya?”

“Prince Arulmozhivarmar apparently drowned in the sea,”

“What? How is that possible? Who told you?”

“Since yesterday, this rumour has been spreading around here. The village elders asked Pazhuvetarayar when he came by this way and he confirmed it. May a thunder fall upon that wily old man!”

“Why are you so angry with him?”

“This danger befell on the Prince because of him. I wouldn’t be surprised if he had hatched a plot to assassinate the Prince himself. The people here are so angry with him that they cancelled all the welcome festivities that was arranged for him,”

“Do the people love that Prince so much?”

“Of course. I am surprised that you would ask such a question. The entire village is mourning the Prince’s fate and soon the entire Kingdom will be wailing for their beloved son. How would the Emperor take such a blow? He is bedridden and sick as it is! I shudder to think what other misery might unfold in this Kingdom of ours. No wonder our elders said that sighting a comet on the sky would bring upon calamity and misery in our lives. They were right!”

Vandiya Devan wondered what could be the calamity that might befall them yet. It was a good thing that the Ironsmith didn’t believe his words. He need not lie anymore but he need not reveal the truth either.

“Thambi! What are you thinking?”

“I was thanking the God was saving me from the storm that almost killed me in the sea,”

“Is there something called ‘God’s Grace’?”

“Why do you doubt it?”

“If God was really there, why would the atrocities of Pazhuvetarayar continue thus? Why would he claim the life of our beloved Prince then?”

“Ayya! Pazhuvetarayar and his men are very powerful people. It would do you no good to talk about them thus. What if someone were to hear? Please be careful!”

“Thambi! It is ‘you’ who ought to be careful. I am talking when I am awake but you talk in your sleep, which is much more dangerous,”

“Ayyo! What did I blabber?”

“You called the Pazhuvur brothers’ messengers of Lord Yama. You called the Pazhuvur queen, many a vile name. While I do agree with you on that count but what if somebody else had heard you! While you were blabbering thus, the Pazhuvur entourage and Periya Pazhuvetarayar himself passed by this way. I got scared as to what would happen if someone were to overhear you,”

“So, what did you do?”

“I shut the door and asked my son to take your horse to the backside,”

“Did I... Did I blabber anything else?”

“You spoke many things...”

“Ayyo! What did I say?”

“You said that you tried to convince the Prince to come to Pazhaiaarai but he refused and was resolved to give himself up to Pazhuvetarayar. Thambi! That’s not all. You said many things about Princess Kundavai too. You need to be very careful,”

Vandiya Devan hung his head in shame. He had never been so mortified ever before. He wondered what he might have said about Princess Kundavai?

Could it have been something terribly inappropriate? Henceforth it would be better to bed down in the woods where no can hear him or maybe in a room with the door firmly shut.

“Thambi! How did you get stuck in the storm? How did you escape?”

“The ship that I was travelling in was struck by lightning and it sank. For many hours, I floated in the waters clutching a sail. Later, a boat girl found and saved my life,”

“Maybe the Prince too could have survived the storm that way, don’t you think?”

“With God’s grace, he might have,”

“Where did you stay last night?”

“I slept in Kuzhagar Kovil as Pazhuvur soldiers were camped in large numbers near the lighthouse and left Kodi Karai early in the morning,”

“Ah! That’s why you didn’t hear the news,”

“I thank you for telling me. I need to go to Pazhaiaarai and want to avoid travelling behind Pazhuvur entourage. Can you help me?”

“Pazhuvur entourage is going on the King’s road. If you go through Mullaarrangkarai you will reach Pazhaiaarai soon,”

“If you could hasten my work and fix the iron shoe, I can leave immediately,”

The Ironsmith hurried and started hammering the Iron shoe again. For each bang of the hammer, he said, “This is for Pazhuvetarayar, this for Chinna Pazhuvetarayar and this for Mazhavereyar and this for Sambuverayar...”

Vandiya Devan could then understand the extent of anger that people had for these noblemen.

After the iron shoe was fixed, Vandiya Devan tried to pay the Ironsmith but he refused the fee.

“I like you so I did the work for you. I don’t want any payment,”

Vandiya Devan thanked him wholeheartedly and climbed on his horse.

“Thambi! Why are you going to Pazhaiaarai?”

“Ayya! If you do not ask me this question, I wouldn’t have to lie,”

The Ironsmith laughed and said, “Thambi! You are becoming cleverer by the day but be on your guard during the night especially when you are sleeping!”

The sun had almost set when he started his journey again but thanks to the Ironsmith’s directions, he found the route that he needs to take. He looked up to see millions of stars lighting his way to Pazhaiaarai. To make the way more scenic a few fireflies came out of the bushes and his heart was filled with happiness.

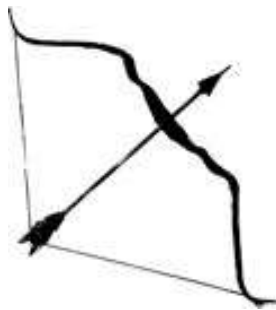
There were many reasons for feeling happy. He was happy that while the rest of the world was worried to death about Prince Arulmozhi’s disappearance in the sea, he alone knew him to be safe. He was also happy to have fooled the Mandiravadi one more time. And the thing that made him most happy was the fact that he would be seeing Princess Kundavai yet again.

He was elated by the fact that he had completed the task that she had given him. He couldn't but be proud of the fact that he had surmounted a hundred hurdles successfully to see the task done. He anticipated that he would be in Pazhaiaarai the next evening if all goes well on the way.

The stars, the gentle breeze and the cool waters of the lake reminded him of an old love song. He was alone there on the horse and there was no one to object to his singing, hence he sang. We need not guess for whom he is singing this song. But sadly, when the song got over, a pack of wolves started howling in competition.

Suddenly a voice was heard laughing uproariously. Vandiya Devan startled and scared turned, around in his horse while his hand clutched his sword's hilt. A man came out from behind a tree.

"Thambi! Your song was good but the song of the wolves was fantastic," said Devaralan and started laughing again.



Chapter 13: Poison darts

Meeting Devaralan unexpectedly startled Vandiya Devan completely. He inadvertently remembered his wild dance at the Kadambur Palace and their last conversation on the ship along with Ravidasan. He still couldn't discern the truth about Nandini but he did know that they were engaged in a murderous plot against the Chola Prince and the Emperor.

Shall I gallop this horse away from him?

Thinking thus he looked around and found that he was near a funeral ground and spotted a corpse burning at some distance.

Life is strange. This was a living man or woman once whose heart was brimming with dreams, hopes, ambitions and aspirations but in another hour or so, all that would remain, would be a mound of ash. It didn't matter whether he was a beggar or a king whilst living, one day their body would feed the fire.

As he pondered upon the vagaries of life, the fear that had gripped him earlier disappeared.

Why should I run away from him? It looks like he wishes to tell me something. Why don't I hear out what he has to say? That's when he remembered seeing Devaralan at the Ironsmith's hiding at the rear entrance when he entered the house. The fish emblem etched in the hilt of that magnificent sword made sense now. Why don't I talk to him and learn more about it?

Deciding thus, Vandiya Devan slowed down his horse. The horse too seemed a bit ungainly after fixing the iron shoe and was moving with a slow trot.

"Where did you spring from so suddenly?" he asked

"Rightfully, I should be asking you the same question. Didn't we leave you in the middle of a stormy sea, alone in a ship? How did

you escape?”

“You are not the only one who knows the mysterious arts of magic,”

“I am happy that you have so much belief in magic. I employed the same magical arts and learned that you would be travelling this way. That’s why I waited for you here,”

“Why are ‘you’ waiting here for me? What do you need from me?”

“Think carefully and you will understand, if not use those magical arts that you supposedly possess and find out,”

“You revealed your secrets to me while we were in the ship. I do not know the truth of those secrets. I have decided to forget about them and have resolved not to share it with anybody...”

“I am not worried that we shared our secrets with you. If you ever share them with anybody, that very instant your tongue would be severed and you will be mute for the rest of your life,”

Goose pimples rose on Vandiya Devan’s body as he remembered the mute women that he met in Thanjavur and Ilangai.

What do I do with him now? Why is he following me? What does he want of me? Ah! Those quicksands in Kodi karai were very convenient. If only there was one here, I could have got rid of him easily. What else can I do with him? Shall I throw him into this lake? But the lake seems half dry... What’s the use? I can always draw my sword and run him through with my blade!

“Thambi! I know what you are about. Do not waste your time with such futile plans of escape. It will not work,”

Vandiya Devan immediately changed the subject.

“Where is your friend Ravidasan?”

Devaralan laughed out aloud in his signature screechy tone and asked, "You are asking me? It is 'you' who should be telling me where Ravidasan is?"

Vandiya Devan was startled and he realized his mistake. He shouldn't have asked about Ravidasan. In all probability, Devaralan has already met Ravidasan and was pretending to the contrary.

"What thambi? Why this silence? So, you will not tell us where Ravidasan is? Is that so? Why don't you tell me where that fisherwoman is?"

With a pounding heart, Vandiya Devan remained silent lest he reveal, anything, inadvertently.

"Alright! Looks like you will not say anything about her either. I don't blame you. You might have your reasons to protect her. You sang a love song, a few moments ago... was it perchance in her memory,"

Vandiya Devan reacted immediately and said, "No!"

"Why are you so agitated?"

"Look here! Why are you holding my horse's head? Why don't you allow me to leave? I want to be on my way,"

"You haven't asked me, why I am here?"

"You haven't told me about it,"

"Did you know this Mullaiairankarai Lake fulfils the wishes of those who pass by it?"

"But I haven't wished for anything,"

“That’s a lie. The woman for whom you sang that love song of yours, is here to meet you...”

“When?”

“Tonight.”

“You are lying...”

“I am not. Look there...” pointed out Devaralan and at a distance, Vandiya Devan could see a veiled palanquin and its bearers.

Ah! That palanquin! It looks familiar. Could it be the Pazhuvur queen’s palanquin? Is Nandini waiting for me, inside?

Try as he might, he couldn’t check the urge to see her once again. He turned his horse towards the palanquin. The veils of the palanquin were moving and Vandiya Devan immediately got down from his horse and went near it. Just then Devaralan gave a guttural shriek and several men emerged from behind the trees and fell upon him at once. They held him with a vice grip that didn’t allow any escape. Moving fast, they bound his eyes, hands and legs, while one of them removed his sword and then they lifted him and dumped him inside the palanquin. The palanquin bearers immediately lifted their burden and started running, while the rest of the gang ran along with them on both sides.

While all this happened within a blink of an eye, Vandiya Devan was not only taken by surprise, he also lost the ability to think! The cloth that bound his hands and legs weren’t tight. With some effort, he knew that he could free himself. He could then jump out of the palanquin and run towards his horse that was being led by these rogues.

Even while he planned his escape, something held him back. A strange lassitude came over him and the reason for that was a

beguiling fragrance that seduced him to breathe deeply. At first, the scent gave him happiness and then it made him weak with pleasure.

Where is this palanquin taking me? Will I meet Nandini at the end of this?

The urge to see her rose high in his heart squashing the counter-arguments from his brain. Soon, desire won over logic.

What will she do to me? Or rather, what can she do to me? Why should I fear her? Let me meet her this once and learn what she wants of me? There might not be another opportunity. I can never go to Thanjavur again. It is best that we meet here...What's the harm anyway?

Yes! There is a reason to see her. That deaf and mute woman in Ilangai! She resembled Nandini! How could that be? Who was she? What's her relation to Nandini? Does Nandini know about her?

And while Vandiya Devan thought about this, his head swirled and he felt sleepy.

No! No! How could I feel sleepy? Didn't I sleep for hours at the Ironsmiths'? No, it is that smell that is intoxicating me... seducing me to sleep... This is dangerous. Why didn't I jump out of the palanquin?

Vandiya Devan tried to remove the cloth that bound his hands but found that his limbs have fallen weak. His legs felt heavy and he couldn't sit anymore and soon he laid his head down and his drowsy eyes closed soon enough.

When he regained his consciousness, he realized that he was not in the palanquin anymore. Instead, he found himself in a large spacious room, laid on an old ornate cot. Many lamps were lit across the room and here too there was a fragrance. But unlike the other scent that seduced his senses, this fragrance cleared his mind. He sat down on

the cot and held his head for a while. The door opened and he looked up eagerly.

Nandini came inside the room. Vandiya Devan stared at her in surprise. There were many reasons for his reaction. Her enigmatic beauty was one of the reasons because it defied imagination. The second reason was the fact that he met her so unexpectedly and the third was the fact that she resembled the deaf and mute woman from Ilangai, in all, except her attire and jewels.

Nandini smiled and said, “Ayya! You are indeed a good man,”

“Devi, I offer my humble salutations to you,”

“I helped you to get inside the Thanjavur fort and you left without taking my leave. I took out the palm engraved Pazhuvur ring from mine own hand and gave it to you. And this is how you repaid me? You didn’t even bother to return it to me?”

Vandiya Devan shamefacedly remained silent.

“Where is it? Why don’t you return it to me now? I don’t think it is of any use to you now. I hope you have no intention of coming to Thanjavur, anymore!”

“Devi, Budhi Vikrama Kesari forcibly took your ring from me at Ilangai. Therefore, returning it to you would have been impossible. Forgive me!”

“You allowed my ring to fall into the hands of my sworn enemy! Well, now I know that you are truly grateful!”

“I didn’t hand it over deliberately. They confiscated it from me,”

“I can’t believe that the brave scion of Vanar clan would allow himself to be taken forcibly...”

“Devi, I am in your presence now after being kidnapped by force... by your men.”

“Be truthful Ayya! Think carefully and tell me. Didn’t you have an opportunity to escape whilst you were brought here? What stopped you from jumping out of the palanquin and escaping on your horse?” she asked and searching looked at his face for truthful answers.

“I agree. I came willingly.”

“Why did you come?”

“Why did you want to see me?”

“I wanted my signet ring back,”

“Is that the only reason?”

“I wanted to know one more thing. The day we met in Thanjavur... that night... you were in the underground treasure chamber of Pazhuvur Lord? Weren’t you?”

Vandiya Devan looked startled.

“You thought that I didn’t know? I knew it all along and so did my lord husband. He commanded the guard of the chamber to kill you but I changed his order after he left. That’s how you escaped with your life that night. But your beloved friend Kandanmaran fell prey to the guard’s knife. If not for me, your bones would have been rotting in the treasure chamber today!”

Vandiya Devan was shocked beyond words but there was still a germ of suspicion in his mind as to whether she really knew about his presence at the treasure chamber or if she was making a wild guess. He felt that he owed her gratitude for helping him out of the Fort.

“Devi...” he said and hesitated.

“Don’t express gratitude for form’s sake...”

“No Devi...”

“I did not save your life that day, hoping to earn your gratitude. I mentioned it, to tell you about the fate of your beloved friend. I undertook the task of healing him and then sent him on his way. I hope you are happy about that. If not, then I will have to conclude that you are a man utterly devoid of gratitude and friendship,”

Nandini’s words hurt Vandiya Devan’s heart like poison darts. He couldn’t think of an appropriate answer for her accusations.

“You trapped that poor physician’s son and sent him back with the Pazhuvur soldiers, in your stead. Don’t you want to know what happened to him?”

“No. I thought I would ask you,”

“I will tell you, but first, you will need to tell me where Prince Arulmozhivarmar is?”

Her words cleared many of Vandiya Devan’s doubts and the reason why she met him. She was after the Prince’s whereabouts! He rallied his mind and resolved not to get caught in her web of seduction.

“My Queen! Forgive me. I am not at liberty to discuss it with you,”

“I knew that you wouldn’t reveal it to me. What about your lover? Will you tell me how she is?”

Fury rising within his heart, Vandiya Devan’s hand went to his sword hilt and he said angrily, “Careful! Whom are you talking about?”

“Aha! I will be careful. Do you think that I am referring to that arrogant Princess in Pazhaiaarai? She would never stoop to talk to poor soldiers like you. You would be treated like a speck of dirt, on her feet. I was talking about that fisherwoman who had taken you to Ilangai. Poonguzhali is your lover, isn't she?”

“No. You couldn't be more wrong about it. I have met her lovers and I am not one of them. Her lovers are the fire bubbles that form in the marshes of Kodi Karai.”

“She is lucky then. Her lovers are beings of fire, flame and light, while mine are born and shaped in the dark. They haunt the dark. Have you ever stayed in isolated mandapams within a forest? Have you seen the bats and owls, flitting away within the dark contours of the night? My lovers haunt me the same way. My heart is a place where no light can pierce and within it these beings exist, eating me away. I know not where they have come from... I know not where they go... I know not why they haunt me? Do you know why?” exclaimed Nandini. Her speech was full of pain and unknown fear.

Vandiya Devan was shocked to hear her speak thus.

“Devi, calm down... I beseech you!”

“Who are you? Why do you ask me to calm down?”

“I am a poor soldier from the clan of Vanars. Who are you, Devi?”

“You are asking, ‘who am I?’ I do not know, truly. Do you want to know, whether, I am an ordinary woman or a ghost?”

“No Devi. I think you are a heavenly damsel who has been cursed to be born here, amidst us mortals...”

“You may be right. There is a curse upon me, but I know not what it is. Who am I? What's the purpose of my birth? I know not. But God has given me something to live by,” said Nandini opened an ornate

chest next to her and withdrew a bejewelled sword studded with gemstones.

Vandiya Devan recognized the sword, as the same weapon that the Ironsmith was working on. Nandini's wild words had panicked his heart, drowning him in guilt, pain and fear. When he saw the sword, he recognized a friend. Swords and spears have been his close companion since childhood. He was not afraid of them and he knew how to counter their attacks.

“Devi, I have seen this sword. Such a magnificent blade! Only the bravest of the warriors can do justice to this weapon! Only the greatest of the Kings should bear it as his arms! How did it end up in your beautiful hands? Why would God give this to you?”



Chapter 14: A flying horse

Nandini held the sword to her heart and then kissed it lovingly but to Vandiya Devan, it seemed as though a beautiful lotus was seeking to come close to a burning furnace. Immediately after this, her facial expression changed. She now resembled Goddess Kali, who demanded a sacrifice from her devotees.

“Yes. God has given me this sword to fulfil a life’s purpose but I can’t fathom what that is. I often send this to the Ironsmith, to sharpen it. I shower it with the same care and affection that a tigress shows its cubs. I am nurturing this blade with the same love that a fierce Arab warrior shows towards his beloved horse. Just as Queen Vanamadevi is devoutly serving Sundara Chola, I too am taking care of this sword. But what does God intend for me to do with it, I know not. Its purpose is still a mystery. These hands that know only to make garlands of flowers, will they be asked to kill my vicious enemy or will I be tasked to plunge it within my mine own heart, I know not. I do know that one day, God will reveal the purpose of this sword to me. I wait, day and night for that moment to come. I stay prepared, dressed up thus, wearing beautiful ornaments and adorning myself with silks and flowers. People around me think that I love to adorn myself. Pazhuvur lord thinks that it’s because I love him. He doesn’t know the fire that the burns my heart...”

Vandiya Devan listened to Nandini's tortured speech with a dazed expression and then he asked, "Devi, where is Periya Pazhuvetarayar?"

"Why do you ask? Are you afraid of that old man?"

"No Devi, when I am not afraid of you, why would I be scared of him?"

"Aha! That's precisely why I like you. I do not know why, but people are afraid to speak their minds in my presence. My Lord Husband who bears 64 deadly scars upon his body, is frightened to voice his opinions, in front of me. My noble brother-in-law Kalanthaka Kantan trembles when he hears my voice. Prince Madhuranthakan who wishes to rule this kingdom as an 'Emperor' comes in my presence with the same devotion that he used to show his Lord Shiva. King Sundara Chola who is at the death's doorstep, loses consciousness, whenever he lays his eye upon me. Parthibendra Pallavan, of whom I have heard many stories of bravery and valour, was in my presence for a little while and now he follows me around everywhere. He has even forgotten his duty to his Prince and wants to come with me to Thanjavur. He comes near me with desire in his eyes yet he trembles in my presence.

Do you know, when I was young, I loved to watch the fire? I would long to touch it and extend my fingers towards it but I could never do it. Whenever I see Parthibendran, I remember, how I tried to play with fire. Even your own master, Prince Aditya Karikalan was for some reason, afraid of me. When we were children, he cherished and adored me, yet he was frightened of me. Ah! If only this weren't so, my life wouldn't have become so unrecognizable.

Ayya! Would you convey this message to him? Tell him, I have forgotten the past and that I am the wife of Pazhvur lord, whom he considers as his grandsire. There is no cause for him to be afraid of me. I will not harm him in any way. Will you tell him?"

“Devi, forgive me. There is no guarantee that I would go back to him alive. Even if I did, I bear many messages of great import for him. There is a possibility that I might forget to give him your message.”

“Amongst all the men, you are the only one around me who is brave. You do not utter falsehood, just to please me. You speak your heart, no matter, how bitter the truth is. Vandiya Devarey! I do not travel in a chariot or an elephant as Princess Kundavai does. I meet very few people and unfortunately, most of them are cowards who pander for my favour with meaningless words. You are the only one who doesn't hide your intentions behind the façade of love...”

“Devi, I find it difficult to hide anything in your presence, because your beautiful eyes are sharp enough to unearth the truth of my heart,”

“You might be right, but so far I have failed to divine your heart's secrets. You asked about Pazhvur Lord, didn't you? He has gone along with Parthibendran to a nearby village to watch Kannagi Koothu and they plan to ask the temple priests about the fate of the lost prince. Poor men, they didn't know that they would have found all the answers to their questions if only, they had caught you. It will be past dawn before they come back. Ayya! Let me ask you again. You do know the truth about the Prince's fate, won't you tell me about it?”

“No Devi, I cannot reveal it to you. Ironically, I had decided today, not to lie about anything. I cannot tell you anything about the lost Prince. I forgot my resolution a few moments ago...” he said and handed over the Palm Signet ring that Nandini had given him, all those days ago.

“Devi, here is the palm signet ring that you gave me. It is true that Kodumbalur Commander's men took the ring from me but Budhi Vikrama Kesari returned it to me later. Kindly accept this with my heartfelt gratitude. I am truly grateful to you,” he said and held the ring in his outstretched hands.

Nandini looked at it intently for a while and then said, “Ayya! You can keep it as my gift. I was testing your truthfulness and you have passed it.”

“Devi, Are you sure about this? If I kept it, I might be tempted to use it again,”

“I am not worried about that. Use it in any way, you choose. I shall now ask my guards to take you back to the place, where they captured you,”

“And if I refuse...”

“If you refuse, you will be trapped in this ancient fort, forever. You cannot leave this place without our aid,”

“Devi, whose fort is this?”

“This fort was built by the Pallavas. When the Pandya Kings captured the Chola Kingdom, they stayed in this fort. During the reign of Vijayalaya Chola, a fierce battle took place and one half of this palace was destroyed and it lies in ruins. People here call this as Pallava or Pandya fort depending on where their loyalties lie. The ruined palace is a maze and only those who are familiar with the place can hope to get out of it. What do you say? Shall I call my men to take to you back or do you wish to stumble your way out of here?”

“No Devi. I will go with your men. I do not have the time to find my way out of here. Before I leave, I wish to ask you something. Is there anything else that you perchance want from me? Can I be of assistance to you in any way?”

“I thank you for the offer. I do need your help. Would it be possible for you to procure a flying horse?”

“Flying horse?”

“Yes.”

“Do you mean the fast steeds that are bred in the Kingdom of Arabia?”

“No. I can’t ride such a horse. I want a horse that can fly with wings. I have heard many stories about such horses and I wish to have one,”

“Why do you wish for such a horse? Do you want to go to the heavens?”

“Do you believe that a sinner like ‘me’ can step into the heavens?”

“Do you think that all the people in heaven are good? People in heavens too indulge in sins and get cursed. They are sent to our world, to seek retribution for their mistakes. Once their penance is complete, they go back to heaven,”

“No. I do not wish to go to heaven. In the Pandya Kingdom, there is a place where there is no greenery. A vast stretch of land that is laid bare to the sun, with just rocks. Not even a blade of grass grows here. In these mountains, there are many caves that *Dingambara Jain Saints*^[39] once used to meditate in. Not even *Amaravathi* – the capital of the heavens can match the beauty of those mountains. That’s why I wish to go there,”

“Devi, your request is quite strange indeed,”

“If I had a flying horse, I would go to the Pandya Kingdom and then from there, I would travel to Ilangai. I have heard that there are trees that almost touch the sky in the forests there. Just as we have herds of buffalo grazing here, there are wild elephants there. I would love to see them. I have heard that there are many lands and kingdoms where mountains of frozen water exist. I have heard that when the sun rises here, these mountains would gleam with a silvery sheen. I have also heard of many kingdoms built in the deserts, where the

sand is white and soft. If I had a flying horse, I could see all these wonders...”

“Devi! It is beyond my powers to procure such a horse for you. However, I can help fulfil a few of your wishes. If the sea is calm, you can reach Ilangai, within half a day on a good boat. If you have a ship...”

“Ayya! I can’t travel by boat or a ship. I am afraid of water. My heart trembles at the very thought of it. Your ideas aren’t of much use to me. You have my leave to go,”

“Devi, is there anything else that you wish to tell me?”

“No. Do you have something to tell me?”

“I have a question, Devi. A few days ago, didn’t you come to Ilangai? Didn’t you stand on the ruined streets of Anuradhapuram, on a full moon night?”

“No. That would be impossible for me. Pazhuvur soldiers surround me at all hours. Why do you think, I was at Ilangai?”

“Devi, I saw you there. You just spoke about ‘Flying Horse’. I thought that you might have already procured one and used it to fly to Ilangai. Your appearance was however different. You wore an ordinary old sari and there were no jewels adorning you. Your hair was not bound... it was free. Tell me, were you that woman?”

“No. I am not ‘she’. Did that woman speak something to you?”

“No. She didn’t speak at all. She could only talk in signs. I thought that since you keep the company of magicians, you might have somehow gone there,”

“No.”

“Then it is quite strange that the mute woman in Ilangai resembles you greatly in every aspect,”

Nandini looked dazed and then she sighed heavily and said, “Ayya! You offered to help me, didn’t you?”

“Yes. I did.”

“Do you truly mean it?”

“I do Devi. With all my heart.”

“Then promise me that if you ever see this mute woman again, you will try to bring her to me. If that were not possible, then you should help me to meet her.”

After half an hour, Vandiya Devan was again in Mullaiarrangarai Lake with his horse next to him. Nandini’s men disappeared fast enough after they left him there.

Vandiya Devan began his interrupted journey through the lake bed on the horse. It was past midnight and on the sky, the comet was seen stretching from one end to another. He wondered if there was any truth in peoples’ beliefs about the disastrous events that would unfold when comets are sighted.

Nandini remained in his thoughts for the rest of the night. When he met her in Thanjavur for the first time, he found her not only beautiful but also distasteful. After meeting her again, he felt pity for her because he realized that she has undergone many untold sorrows in her life. He also realized that he was clueless about her intentions and her association with the Abathuthavigal^[40]. Her life was a mystery and he didn’t know anything about her past apart from what Thirumalai had told him. His mind cautioned him again and he resolved never to meet her again. He was also tempted to throw the

palm signet ring in the lake waters but something stopped him from within.

I might need it again to escape from some danger. I will get rid of it after meeting Princess Kundavai at Pazhaiaarai. I will throw the ring away and never again, will I agree to spy for anyone!

The dawn broke even while he was thinking this. Sore and tired, he tied the horse to a nearby tree and settled down for a nap.



Chapter 15: Kalamugar

The heat of the early morning sun woke Vandiya Devan with its gentle rays but he didn't get up yet. He turned on his back lazily and spotted two Kalamugars coming his way on the road. Their mated hair, trident, holy ash, garlands of skulls and unkempt appearance scared most people. Kalamugars were staunch Saivaites whose devotion to Lord Shiva was absolute.

As he watched them approach, Vandiya Devan sorely missed the one person who could stand his ground against them – Azhwarkadiyan Nambi. Unwilling to be drawn into a conversation with them, he pretended to be asleep, until they passed him by.

“Shivoham! Looks like this boy is a Kumbakarna^[41]...”

“Shivoham! If only we could get someone like him...”

“You are going by his appearance. He is a handsome boy for sure but he is of no use to us. He is going to be in grave danger, very soon,”

Vandiya Devan who was pretending to be asleep was curious to know what danger that would be but he couldn't wake up now. He hoped that they would speak elaborately about that prediction...but they didn't.

“That’s his fate. What can we do about it? Let us be on our way... come.”

The Kalamugars were a sect that branched out from the old Kapaligars. Unlike Kapaligars, the Kalamugars did not offer blood sacrifice but they retained all the other rituals practised in their parent sect. It was widely believed that Kalamugars performed rigorous meditation in the funeral grounds and gained the power of the third eye that granted them a glimpse of events to come. Many feared that their austerity gave them the power to curse. Hence Kalamugars commanded great respect and fear among the citizenry and were given royal hospitality wherever they stayed. Noblemen and chieftains gave temple grants specifically to provide food for Kapaligars. But the reigning Chola Kings were not partial to Kapaligars and didn’t patronize them.

Vandiya Devan who was aware of this didn’t bother much about the ‘grave danger’ prediction.

Let them blabber something. What sort of grave danger is going to visit upon me that I haven’t seen already?

While this is what he told himself, he didn’t acknowledge the fact that he was still curious to know what that ‘grave danger’ would indeed be.

Vandiya Devan got up and looked around casually and noted that the Kalamugars were going towards an old mandapam. Next to it, was an artificial cave with statues of lions. In the past, Jain monks meditated in those caves but now it was being occupied by Kalamugars. Vandiya Devan decided to talk to them before he could go on his way. He led his horse towards the artificial caves that were adjacent to the mandapam. Even while he was turning the bend, he could hear them talk.

“That boy wasn’t pretending to sleep. I think he was really asleep,”

“How can you be so sure about that?”

“I am yet to see another man who would placidly sleep when someone is predicting that he would be in ‘grave danger’ soon.”

“That boy looked like a good warrior. Why don’t we make him join our sect? It would be good for us.”

“Why should we worry about him when we are going to get a royal prince who might be the next king?”

“Whom are you referring to?”

“Who else but Prince Madhuranthakan? Don’t you know about that?”

“But... what about the other two?”

“One is already dead, drowned in the sea, while the other is nearing his death...”

Vandiya Devan’s desire to listen to any more conversation diminished after he heard this. He wanted to leave immediately and reach Pazhaiaarai as soon as possible. After giving his news to the Princess he would rush to Kanchi. He was indebted to Prince Aditya Karikalar more than anybody else and it was his duty to stand by him, while he was surrounded by dangers. Brash and audacious, the Crown Prince was known for courting risk and he rarely listened to anyone. That’s why it was important that he hastened to him.

Vandiya Devan mounted his horse silently and started off. He turned towards the Kalamugars and found them staring at him silently. One of them seemed a bit familiar but he didn’t care to investigate who it was.

On his way to Pazhaiaarai, Vandiya Devan saw many villages where people were thronging the streets intent on their work. It was obvious

that they haven't heard the news about Prince Arulmozhivarmar's death in the sea. He wished to reach the city and give his news to the Princess before she heard anything to the contrary from others.

What if she heard the news about Prince before I reach her? Would she believe it? No! She won't do anything foolish but the same can't be said about that Kodumbalur Princess.

This thought forced Vandiya Devan to ride his horse harder than ever but with his hoof recently shod, it was difficult to ride any faster. Two hours before the dusk, the fort walls of Pazhaiaarai were seen. He could see the guards in front of the walls and also the Durga temple that was built near it.

Now he pondered on how to enter the fort without getting arrested by the guards. He can't show the Palm Signet ring here. They would know that he has it in his possession and would immediately arrest him. He would then be taken away to await Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's pleasure and wouldn't be allowed anywhere near Kundavai.

Thinking thus, he brought the horse to a slow trot and stood near the fort walls. Just then he noticed a crowd of people coming towards the fort. Foot soldiers and bodyguards surrounded a horse-drawn chariot that was shaped like a lotus.

Aha! Who is sitting in that chariot? Isn't that Prince Madhuranthakan Devar? The same prince who had come in the veiled palanquin of Nandini Devi is now coming to the fort in a chariot.

As he watched the Prince, Vandiya Devan got an idea. He decided to test Kalamugar's statement here - "I am yet to see another man who would placidly sleep when someone is predicting that he would be in 'grave danger' soon."

He knew that he was eager to learn more about the 'grave danger' that the Kalamugar had predicted. The same could be true for others too!

Vandiya Devan immediately turned his horse towards the chariot and the Prince's guards were caught unawares. They didn't stop him until he came very close to the chariot. He stood on the stirrup of the horse and shouted, "Danger! Grave Danger!" After that, he suddenly jumped out of the horse and fell down.

The procession stopped and one-half of Madhuranthakan's guards caught Vandiya Devan's horse, while the other half tried to target him using their spears but when he fell down from the horse they laughed. The Prince too laughed out loud and then asked his guards to bring him closer to the chariot.

Vandiya Devan who would normally be incensed by the fact that someone laughed at him, seemed unconcerned about it and was staring at the Prince intently.

"You there! Bring him here," said the Prince

When Vandiya Devan was brought near the Prince, he asked, "Who are you?"

"I... I am... Don't you know me, my King?"

"What! What are you saying? Who do you think I am?" asked Madhuranthakar after bidding his guards move away.

"Who do you think I am?" repeated Madhuranthakar.

"Forgive me, Prince. I mistakenly called you a king. You are still... still..."

"Have I met you before? Have you seen me before?"

"Yes. I have seen you. No... I haven't met you."

"Have you seen me before or not? Speak the truth!"

"I have decided to speak only the truth since yesterday. That's why I am finding it difficult to say, whether, I have seen you or not,"

"Oho! so you have been speaking the truth only since yesterday is it? Good joke!" said the Prince and laughed and then asked, "If that is so, then why would you find it difficult to say whether you have seen me or not,"

"My Prince! In today's world, it is very tough to define truth. One person looks like the other. I saw someone in a veiled palanquin one day and on another day the same person is seen travelling in a chariot..."

"What did you say?" said Prince Madhuranthakan and his voice betrayed the fact that Vandiya Devan's words had shaken him up.

"I said that since one person resembles the other, it is very difficult to discern whether I have met you or not,"

"Whom do I resemble?"

"I have seen you twice or someone who resembles you very closely. I do not know whether it is you that I have seen or someone like you... that's why I tried to come close to you,"

"What did you find out? Am I the one that you have seen or nor?"

"You could be the person that I have seen or you could not?"

It was evident that Vandiya Devan's cryptic answer had enraged Prince Madhuranthakan.

"You are a vagrant... I will have you..."

"My Prince! Please don't get angry. Allow me to tell you as to where I have seen you. You can decide how to punish me, after hearing me

out.”

“Alright! Tell me where you have seen me,”

“It was a huge fort. Many great warriors have assembled there for a midnight meeting. I can see the huge oil lamps that have been lit on the walls. By its light, I can see a veiled palanquin and the warriors discussing something of import. The leader of these warriors is asked many questions and in answer, he comes near the palanquin and opens the veils. A handsome man comes out of the palanquin and smiles at the warriors who hail him victoriously. ‘Long Live the Prince!’ ‘Long Live Chakravarthy! Ayya! The handsome prince who came out of the palanquin resembled you greatly. Have I erred in any of the detail narrated to you?’”

Prince Madhuranthakan who had been listening to Vandiya Devan in rapt attention started sweating after he finished. A shadow of fear was seen in his face.

“Were you one of the warriors in that assembly that night?”

“No. I was not one of the warriors who had assembled there,”

“Then how can you describe it so accurately?”

“My Prince! I know not whether these events that I just described happened in truth or in a dream. I can describe yet another event for you. A dark underground chamber with nary a light and a pathway that takes one around and around...one needs to climb down and up many times before you reach the path. Through this pathway, I see three people. One is carrying a fire torch and the other is guarding them with a spear and in the middle, there was a handsome Prince whose beauty could only be compared to that of Manmathan^[42]. When the fire torch cast a light around the chamber, I could see huge pillars and a pit where the treasure of the world lay. Diamonds, emeralds, rubies, gold, diadems, coins and wealth of indescribable proportions! The prince who was coming through this underground

chamber resembled you greatly but whether it was 'you' or not is something that only you can confirm,"

Prince Madhuranthakan whose fear was heightened with every word that Vandiya Devan uttered said, "Enough! Stop!"

"Are you a soothsayer?"

"No. That's not my profession but I do have the sight. It shows me what has happened and what will happen in the future,"

Madhuranthakan thought for a while and said, "You shouted something while on the horse. What were you saying?"

"I said that you were in grave danger,"

"What danger?"

"Many dangers lie in your path but there is also greatness waiting for you. I cannot speak about them in the middle of the road. Take me along with you, inside the Fort, and I will read your fortune..."

"Alright! Come with me. We can speak in leisure..." said the Prince and then called the Commander of his guards and bid him include Vandiya Devan in their entourage. The Commander didn't seem very enthused by the Prince's idea to include a complete stranger in their midst but he didn't protest the command.

As they neared the Fort, the guards manning the city opened the gates and Vandiya Devan successfully entered the city.



Chapter 16: Madhuranthaka Devar

We met Prince Madhuranthakan at the beginning of this story. But we got a glimpse of him, while he was in the underground chamber in Thanjavur. It is quite unfortunate that we failed to introduce this famous prince (who would later ascend the Chola throne as Parakesari Uttama Chola^[43]) in a befitting manner to our readers. We shall take this opportunity to do so.

Before we introduce Prince Madhuranthakar to the readers, we must learn more about his ancestors. Before King Sundara Chola, his uncle King Gandharathithar ruled over the kingdom for many long years. The King and his young wife Queen Sembiyanmadevi were devout Saivaites who were keen on piety, art and architecture rather than expanding the Kingdom through war.

King Gandaradithar's one great wish was to bring all the Devaram^[44] poems written and sung by divine mystic poets under one-fold but it remained unfulfilled during his lifetime. Nonetheless, he did bring together many poems that he had heard. He was also a prolific poet who penned many poems glorifying Lord Shiva. One of his poems describes Chithambaram temple eloquently, where his father had given all the gold in the Chola treasury to gild the roof, golden for Lord Shiva.

Gandharathithar abhorred wars and had no ambition to expand the borders of Chola Kingdom. He believed that the common people were the true casualties of war and therefore, rooted for peace all through his reign. His noble intentions, notwithstanding, the might of Chola Empire declined considerably during his reign. He had married Sembiyanmadevi at an advanced age and their son Prince Madhuranthakan was an infant, when he breathed his last.

The Kingdom was undergoing turmoil during that period. His brother Aringzha Chola was grievously injured in the war and was in his deathbed. His son Prince Paranthakan (Sundara Chola) was a young warrior who had proven his might in many battles. During the final years of his reign, Gandaradithar decided to crown his nephew as the next heir apparent and decreed a will to that effect. He also wanted his Queen Sembiyanmadevi to bring up their son Madhuranthakan, as a staunch devotee of Lord Shiva, lest power and riches of the Kingdom tempt him.

Sembiyanmadevi kept her promise to her lord husband and brought up their son with devotion and piety. She tried to instill in him the deep devotion for Lord Shiva and kept him away from the affairs of the kingdom.

Prince Madhuranthakan until the age of twenty fulfilled his mother's wishes and devoted himself to the worship of Lord Shiva. He was disinterested in the affairs of the kingdom and to tell the truth, he had no inkling about the fact that he had any claim on the Chola throne.

That would change, after his wedding to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's daughter. From a shy introvert Prince, he transformed into a resentful angry young man.

Pazhuvur Queen Nandini Devi had much to do with his transformation, as did the Pazhuvur brothers. He resented the fact that Sundara Chola had ascended the throne that was due to him and that his own mother played an important role in denying him the kingship. His wishful dreams of being a king, became a raging wild

fire, when he learned that the most powerful noblemen of Chola Kingdom supported his claim. While these noblemen wished to wait for Sundara Chola's demise, the Prince was unwilling to wait that long. He believed that Sundara Chola never had any true claim to the Kingdom and that it had rightfully belonged to him in the first place.

Now that Sundara Chola was bedridden and unwell, why can't I take over the reign of the Kingdom?

The Pazhuvur brothers found it difficult to keep the Prince's desire for the kingdom in check. They feared that the Prince might do something foolish and foil all their plans to secure his succession. King Sundara Chola's sons were brave warriors who commanded much respect and love from the army and the citizens. Two powerful noblemen – Thirukovaloor Malayaman and Kodumbalur Vellar, supported the Crown Prince's claim to succession. The Pazhuvur brothers felt that Madhuranthakan should not stake a claim to the throne, while the Emperor was still alive. Therefore, they had decided to stall their plans until Sundara Chola, breathed his last.

In the meanwhile, when they learned that the Emperor himself wished to crown Madhuranthakan, instead of his own sons, they felt that an amicable solution was possible after all... If the Emperor himself wished to deny his sons the throne and crown his cousin, there was no need for any subterfuge.

Only two women were capable of opposing such a scheme – one was Princess Kundavai and the other Dowager Queen Sembiyanmadevi. It would be easy to foil Kundavai's plans but how could they counter a woman, who was highly respected and literally worshipped by the people of the kingdom.

Sembiyanmadevi has been resolutely against Madhuranthakan ascending the throne and everyone knew about it. This, they felt was a real hurdle in the path of succession and even if, Madhuranthakan were to ignore his noble mother's words, the people of this kingdom

would never forgive him for it. They felt that there were two solutions for this problem... either the Dowager Queen should breath her last, after which the Prince can pursue his heart's desire or he could try and change her mind.

And who but her beloved son can try to attempt this?

Therefore, the Pazhuvur brothers had explained all this and more to the Prince and had impressed upon him that Sembiyanmadevi's approval was of paramount importance, if his succession plans were to materialize. However, the Prince was less than enthusiastic to undertake this mission. Though, he was more than ready to take charge of the Kingdom, he hesitated to broach the subject with his mother. What more... he had no desire to meet her.

Meanwhile Sembiyanmadevi had sent him a message saying that she wished to fulfil an important wish that her lord husband had held dear to his heart and wanted her son to be present at the occasion. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar persuaded the Prince to make the journey to Pazhaiaarai accordingly. He also advised him to try and change her heart, to make her favourably disposed towards his succession to the Chola throne.



Chapter 17: Thirunaraiyur Nambi

Vandiya Devan entered Pazhaiaarai city again along with Prince Madhuranthakan's entourage. As they passed through the Chola warriors houses at Ariya Padai Veedu, Pambai Padai Veedu, Pudu Padai Veedu, Manapadai Veedu, temples and the market, Vandiya Devan noted that people didn't greet the Prince enthusiastically and nor were they curious enough to throng the streets to gawk at him. He couldn't help but compare their present reception to the excitement and delight of the people during his last visit, when they celebrated Krishna's Janmashtami^[45].

People had thronged the streets moving from one street play to another... Jostling crowds, merriment at every corner, delighted happy faces were to be seen everywhere. However today, the streets were deserted and no one came out of their houses even while the Prince's entourage and the heralds were hailing his presence, loud and clear.

It was easy to deduce from this less than tepid reception that, Madhuranthakan, was not a popular Prince in the city. Vandiya Devan was happy about the lack of crowd, as he could avoid the eyes of anybody, who might recognize him.

When the procession neared the Chola Palaces, they could see a huge crowd coming from the other end of the street. Amidst the crowd, was an open palanquin bearing a young Saivaite. As the crowd passed them, Vandiya Devan noted that the people were more enthusiastic about the young anchorite who was seated in the palanquin than their own prince!

The devout crowd passed by singing hymns, songs, playing drums and many stringed instruments. Many cheered the procession by shouting, 'Thiruchitrambalam!' 'Hara Hara Mahadeva!' "Long Live Thirunarayayur Nambi"

Prince Madhuranthakar viewed the procession with resentful eyes and then asked something about the Saivaite who just passed them by. The soldier confirmed that the Saivaite was indeed Thirunaraiyur Nambi.

"How strange? The people of this city ignore their own Prince and yet crowd around this Nambi and cheer him wildly!"

Vandiya Devan who had turned around to see the tail of the procession noted that one of the Saivars along with Thirunaraiyur Nambi seemed familiar. He resembled the Saivar who had crossed the Kollidam River along with him and Thirumalai.

The Prince's entourage proceeded ahead and they soon reached Sembiyanmadevi's Palace. The Dowager queen was waiting outside accompanied by her handmaidens and companions bearing Aarthi plates and flowers. Madhuranthakar got down from his chariot and greeted his mother by seeking her blessings. The dowager queen lifted her son and breathed the scent of his hair lovingly, and said, "My son, you have come here at a very opportune time. Thirunaraiyur Nambi has come to our city. Refresh yourself soon and come to my Sabha Mandapam."

Vandiya Devan couldn't help but note that the Prince's face lost colour, when he heard his mother speak thus.

Poor man! He thought that his mother had arranged a welcome reception for his sake at the palace and was waiting to welcome him with garlands and flowers. Instead, he found that they were waiting for the young Saivaite, whom they had just seen in the streets, he was naturally disappointed.

In Sembiyanmadevi's palace, the Prince got ready to meet Thirunaraiyur Nambi at a very slow pace. He had no interest in glorifying yet another Saivaite but his mother sent message after message, asking him to hurry up. At last, when he was ready, he asked, "Where is that soothsayer?" Vandiya Devan who was waiting impatiently to go along with him came forward and said, "I am here," The Prince took him and few other bodyguards and went to the Sabha Room.

The Sabha room was packed with people. Queen Sembiyanmadevi and Princess Kundavai sat on their seats on side, while in the center of the room, sat the young anchorite Thirunaraiyur Nambi. There were many Olai Suvadi^[46] placed before him. Next to him stood the same Pattar whom Vandiya Devan had encountered at Kollidam. Vandiya Devan's eyes roamed all through the Sabha Room and finally rested on the Princess's face. Kundavai looked surprised to see him at first but she didn't spare him a glance afterwards. It made

our hero anxious and hurt, leading him to wonder whether she had forgotten him altogether!

When the Prince entered the Sabha Room, men stood up respectfully and bowed low towards him.

Sembiyanmadevi said, “My Son! This Nambi is from Thirunaraiyur and due to the blessings of Polla Pillaiyar (Lord Ganesha) he has found a few rare Devaram hymns. Centuries ago, a Chola Princess Mangaikarasiyar became the queen of Pandya Kingdom. She invited Gyanasamandar^[47] to Madurai to debate with the Jain monks. Gyanasamandar won the debate and also sung many Devaram hymns, where he describes the glory of the queen too. We are truly fortunate to be given the opportunity to listen to these hymns. If your father had been alive, he would have been thrilled but I can only wish that you hear them instead,”

The Prince said, “I can’t wait to hear them Amma! Let the recitation begin...” Though he gave his assent thus, his mind and heart were engaged elsewhere. He loathed the fact that his mother admired young Saivars, like this boy and showered him with such respect and attention but he swallowed his words and remained patient.

He had to please his mother...

The Nambi started reading the hymns chronologically, where Gyanasamandar described the beautiful city of Madurai and praised it with many verses.

Listening to the verses intently, pearls of tears formed in Sembiyanmadevi’s eyes. She was profoundly moved by the potent words of the hymns that described Queen Mangaikarasiyar^[48]. She thought herself to be fortunate to have been married into the same family, where the erstwhile Pandya Queen was once born. While the mother thought thus, the son could only hear the hymns that described the Chola might and their glories. He found himself thinking about the Chola throne and his rights towards it.

As the Nambi continued his hymns, there came a dialogue between the Pandya Queen and Gyanasambar.

“Ayyo! This boy is so small. How can he debate with those old monks?” Gyanasambar assured the queen with sweet words that he had the blessings of his Lord and that he could defeat the Jain monks.

When Sembiyanmadevi heard these verses, she imagined herself to be Queen Mangaikarasi and the young Nambi to be Gyanasambandar and experienced a bliss that was indescribable in words.

However, Madhuranthakar inferred the same verses differently.

Yes! I am a young man, however, I will not be scared by the likes of Thirukovallur Malayaman and Kodumbalur Vellar, who support Sundara Chola's sons. I will claim my birth right and ascend the throne...

Vandiya Devan oblivious to the hymns or their inherent meaning, found himself looking at Princess Kundavai. The Princess didn't look at him and nor was there any indication that she recognized him. Vandiya Devan was sorely disappointed and crushed by her disregard. He kept wondering what could have angered her thus.

Could it be because he didn't go to her directly or could it be because she expected him to come early?

While he churned up one question after another, he was also thinking about a viable plan to meet the Princess alone.

When the recitation ended, Sembiyanmadevi told the Nambi's entourage, “Ayya! When I look at this boy, I feel as though Gyanasambandar himself has been born anew to take us on the path of devotion. I bid you to take him all through the land of Tamil

Nadu. Bring forth all the Devaram hymns sung at many temples under one-fold. Segregate the hymns sung by divine saints Appar, Gyanasambandar and Sundaramurthy and let their verses be heard in all temples. This was my Lord Husband's wish and I want to fulfil it during my lifetime. I have arranged for palanquin, men, guards and gold for your entourage to travel through the Kingdom. My son here, would get the emperor's permission for this venture,"

The dowager queen's announcement was greeted with loud cheers from the crowd gathered but Prince Madhurathakan found them extremely unpleasant.



Chapter 18: The Soothsayer

As the crowd dispersed from the Sabha Room, Sembiyanmadevi told her son, “Madhuranthaka! Do rest awhile and then come to my chambers. I will bid farewell to Nambi and his entourage and join you there. I have many important matters to discuss with you,”

“As you wish, mother.” said Madhuranthakan and withdrew to his quarters, which was just as well. He needed some time to compose himself. as his heart was brimming with anger, jealousy and resentment.

How dare she bring such pious beggars to the palace? She has no royal pride and if things were to continue thus, she would drag the glorious name of Cholas through the mud.

He felt that the Pazhuvur brothers were right about his mother’s madness.

The queen needs to see any wandering mendicant or a sanyasi and they would be brought to the Palace with great respect and treated to a royal feast... and if they were to sing hymns or talk about some temple, then she would immediately open the royal treasury for them. The treasures of the glorious Cholas are being depleted thus... by these pious beggars.

If this weren’t enough, there is Princess Kundavai who goes about opening medical clinics all over the Kingdom. The remainder of gold

in the treasury that is left behind after temple renovation is used to for her charity work.

If these two women waste gold on such trivial things, where would I find the gold to fulfil my heart's desire? How can I raise huge armies and conquer other lands?

And now she wishes to speak to me again? What could be so important? She might speak about some obscure tale of Lord Shiva or the deeper significance of his cosmic form, or about kundalini meditation. She drove me mad for twenty years, with these tales and made me the laughing stock of all in the Kingdom. I will not allow her to talk to me, thus and if she persists, I would have to shut my ears.

Before my mother sends for me again, I need to speak to that Soothsayer. How surprising? He seems to know about two secret incidents so far... He surely has some strange powers indeed! If he can see the past events through his sight, surely, he can see what is to come in the future...

Before he left the Sabha room, he saw the soothsayer standing hesitantly at the entrance. He signalled him to come along with him to his quarters.

Vandiya Devan was trying to convey various messages through his eyes, to the Princess but she didn't turn towards him, instead she withdrew from the hall along with the dowager queen, with nary a glance at him.

What is this? Has the Princess completely forgotten me? It must be so! She meets thousands of people every day. How can one expect her to remember someone she had met once or twice? I was insane. I thought about her all through my trials and tribulations but why should she think about me? It is the bee that hovers around the beautiful flower for its sweet nectar. But to the flower, the bee is inconsequential. The flower instead looks up to the sun and smiles... who could be the sun that makes Kundavai smile? I wonder...

Wouldn't she be interested in knowing how I fared in my mission? Could it be possible that someone had already informed her about the Prince? How can that be? No! No! She is worried about something and that's why she pretended not to recognize me. She might have wondered how a man that took her confidential message to the Prince could come back to the city as a part of Prince Madhuranthakan's entourage.

Aha! How surprised is she going to be when I tell her, how I managed to hoodwink Prince Madhuranthakar into believing that I am a soothsayer? But how do I meet her?

"You there! What are you thinking?" Madhuranthakan's question startled Vandiya Devan. By then, they had reached the Prince's quarters in the Palace.

There are astrologers who would predict the future by reading one's horoscope and Palmists who would delve into the lines of one's palm. There were also many obscure ways of predicting future - by calculating the time of the question and direction (which is generally known as Prashnam astrology) and there were also Soothsayers who genuinely possessed the sight and could see the future events unfold in front of their eyes. Some would sit in meditation and recite one's life history and other impending events, while others would sit in front of a lamp and look deep into the fire, to see the future. Few other Soothsayers, knew the art of reading faces and could accurately predict past, present and future.

Vandiya Devan knew that he was in a fix. He wondered what questions the Prince was likely to ask and what kind of answer he ought to give him.

I will have to give some clever answers somehow escape from this palace and meet Kundavai. But how?

“Nothing of consequence, my Prince. I was thinking that if only I had learned a few Devaram hymns instead of being a Soothsayer, then Queens and Princesses would have received me respectfully too,”

“What’s stopping you from doing so? You can do it even now,”

“My Prince! All our fates are already written. We will only get what we truly and rightly deserve,”

“What do you think about that boy who was reciting the hymns at the Sabha room? What do you know about his future?”

“He has a very bright future, indeed. Shiva Yogam^[49] and Raja Yogam^[50] will take him on a path to greatness. He will be well received by kings, queens and princes and his name will be added to the many great saints who have worshipped Lord Shiva,”

While Vallavareyan took a shot in the dark here, he didn’t know that his words had a very profound effect on the Prince. He immediately asked him, “What about my future?”

“Your future too is similar to that Nambi. Shiva Yogam and Raja Yogam will take you on the path of greatness...”

“Appaney! Be more specific,”

Vandiya Devan needed some time to concoct a believable story. He said, “Prince! If you want more specific predictions, kindly light a big lamp and incense. I can look into the fire and tell your future, as it unfolds in front of my eyes,”

The Prince restlessly issued a string of orders to his retainers and they hurried around to follow his orders. Soon a lamp was lit along with the incense and Vandiya Devan seated himself in front of it, while Madhuranthakar sat on the opposite end.

Vandiya Devan sat down with his eyes closed, as if he were in meditation, while his mouth mumbled away some mantras. Next he shook his body rather theatrically and shivered as though he was cold. Then he opened his eyes wide and looked deep inside the fire.

“Ayya! Do forgive me, if I had said something impertinent. Your future is not similar to that boy we saw in Sabha room. All through his life, that boy would be supported by Kings and Queens for his knowledge and piety but you... what can I say? How do I say it? I am astonished...”

“Appaney! What are you seeing? Tell me!”

“Aha! I have no words to describe what I am seeing here. I see a row of Kings standing with their heads bowed. Ministers, noblemen and merchants are standing in large numbers with their hands joined together in salutation. Behind them, an army of soldiers with their armours gleaming in the sun and their arms, sharp are standing cheering wildly. On top of Fort, countless numbers of people are perched wanting a glimpse...”

“Glimpse of whom? What are they saying?”

“My Prince, I can hear thousands of voices and they are saying, ‘Long Live the King!’ ‘Long Live the Emperor!’”

“And then... what?”

“I see the people surging forward while the soldiers are trying to stop them from entering the Fort. People are angry with the guards, for not allowing them inside and are fighting with the soldiers... too much noise...”

“Alright! Why are these people gathered here? Tell me that.”

“Yes. I can see that now. I see the huge tiger flag flying as high as the sky. Below that, I can see other flags – The Fish, The Palm Tree,

The Lion, The Bull and The Boar, flying under its shadow. I see a palace that can only be described to be as wondrous as the one that Mayan built for the Pandavas^[51]. In there, I can see the golden crown of the Cholas. One truly needs thousand eyes and one, to see the gleam of this gold and the sparkling gemstones that are studded within. Next to that is the ancient throne of the Cholas and the royal umbrella of the Kings, gleaming with white silk. Beside the throne stand two beautiful women – apsaras who have come down from the heaven waiting to fan their king and at the foot of the throne, there are hundreds of golden pots filled with holy waters of river Kaveri. My Prince! They are waiting to anoint the Emperor of Chola Kingdom!”

“Who is going to be the Emperor? Tell me fast!”

“There... I can see the doors of the palace opening. Ushers are heralding the arrival of someone. A mighty old man enters the palace and yet another warrior who looks like his brother, comes in bearing arms. Behind them is a Prince, whose handsome mien can only be compared to that of Manmadan, the handsome God of Love.”

“Who is it? Who?”

“Ayya! That Prince resembles you in all aspects...indeed it is you! The two old men lead you towards the throne, amidst cheers of victory, from all those who were gathered there. Thousands of flowers and grains fall upon your head blessing you with fortune, riches and grace. There... you are near the throne now. But what is this? Who is that woman... inauspicious incarnate with her hair wildly free and is standing in front of the throne...She says, ‘Do not! Begone!’ but you don’t listen... you push her to one side... Aha! What’s happening here? I can’t see anything but smoke... smoke...”

“Look again! Look carefully! Tell me what you see!”

“My Prince! Forgive me! I can only see smoke now.”

“Look again! Tell me who that woman is? Have you ever seen her before?”

“My Prince! The woman has vanished and so have you. Everything has gone up in that smoke... the palace, the throne and the crown. I think there is someone in this Palace who knows the dark arts of magic. My face is burning... it's burning!”

Saying thus, he closed his face with his hands and rocked back to and fro. After a while he took his hands off the face and opened his eyes to find the Prince burning up in anger. His eyes were slits of red and his lips were trembling with rage! Vandiya Devan wondered fearfully, whether he had fanned the Prince's heart desire beyond the limits.

“See again! Tell me what you see!”

“My Prince! There is no use in trying to see something that has vanished. I might see it again but not immediately. I can however look into the fire and tell you other things...”

“Tell! Tell me what else do you see?”

“There is too much confusion out there. The people are angry, confused and scared. A royal messenger gives them some news. Someone from the royal family has had a tragic accident. Someone has drowned in the sea... poor man! I can see the crowds lynching the messenger for giving them this news. My Prince! Do not ever go out in the crowds, during such a time. It might prove fatal for you,”

“Who has drowned in the sea?”

“I hear many people crying and wailing therefore I can't hear clearly as to who has drowned. Now that scene has vanished. Here is another one. I can see men wearing garlands of skulls with tridents and unkempt hair. They are Kalamugars. One of them is wielding a huge sword and is waiting by the sacrificial stone. Here too, I can

see a Prince arriving and the Kalamugars surround him hailing him wildly. Ayya! I beseech you, do not ever go near any of them,”

When the prince heard this, he started sweating and his hands trembled. Vandiya Devan noted this and said, “My Prince! I can’t see anything else, anymore. My eyes are burning... my head is aching. Someone is using dark magic that is preventing me from seeing anything more,”

Just then, a messenger came with summons from his mother and the Prince left the palace with barely contained anger. Before he left, Vandiya Devan sought his permission to see the city, “Ayya! I need fresh air. My headache is excruciatingly painful. I wish to see this city for a while, only then, I will get some relief from this pain,”

.....

Pazhaiaarai’s Physician’s son Pingapani had found a new purpose in life. Until a sometime ago, he was content learning the art of healing from his father. But after his journey to Kodikarai, he became a changed man. The credit to this transformation must be given to Vandiya Devan, who literally opened his eyes to many possibilities of life.

It is but natural, for people, who are in love wanting to talk and share their experiences with people around them. Unfortunately for Vandiya Devan, that person turned out to be Pinagapani. Since the Physician’s son appeared to be simple (if not stupid) Vandiya Devan spoke to him about vagaries of love and the inherent dangers of losing one’s heart to a woman. Citing himself as an example, he described the many trials and tribulations, that he was facing, after he fell in love with a woman.

At first, Pingapani ignored Vandiya Devan’s talks about love but the more time they spent in each other’s company, he became jealous of his companion and developed an irrational resentment towards him. He asked him to reveal the identity of the woman who had stolen his heart. Vandiya Devan refused to divulge her identity and this in turn,

increased his anger towards him. By the time they reached Kodi Karai, he considered Vandiya Devan to be his sworn enemy.

Pinagapani's jealousy and resentment, increased hundred-fold, after they met Poonguzhali. His proposal to her was not only rejected but also mocked and when he realized that she thought Vandiya Devan was a better man than him, his anger knew no bounds, and he was maddened. He sought to get his companion arrested by the Pazhuvur soldiers but was appalled when they arrested him instead. They took him to Thanjavur and locked him in the underground prison, to await the Emperor's justice. He had enough time within the precincts of the prison, to brood over his fate.

We saw how Princess Kundavai fought with Chinna Pazhuvetarayar to release him from the prison but before she could meet him, Pazhuvur Queen Nandini Devi had him released and met him at her palace. Nandini was furious with Vandiya Devan for escaping from her palace, without taking her leave and she suspected that Kundavai had sent him to Ilangai with a message to her brother. She believed that he would return to Pazhaiaarai, and try to meet the Princess. Therefore, she needed someone in the city to keep an eye out for him. After meeting Pinagapani, she decided that he could be used to spy on Vandiya Devan, if he ever turns up.

"The man who betrayed you at Kodi Karai and left you at the mercy of our soldiers, will return to Pazhaiaarai one day. I want you to follow him and report to me about his activities. If you do so, I will reward you beyond your dreams,"

Later, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar too called him and gave him similar orders, "If you could help us catch that spy, I will enlist you in my secret order of spies and make a commander out of you."

Since then, Pinagapani lost all his interest in his father's profession. Building many castles in the air, he roamed through the streets of Pazhaiaarai incessantly and followed random strangers. Sometimes he would get suspicious and would run towards them to see their

face closely. When he found that they didn't resemble Vandiya Devan he would leave cursing. Many felt that he had become insane but he was determined to catch the spy somehow.

When Vandiya Devan entered the city along with Prince Madhuranthakan's entourage, Pinagapani didn't notice him at first. Instead he joined the crowd that had come along with Thirunaraiyur Nambi, to check whether Vandiya Devan could be there, disguised as a Saivaite. When Nambi's entourage met the Prince's chariot in the streets, one of his men, turned towards them for a split of a second and Pinagapani's heart almost stopped beating. He had spotted Vandiya Devan! But before he could raise an alarm, he had entered the palace along with the Prince!



Chapter 19: At the nick of the time

During the welcome reception of Thirunaraiyur Nambi, Pinagapani couldn't enter the Sabha room. He stayed with the thronging crowds outside and kept his eyes trained on Vandiya Devan. And we knew that Vandiya Devan didn't notice him because he was more intent on sending silent messages through his eyes to Princess Kundavai.

There was one more man, who was looking at both of them. unnoticed and that was our old friend Azhwarkadiyan Nambi.

After foretelling disastrous fortunes for Prince Madhuranthakan, Vandiya Devan exited the palace and came to the courtyard where his horse was tied. Pinagapani who was waiting for him there came to him and asked, "Appaney! Who are you?"

Vandiya Devan was startled to see Pinagapani there, but he acted as though he didn't recognize him, and asked, "What did you ask?"

"I asked, 'who are you'?" repeated Pinagapani

"Who am I? Who are we in reality? Do you perchance refer to this body that is made of five elements – air, water, earth, fire and the sky? Or do you perhaps refer to this entity that rests within this body? Would you be referring to the supreme lord who created this universe and gave life to us? Appaney! Your question is absurd. In truth, there is no 'you', 'I' or 'me'. Everything that we see around us is Maya. It's an illusion that has been woven around to keep us bound

in this physical plane. If you wish to learn more about it, you should listen to Thirunarayar Nambi's discourse about the same and get enlightened." Said Vandiya Devan and nimbly got onto his horse, within the blink of the eye he trotted out of the palace before Pinagapani could raise an alarm.

However, this didn't deter the physician's son. He hastened to the city guards and alerted them about the spy's arrival and along with a few soldiers, they scoured the city and finally found him on one of the streets.

"There! He is the spy. Imprison him immediately."

"Are you insane?"

"Who is insane? Are you referring to my body, my soul or the supreme lord who created this universe?" shot back Pinagapani.

"From the way you are blabbering, it is evident that you are mad."

"I am not insane. I am the physician who came along with you to Kodi Karai. Guards! This is the spy who escaped from Thanjavur fort. Imprison him immediately!"

When the guards came towards Vandiya Devan, he warned them, "Be warned! Do not lay a hand on me. I am the soothsayer who came along with Prince Madhuranthakar."

"No! No! No! He lies! Bind and chain him immediately. He is the spy." Shouted Pinagapani.

Soon a large crowd had surrounded them gawking at them and guessing whether Vandiya Devan could be the spy.

"He doesn't look like a Soothsayer." Said one of them in the crowd

"Neither does he look like a spy."

“Have you ever seen a soothsayer, so young?”

“Why not? If you have the sight, it doesn’t matter how young you are. Would a spy roam on the streets of the city, so boldly?”

“Why would a soothsayer bear arms?”

“If he is a spy, who does he work for? What is there to spy in Pazhaiaarai?”

While speculation about Vandiya Devan’s life, motives and intention ran rife among the crowd, Pinagapani impatiently shouted, “Imprison this spy immediately! This is the order of Pazhuvur brothers.”

Unfortunately for him, this had an adverse effect on the crowd. When they heard the name ‘Pazhuvur’ they decided that Vandiya Devan was, after all, an innocent man and sought to help him escape.

That’s when, Azhwarkadiyan elbowed his way through the crowd and asked, “I am looking for the soothsayer who accompanied Prince Madhuranthakan.”

Pinagapani countered it saying, “No! No! He is the spy.”

“What’s this trouble? If you are truly the soothsayer, come along with me. Princess Kundavai wishes to consult you,”

Vandiya Devan’s heart skipped a beat and he immediately said, “I am the soothsayer. I am ready to come with you,”

Pinagapani who was horrified by the turn of events, shouted himself hoarse. “Don’t let him escape! He is the spy! He is the spy!”

‘Why don’t you prove that you are a soothsayer? I will take you to the Princess if you can predict something for us.” Said Azhwarkadiyan and signalled him with his eyes.

“How should I prove that?” asked Vandiya Devan hurriedly.

“There! Do you see those two men on the horses? They look like royal messengers bearing some important message. Why don’t you tell us what possible message they are bringing?”

Vandiya Devan trained his eyes on the men who were trotting slowly and looked at them intently and then he said, “These messengers are bearers of unfortunate news. Someone belonging to the royal family has met with an accident, at the sea.”

The messengers soon reached the crowd and they stopped the horses from proceeding further. Azhwarkadiyan asked them, “Looks like you are royal messengers. What news do you bring?”

“Yes, we are messengers. We bring news about Prince Arulmozhivarmar. His ship was trapped in a fierce storm and the prince jumped into the sea to save someone and was not found again!”

When the messenger gave the sad news to the crowd, a universal shout of dismay and sorrow was heard. It was difficult to discern from where such a huge crowd came. Scenes of wailing, crying and disbelief, were seen all over the place. People crowded around the messengers, asking them for more details, not wanting to believe that they have lost their beloved prince.

The people in the city knew that the Pazhuvur brothers detested their prince and that they had sent soldiers to Ilangai to imprison him. The prince’s death news was the last straw that broke their back. They openly started cursing them for the tragedy that had struck the kingdom.

“Pazhuvetarayars are responsible for this. It is them, who have drowned our dear prince in the sea.” As the talk spread further,

everybody in the crowd started shouting against the brothers and unrest spread further.

Stuck in the crowd, the royal messengers couldn't move. Azhwarkadiyan then took charge of the situation and asked the guards who had accompanied Pinagapani, "Why are you guards watching all this silently? Help these messengers reach the palace. Disperse the crowds!"

The guards who too were in despair after hearing the news about the Prince snapped out of it and tried to lead the messengers, by parting the crowds. As the messengers moved towards the palace, so did the crowds but one soul alone didn't wail about the Prince's fate. "Ayyo! What is happening here? This is a plan to help that spy escape!" However, no one noticed the poor physician's son. He was swept away by the sea of people, who were proceeding towards the palace of the dowager queen.

Thankfully, Vandiya Devan had got down from the horse right when the crowd had started gathering. When the crowd started moving, Azhwarkadiyan grasped his hand and said, "Leave the horse. We can find it later. Let's go now,"

"Appaney! If you hadn't arrived at the nick of the time, I know not what would have happened to me."

"You ought to be used to it by now. That's how it happens all the time. You will endanger yourself somehow and someone will come at the nick of the time to save you," said Azhwarkadiyan cheekily.

They had by then reached the edge of the street and waited until the crowds had gone and then Azhwarkadiyan took him towards the opposite street, where the palaces of noblemen and ministers lay.

They went to Prime Minister Anirudhar's locked palace and approached the garden grounds. Through the garden, lay a path towards Princess Kundavai's palace. As they neared the place,

Vandiya Devan could see the lake that adjoined the Princess's palace. On the lake, there was a boat and a fair maiden seated... waiting for him. Vandiya Devan's heart soared high in anticipation of meeting her again.



Chapter 20: Mother & Son

Prince Madhuranthakar went reluctantly to his mother's quarters for a private audience. Everybody in the kingdom, unequivocally respected and revered, this dowager queen for her single-minded devotion towards Lord Shiva. The Prince too had great respect for his mother once, but now he bore only rage and contempt, towards her. She was the sole reason for his lack of kingship.

How could a mother act thus, that too towards her own son? Even in stories, legends and myths it's hard to come across a mother, who would deny the throne, to her own son. Why did he have the misfortune of being born to such a mother?

He found her sitting placidly with divine serenity on her face and his anger simmered down, a little. He knelt and took her blessings, as he always did and she blessed him thus, 'May your devotion to Lord Shiva, know no bounds!' and bade him sit next to her. The Prince's temper rose again, when he heard her blessing.

"Madhuranthaka! Is my daughter-in-law in good health? Is your father-in-law well?"

"Everybody is in good health and are fine but why would you be worried about them?" said the Prince, muttering the last few words to himself.

"Did you meet the Emperor, before you left Thanjavur? How is his health?"

“I met him briefly. His health is indeed declining, day by day. He has pain in his heart, more than anything else but I have heard that that’s how, it is with people who feel guilty of wrongdoing,”

“Child! What are you saying? What wrongdoing did the Emperor do? Why should he feel guilty?”

“He is guilty of snatching a kingdom, that rightfully belongs to me. He has wronged me gravely, and that’s why he is feeling guilty,”

“Child! Who is responsible for the venom that you bear in your innocent heart? Who has poisoned your mind, thus?” asked the queen pitifully.

“No one has poisoned my mind. Do you believe that your son is such an imbecile that he has no brains to speak of?”

“No matter how intelligent a person is, it is possible to poison their mind with the choicest words. Didn’t Kaikeyi^[52] start hating Prince Rama, thanks to Mantara^[53]?”

“Yes, I do know that a woman’s mind can be meddled with easily...”

“Madhuranthaka! Whom are you referring to?”

“Mother! Why did you summon me?”

“Child! You seemed distant, during the recitation,”

“That’s true. You brought that pious beggar to the palace, seated him upon the throne and honoured him with gold and grants. His pride must have multiplied, a thousand-fold...”

“Ayyo! Do not talk such words, my child! He might have been young in years, but his wisdom and knowledge, about this world is more than anything, you and I, could ever learn...”

“Alright, let him be a saint. If he is truly so, nothing that I say is going to lower his worth. I would like to know, why you summoned me?”

Sembiyanmadevi sighed aloud, and said, “I am astonished to see how changed a man you have become. I never dreamed that two years of living away from me in Thanjavur, along with the Pazhuvur clan, would turn you against me thus.

Be that as it may, I still have to do my duty towards my husband and fulfil my responsibility. Child! Before I tell you why I summoned you, I need tell you, how I married your father. Will listen to my story patiently?”

Madhuranthakan rested his hands on his seat, indicating that he was willing to listen to her.

“I was born in Mazhapadi^[54]. When you were a small child, I had taken you there twice. The Shiva Temple at Mazhapadi was built by Kochankada Chola and was one among the 64 shrines that he built during his lifetime. Your grandsire, my father was an important man with a large household. The history of our clan is quite ancient and we were formidable warriors and kings of Mazhapadi. During the wars fought in Vijalaya Chola’s time our clan allied with the Pandya King. When the Cholas won the war, they stripped us of our power, lands and reduced us to the state of mere lords. However, when I was young, I never thought about our circumstances to be dishonourable and nor did I dwell in the glory of the past. My heart and soul were fully engaged with Mazhapadi’s Lord Nataraja.



Thirumazhapadi Vaidyanathaswami Temple
Image Courtesy: Wikipedia

When I was very young someone told me the story of Sundaramurthy Nayanar and how he discovered this temple. Once, while he was traveling with his disciples through the village, he failed to see the temple that lay on his way due to thick grove of trees. And then he heard a divine voice, ‘Sundaram! Have you forgotten me?’ he turned around and asked his disciples whether they heard anything. Then he asked around if there was a Shiva temple somewhere close by. Soon he made his way to the temple and sang the divine Devaram “Ponnaar Meniyaney”.

This story made a great impression on me at a very young age. I would visit the temple daily and sit before Lord Nataraja and say the divine hymns of Devaram, countless times. As I grew into a young maiden, my heart yearned for Lord Shiva. I began daydreaming that the Lord would come out of the stone idol and claim my hand, in marriage. I would imagine myself to be Uma, Parvathi, Dakshayani and would sit in meditation to make myself a worthy consort for my Lord. If someone in my family spoke about my marriage, I became

bitter and frustrated. As years went by, my devotion to Lord Shiva became more steadfast and resolute. People around started calling me 'mad' but they longer mattered to me. I spent all my waking hours at the temple, serving my lord, with all my heart and soul. I used to make hundreds of garlands and would meditate for hours, wishing that I be granted a glimpse of his divine form.

One day, while I was thus engaged in meditation, someone arrived at the temple. Upon opening my eyes, I saw many soldiers and a man stood in front of them. I thought that my penance had been successful and that Lord Shiva himself had come to claim to my hand. I stood with my hands folded together, with streams of tears rolling down my eyes. The visitor noticed my tears and asked, 'Who is this maiden? Why is she crying thus?' and then I heard my father say, 'This is my daughter. She is an ardent devotee of Lord Shiva. She serves her lord here, with flowers, songs and hymns and is forever meditating.'

My father's words woke me up and then I realized that it was not Lord Shiva who had come there, but some man. I felt mortified. I ran all the way home, to hide my shame. But he didn't leave me alone. He followed me there and asked my father, for my hand in marriage. That's when, I knew that the man, I saw at the temple was King Gandharathithar, my child!"

The dowager queen paused for a while. Memories of past events brought pearls of tears to her eyes. She wiped her eyes with the edge of her saree and continued. "I learned all about your father that day. He had ascended the throne, a few years ago and since then he had been touring the Kingdom and visiting as many Shiva Temples. as he could. He was around 40 years of age and a widower. His first wife had died, many years ago and since then, he didn't wish to marry anybody else. However, his chaste heart became restless after meeting me. In the presence of my father, he asked me, whether I would marry him. I was overwhelmed and dazed. My heart sang to me and said that it was Lord Shiva, who had come in mortal form to claim me. I agreed to marry him, wholeheartedly. We were

wedded, soon enough, and after that your grandsire was granted all the ancestral lands that were confiscated and he became the king of Mazhapadi, again.

“My child, your father and I wanted to dedicate our lives to serve Lord Shiva. Therefore, we decided that we would not sire a child. There was an important reason behind this decision. I never thought that I would be forced to share all this with you but you must learn, why we acted so.”



Chapter 21: Are you truly my mother?

“My Child! When your father ascended the Chola throne, the Kingdom was in shambles. You know all about your grandsire King Paranthaka Chola. During his glorious reign, the tiger flag of the Cholas, flew from Ilangai to Krishna River. However, during the last years of his reign many misfortunes fell upon the royal family and the Kingdom.

Rashtrakutas came with a huge army to oust our rule. They fought with our army that was led by the King’s heir and Crown Prince Rajadhithan at Thakollam. Rivers of blood flowed endlessly, as soldiers fell on both sides and in the end the Rashtrakutas’ army retreated in defeat but not before slaying our peerless Prince who died bravely on his elephant. Your uncle Aringhzha Chola (Sundara Chola’s father) too was gravely wounded at the war and his whereabouts were unknown. Aringhzha Devar’s young son Sundara Chola who had gone to Ilangai, was also missing. It was your father, who was next to Paranthaka Chola, as he lay in his chambers reeling from the misfortunes that had struck the kingdom and the family.

All his life, your father stayed away from the affairs of the Kingdom. He was a saint at heart and wished only to serve Lord Shiva with a single-minded devotion. He abhorred wars and battles. He believed that it was the common people who would ultimately suffer trying to serve the greed of the kings. He used to argue with his brothers and his father about this.

He led his life on his own terms. Visiting temples, shrines, holy places and pilgrimages, was the life that he sought. Swords, spear, bow and arrow were no use to him, as he did not bear arms and nor did he learn the art of warfare, from his teachers. He hated politics, schemes, and intrigues, because they gave birth to betrayals, treason and slaughter. He used to ask, 'a common thief steals gold from other people and in the same manner the King tries to covet lands from other Kingdoms. What's the difference between the King and the thief?'

My Child! It was truly unfortunate that a man of such sentiments, had to take on the mantle of the Kingdom. The misfortunes that fell upon the kingdom and the death of his heir, had left Emperor Paranthaka Chola prostrate with grief. He summoned your father one day, and said, 'You will need to bear the burden of this Kingdom henceforth'. And your father accepted it because he didn't wish to cause any more pain to his father. Your father was a widower then and his first wife Veeramarayani Devi had died many years ago, leaving him childless. Your father had no intention of getting married again and your grandsire was worried about who would succeed your father. Thankfully, your cousin Sundara Chola was found alive in one of the islands near Ilankai and was brought back to the Kingdom.

Paranthaka Chola was very fond of Sundara Chola right from the time he was born. Many astrologers had predicted that through Sundara Chola and his heirs, the Chola Kingdom would attain unparalleled greatness and glories. That's why he decreed that after the reign of your father, Sundara Chola and his heirs, should succeed him and rule the kingdom. Your father explained all this to me, while on his deathbed. He wanted Sundara Chola and his heirs to inherit the throne after him.

Your father didn't covet the throne and nor did he wish to rule the Kingdom. He possessed a pure heart that dwelled constantly upon Lord Shiva. Though he ascended the throne and became the King, it was his brother Aringzha Chola and Sundara Chola who took care of

the affairs of the Kingdom while your father roamed through the Kingdom visiting Shiva temples and other holy places. He didn't wish to marry or sire an heir and was content with his lot in life, until he met me.

Your father happened to meet me at Mazhapadi and developed affection towards me. It was my good fortune to marry someone like him and I know not what good deeds I did in my past life to merit such a life partner. You are fortunate too, as you get to call him, your father. In this world, there are very few people who are blessed with eyes to see the divine form of Lord Shiva and your father was one among them. Therefore, it is our duty to fulfil his last wishes..."

Prince Madhuranthakan who was listening to his mother intently until then, was fuming with anger.

"Mother! My father didn't tell me anything about this. How can it be my duty to fulfil his last wishes?"

"Child! Listen to me. When your father attained a seat in Kailasam^[55], you were an infant. Therefore, he entrusted me with the responsibility of fulfilling his last wishes. During the early years of our marriage, we had decided not to sire a child but unfortunately, I couldn't uphold this resolution. The devotion that I felt towards Lord Shiva during my formative years, transformed into love towards your father. As days went past, I yearned for a child. When I saw other women with children, I felt doomed and sad. I turned to Lord Shiva and ardently wished for a child and he fulfilled my wish. When my womb quickened, I was thrilled and yet I was afraid that your father might be angry with me. He didn't get angry but he did entrust a huge responsibility on my shoulders..."

Child! I promised your father that I would bring you up away from the affairs of the state as a devotee of Lord Shiva. Until a few years ago, I thought that I had kept that promise.

My dear child! I have been hearing many accounts of how much you have changed and I want your assurance that you haven't. I want to tell everyone that you are still mine own son. Will you give me this assurance? Will you heal my wounded heart with your sweet words?" begged the Dowager Queen.

"Mother! Why are you speaking so mysteriously? Who is telling you lies and falsehood about me? What kind of assurance do you expect from me?" lashed out Prince Madhuranthakan.

"My Child! Have you lost the ability to learn the deepest wishes of my heart? Alright then, I will tell you. Many tell me that your heart has strayed away from the path of righteousness that leads towards Lord *Shiva* and that you have fallen into the deepest pits of greed. They say that you wish to ascend the throne and rule this kingdom. Your enemies have corrupted your pure heart and have led you astray. I want your assurance that this isn't so, and that you are not interested in ruling this Kingdom. If I hear this from your own mouth, I would be reassured,"

Prince Madhuranthakan stood up abruptly in anger and started shouting.

"My heart was not corrupted by my enemies. The people whom you call as my enemies, are those who wish to see me ascend the throne that rightfully belongs to me. Are they my enemies? Those are the people who are ready to pledge their life and sword to me. Do you think they are my enemies? No. My one true enemy is 'you', the one who gave birth to me..."

In his rage, the Prince forgot the courtesy and the respect that was due to his mother. He also forgot Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's advice where he asked him to speak sweetly to his mother and change her mind gradually.

"Yes. You are my enemy. What kind of a mother are you? I have seen women all around the world, fighting for the rights of their son. I

have heard of such woman in stories, myths and mythologies but I have seen none like you. Your actions and words are not like any mother of this world. What harm did I cause you? Why do you act against me thus? Why do you wish to snatch a Kingdom that rightfully belongs to me and give it to somebody else? You take my father's name... and say that it's his wish but I do not believe you. You say that someone has corrupted my mind but I think that it's your mind that has been meddled with by someone, who wishes to turn mother against the son.

Listen to me! I will not give up my rights to this kingdom, not even to keep you or my dead father happy. The Chola Kingdom is mine, by rights. The ancient throne of Cholas is where I belong. The golden crown of King Karikala Peruvellathan belongs to me and I will not give them up. Here is the rudraksha^[56] chain that you gave me once. I have been wearing this out of respect for you. It is 'this' that has made me the laughing stock of this kingdom. You can keep this..."

After shouting at his mother madly, the Prince attempted to remove the chain hurriedly but the chain became twisted and it became impossible to remove it.

Madhuranthakan was a very handsome man. Some might even call him 'beautiful' as he possessed more feminine grace and elegance in his form. However, his anger and hatred towards his mother had deformed his features and his face became ugly and fearsome to look upon. Sembianmadevi who was truly taken aback by his tirade closed her eyes, as she couldn't bear this transformation. She waited until he had shouted himself hoarse, and then spoke to him softly.

"Child! Calm down! I might be a demon in disguise of a woman, but I beg you to listen to my words,"

The Prince's wrath and anger subsided a bit after hearing her soft entreat. He said, "Tell me..."

“A little while ago, you spoke about the nature of a true mother who might be a demon to others but would never harm her own children. In the same manner, I too am trying to save you from harm. I do not want you to ascend the throne of this kingdom and not just because it was your father’s wish, there is yet another reason for this.

I fear for your life Madhuranthaka. Won’t a mother want to see her only son alive and living? Is that a crime? Your wish to ascend the throne, will instantly earn you enemies among those who support the claim of Prince Aditya Karikalan. Karikalan and his brother are seasoned warriors, while you are not. The entire army of Chola Kingdom supports Sundara Chola’s sons and they would never look to ‘you’ as their leader.

In such a situation, who would support your claim? Who would you trust? Can you wage a war against them, alone? My Child! I see many ill omens all around me. A comet is seen stretching its tail from one end of the sky to another. It is known that whenever a comet is seen on the sky death occurs in the royal family. What if this death comes for you? Wouldn’t a mother want her only son, alive? What is more important – claim to a kingdom or life? Would you call me an unnatural mother, just because I want my only son alive?”

The queen’s words calmed the Prince’s heart a bit, and he spoke to her calmly, “Mother! If only you had told me that this was your worry then I wouldn’t have spoken to you thus. I would have given you news, that would have extinguished such worries. I am not without any support, mother! Chola Kingdom’s most powerful noblemen support my claim and are ready to pledge their swords for my cause. Pazhuvur brothers, Kadambur Sambuverayar and many more are backing my claims. They have sworn a holy vow, to help me ascend my rightful throne...”

“Child! I have no faith in these promises or holy vows. These people once pledged their word, honour and the strength of their armies to support Sundara Chola and his sons. When they were not true to their own Emperor, how can you expect them to be true to you? If

you are depending upon the might of their armies, then you must know that they command only a fraction of soldiers, when compared to both the princes. The northern command is under Aditya Karikalan, while the southern command is under Arulmozhi...”

“Mother! The noblemen who support my cause are capable of raising huge armies at my behest,”

“Even if I were to agree to that child, what about the people of this kingdom? Don’t you know how popular Prince Karikalan and Arulmozhi are with the masses? You might have seen today. If either of these princes had come to this city today, wouldn’t they have flocked to the roads to cheer them? Did they even spare a glance at you? Once before, you too commanded the same respect and love from this city but ever since you allied yourself with the Pazhuvur brothers, you have fallen out of grace...”

“Mother! Why are you so worried about people’s love? How is that going to affect me? The realm is mine and I will rule over them and whoever sits on the throne will demand respect from the people and it’s their duty to be devoted to the king,”

“Child! I can see that whoever has educated you about the affairs of the Kingdom has not taken the trouble to teach you finer points of politics. A king who does not have the love of his subjects, cannot rule over them for long...”

Just then they heard a roar of voices and confused babble of several hundred people from the gates of the palace. Worried, the dowager queen went near the window and saw a sea of people, heading towards them.

“Child! Some calamity has befallen the Chola Kingdom. This is the first sign of things to come. I will go to the palace balcony to learn what is amiss. Until then, I want you to stay inside.”



Chapter 22: What's that noise?

As they neared the lake, Vandiya Devan saw Princess Kundavai waiting for him in the boat but he hesitated to move forward due to Azhwarkadiyan's presence.

Realizing this Azhwarkadiyan said, "Why are you standing here, hesitating? The Princess has been waiting here for some time now. Get on the boat and give her the good news, 'The Prince has arrived and is safe' and then you can go on about your exploits. I will take my leave now and see if I can control the madness that we have unleashed upon the city today. Your dare devilry comes with a heavy price and I end up cleaning all the mess in the end..." said Azhwarkadiyan and returned to Anirudhar's palace.

Vandiya Devan watched him surprise.

How did he know all these details? He didn't even ask me anything! Was he merely guessing or did he really know everything?

Vandiya Devan had heard that there were two types of beggars in the world – those who did it as a profession and those who were forced by circumstances. In the same manner, maybe there are two types of spies around.

I became a spy when my hand was forced and have since then courted nothing but trouble. Azhwarkadiyan is surely a spy by profession, therefore, he goes about his work without any worries.

But who does he work for? Is there any truth in the stories that he told about his past life?

Thinking thus, he came to the bank of the lake and looked at the Princess's face and forgot everything else.

Aha! This is the face that followed me through all my trials and tribulations.

As he looked at the face of the woman who had stolen his heart his heart fluttered and he lost his voice to the wonder of her beautiful visage.

Intoxicated with love and beauty, Vandiya Devan stepped into the water and got into the boat. The Princess signalled the boatman and the boat started moving.

“Soothsayer! Will you predict something for me or do you serve only the Princes of this realm? How do you predict the future? Do you perchance look at the stars and the planets or do you watch the movements of birds like crows and sparrows? Maybe you are one of those who predict future by looking at the face of the person...is that why you are staring at me so intently? Be warned, if you persist thus, no high-born woman will ever demand your service.” spoke the Princess with a smile.

“I am not looking at your face to predict your future. I am looking because I am trying to remember where I have seen you...”

“I know you have a very bad memory. Allow me to refresh it. Almost forty days ago, we met at Kudanthai Jodhidar's house and then we met again on the same day near the banks of Arisalaru...”

“Stop! Please! I cannot believe your words. Surely, it can't be forty days. I believe that I have seen you 40,000 years ago. Didn't we meet, hundreds of eons ago? I have seen you on the mountains, on the swirling currents, dense woods, on the banks of the river... Didn't

I save you once when a fierce tiger hunted you in the woods? Then, I was a hunter who lived in the forest and I trapped many colourful birds and parrots for your pleasure. Don't you remember you would take these birds and set them free?

Once, I was a fisherman and I went to the seven seas to catch silver and gold fish for you and what did you do? You set them free and watched with pleasure, as they swam away from us.

I brought you pearls, corals and many other precious gems from the floor of the ocean but what did you do? You called small boys and girls and pressed a handful of these gems onto their hands and smiled happily.

I brought you a rare fruit from a tree that bears them once in 300 years but you fed it to your pet parrot and watched with pleasure as it pecked and ate it slowly. I went to the heavens and got you all the fragrant flowers that blossomed there, but you said that they didn't compare to the scent of the jasmine flower that grew in your backyard. Then I went back to the heavens and got Indra's precious gemstone haaram^[57] but you disdainfully declared that you wouldn't touch anything that was worn by god as fickle as Indra.

Then I went to Kailasam and lay prostrate at the feet of Devi Parvati. Devi, in all her benevolence, removed her anklets and gave it to me but you said, 'Ayyo! How can I wear the divine anklets of Devi Parvati? Please give it back to her.'

I then went to war and won over hundreds of kings and presented their crowns at your feet but you kicked them aside with nary a thought and I was worried that your beautiful feet might have been hurt. Devi, are these memories true or not? Or do you still think that we met just forty days ago?" said Vandiya Devan.

Even then, he had not finished with his long list of memories. He started again, "Devi, I can remember yet another memory. Once we were traveling in a golden boat fitted with silver oars..."

“Ayyo! This soothsayer has truly gone mad. I think we should go back to the palace,”

“No Devi, until I got into this boat my mind was clear or else would it be possible for me to meet Prince Madhuranthakan and convince him that I am a soothsayer? Do you think I could have escaped from physician’s son, so easily? It was when I saw your face that I got intoxicated and lost my senses,”

“Ayya! Then please do not look at my face. You are free to stare at the clear waters, the gardens, and the palace or even at this deaf boatman and tell me what happened to the mission that I sent you on? Did you succeed or not? Has the Prince returned? Does he fare well? If yes, where have you left him? And then tell me about your journey?”

“Devi, If I had not concluded my mission successfully, I would never have shown my face to you. Yes, the Prince has returned and I crushed hundreds of obstacles to bring him back to you but I can’t say that he fares well. When I left him, he was suffering from shivering fever but he is in the capable hands of the boat girl Poonguzhali and my friend Senthana Amuthan. They are utterly devoted to him and would lose their lives to save him,”

Suddenly, they heard hundreds of voices raised in protest, women wailing and crying. Princess and Vandiya Devan looked at the banks of the lake worriedly, trying to ascertain the source of the disturbance.

“What’s that uproar? It sounds as if hundreds of people have gathered and are shouting and wailing?”

“Yes. It seems like that.”



Chapter 23: Vanathi

If the poets were asked to describe the beauty of Princess Vanathi, they would surely compare it with the lovely elegance of the dusk. When the sun sets in the evening, after a glorious day, there is a hint of sadness and a still peace. That's probably why, the Gods of nature, lit the skies with the lustrous moon and many millions of stars to compensate for the disappearance of the sun.

While it is true that the lovely lotus flowers close their petals during the dusk, the jasmine blooms and its heady fragrance intoxicates everyone around.

The birds return to their nests during the dusk and the world is bereft of their chitter-chatter but the bells of the temple tinkle through the space and the heavenly music of the nadaswaram^[58] and flute replaces them. The alluring strings of an ancient Yazh and the dainty fingers of the beautiful maiden who plays them are certainly worthy sights to behold during the dusk.

Vanathi's beauty had the same tinge of sadness and forlorn sorrow, mixed with charming elation of innocent joy. Her character too had the same twin characteristic of sorrow and joy, in equal measures. Sometimes she would seem as sorrowful as Chandramathi and Savithri^[59] while at other times she would be as joyful as apsaras Urvashi and Rambha in the heavens. When she was sad, it would be difficult to elicit a small pitiful smile from her while on some days she would be found laughing gaily immersing those around her in a joyous world.

The origin of these dual characteristics in Vanathi can be traced back to the time of her birth and the circumstances of her upbringing. When she was in her mother's womb, her father Kodumbalur Siriya Vellar, was fighting many terrible wars. The news from the battlefield swung from good to bad every day, swaying her mother's anxious heart from joy to sorrow. Weakened in heart, her mother died tragically after giving birth to her and her father assumed sole responsibility of raising her. Unfortunately, this too did not last. Kodumbalur Siriya Vellar was a great warrior, he didn't wish to stay away from the battlefield even for the sake of his only child. When Veera Pandyan escaped yet again, he sought the command of the armies and chased him all the way to Ilangai and bravely gave up his life in the battlefield winning acclaim and glory for eternity.

After her father's death, Vanathi felt as if all the joy in her life was sucked out. She felt adrift, lonely and lost. No words can describe the sorrow of the child, who has lost both the parents and only those who have sadly experienced this, can feel the pain. Though servants and handmaidens raised Vanathi lovingly, none could replace her father in her heart of hearts. Many tried to console her in different ways, and one of them said, "Don't grieve child! Your father will be reborn as your son and he will be a great warrior too."

For some reason, these words stayed with Vanthi, embedded deep within her. She transformed her loneliness and grief into daydreams about the son that would be born to her. She would imagine her son to be a great commander who would win countless wars and come back to her unscathed. She would see his battle campaigns through imaginary eyes and cheer for him loudly when he brought back treasures and presented to her. She would see him climb the throne of a great kingdom and watch with pleasure when other kings paid homage to him. She would watch him sail away in thousands of ships and conquer lands far away. When he came back to her, he would say, "Mother! You are the reason, why I have been so victorious."

Innocent of the ways of the world, Vanathi would sometimes touch her womb and wonder whether her son was already there. In those days, men and women were taught the great mythological stories of yore like Ramayanam, Mahabharatam and many more. She knew that Kunti Devi^[60] conceived the Pandavas, by uttering a potent mantra. She wondered whether some God would appear before her and grant her a son, who would fulfil all her dreams. Young as she was, she didn't realize that marrying a husband was a prerequisite to have a child in their society. When she came of age, she learned that only her husband could grant her a child but she didn't think too much about it. All her dreams were focused solely on the wonder child that she would have in the future.

When her uncle sent her to Pazhaiaarai as a companion for Princess Kundavai, her life changed for better. Kundavai's grace, benevolence, wit and intelligence had a huge impact on her. She learned more about the whole wide world at the knees of this princess, than anywhere else. Courtly behaviour, scriptures, poetry, mythology, history and yore of distant lands were the many things that Kundavai taught her pupil. Kundavai's affection for Vanathi was a bone of contention among the other princesses, who too had been sent to her as companions. Vanathi was pleasantly surprised and also bemused by the fact that they were jealous of her, as she never thought herself to be special in any way. Vanathi's sweet nature and innocent charms endeared her to all and Kundavai preferred her company to anybody else. Amidst all this, she didn't stop daydreaming about the son who would be born to her.

The day, she met Ponniyin Selvar and all her dreams shattered. She knew that she had to marry if she wished to give birth to a son but she didn't think much about the husband in the first place. Unfortunately, her heart didn't listen to the dictates of her mind and she lost hers to a Prince, who was the object of affection of every maiden in the realm. Marrying the Prince seemed like an unattainable dream for her and nor could she marry anybody else either. Therefore, her dream of a son disappeared like a puff of smoke.

Disappointment and grief overtook her and she soon forgot to smile. Kundavai who astutely deduced the source of her grief began to counsel her and encouraged her towards her dream by saying that she could dream of marrying the Prince. Added to this, their visit to Kudanthai Jodhidar resurrected her old daydream of a great warrior son. Whenever she experienced extreme joy or grief, her senses overwhelmed her and she fell faint. One can even say that it was nature's way of saving her life from an excess of emotion.

When Vanathi went to Thanjavur along with Kundavai she couldn't forget the day she heard the Emperor's pitiful plea for help and the subsequent scene that she had inadvertently witnessed. She also learned the extent of hate and distrust that existed between her clan and that of the Pazhuvur brothers. She also realized the true state of affairs and the extent of power that the Pazhuvur brothers wielded at the capital. She would often wonder whether the Pazhuvur brothers would allow a Kodumbalur Princess to marry the Prince of the realm.

If even they didn't object, Nandini might have something to say about it. Whenever she thought about Nandini she was reminded of a beautiful cobra – alluring, mesmerizing and dangerous. What if she tried to weave her seductive allure upon the Prince? She also remembered Nandini standing in front of the King, in his bed chamber? Was it really her? Why did the Emperor piteously beg her to leave him alone? Kundavai had not spoken to her about any of these things but she knew that the Princess was terribly worried. That's why she refuses to speak about certain things to me. Is she perchance worried about the Prince? That's probably why she is hesitant to talk to me about it.

Kundavai was missing again today. In her absence, these girls behave with uncontrollable abandon. They have truly never known any worries, pain or unhappiness.

Vanathi was sick of her companions and wished to be left alone. The past few days, she had been immersed in sorrow that she found it

jarring to hear her friends mock her with jokes and japes. As she searched through the palace for Kundavai, her handmaiden told her that she had gone to Sembiyanmadevi's palace. When she reached the palace, she learnt that Sembiyanmadevi was with her son and that they were not to be disturbed. This news unnerved her and she became impatient. In the meanwhile, she also noticed the crowd that had started gathering outside the palace, which seemed ominous. She went back to Kundavai's palace and learnt that the Princess was meeting with Azhwarkadiyan at the lake. Vanathi hesitated to go there as the Princess often sought the lake, only when she wished to be alone. While she stood debating whether to go or not, one of her friends Varini burst into the room.

"Ponniyin Selvan has gone missing in the sea!" she shouted and started crying. The rest of the women in the room started crying in disbelief and true agony. Vanathi didn't really feel anything at first. She stood watching the scene with a detachment that was very uncharacteristic of her.

She looked around and found the women watching her and accusing her. It seemed as though they were saying, "Girl! It was your bad luck that drowned our darling Prince in the sea!"

She couldn't stand them staring at her thus. She turned on her heel and ran towards the lake. As she ran, the news about the Prince sank into her mind and things began to make sense. She had been seeing the Prince's face as a reflection whenever she was near the lake. When she drew near to touch the water, his face would vanish.

The Prince probably thought about me when he died and he called me to him. The foolish girl that I am, I didn't heed his summons and stayed on in the banks. I must go to him now. I can't bear to be here alone when he waits for me. This lake goes all the way to Arisalaru, which goes to the sea. At the bottom of the sea, my Prince awaits me. Why should I stay here, and for whom?

After deciding what to do, a strange peace settled into Vanathi's heart and she stopped running. She felt strangely light. Her worries and burdens fell away. She came near the lake and climbed down the steps that led them into the water. She looked around the lake and at a distance, she spotted a boat. Kundavai was with the warrior who had gone to Ilangai taking her message.

That's probably why the Princess wanted to meet him alone. She wanted to spare me all the horrific details of the Prince's tragic death. I need to go to him before she comes back. If she comes back, she would try to console me and would stop me from joining my beloved prince. But I do wish that I could bid her a last farewell before I leave. I wish I could thank her for all that she had done for me... but no. I can see his visage on the water again. He was calling her again with outstretched arms. 'Come... we can get married now. There are no more hurdles to cross...' Why should I wait? He is calling me now and I have to go. Why is my head whirling? Am I going to faint? It would be good if I can faint and fall into the water...

Vanathi's wish came true. She fainted and fell into the water. The cool swirling waters of the lake soothed her heated body and as she floated down, she travelled to the magical world that exists beneath the sea. Corals, pearls and many other treasures lay there, beckoning her in their midst. She saw palaces of crystal, gold, silver filled with all the treasures of the world.

Next, she saw a group of maidens who looked like snake maidens of yore with a serpentine grace and an alluring glance that made her wonder if she was in the Kingdom of Nagas.

The maidens took her into a palace and adorned her with all the beautiful ornaments that they could find in their world. A shimmering courtyard was waiting for her decorated with flowers and there stood her Prince, with a garland in his hands and a beautiful smile. They got married by exchanging garlands and the heavens showered millions of flowers to celebrate their union. Unable to bear the happiness, Vanathi fainted once again and for a long time, she felt

as though she was floating until a pair of hands held her. At first, she thought that it was Ponniyin Selvan who had taken her in his arms and held her in his lap trying to revive her. However, she heard the sound of bangles and the beautiful voice of Princess, “Vanathi! Vanathi! How could you do this to me?” With much effort, Vanathi opened her eyes and saw Kundavai’s worried face and murmured, “Akka! Akka! Did you come to my marriage? I didn’t see you there.”



Chapter 24: She regained consciousness

Vanathi fainted yet again and for a while, she remained unaware of what was happening around her. When she slowly regained her senses, the dream world faded away and she became aware of the fact that she did not marry the Prince of her dreams beneath the seas. She remembered hearing the distressful news about the Prince's death at the sea and coming to the lake. She remembered fainting and falling into the waters. As soon as she realized this, she felt an almost physical pain of a hundred spears searing her heart apart. She tried to open her eyes but they seemed to weigh upon her with a heavy burden and refused to open. She wondered for a while, who could have saved her and then remembered seeing Princess Kundavai's boat in the lake.

Why did she save me? Why didn't she leave me to my fate?

She wanted to open her eyes and fight with Kundavai. 'Why did you save me? Do you love your brother so little that you would not want me to join him in the afterlife?'

There now, the Princess is talking something. Who is she talking to?

"She is not in her senses. She is talking in her dreams. If our boat were any farther, she would have been dead by now. I shudder to think that we came so close to such a possibility."

"If she had drowned today, it would have been a sweet end for this girl. You saved her out of the goodness of your heart but unfortunately, she will undergo more suffering all through her life."

“How can you speak such heartless words? You might just prove the fact that all men are beasts with nary a heart within them.”

“Devi, what did I say? How can you call me heartless?”

“You just now said that it would have been good if she had died. Isn’t that enough? I have nurtured and taken care of this girl, for so long...”

“Didn’t you hear what she just now said?”

“What did you hear?”

“I thought I heard her talking something about marrying the Prince.”

“Yes. While unconscious she did speak something about it. Her love for the Prince is deep and pure...and she dreams of marrying him.”

“I don’t think she should harbour such impossible dreams in her heart. It isn’t good for her. She will only gain disappointment and regrets through such dreams.”

“Why do you say that? What does she lack that makes her so unfit a bride for my brother? Can you find another highborn maiden such as her? Don’t you know that Kodumballur clan is one of the oldest in our Kingdom?”

“I know that but you are not understanding my intent. No matter how highborn this girl might be, her dream will never be fulfilled.”

“It will be fulfilled. This is not merely her dream but my desire as well and my decision.”

“I regret to say, your decision in this matter will not be fulfilled.”

“Why do you keep saying that? Isn’t the Prince safe at Nagapattinam Choodamani Viharam?”

Aha! What a relief? The Prince is safe and sound. He is in Nagapattinam Choodamani Viharam. How fortunate am I? I will have to thank Princess Kundavai for saving me from drowning after all. I am indebted to the Princess for many things and now I owe my life to her. But why is he saying such things about me? Why do I feel dread and fear, even as I hear him speak?

“Devi, be rest assured, the Prince is safe. However, that doesn’t mean that he would consent to marry this girl tomorrow. I feel that he wouldn’t marry her...”

“You are free to think whatever you fancy. In this world, if there is a man who would listen to me and accede to my decision – that’s my brother Arulmozhi.”

“Princess! You forget that I too exist in this world, just to do your bidding.”

“If that is so, then why are you are being so pessimistic about everything? Who could possibly throw hurdles in our way? Do you think the Pazhuvur brothers would object...?”

“I do not know that. I do know that the Prince has boundless love and respect for you. He might listen to you in other matters. He has no wish to rule over a kingdom. He refused the throne of Ilangai before my eyes. However, if you insist, he might even agree to rule the Kingdom but he will not marry this girl...”

“Why would he do that? What possible imperfection does he see in her? What do you think is wrong with her?”

“Devi, I see no fault in this girl and even if I did I would not believe it. In my learned opinion, the women in your Palace, be it the lowest of the servant or handmaiden would seem like an apsara to my eyes.

Those adorable white rabbits in your garden seem like Iravatham^[61] to my eyes. I don't think that the Prince sees any imperfection in so fair a maiden but I fear that he might have lost his heart to somebody else..."

Ayyo! Why is this man hurting me with such words? Doesn't he know, that my heart is already bleeding?

"Vandiya Devarey! I do not understand the meaning of your words. Why are you saying such lies and falsehood about my brother?"

"They are not lies and falsehood if they are true. I am merely stating the fact, as I had seen and heard it."

"Alright. Tell me everything. I think I can hear the worst of what you have to say."

"I told you about the fisherwoman Poonguzhali didn't I? It was she, who had taken me to Ilangai. When the Prince and I were struggling to survive in the storm, it was she, who had saved our lives. She has now taken the Prince to Choodamani Viharam. I left the Prince in her care because I know for a fact that she would give her life a thousand times over before she let any harm befall him."

"So what? She is still just a fisherwoman. Would she dare to dream of marrying a Prince who would one day rule the world? Can a little sparrow dream of joining its fate with that of the mighty Garuda^[62]?"

"Why do you think it's not possible? The sparrow can look up the sky and Garuda too can look down and desire the sparrow."

"If my brother is harbouring such unwanted desires then I will ensure that they are removed from his heart. This cannot happen and nor will I allow it. I have protected my brother and have kept him safe from many dangers. I will bring him out of the seductive net of this fisherwoman."

“Do you think so less of her? Is one’s birth and family so important that it eclipses their own value? Doesn’t the fisherwoman’s blood run red? Do you think that she suffers any less than a Princess, born in a palace? When you come to think of it, one might even say that the Princess’s love for your brother is self-serving. She might want to rule over the Kingdom as a Queen but Poonguzhali’s love is pure and unsullied with such desires. That’s what the Prince believes. Why should we throw hurdles in the path of pure love? Now... take me for an example. If only I could open my heart and reveal what lies beneath...”

“No. I do wish that you could keep your heart to yourself and guard it safely. That would be the most prudent course of action for all concerned. Common people have the freedom to indulge in desires of heart but those who are born in the royal family should learn to rein in their heart and marry their equals. If they fail to do so, the repercussion of such an action would be catastrophic. There is one such example, in my own family. When my father was young, no one thought that he would ascend the throne he met a young woman in the forest and... But why am I telling you all these things? This girl is regaining consciousness. Don’t you have anything else to talk about? You did say that you encountered many other dangers while in Ilangai? Tell me more about it.”

“Yes, Princess. It happened the night the Prince had refused the throne of Ilangai. We were walking by a deserted road in Anuradhapuram that night when a house almost collapsed on us. If we had tarried there a second longer, we would have been buried alive. Thankfully, a woman appeared suddenly and called the Prince aside...”

“My God! Another woman! You both seem to need women around you at all times, to rescue you from dangers. Who is this woman?”

“I don’t know who she was but the Prince was acquainted with her... Devi, don’t get so agitated. This woman is older than him.”

“How old?”

“Old enough to be his mother and she is also deaf and mute.”

“Ayya! What are you saying? Did you really see such a woman in Ilangai? What else do you know about her? Where is she from?”

“She is from one of the many islands that are near Ilangai.”

Kundavai’s excitement reached its peak, when she heard this and she asked, “Ayya! Tell me more. How does she look?”

“Devi, her appearance was a big shock to me and I don’t know how to tell you about it.”

“Please do not hesitate. Tell me. How did she look?”

“She resembled a woman that I had seen in the Chola Kingdom. I found no other difference between them except for the fact that she was older than the other. Her attire was simple, devoid of any ornaments and her hair was free. Apart from these differences, their faces resemble each other greatly.”

“Who resembles this deaf and mute woman?”

“Devi! Can’t you guess?”

“Is it me or this girl Vanathi or could it perhaps be my mother in Thanjavur?”

“No.”

“Is it Pazhuvur Queen Nandini Devi?”

“Yes. It’s Nandini.”

“My God! My suspicions have come true.”

“What did you suspect?”

“The woman who I hate as a vile cobra might just turn out to be my own sister. Your news about the deaf and mute woman just confirmed my suspicions. If what I think is true, then fate has dealt us a very cruel hand indeed. This proves my point - a royal prince should never marry someone whose birth is inferior to theirs...”

“Devi, I am not so inferior in birth as you seem to think. My forefathers ruled over this land for more than 300 years. They won over Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas and had brought their lands under one rule. Today, I may not have a Kingdom of my own but I do have a sword in my hand, strength in my arms and courage in my heart...”

“Ayya! I will listen to stories of your valour at a later time. There are a few things that I need your help with. I hope you would help me.”

“I would give my life thousand times over for you...”

“Are you perchance this fisherwoman’s brother to offer a thousand lives to me? But let’s not talk about that girl now that Vanathi is waking up.”

Yes. By then Vanathi was fully awake and her body had regained its strength. Many thoughts flew through her mind. Foremost among them was that she wanted to show the Prince that her love for him was pure and unsullied with any unwanted desires. She resolved to end her life after proving the same to her Prince. Along with this, she also remembered the scene that had taken place in Thanjavur palace in the King’s bed-chamber. After hearing what Vandiya Devan had told about the deaf and mute woman, the Emperor’s words on that occasion started making sense to her.

When she opened her eyes, Kundavai affectionately spoke to her, “My sweet! How are you feeling now?”

“I am fine now Akka. I beg your forgiveness for giving you so much trouble.”

At that time, Azhawarkadiyan Nambi made an entrance suddenly and said, “Devi, I too would like to beg your forgiveness for the trouble but a large crowd has gathered at the gates of the palace. They are distressed over the news that the Prince has disappeared in the sea. If you do not pacify them now, they might just destroy this city in anger.”



Chapter 25: Prime Minister arrives

The city of Pazhaiaarai was in turmoil that day. People converged from every corner of the city, onto the streets that housed all the royal palaces of Kings. Old men and women, children, girls, boys and soldiers were out on the streets. Vaishnavaites, Shaivaites, Kalamugars forgot their inherent differences and stood shoulder to shoulder, outside the palace demanding to know what happened to their dear prince.

Young men with sticks and sickles stood together banging their weapons angrily, while many in the crowd urged them on saying, 'You should bang the heads of Pazhuvur brothers thus'.

The royal palaces of Pazhaiaarai were constructed in vast grounds to resemble the arc of a moon's crescent. The courtyard in the front was extended and large. A large boundary wall screened the palaces from the public eyes. During festival days, the gates of the wall would remain open for the public to enter and watch the festivities, while on the other days, the gates would remain shut. Today, however, the guards at these gates tried to contain the crowds but they were unstoppable and they burst through the gates and came inside the palace courtyard. The throngs of the crowd that entered the palace kept increasing every minute and the palace guards helplessly looked around, trying to contain them. As the crowd increased, people started pushing others from the behind and it soon looked as if, a stampede was imminent. The cries of thousands of people filled the area and it was this uproar that Dowager Queen Sembiyanmadevi heard, while she was speaking to

her son. The queen immediately bid Prince Madhuranthakan stay inside and stepped into the balcony to see what was happening. The queen's placid peaceful face brought a semblance of order among the unruly crowd below. They immediately stopped shouting and stood silent and then one of the people from the crowd asked her, "Mother! Where is our Prince? What happened to Ponniyin Selvar? Where is our darling Arulmozhi?" Following this, many others asked the same question and the uproar began again.

Sembiyanmadevi stood dazed by their questions. She then knew that something untoward had happened to Arulmozhi. Her heart was filled with dread and fear and she wondered whether the Pazhuvur brothers had a hand in it. If that were true, then they have doomed her and her son, to disgrace and infamy.

The royal messengers from Thanjavur, now came forward with great difficulty and the guards who came along with them said, "Mother! These messengers have come from Thanjavur and they have brought very important news."

Sembiyanmadevi appealed to the crowd to keep quiet and asked the messengers, "What news do you bring?"

"Mother! We are the bearers of unfortunate news. Prince Arulmozhivarmar was on his way to Kodi Karai on the orders of Chakravarthy. His ship got stuck in the cyclonic storm that raged in the sea. The Prince jumped in to save someone went missing in the sea. Arrangements have been made to search for the Prince, all along the coast and in the sea. The Emperor and the Empress are distressed beyond words, and they wish that Prince Madhuranthakan, Princess Kundavai and yourself come to Thanjavur immediately."

Hearing this, Sembiyanmadevi's eyes were filled with tears and they started flowing copiously. Those who stood near the messengers cried out aloud and the crowd's uproar started yet again. Those who didn't hear the messenger's news were distressed to see the old

queen crying and knew that something catastrophic had indeed occurred.

Many in the crowd started shouting and one of them said, “Mother! You should not go to Thanjavur and nor should Princess Kundavai. The Emperor must come here.”

Yet another shouted, “This news is false. Ponniyin Selvar didn’t drown in the sea. The Pazhuvur brothers have killed him in cold blood.”

“Prince Madhuranthakar should not go back to Thanjavur. He should stay here.”

Few other voices called out, “Where is Princess Kundavai? We wish to see her.”

Hearing this, Sembiyanmadevi bid one of her handmaidens to bring the Princess there. Azhwarkadiyan who was standing in front of the crowd heard this and left the place silently to bring Kundavai. When he entered Kundavai’s garden, he found them trying to revive Vanathi who had just regained consciousness. He informed the Princess about the thronging crowds and their demands. Kundavai entrusted the care of Vanathi to her maidservants and left the palace hurriedly.

She went to Sembiyanmadevi’s palace and joined the Dowager Queen in the balcony. The queen’s tears and worry lined face, brought tears to the Princess’s eyes. This caused more distress to the crowd, who saw this as proof that their beloved Prince was indeed dead.

They shouted, “Ponniyin Selvar didn’t drown in the sea. The Pazhuvur brothers have killed him. We must seek vengeance for their vile act.”

Many others shouted, “They have imprisoned the Emperor in his palace. If the Princess would allow us, we will go to Thanjavur and free him from their clutches.”

Kundavai was faced with a dilemma. She didn’t want to reveal to the crowd that Prince Arulmozhi was alive and safe and yet she needed to placate the crowd and send them back home. She could think of only one idea.

Wiping the tears off her eyes, Princess looked down at the courtyard. Azhwarkadiyan and Vandiya Devan were standing at the forefront of the crowd. She signalled them to come up and when Azhwarkadiyan came, she whispered something to him.

Azhwarkadiyan stepped forward to the courtyard and signalled for silence and then with a booming voice he said, “Princess Kundavai does not believe that Ponniyin Selvar is dead at the sea. Years ago, Mother Kaveri saved his life and gave him back as a gift to this Kingdom and she believes that the God of Sea too would save the Prince’s life and give him back to us. She has consulted the Soothsayer and he too says the same thing. The Princess has therefore decided that she would make proper arrangements to search the Prince. She requests you all to go back home now.”

After hearing this, the crowds cheered wildly and one of them said, “Where is this Soothsayer? We would like to hear this good news from him.”

Hearing this, Vandiya Devan stepped forward and said, “It is true that the Prince was in grave danger but the stars foretell that his life is safe. He will be back among us, soon.”

Someone from the crowd asked, “How do you know?”

“I am a Soothsayer. I studied the planets and stars and learned about the Prince’s fate.”

“Lies! You are lying. You are not a Soothsayer. You are a spy.”

Startled, Vandiya Devan looked down the crowd and found that the voice belonged to Pazhaiaarai Physician’s son.

“Fool! How dare you call me a spy? Whose spy am I, then?”

“You are the spy of Pazhuvur brothers or the Pazhuvur Queen.”

“What did you say?” growled Vandiya Devan.

The balcony where they were standing was at least 12 feet in height, and yet that didn’t deter Vandiya Devan from pouncing on the Physician’s son and soon, the two were engaged in a fistfight, while the rest of the crowd looked on.

Kundavai and the others watched this with trepidation from the balcony and the crowd started shouting, yet again.

Just then, the blaring of couches and pipes was heard and a herald announced someone’s arrival, “Make way for Prime Minister Anirudha Brahmarayar” and the crowd parted automatically.



Chapter 26: Anirudhar's request

When Anirudhar's presence was announced, the crowd parted automatically to allow his palanquin through to the courtyard. People of Pazhaiarai had immense respect for his person and had total trust upon his loyalty towards the Emperor. As he made his way through to the forefront of the crowd, many spoke to him expressing their distress about Prince Arulmozhivarmar's fate. He soothed their fears, allayed their doubts by telling them about the rescue plans that were underway. When the palanquin reached the courtyard, the bearers lay it down and he emerged out of it and looked up at the balcony. Noting that the dowager queen and princess were standing, he bowed low to them in respect. Next, he saw the fistfight that was still underway between Vandiya Devan and Pinagapani.

Yes... they were still fighting, completely unaware of what was happening around them.

The Prime Minister then told the guards, "Arrest these ruffians..." The guards along with Azhwarkadiyan moved through the crowds and pulled Vandiya Devan away from the physician's son. Azhwarkadiyan signalled Vandiya Devan to keep quiet when they bound them both in ropes and dragged them away.

Anirudhar, in the meanwhile, made his way to the balcony and addressed the crowd.

"I can understand your distress and anguish very well. The Emperor and the Empress too are equally distressed and worried about the Prince's welfare; therefore, I request you not to indulge in any activity

that would elevate their worries. I seek your support in this and hope that you will give it. I have made adequate arrangements to search for the Prince in the sea and all about the coast and I am sure, he will be found soon. I request you to go back home peacefully.”

In response to his request, many other voices rose with questions again...

“We wish to see the Emperor. We want him to return to Pazhaiaarai,”

Yet another asked, “What about the soldiers who went along with the Prince to Ilangai?”

“The Emperor is safe in Thanjavur and his palace is being guarded by Velkarar soldiers. I will bring him back here very soon...Do not worry about our soldiers in Ilangai. We have won the war in Ilangai and our soldiers will soon be on their way back home.”

Hearing the Prime Minister’s explanations, the crowd burst out in cheers and soon began to disperse. After watching this for a while, Anirudhar turned towards Sembiyanmadevi and said, “Devi, I need to discuss many important matters with you. Shall we proceed to your visitor’s chambers?”

Next, he turned towards Kundavai and said, “Princess! I need to talk to you as well, I will come to you afterwards,” Kundavai nodded her assent and went to her palace. Her troubled heart swirled with many worries.

The Prime Minister was one person in the Chola Kingdom of whom she was scared. He was a man with an eagle’s eye and was privy to many secrets that would bring his enemies to the knees. The depth of his knowledge about the kingdom and its affairs was unfathomable and no one could be sure what secrets he knew. Kundavai was often at a loss to know, what to tell him because he inevitably seemed to know at all times, what she had been up to behind his back.

When Vandiya Devan was arrested at the courtyard, the Princess was enraged beyond words, but she couldn't reveal her anger and nor could she openly support that warrior.

So, he wants to talk to me, is it? Let him come, I will give him as good as it gets. She thought to herself and went to her palace.

.....

It's a fact that Sembiyanmadevi commanded universal respect among the people in the Kingdom and the Prime Minister too treated her with utmost devotion. Despite that, the Dowager Queen stepped into her Visitor's chamber with trepidation and fear, about what he would talk about.

"Ayya! For the past few months, I have been hearing many an untoward news that has pained by heart immensely. Have you perchance come here to console me or to give more shocking news?"

"Amma! I don't know whether the news I have brought to you is 'shocking' or not. It depends on how you react to it."

"Is the news about Arulmozhi true? I cannot believe it at all. We had so many dreams about him... were they in vain? We believed that he would rule this world as one strong empire..."

"Amma! It is true that many astrologers had predicted that he would one day be an emperor but I never acknowledged it and neither did I deny it."

"Alright. I am asking you now directly. Is this news true or not, that the Prince is dead at the sea?"

"I know not whether it is true but I do know for sure that all through the Chola Kingdom this news has spread like wildfire."

“If this is true then I can’t imagine what kind of horrors are in store for our Kingdom.”

“Amma! These horrors that you speak of, is not going to wait until the news about the Prince is confirmed and they are unleashed upon us, even as we speak...”

“True! One spark of a rumour is merely enough to start a wildfire. I have never seen the people of Pazhaiaarai so enraged and angry before this...”

“You speak of Pazhaiaarai, but I have seen scenes like this all over the Kingdom. People in Thanjavur are enraged as well. They fell upon the fort, broke through the palace gates and surrounded Pazhuvetarayar’s palace. Finally, we had to let loose elephants upon them to get them to disperse...”

“Ayyo! This is horrendous.”

“I am glad that Prince Madhuranthakar came to Pazhaiaarai, or else, he too would have been blamed for the Prince’s fate, had he stayed in Thanjavur.”

“Ayya! You will be surprised to learn how much Madhuranthakan has changed in these past few years?”

“I am not surprised Devi. These are things that I have known for a while now.”

“If you had known about it, then why didn’t you make any attempt to change his mind? Alright, at least now you can help me change him.”

“Amma! I see no reason to change the Prince’s mind about ascending the throne. I came here to speak to you, on his behalf...”

“What do you mean by that? I do not understand.”

“Amma! Madhuranthakar thinks that this Chola Kingdom belongs to him, by rights. He wishes to ascend the throne after the Emperor’s reign. It is not merely a wish but a dream that has been sown deep into his heart and any attempt to uproot it would end in disaster for him and for the Kingdom as well. I think it would be more prudent of us to fulfil this wish...”

“Ayyo! What are you saying? How dare you say such treasonous words against the Emperor?”

“Amma! I will never betray the confidence that the Emperor has placed upon me. I am here, at his request pleading you to relent from your rigid stance. The Emperor wishes that Prince Madhuranthakan ascend the throne after his reign. The Pazhuvur brothers are openly conspiring for this for a long time but now with the turmoil in the Kingdom, the Emperor wishes to crown the Prince right away and retire from public life. He wants your assent for this...”

“I will never agree to such a scheme. Do not imagine that I would shirk my responsibilities and my promises to my Lord Husband. You are the Prime Minister of this Kingdom and you know everything about everything. Even if the Emperor has bid you do this how could you come here with such a request? Have you totally forgotten that there are certain truths that we both know? Have you forgotten all about them?”

“Amma! I haven’t forgotten anything. There are many other secrets that I am privy to, of which you have no inkling. That’s why I have come here on behalf of the Emperor to convince you...”

“Ayya! The whole world knows about your wit, intelligence, political acumen and strategies but I beg you, do not use them on me.”

“Amma! I didn’t come here to debate with you and nor to prove to you, my superior intelligence. I came here to beg you to consider the

Emperor's request, as you alone can save this Kingdom from utter disaster."

"Direct your pleas to the God, my Lord Shiva or to your Ranganathar. May they shower their blessings upon us all..."

"Mother! If you refuse the Emperor's plea, then we are indeed doomed and have no other recourse but the Gods.

"What sort of disaster are you talking about and how can Madhuranthakan's ascension to the throne help avert it?"

"Amma! Today you saw the people of this city enraged and up in arms, in the same manner when the news about Prince Arulmozhi spreads around, everywhere people will rise against the Kingdom swearing vengeance. If this were not enough, Kodumbalur Periya Vellar is mustering all the forces in Ilangai and is preparing to march towards Thanjavur. When this news reaches Aditya Karikalan, he too will bring his forces to the capital. Pazhuvetarayars and the other lords who support your son's claim have been busy recruiting an army, to match the forces of Karikalan and Kodumbalur Vellar. A fratricidal war is imminent and you will see your kith and kin perish, just as Pandavas and Kauravas destroyed each other. Would you watch such a carnage, silently?"

"Prime Minister! I have no kith or kin. Adi Sankarar once told –

*Matacha Parvati Devi
Pita Devo Maheshwara
Bandva: Shiva Bakthacha*

My mother is Parvati Devi, my father is Lord Shiva and all those who worship are my family. I too believe in the same. I have no one else and nor do I need them..."

"Devi, allow me to remind you the fourth phrase of the same hymn

Swadesho Buvanathrayam

The same Adi Shankarar also told us that the land of our birth holds more importance than all the three worlds. Will you see your land of your birth and the land where you ruled as a queen, torn apart in strife?"

"The land of my birth is important to me Prime Minister but there are many other places that I would love to visit. I want to go to Kashi, to Kashmir and if God wills, I will go to Kailasam. I have been wanting to start on a pilgrimage for a long time, I request you to make arrangements for the same."

"Mother! Bharatakandam is facing many new threats today. Mughal warriors and Turk warriors are on the lookout to capture new lands and their eyes are upon us. A thousand years ago, the Yavana warriors (Greek) and in the same manner these warriors too are here to loot our land. They follow a strange religion, where they are taught to raze our temples to dust and destroy our Gods. There is no kingdom in the North that is strong enough to fight these hoards. Only we have the strength of arms, to go beyond the borders of Ganga and stop these murderous fiends who have come to destroy our faith. This has been my dream for many years now, only you can help me fulfil it. If you agree to the ascension of Madhuranthakan on the Chola throne, we can arrive at a compromise and avoid fratricidal strife and our armies can help uproot the invaders."

Sembiyanmadevi remained quiet for some time and then she said, "Ayya! I am but a mere woman, how can my decision affect the course of Bharatakandam. If our lands are under such dire threat then I shall pray to my Lord Shiva to avert the danger. That's about the only thing that I can do. Beyond that, I cannot and will not forget my promise to my Lord Husband and nor will I act in a manner that would break my word to him."

"If that is your decision then I believe that it is time that you know the truth."

Before he could continue, Prince Madhuranthakar burst into the room, in a hurry, “Amma! What is this that I hear? Did Arulmozhi drown in the sea?”

“Amma! Do console your son. I will speak with you again, at a later time.” Said the Prime Minister and left the room but not before he heard the Prince’s comment about him,

“There... there goes my first enemy. He dares to come here, even while I am present, to incite you against me.”



Chapter 27: Kundavai's surprise

When Prime Minister Anirudhar entered Kundavai's visiting room in her palace, the Princess stood up respectfully and bowed seeking his blessings.

"May you find a husband who is both valorous and good-hearted!"

"Ayya! Will you bless me thus, at a time like this?"

"It seemed like the right thing to do. What sort of blessing do you seek then Princess?"

"Everyone is worried about the Emperor's state of health and my brother Arulmozhi is missing..."

"However, I don't see a trace of worry in your beautiful face..."

"I was born in a race that valued bravery, courage and valour in women. Do you want me to cry and wail like other women?"

"Definitely not. On the contrary, you need to lend some of your courage to people like me... we are in need of consolation, especially from you,"

"Acharyarey! How can I console you and with what words? You are one of those people who stands steadfast like a rock, even when the sea comes crashing on you..."

“Even the rock can crumble when the wave is strong enough. In this instance, your thoughtless actions can wreak much danger, Princess, I have always believed that women in the royal family should spend their life happily within the walls of the palace. Your interference in the affairs of the Kingdom has brought forth many misfortunes.”

“Ayyo! Why are you blaming me, thus? How did I interfere and when? What sort of misfortune, did I bring forth?”

“I wanted Ponniyin Selvan to remain in Ilangai for some more time but you sent a message asking him to come back immediately. Would your brother listen to an old man’s words as against his dear sister’s? Do you realize what you have done? Your brother sailed into the sea, despite the storm and our Kingdom lost their Prince. You saw how enraged people are outside this palace, a little while ago. This is just a glimpse of the state of affairs in this Kingdom. People all over are fuming with anger and crying for their Prince. Do you realize that you are the one, who is responsible for this?”

“Why do you say that Arulmozhi left Ilangai because of my message? Didn’t you know that the Pazhuvur brothers sent two ships, full of soldiers, to imprison him for treason?”

“I know. But if you hadn’t sent that Olai, the Pazhuvur brothers would be bearing the sole blame for the Prince’s fate but the ships that they sent were destroyed. If they counter you by saying that the Prince left Ilangai upon the receipt of your Olai, can you refute them?”

“Ayya! How do you know that I had sent the Olai? How do the Pazhuvur brothers know about it?”

“Good question Princess! Everyone hereabouts knows about the fact that you sent a message to your brother. Your messenger was first imprisoned in Ilangai by our soldiers and everyone knew that he was carrying your message. That physician’s son who travelled along with him to Kodi Karai was responsible for spreading the news here

Your secret was thus revealed to the entire world. That's why I firmly believe that women should not interfere in the affairs of the Kingdom."

Kundavai was aghast and for a long while didn't know how to answer the Prime Minister. He had effectively countered her and the bitter fact was that there was truth in what he told. When she realized that, she found herself getting angry with Vandiya Devan. She had no doubt that he was capable of brave valorous acts but his indiscretion has spoiled her plans. She wanted to meet and reprimand him strongly and that's when she remembered that the Prime Minister had placed him under arrest.

Oh God! Why does he invite trouble upon himself and on me? Why couldn't he stand quiet for a while? Why did he have to pounce on that Physician's son from the balcony?

"Ayya! I have a plea and I request you to hear it."

"Devi, you only have to command me. Who would dare refuse a request from you?"

"When you entered the palace courtyard, there were two people fighting amidst the crowd and you placed them under arrest."

"What they were doing there was nothing short of criminal activity. How dare they fight in front of the Queen, at the palace and that too amidst an enraged crowd? Just imagine what might have happened, if their actions had sparked a riot! One small spark is enough to destroy a huge forest."

"Yes. I agree with you. What they did was terribly wrong, but I wish that you would forgive and release one of them."

"Who is this lucky man who has gained the benevolence of the Princess?"

“He is the messenger that I sent to Ilangai.”

“What a coincidence!”

“Why do you say that?”

“I wanted to capture this messenger, thankfully, he got arrested here on his own.”

“Why? What’s his crime?”

“Princess! A terrible charge has been laid upon his head.”

“And what’s that?”

“That he killed Ponniyin Selvan in the sea...”

“Who lays such a vile charge upon him?”

“Many do. Parthibendra Pallavan on whose ship the Prince was travelling says so. Pazhuvetarayar says ‘that might be possible’ and I too believe that there is some truth in these accusations.”

“Acharyarey! Do you think that I would send a murderer to Ilangai to murder my own brother?”

“Never! But you might have mistaken his intentions. You believed him to be your spy, while he might have been somebody else’s all along.”

“I don’t believe that. Aditya Karikalan sent him to me, only because he is trustworthy.”

“What if Aditya Karikalan too was taken in by him? Or he might have changed his loyalties while he made his way to you. When I came to the palace courtyard, I heard that someone was being accused as a

spy. A man standing below was accusing the man standing on the balcony. What was that?"

"The man standing on the balcony was the messenger that my brother sent. His name is Vandiya Devan of Vanar clan. The man standing below was the physician's son, Pinagapani. He was accusing him of being the spy of Pazhuvetarayars. How foolish?"

"Why do you deny that possibility?"

"That is not possible. He escaped from Thanjavur right under their noses. The Pazhuvur brothers made many attempts to capture him but they were all in vain..."

"How did he get the Pazhuvur Signet ring then?"

"That vile she-demon... seductive snake... forgive me... Pazhuvur Queen Nandini gave that signet ring to him."

"I am happy that you know this information. I feared that if I had told you about it, you might not believe me. Even if this Vandiya Devan is not a spy of Pazhuvur brothers, I fear that he might be Nandini's."

"How is that possible?"

"I will tell you. Vandiya Devan met Nandini near the fort walls of Thanjavur. That was their first meeting and she gave him her signet ring then. Later, he met her again at her palace gardens, inside the fort. I believe that she helped him escape from the fort through the treasure chamber. She knew that he was taking a message to you. When he came back from Ilangai, he met her again near Harichandra River at the dilapidated Pandyan Palace. Even after all this time, he still bears that signet ring upon his person. What do you think Princess? Do you still have complete faith and trust in your messenger?"

After hearing this Kundavai found herself drowning in confusion!



Chapter 28: A spy for a spy

The Princess remained quiet, for a while, unable to decide what to answer. The Prime Minister, however, relentlessly pursued her with his question. “Why are you silent, Princess? Do you still trust that man?”

“Ayya, what can I say? If you speak for a little while longer, I might probably suspect myself...”

“The times are such that we can’t believe anyone around us. It is very difficult to bestow trust and faith on anybody these days... We have so many enemies around us today and many mysterious things are happening.”

“Nonetheless, it looks like no scheme can be planned in this kingdom, without your knowledge. How did you learn so much about my messenger?”

“Princess! I have a thousand eyes and two thousand ears and they are all over the Kingdom. I have men serving at Pazhuvur palace and one of Nandini’s men-in-arms reports to me. I have many like Azhwarkadiyan, who roam around the kingdom learning secrets, schemes and mysteries. I think I will know, whatever happens in our Kingdom and our neighbouring kingdoms, as well, but no one can be sure about it, least of all me. Maybe, there are many other mysteries that I know nothing of...”

When the Prime Minister spoke so, Kundavai couldn't help but wonder whether he knew the current whereabouts of Arulmozhi. She found it very difficult to school her face, in a manner that wouldn't reveal anything.

"Ayya! What you just said might be true but I can't believe that Vandiya Devan is Nandini's spy. I beg of you, please release him immediately."

"Princess! I want you to think about this very carefully. There is something mysterious about this woman, Nandini. Prince Madhuranthakar who was pious and devout fell into her snare and became power-hungry. Sambuverayan's son Kandan Maran has taken her message to Aditya Karikalan. Parthibendran who once opposed the Pazhuvetarayars, is now her most devoted slave. He has agreed to her scheme of dividing the Kingdom into two and to offer one part to Aditya Karikalan and the rest to Madhuranthakan and is now on his way to the Prince, to convince him about it."

"This is horrendous! How dare she suggest such a scheme? Dividing the kingdom indeed! Our ancestors bled to create this empire ..."

"I know that you will not agree to this at any cost. Ten days ago, if someone had suggested this to Parthibendran, he would be up in arms against them but today, he stands in the forefront, as one of the people, supporting this scheme."

"What is this mystery? What sort of power does this Nandini hold over these men?"

"Princess! I thought I would ask you this question and here you are asking me about it. Nonetheless, why do you think Vandiya Devan escaped Nandini's seductive net?"

"Ayya! If you ask me for a reason, I cannot give you one. Something deep within my heart tells me, that he is true in his intentions."

“If you trust him so much, then shall we put him to test?”

“What sort of test?”

“We need to send a trustworthy man to Kanchi immediately. He needs to carry our message to Aditya Karikalan.”

“What message would that be?”

“A few moments ago, you called Nandini a snake... but in truth, she is more poisonous than any deadly snake in the world. She has only one intention and goal and that is the destruction of the Chola Kingdom.”

“Oh God!” exclaimed Kundavai.

“She has invited Aditya Karikalan to Kadambur Palace under the guise of compromise. She has also proposed a marital alliance with Sambuverayar’s daughter and one of Periya Pazhuvetarayar’s daughters for the Crown Prince. The issue of dividing the kingdom would be decided at Kadambur, it seems... What worries me is that all this is being talked in open, and I dare not guess what plan she wishes to fulfil in secret. People think that I know everything that happens in the Kingdom but I have to concede defeat here, as I cannot hazard a guess about her true intentions.”

“Ayya! What do you propose that we do now?”

“We need to somehow stop Aditya Karikalan from going to Kadambur and warn him about her true intentions. Vandiya Devan will carry this message to Kanchi. If the Prince disregards our warning and goes to Kadambur, then Vandiya Devan too should accompany him and act as his shadow. He should stay with the Prince, day and night, and guard him against Nandini’s schemes. He should not allow the Prince to meet her alone, under any circumstances...”

Kundavai sighed. She understood the importance of Prime Minister's concerns but couldn't discern whether he proposed this plan after really knowing her feelings for Vandiya Devan or with purely political motives.

"Ayya! Why do you think it is important that we stop them from meeting?"

"Princess! A few bodyguards of Veera Pandyan have sworn to avenge the inglorious death of their king and are seeking to uproot the Chola race. These people are right now receiving freshly minted gold, straight from our own treasury, which is under Periya Pazhuvetarayar's control. Need I say anymore?"

"No..." mumbled Kundavai. Her forehead was creased and her thoughts were far away with her brother battling sickness in Choodamani Viharam. He too might be in great danger...

"Ayya! Our Kingdom is being struck by one tragedy after another. Amidst all this turmoil, I am happy that we have someone like you who is capable enough to steer us through this storm. What arrangements have you made with regards to my brother Arulmozhi?"

"I have made arrangements for special pooja and homam to be conducted in all Shiva and Vishnu temples. In the same manner, special pooja and prayers will be conducted in all Buddha and Jain temples as well. Choodamani Viharam in Nagapattinam is organizing a special mandala pooja... If you have any other suggestions, I can act on it."

When the Prime Minister mentioned Choodamani Viharam, Kundavai tried to discern whether there was any change in his expression but was disappointed.

"Ayya! I remembered something when you mentioned Choodamani Viharam. Periya Pazhuvetarayar for some reason is not very happy

with the Bikshus of Choodamani Viharam. It was they who brought the news about Ilangai's crown being offered to Arulmozhi. I fear that he might even blame them for the Prince's disappearance. We need to give adequate protection to the monastery..."

"I will do it at once. I will hasten to Thanjavur and with the Emperor's orders send a small army of soldiers to stand guard there. What do you say about sending Vandiya Devan to Kanchi?"

"Ayya! I understand the importance of the mission that you wish to entrust upon him and that's why I am hesitating? Should we send him for this mission?"

"If you completely trust him, then I would like to send him. I have heard of his many brave deeds and I think we need someone like him... someone who completes his mission, despite adverse circumstances. I saw with my own eyes at the courtyard. He bravely pounced on that poor Physician's son and gave him a fistful of blows. If I had not stopped their fight in the middle, that Physician's son might be on his way to Yamalogam^[63]."

Kundavai's heart blossomed when she heard these words yet she feigned hesitation and said, "He is brave, there is no doubt about that but he is also reckless. You saw how quickly he started the fight..."

"Then we can send my disciple Thirumalaiappan along with him. He doesn't have a reckless bone in his body but his mind is sharper than anybody else."

When Kundavai gave her assent to Prime Minister's idea she thought thus –

*Even the Gods cannot learn what lies deep within this man's heart.
Now he wishes to send a spy after a spy...*



Chapter 29: Vanathi's transformation

When Kundavai was about to leave the palace to release Vandiya Devan from the prison, Vanathi appeared before her and bowed respectfully.

“My dearest! I left you and came away... I still have a few affairs to sort out. I will be back very soon, until then, why don't you sit in the garden but don't go near the lake.”

“Akka! I have decided not to be a trouble for you anymore. I wish to return to Kodumbalur.”

“What is this? Has everyone suddenly decided to abandon me? Are you angry with me? Why this sudden love for your native home?”

“If I were to get angry with you akka, then I would probably be the most ungrateful creature in this world. I haven't developed any sudden love for my native home either. What use is a native home, when you have no parents? My mother, when she was alive had wanted to perform a puja at the nearby Kali temple in Kodumbalur, but she died without fulfilling it. I wish to perform this puja and fulfil her wish. Maybe, I will stop fainting, once I discharge this duty...”

“You don't have to go all the way to Kodumbalur, just for this. I can send word to them to perform the puja.”

“That's not the only reason, why I wish to go to Kodumbalur. I heard that my uncle Periya Vellar is marching towards Thanjavur. He will not come to Pazhaiaarai to meet me, as it would be out of the way,

but I want to meet him at Kodumbalur and learn all that had happened in Ilangai.”

“Why are you so interested in learning about what happened in Ilangai?”

“Have you forgotten that my father too died in Ilangai?”

“I have not forgotten... but there is no taint to his name now.”

“I doubt that. My uncle led the battle campaign in Ilangai but now he is coming back in a hurry, without completing his mission.”

“Are you going to ask him to go back to Ilangai to resume the war? Is that why you want to meet him in Kodumbalur?”

“Who am I to say these things? I just wish to learn what had transpired there...”

“Aha! You wish to learn more about the brave deeds that Ponniyin Selvan did in Ilangai.”

“Is that wrong akka?”

“No. What is wrong is the fact that you are trying to abandon me at a time when I need you more than ever...”

“Akka! I am but one of your many companions. You have scores of relatives, friends, servants and handmaidens, who are ready to fulfil your wishes... How can you say that I am leaving you alone?

“Even you have begun to talk like this Vanathi! I think the news about my brother has addled your mind. You don’t have to worry too much about it...”

“Akka! My worries about him can’t be any greater than yours... you are his sister after all!”

“Tell me the truth! Did you fall in the lake on your own or did you faint?”

“Why would I fall into the lake deliberately? I fainted and fell in the lake and you saved me.”

“You don’t seem grateful enough for saving your life...”

“I will be eternally grateful to you... not only in this life but for eternity.”

“You are talking as if, this life is over... listen to me Vanathi! Do not worry your heart about Ponniyin Selvan. I do not think that he is in any danger. I spoke to the people of Pazhaiaarai about this and let me repeat the same to you. Once when he was young, Mother Kaveri saved his life and gave him back to us, I think the God of Sea will do the same again. We will soon know more news about him and you will know that I am right.”

“How do you know anything for sure? Do you have any proof to support your belief?”

“I believe my heart Vanathi. If something untoward had happened to my brother, I would know it immediately. If he was really in danger, would I be talking to you like this?”

“I do not trust the heart anymore, akka!”

“Why do you say that?”

“For the past few days, I have been seeing a dream. A dream that I see sometimes when I am awake...”

“What dream is that?”

“I see your brother’s face on the water and then I can hear him calling me.”

“This may not be a dream Vanathi, it is a vision that proves to us that this news is true.”

“I don’t know about that akka. If you hear my dream fully you will know. When I fainted in the lake, I went to Nagalokam and I saw a wedding...”

“Who was getting married?”

“I do not wish to tell you that akka! That dream has proved to me that one’s heart can’t be trusted. What we feel and think is different from reality. I have henceforth decided to trust facts that can be ascertained by one’s eyes and ears.”

“Vanathi! What you are saying is wrong! There have been many instances where what one hears and sees have been proven wrong. I can give you many examples of this from stories and myth.”

“I will listen to them at a later akka. For now, I beg you... allow me to leave.”

Kundavai was shocked. She wondered from wherefore, this girl became so determined and resolute to have her way!

“Vanathi! Why this hurry? If you are so determined to go to Kodumbalur, then tarry for a few days. The kingdom is under turmoil and chaos. I will need to make proper arrangements for you to go...”

“Akka! I have no fear. The palanquin bearers who brought me from Kodumbalur are sitting here idly. They will take me back home...”

“That’s not proper! You think I will send you home thus without any escort or guards...”

“Akka! I beg you... I am not frightened of travelling alone. Who would dare to harm me? Everyone knows that I am your cherished companion. I will, however, beg a favour of you. I would like to visit Kudanthai Jodhidar on my way to Kodumbalur. I have a few questions for him.”

“Even I wish to visit him but you are in such a hurry...”

“No Akka! This time, I wish to meet him alone.”

This completed Kundavai’s astonishment about Vanathi’s transformation.

When did she change from a frightened mouse of a girl to this determined woman?

That’s when she knew that it would be impossible to stop Vanathi’s journey.

“Alright, Vanathi. Do as you wish. Prepare for the journey, while I go to the prison, to release Vandiya Devan...”



Chapter 30: Two prisons

Kundavai went to the city's prison directly after her conversation with Vanathi. She asked the guards to wait outside and entered the building, where Vandiya Devan was kept in an isolated cell. When she entered the outer chamber, she found him singing a love song with his back on the cell bars.

Kundavai waited until he finished the song and then coughed discreetly, to gain his attention. Vandiya Devan turned around immediately and welcomed her, "Welcome! Princess! Do sit down!"

"Where do I sit?"

"This is your palace. The city is under your reign. You can sit on any of the thrones available here..."

"When the Vanar clan ruled over this Kingdom did your people build palaces like this? Under our reign, we call this a prison."

"Devi, I do not know how a palace or prison looks like, because we have none in our city. A hundred years ago, many kings brought their armies to our city and destroyed our prisons and palaces."

"Why would they do that? Why did they hate your palaces and prisons?"

"They were destroyed, thanks to a poet's imagination."

“Really! How did that happen?”

“When my forefathers ruled over this Kingdom, they would imprison the kings and noblemen who didn’t pay their taxes on time. They would be held in cells that overlooked the palace and they would be made to wait for days, before the King would grant them an audience. These people would wait in the cells and watch the days roll by, hoping that one day, the King would call them to the court, where they could apologize and go back home.

But unfortunately, it was not easy to gain an audience with the King, unless, you happen to be a poet. These poets were fortunate beings, who could gain the King’s attention any time of the day and when they left, they were plied with gifts, precious jewels and what not!

The noblemen and petty kings who were imprisoned would watch these poets take away the gifts, that they had once given the King. ‘Aha! See how lucky these poets are? Isn’t he carrying the golden umbrella, that I once gifted the King? Look at that! That poet is going away on my chariot! This one is taking my best horse! Ayyo! My royal elephant is bearing that god-forsaken poet!

In the end, there came a poet who heard the lament of these kings and he composed a poem on it. This unknown poet spread the poem all over the Kingdom and the people would listen to it with love and pride. One day, this very poem became the bane of our life, when many kings joined their forces together and attacked us, razing our palaces and prisons to dust...”

“Even if they razed your palaces to the ground, they couldn’t destroy this poem that describes the greatness of Vanar Kings. Your clan is indeed glorious...”

“It is, however, unfortunate that the glorious name of Vanar clan is getting tainted because of my actions.”

“Aha! So you will accept the truth, no matter how bitter it is?”

“What else can I do? They say that of all kinds of slavery in this world, the worst is to be a slave of a woman. In the name of fulfilling your wishes, I tainted the glorious name of my clan. I had to hide, lie, use dirty strategies and tricks, just to keep myself alive. When I sought to release my anger and frustration on that physician’s son, that satisfaction too was snatched away from me.”

“Ayya! Why are you so angry with the Physician’s son Pinagapani?”

“I have valid reasons to get angry. Couldn’t you find somebody sane to send along with me to Kodi Karai? He almost sabotaged my mission to Ilangai. And if that weren’t enough, he tried to get me arrested as a spy and after I escaped from that he pursued me again and accused me of being Pazhuvur queen’s spy, in front of thousands of people...”

“Prince of Vallam! Isn’t that true?”

“Isn’t what true?”

“The charge that you are Nandini’s spy?”

“Devi, I have taken a vow never to tell the truth.”

“That’s a good vow to follow. Did you perchance take it, after meeting Nandini at the Harichandra River?”

“No! I took this vow much before that. People kept believing my lies all the time and yet once when I told the truth that the ‘Prince was safe in Nagapattinam’ they laughed...”

“I am glad that they didn’t believe the truth that you uttered. Just imagine what could have happened?”

“Devi, it was a blunder that I would never repeat...”

“I thank you for that promise.”

“Promise? What promise did I make?”

“You just now promised me that you would avoid making blunders and fulfil the mission that I give you...”

“My God! When did I say that? Enough! Release me from this prison... I will be on my way...”

“If that is so, then I will never release you from this prison. You will have to live the rest of your life here.”

Vandiya Devan laughed.

“Why are you laughing? Did I say something amusing?”

“No Devi, do you think that I depend upon ‘you’ to release me from this prison? Do you think that this prison can hold me for long?”

The Princess looked at him silently for a while with a strange intensity.

“Ayya! You are far too clever for prisons such as this. You are indeed skilled in escaping from them. For a man who escaped the treasure chamber of Pazhuvetarayar, this can hardly pose a challenge.”

“If you truly think so, then open this cell and release me.”

“I might open the doors of this cell for you or you might escape the confines of this prison on your own but know this, there is a prison that you will never escape from.”

“Are you perchance referring to the underground prison in Thanjavur that is under the command of Chinna Pazhuvetarayar?”

“No! You are clever enough to overcome the tigers and escape...”

“Then what prison are you referring to?”

“I was referring to my heart...”

“Devi! I am an orphan. I have neither a home nor a roof. I have no one to call my own. The glories of my ancestors are merely stories and some even dismiss it as a poet’s imagination. You are the Princess of this realm, the daughter of the Emperor who rules over many Kingdoms...”

“Who knows, maybe one day, even our glories might become old stories...”

“Be that as it may, but you can’t dispute the fact that you are the daughter of the Emperor today. Noble Lords like Pazhuvetarayars and even the Prime Minister of this Kingdom, are bound to obey your command.”

“If what you say is true, then how can you defy my commands?”

“Wielding political power is different, while you are talking about ruling over your heart.”

“What’s so wrong about it?”

“What is wrong, is our status in this world. You are a Princess and I am an ordinary soldier.”

“Have you heard of this proverb – ‘Is there a bar that can restrain love?’”

“Wouldn’t this proverb prove true in the case of Poonguzhali and Ponniyin Selvar?”

“Yes. You are right. I thought that my brother was destined to rule this world, so I sought to bar his heart.”

“I had heard so much about him and was very eager to meet him. I wished to travel by his side to far away kingdoms, win glories and victories...”

“I guess that you have lost that particular wish of yours?”

“Yes. Ponniyin Selvar doesn’t seek kingly glories. He is content with a peaceful life. He wishes to build temples, that would astonish one and all, rather than wage wars...”

“In the meanwhile, Madhuranthakan is single minded about ruling this kingdom. The goat has become the tiger and the tiger is happy to be the goat.

“And thanks to you, I became the night wolf. I had to hide, lie and cheat - just to save my skin and escape from my enemies. Princess! I am unsuited for this work! I beg you to release me...”

“Ayyo! Why is everyone abandoning me at the time of my need? Vanathi, who was my dear friend and companion, wants to leave me. Will you abandon me too?”

“Devi, I know not what transpired between the Kodumbalur Princess and yourself. There are Princes, Kings and Noblemen who would consider themselves fortunate if you would but spare a glance at them and they are ready to hold your hand to their hearts, if you would give them a chance. On the other hand, I was sent here to serve you...”

Hearing this, Kundavai extended her hand towards him. Vandiya Devan looked at her astonished and then hesitantly grasped with both his hands. He bent his head and held her hand reverently to his eyes. Every nerve end of body tingled with desire, love and longing.

“Vandiya Devarey! I was born in a family that celebrates a woman’s virtue, just as they would a man’s bravery. Many women born in our

family, considered it their duty to follow their husbands to the funeral pyre...”

“I have heard, Devi...”

“Then know this... the hand that touched you today, will never know the touch of any other man,”

They stared at each other silently... wordlessly. Vandiya Devan couldn't look away from the tear-filled eyes of Kundavai.

“Ayya! You are too reckless. I fear for your life. If anything were to happen to you, what will become of me?”

“Devi! I am fortunate to have gained a place in your heart but do not ask me to be a coward.”

“There is a vast difference between being cautious and in being a coward. Even Prime Minister Anirudhar doesn't doubt your bravery...”

“Then, what does he doubt?”

“He fears that you might be Nandini's spy.”

“If that is so, then allow me to give him the same answer that I gave that Physician's son. Open the door of this cell and tell me where I can find him.”

“The Physician's son at least knew a little bit of fist fight but our Prime Minister has always exercised his sharp mind, instead of a sword.”

“Then I will let him know how sharp my sword is...”

“Next to the Emperor, it is Prime Minister Anirudhar who the people trust and respect. Even the Pazhuvur brothers steer clear of him...”

“Pazhuvetarayars tainted their hearts when they rose against the Kingdom and the Emperor. They would steer clear of anybody, who would tell the truth. I have nothing to hide...”

“Anirudhar is the cherished friend of my father, since childhood. If you disrespect him, you would be disrespecting me and the Emperor.”

“If that is so, then tell me how I can win his confidence.”

“He wishes to send someone trustworthy to Kanchi. I have assured him that you can undertake this mission...”

“Devi, do not send me to Kanchi. A voice within my heart keeps telling me, ‘Do not go to Kanchi’.

“Could that voice perchance belong to Nandini?”

“Never! I would never listen to that snake.”

“Ayya! Please do not call her thus, I beg you.”

“What is this? Why this sudden change?”

“Yes. My heart has changed indeed after I heard about that deaf and mute woman in Ilangai.”

“If that is so, then, you will be telling me next that I will have to behave respectfully towards her.”

“Yes.”

“So, if she were to hand me the sword that she worships every day, and asks me to kill someone, should I go ahead and do it?”

Kundavai shivered when she heard this. “It is enough if you are respectful towards her, you don’t have to listen to her. I fear that she has no idea what she is involved in.”

“She too said the same thing. She said, ‘I know not, why I am worshipping this sword’”

Hearing this Kundavai shivered once again and said shakily, “Only God can save the Chola race.”

“And I wish that the God would use me as a weapon to save it.”

“I wish the same too. Once you return from Kanchi, I want you to return to Ilangai and bring that deaf and mute woman to me...”

“That would be impossible. It would be like trying to bring a storm ashore.’ Someone said this once... yes Azhwarkadiyan did. Maybe he tried to do it once.”

“No. He couldn’t do it. I think that only you can do it.”

“If you truly believe that then don’t send me to Kanchi.”

“Why?”

“My master is in Kanchi and if he asks me, I will be honour bound to tell him everything. If he comes to know of the conspiracy that the noblemen are hatching, he will be furious. If he knows that the Emperor is literally treated like a prisoner, then he would immediately start for the capital, to release him. If he had heard the news about his brother, he might have left Kanchi, even as we speak.”

“That’s exactly why we are sending you. You will need to stop him from leaving Kanchi.”

“What if he had already left?”

“If he has already left, then join him on the way... you will need to do a very important thing”

“Tell me.”

“I have received word that Periya Pazhuvetarayar and Nandini have started from Thanjavur and are on their way to Kadambur.”

“Is he going there with Nandini or is he taking someone else in her palanquin?”

“No! It is Nandini who will be travelling with him. My uncle is here. How could it be him?”

“Why are they going to Kadambur?”

“They have invited Aditya Karikalan to Kadambur. Outwardly, they wish to discuss marriage and a compromise by dividing the Kingdom into two.”

“My master would never agree to that.”

“I am not worried about that at all.”

“Then what are you worried about?”

“A nameless dread has filled my heart. Sometimes, I wake up in the middle of the night, with my heart pounding away. If I happen to sleep, I dream of darkness that comes swirling towards me. This darkness brings along with it many ominous dreams, that I dare not describe.”

“In such a situation, why do you want me to leave you and go away? I would give my life to save you from any danger...”

“Ayya! I do not fear any danger to myself but for my brother. My fears are for Nandini too. I dread them meeting again. I want you to stop

them.”

“Devi, you know your brother. If he decides to do something it would be impossible to stop him.”

“And yet, I wish that you become his armour. If necessary, I give you leave to tell Karikalan who Nandini really is?”

“Will he believe it?”

“You will need to make him believe it somehow. If you could but stop them from meeting, many dangers can be averted.”

“Devi! I will try to fulfil this mission but I doubt if it would be successful. Do not blame me if I fail.”

“Ayya! Irrespective of whether you succeed or fail, you will remain imprisoned in my heart.”



Chapter 31: Verdant green lands

Next day, Vandiya Devan found himself on his way to Kudanthai through the banks of Arisalaru River bearing the message that Prime Minister Aniruthar had given for Aditya Karikalan. It was a beginning of the monsoon season (the month of Aipasi^[64] in Tamil Calendar) and the everywhere in the Kingdom he could see verdant green lands and cool breeze serenading the trees. He could see various hues of green enchanting the senses. Doting these green lands and farms, were pristine ponds and lakes, reflecting the cloudy skies and welcoming the occasional drizzle of the rain.

Vandiya Devan drank in the beautiful scenes that unfolded in front of him and couldn't help remembering the sights he had seen two months ago when he passed by the same route. The varying shades of green fields made a very alluring picture and he compared it with the sage green leaves of the trees, the soft green grass of the meadows and the gleaming green of the frogs that were leaping about.

As he trotted his horse slowly, he realized that his heart was weighed down by sorrow and that was preventing him from enjoying these sights fully. This was strange because there were many reasons for him to be enthusiastic about. Two months ago, when he passed by this way, all the desires that he had borne in his heart have been

fulfilled. Some of those wishes were mere dreams that he had never hoped to fulfil in the first place!

He met the Emperor Sundara Chola... he also had the opportunity of visiting cities such as Thanjavur, Pazhaiaarai, Anuradhapuram, Maanthotham...he won the friendship and trust of the most beloved prince in Chola Kingdom, Prince Arulmozhivarman...he also got a chance to help the Prince at an opportune moment...he met the most beautiful woman in Chola Kingdom and was lucky enough to secure a place in her heart... now who could be more lucky than that? When he remembered their last meeting and Kundavai's declaration he felt happy and sad, in equal measures. Questions and doubts, swirled through his mind... Do I truly deserve her? Will our wishes ever get fulfilled? What if there are insurmountable hurdles in our way?

Aha! There is no dearth of hurdles! The world is indeed full of hurdles, thanks to people like Ravidasan, who conspire against the Kingdom, seductresses like Nandini, noble lords like Pazhuvur brothers who turn against their own king, unworthy friends like Kandanmaran and Parthibendran, lovelorn girls like Vanathi and Poonguzhali and if that weren't enough spies like that Veera Vaishnavan, Kalamugars, who can't fill the belly of the largest quick sands in Kodi Karai...

With the grace of God, I have somehow escaped from all these dangers.

But he knew that none of the dangers that he had faced so far could compete with what he might have to face in this mission that the Prime Minister had set about for him. On one side there is Prince Aditya Karikalar, whose recklessness was legendary and on the other, is a seductress who has reduced one of the most powerful lords of the Kingdom into a mere puppet.

How does he expect me to foil their meeting? Is that even possible? What does that Brahmarayar, think of himself? What is his ultimate

plan here? Does he wish to remove me from the Princess' heart altogether? He said that Azhwarkadiyan would join me on the way and he too has not shown up yet. How long do I rein in the horse and trot slowly? I don't really know, who that Vaishnavan is truly, but he has only helped me in all the time I have known him. If he comes along, the rigours of the journey would disappear.

There....those thick groves of trees. That's where I met the Princess for the second time where they were trying to scare Princess Vanathi with the crocodile. When all her companions laughed at my stupidity, Princess Kundavai came forward and spoke sweetly and put the girls in their proper place. Let me stop here for a moment...

Vandiya Devan got down from the horse and stood near the trees almost reliving the moment. As he stood watching the water, he could almost see the Princess's face reflected on the water and it increased his longing to see her again... That's when, he heard a familiar voice singing from the top of the tree. It was Azhwarkadiyan perched on top of the tree singing a song about how divine the Lord Vishnu's form was...

"Oho! So, I look divine to your eyes Vaishnavaney! Please give me the opportunity to see your divine form, as well. Kindly come down the tree and favour me with your presence."

Azhwarkadiyan got down from the tree and said, "I was not singing about you! You don't look divine, by any measure. I would say that you look only dangerous with your long sword, daggers, spear and what not..."

"Then whom were you referring to?"

"I was singing about my Lord Vishnu; whose dwarf form was enough to measure this entire world under his foot..."

"Stop! You will henceforth stop deriding Lord Shiva thus. If you persist, you will encounter danger."

“What danger? I am under the protection of my Lord Vishnu who didn’t think twice before mounting his Garuda and come all the way from Vaikuntam^[65] just to rescue, a mere elephant from a crocodile.”

“It was my duty to warn you and I did that.”

“Alright tell me. What danger are you talking about?”

“That day in Pazhaiaarai, when the people crowded around the Palace, I heard a few Kalamugars discussing....”

“What were they discussing?”

“They wanted to sacrifice the growing crop of Vaishnavaits to Maha Kali and then build a pyramid of their skulls and dance a thandavam^[66] atop!”

Vaishnavan brushed his hand on his head and said, “This seems strong enough and I am sure it can withstand the dance of the Kalamugan.”

“I think you will find my warning in good stead because since morning I have been seeing more and more Kalamugars, going this way, rattling their skull garlands and heaving their trident, up and down. It would be better, if you could take Lord Shiva’s name and remove that knot of hair in the front...”

“Never! Thambi! Never!”

“What ‘never’?”

“I said that my mouth could never utter the name ‘shiva’ and change my appearance. I can probably take my Lord Vishnu’s name and change it perchance. Look there!”

Vandiya Devan looked at the direction, where Azhwarkadiyan was pointing. Along the road, a palanquin was coming borne by bearers and a woman companion was walking beside it. The gilded palanquin resembled those that a high-born maiden might travel in and this made Vandiya Devan wonder as to who would be going within. For a minute, he wondered if it might be Princess Kundavai and then immediately dismissed the idea.

“Vaishnavarey! Who do you think is going in that Palanquin?”

“Thambi! Listen to me. Do not interfere in matters that do not concern you. You have got into many troubles because of this habit of yours. People, palanquins, chariots and horses will go on the King’s road and how do they concern you or your mission? Just get on your horse and gallop away!”

“Really! Looks like our good old Vaishnavan has become all business these days! Maybe you have forgotten what happened in Veeranarayanapuram? Didn’t you ask me to take a message to that woman in the palanquin?”

“That’s old story. Why do you rake it up now?”

“They said that you would join me on the way. That’s why, I have been trotting this horse along slowly.

“You are travelling on a horse while I am walking afoot. How can we travel together? You go on your way and wait for me near Kollidam River. I will join you there tomorrow.”

Vandiya Devan then knew that Azhwarkadiyan was engaged in some other secret spy work that he didn’t wish to inform him about.

“Alright! As you wish.” He said and mounted his horse and noticed that storm clouds had gathered in the sky.

“Vaishnavarey! Do you think it will rain?”

“Do you think I know astrology? It is the month of monsoon, so one can expect rains at any moment. It would be best, if you were on your way as fast as possible. Try to find a place to stay dry tonight.”

Vandiya Devan for once heeded Azhwarkadiyan’s words and galloped away but when he mentioned ‘astrology’ he remembered Kudanthai Jodhidar. His house lay on the way and he thought it would be interesting to meet him, before he started his new mission. He can try and find what the stars say about Chola Kingdom now.

Will Madhuranthakan ascend the throne? What about Arulmozhi-varmar? The astrologer had compared him to Dhruv star (Pole Star). What would his fate be? He said that the Prince would one day become an emperor? How will that come true, when he carelessly rejected the throne of Ilangai?

What about the predictions that were made about me? Will I ever get back my Kingdom from the tiger’s mouth? What about my new mission? Will I succeed in it? How can I prevent Karikalar from meeting Nandini?

In the past, he had met her twice and had gotten away through sheer luck.

Will my luck hold on forever? Whenever he thought about Nandini, an unknown dread flooded his heart even though she had behaved with him with utmost respect and love, he couldn’t fathom her motives, by any measure. He often suspected that she had allowed him to escape time and again, for some future purpose that might lead to his utter devastation. That’s another reason, why he was reluctant to accept this mission.

As he galloped away, his horse rode through the same path that the palanquin had taken a few moments ago. Soon, he could see it bearing down the pathway. He overtook it but not before seeing who was inside it. It was Kodumbalur Princess Vanathi!

He almost reined in the horse and stopped it but then changed his mind and went ahead. He remembered Kundavai had mentioned something about Vanathi leaving her during their last conversation.

Where is this young maiden going, that too without any proper escort?

He became more worried about her when he noticed a few Kalamugars under a tree whispering amongst them, as they watched the palanquin with their red-rimmed eyes. To Vandiya Devan, they looked like the same Kalamugars, whom he had encountered earlier near the Harishchandra River.

What's their interest in this young girl? Why are they looking at her palanquin thus?

Vandiya Devan didn't have much sympathy for Vanathi. He had often felt that the Princess was out to steal Arulmozhivarmar away from Poonguzhali. Many a time, he also felt an irrational anger towards the poor princess! However, Princess Kundavai had boundless love for the girl and would be devastated if some danger befell her.

Why would she be in danger? No! No! Azhwarkadiyan was right. I need to focus on my mission and not get distracted by women.

Despite this resolution, he found himself getting uneasy as he encountered more Kalamugars on the way. Soon, he neared Kudanthai and could sight the astrologer's hut. That's when he realized that the Kodumbalur Princess too might be on her way to consult the astrologer. Thinking thus, he tethered the horse to a tree near the house and entered it.



Chapter 32: Brahma's head

When Vandiya Devan entered Kudanthai Jodhidar's house for the second time, he experienced the pleasure of reliving his first glimpse at Kundavai. He remembered seeing her lotus-hued complexion flushed, animated and her eyes wide in surprise, when she saw him barging him inside the house. He remembered her soft voice laughing...

Jodhidar who was making preparations for the evening pooja greeted him happily.

"Welcome! Welcome! Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan, you are most welcome!"

"Jodhidarey! Though your astrology is not very accurate, your memory is sharp indeed!"

"One needs good memory to learn astrology, as we need to memorize the names of the planets, directions, bhukti, stars, their movements and many other minute details that rule our fate. Keeping this in mind, we need to take into consideration the past, present and future, before we can predict even a small thing. But why do say that my astrology is not very accurate? Didn't my predictions come true?"

"Can't you find that out in your astrology?"

“Of course, I can but I would rather use my deduction skills. My predictions about your future must have come true or else why did you seek me out again?”

“True! Very true! Your predictions did come true.”

“There! That is very gratifying to hear. Now tell me, which prediction came true?”

“All of your predictions came true. You predicted that ‘your mission might become successful or not successful’ and that was very accurate.

“Thambi! You have a great sense of humour.”

“True, but I am also quick tempered.”

“You need to leave your temper outside, when you come into my house.”

“I would have done that but there was no one out there to guard it. What if someone makes off with my bag of temper? I didn’t see your disciple outside? Where is he? I still remember the way, he barred my entry, the last time I came here.”

“Today is Amavasya. He has gone to the banks of Kollidam.”

“What’s the connection between Amavasya and Kollidam river bank?”

“Today, a huge gathering of Kalamugar Saivaites is meeting near the banks of Kollidam. My disciple belongs to that sect.”

“I have been thinking for some time now. I want to turn myself into a Vaishnavait, like your friend Azhwarkadiyan Nambi.’

“Why?”

“I saw some Kalamugars, while I was on the way here. They were all wearing garlands of skulls. I found it repulsive. I would rather be a Vaishnavaita than hold skulls.”

“That’s surprising. You have fought in so many battles and wars, why do you fear skulls?”

“I do not fear them but I do find them distasteful. There is a difference between killing your foes in the battlefield and wearing their skulls as a garland.”

“Didn’t your master Aditya Karikalar behead Veera Pandyan and take it along with him in a victory procession?”

“He had sworn a holy oath to behead Veera Pandyan. I know that he regretted his actions later but he never wore the head or the skull as a garland like these Kalamugars do. Why do they do it, anyway?”

“They wear a garland of skulls to remind themselves that life is transient filled with momentary happiness and sadness. Do you know, why we smear the holy ash on our body? It is to remind ourselves that we too, would one day turn into ash.”

“I understand what you are saying. None of us here are immortal. One day, we will be dead and gone and turn into ashes. But why does Lord Shiva hold a decimated head on his head. He is an eternal being, he can’t die?”

“The head that Lord Shiva holds denotes the pride of man. He carries it with him to remind us that if we win over pride, then we will attain a state of pure bliss and happiness.”

“How could the head denote pride of the man? I don’t understand.”

“There are many things that you need to understand thambi! Let me tell you the story. Once Brahma and Vishnu taking pride in their

prowess, tried to establish supremacy over each other claiming that they were powerful than the other. Shiva interjected in this fight and became a long pillar of fire and asked Vishnu to find his feet and Brahma to find his head. Vishnu took the form of a wild boar and dug through the ground to find the feet, while Brahma turned into a swan and flew high to find the head. Vishnu came back and accepted that the pillar of fire was endless and that he was unsuccessful, while Brahma lied and said that he had seen the head. Enraged by his lie, Lord Shiva took for himself, one of Brahma's five heads and since then the lord of the creation is seen with only four heads."

When the astrologer finished the narration, Vandiya Devan started laughing.

"Why are you laughing thambi?"

"If someone were to punish me in the same manner, then at the very least, I will need ten thousand heads."

"So, you have told so many lies!"

"That's right. I think there is something special about my horoscope. After meeting Prince Arulmozhivarmar, I decided to speak only the truth. I tried to stay true to my resolution and uttered a very important truth at one point but no one believed it and who ever heard it, laughed."

"Thambi! Times are so bad these days. People find it difficult to distinguish lies from the truth."

"Looks like even your astrology is fated to be false. Do you remember what you told me about Prince Arulmozhivarmar? Didn't you compare him to the Dhruv Nakshatram?"

"Yes, I did. What of it?"

"Haven't you heard about the rumours of his death?"

“How could I not hear? The entire kingdom is under turmoil.”

“So, do you think the Pole Star has drowned under the sea?”

“It cannot drown in the sea but it might be hidden beneath the clouds. Today, if you look at the night sky, you will see dark clouds and nary a star. If a star is hidden by the clouds, it doesn’t mean that it has disappeared is it?”

“Is that so? Then do you know any news about Ponniyin Selvar?”

“How would I know that? You were the one who jumped into the sea along with him. If someone in this Kingdom knows about the Prince, that would be you. I had thought to ask you about him.”

Sensing the dangerous turn of their conversation, Vandiya Devan changed the subject.

“What of the comet? How is that faring?”

“You will find it extending from one end of the sky to another. Very soon, it will disappear and god knows what calamity it will bring upon us. Our elders say that death is imminent in the royal family, when the comet appears in the sky.”

Vandiya Devan’s mind ran through different possibilities from one location to another. Emperor Sundara Chola paralyzed and weak to Prince Arulmozhivarmar in the grips of a deadly shivering fever and Prince Aditya Karikalar who would soon meet Nandini at Kadambur Palace and Prince Madhuranthakar who had earned the disrespect of the subjects, whom he wished to rule.

Whom will the comet strike dead?

“Never mind all that. Why should we discuss royal affairs? Tell me about my future?”

“Whatever I predicted earlier holds good even today. You will encounter many dangerous situations but you will also get unexpected help against your adversaries.”

Just then, he heard a sound outside the hut and wondered whether it was impending danger or help. The astrologer and Vandiya Devan looked towards the door when Princess Vanathi and her companion, entered the hut.

Vandiya Devan leapt to his feet and bowed respectfully and said, “Devi, I didn’t know that you were headed here. If I had known, I wouldn’t have come.”



Chapter 33: Vanathi seeks help

“Ayya! Why are you so angry with me? What harm have I ever done to you?” asked Vanathi and her soft feeble voice melted Vandiya Devan’s heart. He began to wonder, why he was angry with this Princess, in the first place. Then he remembered Poonguzhali and wondered whether there was any justification, to hate Vanathi just because she too, loved the Prince.

“Devi! Forgive me! It was not my intention to hurt your feelings. I only meant that I would be happy to wait for you, outside the hut, while you consult the astrologer. I am not in a hurry to leave, hence I can await your pleasure.”

“There is no need for you to wait outside. I am happy to learn that you are not in a hurry though. In truth, I didn’t come here to consult the astrologer. I have no faith in his astrology anymore...”

“Devi! No matter what you think of me today, I am positive that one day, you will remember this poor man, when my predictions come true.”

Vanathi said, “I doubt that” and turned towards Vandiya Devan and said, “Ayya! I stepped into this hut, just to have a word with you. I saw you on the road and thought that you might stop the horse and speak to me but you seemed angry for some reason and galloped

away. I am not surprised by your actions because why would you care about an orphaned girl anyway?"

Emotionally moved by her words, Vandiya Devan emphatically said, "Devi! How could you say such words? You are the adopted daughter of your uncle Budhi Vikrama Kesari and the cherished companion of Princess Kundavai. I felt that it might be not be courteous to stop and speak with you, whilst on the road. Please forgive me, if I had offended you. If you think that I can help in any way, I would be glad to do it..."

"Yes. I need your help. I came here, just to seek assistance from you."

"If it is within my powers to help you, I would be happy to do it."

"Is there anything that you cannot do? I have heard all about your adventures, when you were in Ilangai. Would you promise me that you would help me for sure?"

Vandiya Devan with a great deal of hesitation said, "Devi, if you can tell me what sort of assistance you require, then I can help you."

"Alright. I will tell you about it. It doesn't matter, if our astrologer also gets to know of it. I have decided to join the faith of Buddha and become a Bikshuni."

"What? What?"

"What is this?"

"How can this be?"

"Never!"

"You can't do this."

“This will never happen!”

Kudanthai Jodhidar and Vandiya Devan declared their reactions to Vanathi’s startling decision thus but the Kodumbalur Princess went on to say, “Yes I have decided to give up on this world and embrace the faith of Buddha. Why do you object to my decision? So many women in our Kingdom have become Bikshunis and dedicated their life to the teachings of Buddha. In the Sangam era, didn’t Madhavi’s daughter Manimeghalai join the faith of Buddha? Don’t we revere her as ‘Manimegala Deivam’ today? I tried to end my life and failed. Maybe God wishes me to be alive, for some more time. Whatever else is left in my life, I wish to dedicate it to Lord Buddha and immerse myself in work that would give me peace. Will you help in this?”

A germ of doubt appeared in Vandiya Devan’s mind that startled him out of his wits.

“Devi! Your decision is most unfair, however I have no right to object or protest against it. Members of your family should advice you regarding this. I have heard that your uncle is returning from Ilangai and will be here soon...”

“I don’t intend to wait for my uncle and I don’t want anybody’s advice. I have made my decision. Will you help me?”

“In what way, can I help you?”

“I wish to go to Nagapatinam’s Choodamani Viharam. I wanted to meet the monks and learn the ways of their faith. Would you escort me there?”

Vandiya Devan was properly shocked now.

This Kodumbalur Princess is very clever indeed! She has overheard the conversation between Kundavai and myself. Maybe, she wants

to learn more about what she heard or she wishes me to confirm the Prince's whereabouts through a farcical lie.

“Devi, forgive me but I don’t think I can help you, in this matter.”

“How strange? I thought nothing is impossible for a warrior who went to Ilangai on a tough mission. Can’t you escort this poor orphaned girl to Nagapattinam?”

“It’s not an impossible task, Devi, but it is something that I can’t undertake right now. Princess Kundavai and Prime Minister Anirudhar have bid me to go to Kanchi immediately bearing their important message. That’s why I will have to refuse the honour of escorting you to Nagapattinam.”

“Alright! One can give over a thousand excuses if they are not inclined to help. I started on this journey alone but the presence of Kalamugars was a bit disturbing. No matter, I am sure God will protect my honour and my sorry self. Come to think of it, who would want to cause harm to a girl, who is determined to renounce the life. I will take your leave now.” Said Vanathi and turned towards the entrance of the hut.

Kundanthai Jodhidar followed her saying, “Devi... Devi, It is already dark outside. It is amavasya – the night of the dark moon and it looks like it is going to rain soon. Please accept my hospitality and stay here tonight.”

“Forgive me. I had planned to reach Thiruvarur by tonight, where arrangements for my stay have been made. Now that this man has refused to escort, I am sure I will find someone more inclined to help in Thiruvarur. Not that I am worried about myself...”

Saying thus, Vanathi got into her palanquin and was soon on her way. Vandiya Devan and Kundanthai Jodhidar watched until the palanquin disappeared from their line of sight.

Vandiya Devan shook his head and said, “Kodumbalur Princess was a very cowardly girl, until some time ago. Her companions used to mock her for her cowardice and used to play tricks on her. Even, I fell for one such trick. Look at her now. I can’t believe it is the same girl! How strange that she left the safety of her palace to travel alone? I wonder how Princess Kundavai allowed this!”

“I too am surprised by this transformation. Last time, when this girl came here, she suddenly fainted. She spoke with a very meek hesitant voice. She is different today. Look how confidently she spoke up, demanding your assistance.”

“What do you think might have brought about this transformation in her?”

“I think that she might have heard something drastic to bring about this kind of transformation.”

“What would that be?”

“Even the news that Ponniyin Selvar is missing in the sea, ought to be enough. She was his prospective bride after all.”

When the astrologer said that, Vandiya Devan privately wondered whether Vanathi’s transformation came about because of Ponniyin Selvar’s disappearance or the news about the Prince’s interest in Poonguzhali.

Mulling over it, he further asked, “Why is she suddenly so interested in the faith of Buddha? I had heard that the clan of Kodumbalur are staunch saivaites.”

“Some people develop such beliefs due to their past life deeds.”

“Why would she start for Choodamani Viharam in Nagapattinam, of all places?”

“That is indeed surprising.”

“Can’t you find out through your astrology?”

“How can I find this through the science of astrology? One needs to use Thiruvalluvar’s edicts of spying instead.”

“Thiruvalluvar has written an edict on spying?”

“Yes indeed. I am surprised that you didn’t know.”

“What does he say in these edicts?”

“He says many important things that spies need to know. Listen to this...”

Saying thus he sang a small couplet from ‘Otradal’ and explained its meaning to Vandiya Devan.

“Thiruvallur advices the king to keep his spies, working all the time. Just as he needs to know what his enemies are doing; he also needs to know what his own family members are doing as well.”

He sang one more couplet and proceeded to explain it to Vandiya Devan.

“Do you know how he describes a spy? This is how. A spy needs to disguise himself as a holy man or act as though he is dead... he needs to be on alert at all times. He also says that Kings ought to learn what their spies are doing through other spies. Have you never heard of these couplets?”

Vandiya Devan was astonished by the wisdom of Thiruvalluvar’s words. How intelligent and wise this poet saint must have been to write such words that are relevant even today? He resolved to read Thiruvalluvar’s Thirukural thoroughly, the next time, he had enough time.

He spoke with the astrologer for some more time before taking his leave. The astrologer invited him to stay the night. “It is very dark now. Why don’t you spend the night here and go on your way tomorrow at first light?”

Vandiya Devan declined his invitation and said, “I need to be on my way. Next time, I am here, I will accept your hospitality.”

“Next time you are here, you will find that all my predictions about you have come true.”

“Ayya! You haven’t predicted anything at all for me, then how will it come true.” Joked Vandiya Devan and mounted his horse.

After leaving the astrologer’s hut, Vandiya Devan had to go in the same forest path as Vanathi’s palanquin had gone a few minutes ago. The path wound in the same direction for some time and then diverged into two separate paths – one leading to Kollidam river banks and the other towards Thiruvarur where Vanathi was headed. Even at a distance he could see her palanquin heading in the Thiruvarur forest path. For a moment, Vandiya Devan hesitated on the crossroads wondering whether he should have offered his assistance to Vanathi.

Why did I refuse to help her? What if she needs my help truly? What if some danger befell her while on the way? If something like that happens, he knew that he would berate himself forever for not escorting her to safety. But he had a mission to fulfil. Kundavai and Anirudhar were most emphatic about him reaching Kanchi, as soon possible, to stop Karikalan’s journey. No! No! I shouldn’t get distracted from my mission. I should remember the resolution that I made. I should keep my mind focussed on my mission and nothing else.

After deciding thus, he turned his horse towards the path that would take him towards Kollidam River bank. That’s when he heard the

piercing scream of a woman. He turned back within an instant but couldn't see the palanquin at the far end of the path. He immediately galloped his horse through the path and reached the far end of the path where the road turned. There he found a woman tied to a tree and her mouth gagged. He reined his horse and jumped down and ran towards the woman. The night was so dark that it was impossible at first to see who it was. She looked like Vanathi's companion who had walked along with her in the palanquin. He removed her gag and released the ropes easily, as they were not tied too securely.

"Woman! What happened? Tell me. Where is the palanquin? Where is your mistress?"

Her companion who seemed scared out of her wits said that as they were nearing the bend on the road, a few Kalamugar mendicants joined them and asked the palanquin bearers to keep their burden down and run away. Next, they had tied the woman to the tree, while the rest of them carried the palanquin away through the same path.

After telling her story, the woman broke down crying.

"Woman! Down this path if you go, you will find Kudanthai Jodhidar's house. Stay the night there. I will go after these Kalamugars and rescue your mistress."

Saying thus, he mounted the horse and galloped away through the forest path.



Chapter 34: Firelight extinguishes

It was Amavasya, the dark night. Gathering clouds threatened to pour down any time, hid the stars well enough and not a glimmer of light could be seen around. The only available was through a group of glow-worms that were hovering in the bushes.

Vandiya Devan rode steadily through the forest path without any idea as to where he was headed and whether he would be able to save Princess Vanathi, at all. Despite misgivings he forged ahead. He knew that Princess Kundavai loved Vanathi more than her life and if he didn't attempt to rescue her, he would regret it for the rest of his life.

Even after riding the horse for almost one hour through the forest path, he couldn't find where Vanathi's captors had taken her palanquin. As he pondered the situation, he also wondered whether he was getting embroiled in something that was not his business, in the first place. He stopped the horse for a while, wondering what to do next. At the same time, he heard a slight noise at a distance. It seemed like the trot of a slow horse. Could it be Vanathi's captors guarding her palanquin from behind? He followed the sound and it became apparent that he was following a single lone horse and not a handful of people carrying a palanquin.

Soon the horse was on a higher ground like the banks of the river. Vandiya Devan didn't follow the horse there, wishing to remain

hidden in the lower ground. He got down from his horse and waited beneath the tree, all the while, keeping the other horse in sight.

“Who’s there?” asked a voice. Vandiya Devan was startled out of his wits because it was a voice that he had heard before.

“Maharaja! It’s me, your slave!” said yet another voice.

Momentarily a fire torch was at the place where the lone horseman and his slave were standing.

Vandiya Devan could see who it was. It was Prince Madhuranthakan on the horse and an unknown manservant holding the fire torch.

The man lifted the torch high, lighting up the area around him and that’s when it happened. The horse reared its legs in fear and sprang ahead in the riverbank. The man holding the torch frightened by the horse’s action tried to run after it, shouting ‘Maharaja! Maharaja!’ but slipped and fell. His torch extinguished plunging the surrounding in darkness.

Vandiya Devan knew that Madhuranthakan was not skilled enough to ride a horse in the first place. It would be far too much to expect that he would be able to bring the beast under control, especially when it was galloping wildly in fear. He worried whether the Prince would survive this adventure unhurt.

What if he falls from the horse and hurts himself? Would that manservant save him?

Next, he wondered what he should be doing.

Should I go in search of Vanathi or should I hasten to help Prince Madhuranthakan?

I don’t know where Vanathi was taken but Prince Madhuranthakan fell in danger right in front of my eyes. Let me follow his horse and

ensure that he is unharmed and then I can go in search of Vanathi.

My God! Didn't I resolve not to interfere in matters that do not concern me? What did I decide and what am I doing now?

He mounted his horse again and started towards the direction that the Prince's horse had gone. He spurred his horse to climb the high ground and neared the banks but couldn't find the Prince or the manservant who was with him. He could, however, hear a medley mix of unknown sounds emanating at a distance.

He decided to follow the sound and entered a narrow forest path near the riverbank. At the same time, nature sought to make his mission more difficult and it started drizzling. He travelled slowly through the narrow path and every minute seemed like an hour to him.

Soon, it started raining in earnest but that didn't deter Vandiya Devan's quest.

Why did Prince Madhuranthakan come here alone on a horse? Who was that man who accosted him with the fire torch?

Could there be any connection between Vanathi's kidnapping and Madhuranthakan's appearance in the woods?

Why am I embroiled in these affairs? I should be trying to find the King's road and head towards Kanchi, instead of searching for this Prince and Princess?

Then he reasoned to himself that it wouldn't be possible to find the King's road in this rain anyway.

Who is to say that I shouldn't interfere in these affairs anyway? Didn't it prove beneficial at a later day that I was able to overhear the entire conspiracy meeting that Pazhuvur Lord and Sambuverayar held in Kadambur?

When the rain started coming down upon him very heavily, he decided to abort the foolhardy mission and try to find a place to escape the rain.

If the horse slipped and fell, then his entire journey was at a risk!

At that time, a lightning struck on the sky and in that he managed to see a lone horse standing on the banks of the river. He turned his horse again and headed towards the river bank. Before he could near it, another lightning struck and the horse reared again in fear and started galloping. By the time Vandiya Devan neared the place, the horse was gone but he looked around in the surrounding hoping that Madhuranthakan might have fallen somewhere nearby. He thought it would be beneficial to help the Prince, especially, when he was in need.

Who knows, it might help me in future?

He called out for the Prince 'Who's there? Is anyone here?' but the steady drip of the rain drowned his voice.

With the rain intensifying and the wind turning direction, Vandiya Devan felt that it was pointless to stay there. He decided to turn back and remonstrated himself for his lack of self-control.

No more distractions! No point in wasting one's time in pointless quests. I have an important mission in hand and I need to reach Kanchi as soon as possible!

With the rain pouring down in sheets, he followed the horse's instinct to get shelter and soon they were headed towards a dilapidated mandapam in the middle of the forest. His clothes were dripping wet and he entered the mandapam to check if there was some place where he could get dry and even possibly spend the night.

And that's when Vandiya Devan almost jumped out of his skin. Why? Not because he encountered or a ghost or a wraith but because he heard the tender voice of a small boy.

"Amma! Amma!"

Vandiya Devan was frightened for a second.

How could a young boy's voice be heard here, in the middle of the forest path?

But the boy was persistently crying for his mother.

"Amma! Amma!"

Curious to learn who it was, Vandiya Devan entered the mandapam and looked around in the dark. He stopped in the direction, from which the voice was heard and asked loudly, "Who is there?"

The child asked back, "Who is there?"

Vandiya Devan said, "It's me. Who are you? What are you doing in the dark? Come out."

"It's raining outside."

"Where is my mother?"

"Your mother has gone to fetch some milk for you."

"No, she has not. You are lying."

"Are you going to come out or not? Or shall I come in?"

"If you come inside, I have a sword and I will slay you with it."

“My God! Looks like you are a great warrior. Why don't you come outside and show your prowess?”

“Who are you? Are you a tiger?”

“I am not a tiger. I am a horse.”

“You are lying. Will a horse talk?”

“Would a tiger talk then?”

“My mother told me that if I come outside there might be a tiger that might pounce on me.”

“I am not a tiger and I will not pounce on you. Come out and don't fear me.”

“Fear? I have no fear.” Said the boy and came out of the dark interiors of the mandapam.

By then, the rain had subsided and the clouds had passed over revealing the stars. In the dim light of the stars, Vandiya Devan saw the child. He was a four-year old boy, who was not only beautiful but also richly dressed in silk and a gold haram studded with precious gems. The boy was obviously the child of a rich family and a powerful clan but how did he come here? Who would have left the child here alone?

The child came near Vandiya Devan and looked at him intently and said, “You don't look like a horse. You look like a man.”

Vandiya Devan pointed to his horse tied outside and said, “There is the horse.”

“Oh! You have brought the horse for me is it? But they said that a palanquin will arrive.”

The child's response roused many doubts in Vandiya Devan's mind.

Who is this child? Why is he alone here? How come this child is so unafraid of anything? Who was planning to bring a palanquin for the child? Why didn't it come? Where is the child's mother? Why did she leave him alone?

"Child! Why did your mother leave you here and go away?"

"I saw a horse and I told my mother I would like to mount it but she forbids me from doing so. I waited for a while and left her silently to catch the horse. Is this the same horse?"

"No. This is a different horse. How did you come here?"

"I searched for the horse. I couldn't find it and nor could I find my mother. It was raining heavily, so I came to this mandapam."

"Were you not afraid of the dark?"

"What's there to be afraid? I live in the dark all the time."

"You are not afraid of the tiger."

"Only my mother is afraid of tigers. I am a fish. I will swallow the tiger."

"Ah! How can a fish swallow the tiger?"

"I am not a small fish. I am a whale. I am big enough to swallow tiger, lion and elephant too."

Vandiya Devan's mind was clouded with doubts.

It should indeed be a very big fish that could swallow an elephant and a tiger! Who would have taught this child such a thing?

“There! What’s that sound?” asked the boy

Vandiya Devan looked in the direction and found that a few people were coming towards the mandapam. In their midst, there was a palanquin borne by bearers. The rest of the people seemed to be searching for someone as they shouted, “There! He is there! Here! Here!”

“There! They are coming. They are bringing the palanquin too but I hate to travel in it. Will you take me in your horse instead?”

The child was so adorable that that Vandiya Devan was tempted to take him away but he was also curious to know more about him.

“I have important work elsewhere.” He said

“Where are you going?”

“I am going to Kanchi.”

“Kanchi! That’s where my first enemy lives!”

Vandiya Devan was more than startled now. He then realized that he was courting grave danger even as he stood next to the child. But there was no time to escape. The crowd of people searching for the child arrived at the mandapam. He also wanted to know more about these people who would teach a child such unusual things. He left the child and walked to the darkest part of the mandapam and waited.

The child followed him with his eyes and then called out to the people who were coming inside the mandapam, “I am here.”

At the head of the crowd there was a woman who came rushing inside the mandapam. Her breath was coming in gasps, as if she had been running for a long time.

She rushed to the child and held him tight and said, “Pandya! How can you do something like this?”

Next, a man came near the child and his mother. It was Ravidasan. He said, “Chakravarthy! How can you scare us thus?”

The child laughed merrily and said, “Yes. That’s how I will scare you. I asked for a horse, why did you get the palanquin for me?”

Even as he spoke, the rest of the people who had come in search of the boy gathered at the mandapam – Soman Sambavan, Edupankari, Deveralan and others members of the Pandya Abathu Udavi.

“Chakravarthy! Why worry about one horse? I will get you thousands and ten thousand horses very soon. But just for today, I beg you, please get inside the palanquin.” Said Soman Sambavan.

“No. I will come in that horse.” Said the child and pointed towards Vandiya Devan’s horse that they had failed to notice earlier.

That’s when they saw Vandiya Devan behind the horse. Ravidsan’s face reflected disbelief, anger and fear in equal measures.

He took a step towards him and said, “You! Scoundrel! How did you come here?”

“You! Ghost! When did you come back from Kodi Karai?”

Ravidasan started laughing and said, “Did you really think that I was a ghost?”

“Some become a ghost after they die but you have become one even while you are alive.”

The child interjected then and said, “Don’t fight with him. I like him very much. He stayed with me when it was dark. He said that he

would kill the tiger, if it comes.”

Ravidasan said to the child, “If that is so, then we will definitely take him along with us but only if you get into the palanquin for one day today.”

The child immediately got into the palanquin and sat inside.

Ravidasan looked at Vandiya Devan and said, “What are you going to do now?”

“That’s up to you isn’t it?”

“Join us. You know everything about us now. We can’t afford to let you go free.”

“If I refuse?”

“Impossible. We know that you are a brave warrior but even you can’t resist twenty of us. You can’t escape us now.”

“You mean, I can’t escape with my life intact.”

“You are young. You haven’t experienced any pleasures of life. Why do you wish to give it up, in vain?”

“That’s true. I don’t want to give up my life in vain. You are asking me to join you, where are you going?”

“Ah! That’s my boy. We are going to Pazhuvur Queen Nandini Devi.”

“Oh! I thought so. Where is Nandini Devi?”

“She would have reached Thirupurampayam by now. Will you come with us?”

“I too am headed in that direction and I was worried that I didn’t know the way. Thank God! You people came. Come let’s go.”

They left the place immediately. Ravidasan and his gang surrounded the palanquin and Vandiya Devan in the midst followed them on his horse.

Vandiya Devan was plagued with worries.

What about Vanathi’s fate? What about Madhuranthakan? What will happen to them? What about me? What’s going to happen to me? That too is a mystery

Despite his worries, Vandiya Devan felt sure that he was about to learn many more mysteries that would surpass the conspiracy that he stumbled upon in Kadambur. The things that he learned in Kadambur proved to be helpful during his mission in Thanjavur but what will happen today?

Will this gang allow me to leave after learning all their secrets? No. They would try to persuade me to join them and if I say ‘no’ they will try to sacrifice me for their cause. Maybe I could invoke Nandini’s pity, yet again...

When Vandiya Devan thought about Nandini, he could only wonder about his helplessness at the face of her beauty.

How quickly did I agree to go along with them, when I learned that we are going to meet her? Elders in the family often talk about ‘Maya’ and I am surely caught in its web.

He was also aware of the fact that Nandini was involved in a deadly plot against the Cholas, yet, he seemed to find it difficult to bypass a chance to meet her again. But then, it would have been foolish to fight with these twenty people. It would be more prudent to accede to their demands and look for a chance to escape later.

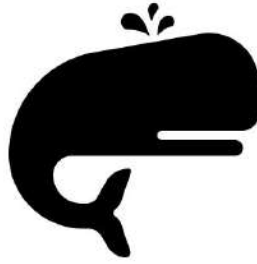
In the meantime, I will get a chance to learn more about them, which would prove to be useful.

The child's words reverberated through his mind. "Kanchi! That's where my first enemy lives!"

Who would teach the child such words? Why does this gang call him 'Chakravarthy'? What did the child mean when he said, 'First Enemy'?

His speculations about these questions swirled through his mind indicating just how dangerous his situation would become, if his surmise about the boy were true!

Even while he was thinking about it, they reached Thirupurampayam.



Chapter 35: Our time is nearing...

Built hundred years ago, from the time of our story, we have seen the memorial temple of Ganga King earlier when the Pandya conspirators met to discuss their next move, even while Azhwarkadiyan was spying on them. Ravidasan and his gang, along with the boy and Vandiya Devan reached the same place that night.

They dumped Vandiya Devan along with his horse near one end of the wall that was half intact and said, “You can sit here awhile. Don’t even think of escaping. It is impossible. Only those who are familiar with this forest can hope to cross it over. If you still dare to escape, you will die for sure.”

“Oh yes! I am sure you will work some sorcery and kill me!” said Vandiya Devan cheekily and laughed.

“Laugh! Laugh Well!” said Ravidasan and laughed as well.

A wolf howled at a distance and an owl hooted in response. Vandiya Devan looked around and noted that the dense forest trees had shielded its surroundings from the rain. Though a few patches of ground were wet largely, the forest was so dense and thick that the thundering rain that had soaked him to the bone had not flooded the place. He removed his upper garment and dried on the stone wall. He sat down with his back on the wall and watched the clearing, where the rest of the gang was assembled. Ravidasan had, however, left a guard with him to ensure that he wouldn’t escape.

The gang was sitting on the ground talking amongst themselves. One of them ventured inside the memorial temple and brought an old throne, decorated with gilded gold and bronze. The child whom they called 'Chakravarthy' was made to sit on the throne. Next, they put out the firelights that they carried, all except two. The smoke from the extinguished firelight enveloped the place.

"Why is the queen so late?" asked one of them.

"She can come only when the time is right. I told her to come late in the night. There is still time. Until then, can someone sing the songs of Pandya Empire?"

Hearing this, Edupankari took out a small drum and started playing it and Devaralan started singing a song. The low tone of his voice and the rhythmic beat of the drum made his sad song more poignant than ever.

Vandiya Devan who was watching all this intently closed his eyes for a while. The melancholy of the song, lulled him into a drowsy sleep, even as he realized that Devaralan was singing about the terrible war that was fought at the same spot that they were sitting on.

Yes. That's where Varaguna Pandyan and Aparajitha Pallavan had fought for three long hard days. To aid the Pallavan, Ganga King Prathivipathy had come with his army and fell prey to the ferocity of Pandya assault. This war memorial that was built to glorify the Ganga King's brave deeds and today, has become a home for these cowardly conspirators.

After the fall of the Ganga King, the Pallavan army disintegrated completely and a Pandya victory seemed imminent. That's when the Chola army came to aid the Pallavas. At the head of the army, was the old wizened warrior who bore 99 battle scars on his body – King Vijayalaya Chola. Paralysed in both his legs, four men bore the warrior on their shoulders and brought him to the battlefield. Unsheathing two long swords, the old warrior created havoc among

the warring army. Wherever he went, scores and scores of soldiers fell down like flies. The Pallava army that had disintegrated came together to watch Vijayalaya Chola create history.

He could see the swordplay of the old warrior and the flood of blood right behind him. Drums were beating urgently while horses and elephants beat a retreat. The Pandya army that had almost tasted victory was now trying to flee the scene, with their lives intact. And even as they retreated, the Pallavas and the Cholas were intent on exacting their revenge.

“Don’t let them flee! Get them!” they shouted.

Pandya soldiers fled the scene screaming ‘Ayyo! Ayyo!’

As the din of the battle grew louder and louder, the Pallavas and the Cholas won the war.

Vandiya Devan woke up with a start. He looked around and realised that he had fallen asleep to the song that Devaralan was singing and had seen the war play out in his dreams. The song was still going on... extolling the bravery of Pandyas.

Suddenly Edupankari stopped playing the drums. They could see a fire torch approaching the clearing from a distance. Few men were carrying a veiled palanquin. They neared the clearing and kept their burden down. A woman emerged out of the palanquin. It was Nandini Devi but she looked different today. Unlike the other times when she was adorned with flowers, jewels and silk, this time, her hair was free of any restraint. To Vandiya Devan’s eyes, she looked like Durga who had vanquished the hoard of asuras.

Her appearance disturbed Vandiya Devan and his limbs shivered, when she approached the throne, where the child was sitting. Everyone’s attention was riveted by her appearance and they looked at her with stunned silence.

The woman who had accompanied the child, whom he called his mother, was also present behind the throne.

Nandini approached the throne and then opened her arms to the child. The child looked at her and his mother behind and said, "You are my mother, aren't you? She is not my mother, is she?"

"Yes! My sweet."

"Why does she say that she is my mother then?"

"She is the mother who brought you up?"

"Why didn't you bring me up then? Why didn't you keep me with you? Why is she keeping me in a mountain, away from you?"

"My sweet! You have been kept away from me because we need you to be safe, to fulfil your father's wishes and to seek vengeance against those who killed him in cold blood."

"Yes, I know about that." Said the child and went near Nandini.

Nandini embraced him lovingly and breathed the scent of his hair. The child too held on to her tightly not wanting to let go of her!

Nandini prised open his hands by force and freed herself and then led the child to the throne and made him sit on it. Next, she went near the palanquin and took out a sword that we have already seen. She then asked the palanquin bearers to wait at a distance and then came back to the child and placed the sword on the throne.

The child looked at the sword with admiration and said, "Can I hold it?"

"Very soon, my Child. You will need to wait." She said.

Then she looked at Ravidasan and his gang and asked, “Do we have anybody here who hasn’t taken the holy oath?”

“No Devi” said Soman Sambavan.

She then looked Ravidasan and said, “Senathipathy!”

Ravidasan laughed thunderously.

Unperturbed by his reaction, Nandini said, “Today you might feel like laughing but by next month, you might see our plans come to fruition.”

“Devi, we have been waiting for you to announce this for many years now.”

“Ayya! We are but a mere handful. Our Emperor is just a child. Chola Empire is large and powerful. Their army has countless soldiers. If we had rushed through our plans, all would have been lost. Now the time is ripe to seek vengeance. Ravidasarey! Do you have anything to say or ask? Does anybody here want to ask me questions?”

Ravidasan looked at his gang but none seemed to have any questions to ask.

“Devi, we have no questions to ask. We are eager to hear when we will be exacting our vengeance upon these Cholas. When? Where? Who? How?”

“Alright. I came here to give you news about it. That’s why I called everybody here. That’s why I also wanted our Chakravarthy to come here.” Said Nandini and paused.

Everybody’s attention was upon her now.

“Some of you were impatient. You wanted immediate results. You feared that I might have forgotten the oath that swore upon our

King's dead body. You didn't know that I had more reasons to remember my oath every second of my life. For the past three years, I have been plotting each move of ours so that we meet our goals. I have no other thought left in my mind but this. The time to strike has finally arrived. Today, powerful noble families and influential noblemen are split into two groups. Sambuverayar and his supporters want Madhuranthakan as the next King while Malayaman and Kodumbalur Vellar are against them. I also heard that Kodumbalur Vellar is bringing his army to Thanjavur to make sure they don't crown Madhuranthakan. Malayaman too is raising an army to support his grandson's claim. A war seems imminent between these two groups."

"Devi! We heard that you are also trying your utmost to broker peace between these two groups. I heard that you have invited both the parties to Kadambur Palace to talk and negotiate an agreement?"

"That's right. I had organized these peace talks. Can you guess why?"

"No Devi! Who can indeed fathom what lies beneath the depth of a woman's heart?"

"That's true. It is indeed impossible. I will tell you. If a fratricidal war breaks out before our mission is complete then we can't really predict the outcome. Sundara Cholan is still alive and so is his Prime Minister Anbil Brahmarayan. They would intervene and pacify both groups. Even if one group wins the war and the other loses, our wishes and intentions will not be fulfilled. That's why I called for these peace talks. We need to fulfil our mission and take our vengeance before the war starts. Once we do that, a civil war would begin in earnest that would destroy the Chola clan from head to foot. Now, do you understand?"

When they heard of Nandini's plan, they shook their head in surprise and expressed their happiness. Some spoke amongst themselves

and shook their head expressing their approval of her intelligent plan.

“Devi, we are in awe of your brilliant mind. We want to know when we will be putting our plan to action? You said that the date is near? When will we be doing it and who will do it?”

“That’s the purpose of these peace talks. I have called our first enemy to Kadambur Palace under the pretext of a peace agreement. He will come there for sure. That’s where we will fulfil the holy oath that we swore upon our King’s body. Today is Saturday. By next Saturday, trust me, our first enemy would be dead!”

Nandini’s words had a ripple effect on the gang that was gathered there. Some shouted their encouragement and approval, while some clapped their hands on their thighs and gave their approval. Edupankari enthusiastically drummed a small beat on the hand drum!

The unusual sounds of cheer roused the bats in the nearby tree and they took flight eerily. Vandiya Devan couldn’t hear the conversation that was taking place at the clearing but he could discern that Nandini had given some good news to Ravidasan’s gang.

Ravidasan stood up and raised his hands to signal silence and then turned towards Nandini.

“Devi, your last words have filled us with eagerness and hope. We never thought that we would see this day. I wish to know who gets the honour of fulfilling our oath.”

“I am not surprised at this question. It is but natural that each one of you would want to be the sword that strikes down the enemy. That’s why I asked you to bring the heir of Veera Pandyan here. Here is his father’s sword. Let the child decide who deserves the honour of seeking vengeance and hand over the sword to them. The rest of us will stay close to that person and aid him in whatever way possible. If

that person fails in his mission, then we should be ready to fulfil it somehow. I will be inside Kadambur Palace and Edupankari is one of the guards there. We will help you to get inside the Palace. Do these arrangements meet with your approval?"

Ravidasan and his gang nodded their assent and said, "Your arrangements are fine, Devi. There is, however, one more thing. Whoever Chakravarthy selects to fulfil the oath, will emerge as the undisputed leader of this gang. The rest of us should and must listen to him, no matter what."

Nandini's face broke into a mesmerising smile after hearing this.

"You wish to bind me too into agreeing to this, don't you?"

"Yes, Devi, you are one of us hence we cannot differentiate."

"Alright. I agree. Do you all agree with what Ravidasan just said?" asked Nandini

The rest of the gang looked at each other and hesitated. Soman Sambavan stood up and said, "How is it possible? Nandini Devi has been helping us for so long. How can we force her to accept somebody's orders?"

"Please do not worry about me. I have been living only to see our oath fulfilled. I would happily be the slave of anyone, who fulfils it for me."

Next, she turned towards the child who had been avidly listening and watching the entire scene though it was doubtful whether he understood anything.

"My sweet! This is your brave father's sword. Take it in your small hands and give it to the one you like the most."

Ravidasan came near the child and said, “Chakravarthy! Take a good look at each one of us. You need to give the sword to whoever you think is bravest here.”

Cowed down by Ravidasan’s scarlet eyes, the child looked around at the rest of the gang.

Everyone stood up and came near the child. There was an air of expectancy and a hushed silence fell over them, as their eyes begged the child entreating him silently, to give the sword to them.

Ravidasan’s red-rimmed eyes looked at the child with menacing authority, as if commanding him to hand over the sword to him.

The child looked at everyone again and then took the long sword in his hands. Excitement ran rife among Ravidasan’s gang. Instantly, the child turned towards Nandini and said, “Amma! I like you more than anybody else here. I want you to rule my Kingdom, until I come of age,” and handed over the sword to her.



Chapter 36: Someone in the dark!

Nandini accepted the sword from the child and held it close to her heart. Next, she embraced the child and breathed the scent of his hair, while tears streamed from her eyes.

The rest of the gang looked on silently shocked at the turn of the events.

Ravidasan then said, “Devi, I don’t think that ‘Chakravarthy’ has understood what we want of him and gave the sword to you in a whim. Let us explain to him the consequences of his action and then try again.”

Nandini said, “No, Ayya, no. Our Chakravarthy understands the consequences. That’s why he gave the sword to me. Do not worry about these tears of mine. I am merely happy that I have been given the opportunity to take vengeance for our noble king.”

“Devi, when we are alive, how could we allow a woman to try and bring down our enemy. It isn’t right...” said Soman Sambavan.

“There is no cause to worry. This is my burden and my responsibility. Just because Chakravarthy has given the sword to me that doesn’t mean that the rest of you have no part in this. I want half of you to take Chakravarthy back to Pandavar mountains and the rest can

come to Kadambur palace. Those of you, who can gain entry into the palace can aid me in this mission of vengeance and the rest can wait outside with fast running horses. Once I complete the mission, we need to make an attempt to escape.”

Ravidasan came forward and said, “Devi, I forgot to tell you something...”

“Pazhuvetarayar is at the Kalamugar council meeting that is being held at the Kollidam River. I need to return to the Palace before the meeting ends.”

“You said that our first enemy Aditya Karikalan would come to Kadambur Palace. I am not so sure about it.”

“Why do you doubt so?”

“With reason Devi. I know for a fact that Princess Kundavai and Prime Minister Anirudhar have sent messages to the Crown Prince warning him not to come to Kadambur Palace, at any cost.”

“Did you think that I didn’t know about this?”

“You knew! Despite that, you believe that he will come to Kadambur?”

“Yes. He will surely come to Kadambur. That snake in Pazhaiaarai doesn’t know her own brother and nor does Anbil Brahmarakshan^[67]. I am surprised that even you, who often boasts of being a sorcerer, can’t fathom our first enemy’s character. If someone were to go to Aditya Karikalan and tell him that ‘not’ to do something, that would be the first thing that he would go ahead and do. I know this for a fact. Aditya Karikalan is not putty in Kundavai’s hand, like Arulmozhivarman and nor is he a cowardly puppet, like Madhuranthakan. If his sister and the Prime Minister have sent the message warning him to stay away from Kadambur, then for sure he would come there.”

“Devi, that message will not reach Kanchi. I can guarantee that.”

“What are you saying? Explain.” Asked Nandini sharply. There was shrill anticipation in her voice.

“Devi, do you know who is taking this message to Karikalan?”

“No... but I can guess.”

“Good! There is no need to guess. We have brought him here. We caught him red-handed trying to escape with our ‘Chakravarthy’. He knows all our secrets and now he knows more. If we show any more mercy to him, it would lead to our destruction for sure. Edupankari! Bring that spy here.”

Edupankari and two others went towards the dilapidated temple. Nandini looked at the direction with bated breath. The serious tones of her face relaxed and a seductive smile bloomed.

Edupankari sprang on our hero suddenly and pulled him upright. Tired, exhausted and half drowsy with sleep, Vandiya Devan woke up with a start. At first, he thought of resisting Edupankari and his friends but good sense prevailed. He stayed still and allowed himself to be led to the clearing. He wanted to see what they would do with him.

Vandiya Devan smiled at Nandini, who looked peaceful and serene with nary an emotion on her face.

“Ayya... yet again, we meet.”

“Yes Devi, I have come again, but I didn’t come here by choice.”

The child then told Nandini, “Amma! This man has got a good horse. Can you ask him to give it to me?”

“Child! Come with me. I will take you far away on my horse.”

Ravidasan’s enraged face loomed in front of Vandiya Devan and he shouted hoarsely, “You! Shut your mouth!” and then he turned towards Nandini and said, “Devi, what are your orders?”

Nandini was unperturbed by this exchange, she calmly asked, “How did he come here and when?”

“This scoundrel was trying to escape with our ‘Chakravarthy’ when he took refuge in a mandapam to get away from the rain. Thankfully, we arrived there on time to stop it.”

Nandini looked at Vandiya Devan and asked, “Ayya, is this true?”

“Only you can decide whether your people speak lies or the truth. How would I know?” he said.

Nandini’s smile vanished immediately and she became serious. She turned towards Ravidasan and said, “Ayya! I request you and your men to withdraw for a while and give us some privacy. I wish to speak to him alone. Take Chakravarthy along with you.” And then she bent down and told the child, “My sweet! Go with them for a little while. I will speak to him and get his horse for you.”

Ravidasan acceded to her request and took the child with him and signalled his gang to withdraw to a respectful distance.

Nandini looked at Vandiya Devan and said, “Ayya! I think there is a bond between us...”

“Devi, that is so true! That bond is very strong and very tight and it has bound my body and arms.”

“I would suggest that you stop your antics. I am no mood for such humours! Tell me plainly, how did you come here? Did you come on your own accidentally or deliberately?”

“I didn’t come here by choice or on my own. Your men brought me here. If they had not interfered, I would have reached the banks of Kollidam hours ago,”

“I understand that you find it abhorrent to your senses to meet me and you want to leave me and escape as soon as you can.”

“You are wrong. Meeting you, is by no means, a difficult proposition but leaving you ‘is’. If you say ‘yes’ I will strike down that old Pazhuvetarayar and this murderous gang of thieves with one stroke of my sword and take you away from here.”

“Where would you take me?”

“I will take you to your mother who roams through the forests of Ilangai, like a mad woman.”

Nandini sighed sorrowfully and said, “Do you want me to roam around like her, lost and helpless? Who knows, I might even agree to your proposal and come away with you? If I need to see my mother, I will surely request you, but before that my wishes need to be fulfilled. Will help me fulfil them?”

“Devi, If I know what your wishes are, then I can tell you whether I can help fulfil them or not?”

“Those who bear true love for me in their hearts will not talk thus. They will agree to help no matter what those wishes are.”

“Devi, those who bear true love in their hearts will also try to warn you about the dangerous path that you are treading. These scoundrels are using you to fulfil some dangerous scheme and will abandon you, once they achieve their purpose.”

“Wrong! It is ‘I’ who is using them to achieve my purpose. I wish that you understand this well.”

“They have brought this child from some forest and are fooling you with lies and falsehoods...”

“Do you know why we need this child?”

“You wish to crown him as the King of Pandyas.”

“Wrong! He will not be just the King of Pandyas. He will rule over the land from River Tungabhadra to Ilangai. He will ascend the Chola throne and rule over this kingdom.”

“My God! What a grand scheme, indeed? May I ask, how you are going to achieve this? Let me guess! With the help of this gang of murderers and thieves? Each wing of the Chola army has over 20 lakhs of soldiers, do you know that? And do you think you can vanquish such a great army with the help of this gang that hides itself during the day and comes out bravely during the night?”

“I don’t depend only on them. I have this sword. I have more trust in this than anybody else. I intend to fulfil my wishes with the help of this sword.”

“Devi, you will never use that sword. Your hands do not have the strength to wield it.”

“Why do you say that?”

“I don’t know. I felt that you wouldn’t be able to use the sword.”

“I can prove your statement false, right here, right now.”

“If that is so, then I am lucky indeed. It would be my good fortune to die at the hands of a beautiful woman.” Said Vandiya Devan and bent his head, inviting Nandini to behead him.

“You wish to get beheaded? Truly? Don’t want to get crowned by me?”

“How many people do you intend to crown Devi?”

“I have the power to decide who get to wear the crown.”

“Then, what will happen to this child?”

“It is entirely within my power to decide whether I want to crown him or not.”

“Devi, feel free to crown, whomsoever, you wish but do spare me the honour.”

“Why?”

“Many have complimented the beauty of my curling locks of hair. I do not wish to hide it with a crown.”

“Looks like, you will not ever get serious about anything. Alright! Do tell me one thing? What did Princess Kundavai do when she heard that her brother is missing in the sea? Did she grieve a lot?”

Vandiya Devan was astonished by the sudden change of subject. Nonetheless, he recovered quickly and said, “Of course. She was very sad. I don’t think all women are heartless in this world.”

“I also heard that Kodumbalur Princess tried to give up her life by drowning in the lake? Who saved her in the end?”

This reminded Vandiya Devan about Vanathi’s fate in the forest. He wondered what might have happened to her and whether she would have escaped the clutches of her kidnappers.

Nandini persisted with her questions in a serious tone. “Alright! Looks like you will not answer any of those questions. Let me ask

you plainly. Do you intend to stop Princes Aditya Karikalar from coming to Kadambur?"

"Yes. I am going to try."

"What if I tell you that it would be impossible for you to do so?"

"Devi, I am not saying that I can do it, I can only attempt to stop him. If the Prince decides to do something, it is impossible to change his mind."

"You seem to know the Prince's character all too well."

"And you seem to know him better than anybody else in this world."

"Alright! No matter what, you will not join me will you? You will take sides with my enemy."

"Devi, who is your enemy?"

"Who is my enemy? Don't you know? That arrogant Princess in Pazhaiaarai is my enemy. Who else?"

"Devi, that's your imagination. I need to tell you an important truth about..."

"Enough! Save your breath. I know what kind of truth would come out of your mouth. The only truth that you can utter is the one that is coated with falsehoods and lies." Said Nandini angrily and clapped her hands. Ravidasan and his gang came near them.

Vandiya Devan felt that he had not used the opportunity of a private talk with Nandini to impress the truth upon her. He wondered whether she would ask her men to kill him.

Oh! God! Is this your will? Will I be killed ingloriously in the hands of this murderous gang?

Ravidasan and his gang surrounded them and to Vandiya Devan they resembled hungry wolves' intent upon their prey.

"My Queen! No matter what you tell him, he will never join us. I suggest that you leave now. It is way past the time you return. We will sacrifice him at this holy battlefield and leave."

"Mandiravadi! Be warned! That is not what I wish. Do not lay a hand upon him. If you do, I will cut you into half, with this sword of mine." Growled Nandini.

Ravidasan and his gang watched Nandini's aggression with open-mouthed astonishment.

"I do not want him harmed. He is useful to me in more ways than you can fathom. He is free to leave, whenever he wishes. Please do not stop him."

"Devi, we are here to carry out your wishes but is it advisable to allow him to leave first? He has a horse."

"Alright! Tie him to that pillar. It will take a while before he unties himself and by then, we would have cleared the forest."

Acceding to her wishes, Ravidasan's gang tied him to the pillar of the temple and his horse was tied to a nearby tree.

Nandini got into her palanquin and was borne away through the dense forest path. Ravidasan's men took the throne inside the temple and then hurried away through the same forest path. With no fire torch, darkness enveloped Vandiya Devan and soon he began to wonder whether all these scenes that he witnessed were a figment of his imagination.

A few bats took flight from the nearby tree, completing the eerie picture of the forest to the hilt.

A lone wolf howled at some distance and soon it was heard nearby. Vandiya Devan remembered the terrible wolf dream that he had while he was at Kadambur, where thousands of wolves had surrounded him from all directions and were trying to devour him.

He tried to untie his bonds but Ravidasan had tied him a tad too securely this time. With no light to guide him, he was finding it difficult to untie the ropes.

Suddenly he heard a sound. It sounded like a man's footsteps. His horse neighed sensing danger. Something appeared darker than the forest around and it was coming towards him.

Is it an animal or a man? Or could it be something else?

Vandiya Devan steeled his body and waited until 'it' approached him closer and then kicked it with all his strength. 'It' fell down with a shout that seemed almost human and then seemed to crawl away.

Soon he could hear the sound of a stone being scratched and a fire torch was being lit. There was a light at the entrance of the temple and someone was coming towards him. Vandiya Devan tried to turn around and see who it was?

He came close to Vandiya Devan and held the fire log up to see his face. It was a Kalamuga Saivar with matted hair and a massive beard.



Chapter 37: Disguise removed

Seeing a fierce-looking Kalamugan in the middle of the forest, at the dead of the night, was a fearsome prospect but Vandiya Devan's natural fearlessness asserted itself after a while.

He wondered, *"Where have I seen him? He looks familiar. Ah! He looks like the same Kalamugan who he met that day in the woods. Why does he look so familiar? Where else have I seen him?"*

The Kalamugan who had been staring at him for a while now burst into a hearty laugh.

"Ha Ha Ha!" To Vandiya Devan's ears, his voice too seemed familiar.

"Cha! It's you. I can't believe that I came all the way in the middle of the night through this forest, for you!" Vandiya Devan's suspicion deepened. It seemed as though the Kalamugan was deliberately trying to disguise his voice.

"Then why did you come and for whom?"

"I came in search of the Prince."

"Which Prince?"

"How does it concern you? Why do you ask?"

"I too am a Prince. That's why I asked."

“You? A Prince? Let me see. Yes! There! It says so right on your face.”

“I think my face is any day better than yours unless you wish to improve upon it by adding matted beards and dreadlocks.”

“Why don’t you try it? It might indeed improve your appearance.”

“I thought so too...”

“What did you think?”

“Nothing. Just untie me. I too will join your group and become a Kalamugan.”

“No thanks. We don’t need any more spies in our group. It’s because of spies like you that our Maha Sangam meeting ended thus.”

“What happened?”

“We were waiting for the Prince to come to our meeting. We thought that once he becomes the king, he would pledge to make our leader the Raja Guru [\[68\]](#) of the Cholas. But he didn’t come.”

“Untie me and I will tell you why your Prince didn’t come.”

“Which Prince?”

“Who else? King Gandaradithar’s son Prince Madhuranthakan.”

“My guess is right.”

“What did you guess?”

“I guessed that you were a spy.”

“How did you guess that?”

“When I came searching for the Prince, I saw a group of people through the forest path. I didn’t know who they were. They probably thought that you were a spy and that’s why they tied you to that pillar but I can’t believe that they left you alive. I wonder why?”

“I can tell you why, if you untie me.”

“You don’t have to tell me anything and I will not untie you unless you promise to listen to whatever I tell you.”

“What should I do?”

“You should promise me that henceforth you will not interfere in matters that do not concern you and then hold your ears and do thopukaranam [\[69\]](#) for 108 times!”

“Is that so?”

while Vandiya Devan was engaging the Kalamugan in this conversation, he had been busy untying himself. When the Kalamugan asked him to do thopukaranam he had freed himself completely and he sprang upon him and pushed him to the ground. The fire torch that he held in his hand fell down but didn’t get extinguished. Vandiya Devan sat on the Kalamugan’s chest and pulled at his beard and it came away in his hand.

The Kalamugan pushed Vandiya Devan away and got up. Vandiya Devan immediately took the fire torch and held it to his face and was not surprised to see the familiar face of Azwarkadiyan Nambi beaming at him. They both burst out laughing.

“Vaishnavarey! How come you are lecturing me about not interfering in other people’s business when you are doing the same?”

“I didn’t court danger like you do. If I had not come here at the nick of the time, imagine what would have happened to you?”

“Oh! So you think that it was ‘you’ who had untied my ropes?”

“No, but you can’t leave this forest without someone guiding you. You would have been hunted by wolves.”

“Forget the wolves. If you had but seen the Mandiravadi’s wolves a little while ago... it’s a miracle that I escaped them unscathed.”

“I know about them. Who else came with the Mandiravadi?”

“A small fish had come along with him and it wanted to devour a tiger.”

“Aha! Tell me what happened? Who else came? What did they do? What happened?”

“You tell me, why you wore this disguise? Where were you this evening? What happened there? If you tell me about that I will tell you what happened here?”

“I have nothing much to tell you. The Kalamugars had a meeting in the midnight, by the Kollidam River. I wore this disguise to see what’s happening there. I had thought that I would meet you near the ferry, in the morning. Periya Pazhuvetarayar came and the supreme Guru of Kalamugars too came but the one person that they were expecting, didn’t come.”

“They were expecting Prince Madhuranthakar?”

“Yes... but how do you know?”

“If Prince Madhuranthakar ascends the throne, I wonder how he can control this kingdom...”

“Why do you say so?”

“He can’t control a mere horse, then how can we expect him to control rebel lords like Pazhuvetarayar, bloodthirsty Kalamugars and skirmishing Vaishnavars like yourself...”

Azhwarkadiyan laughed out aloud and asked, “Did you meet Madhuranthakar on the way? Do you know what happened to him?”

Vandiya Devan told all about Madhuranthakar’s bolting horse and his failed quest to find him

“Poor Prince! God knows where he is right now. I wonder where he fell when the horse bolted wildly. His life might be in danger. That’s why he didn’t come for the Maha Sangam meeting today. Shall we go and search for him again?”

“Very nice! How does that concern us? Are we not on a mission to reach Kanchi as soon as possible? Come now. Let us leave immediately. We need to be at Kollidam River, by dawn.”

“What if Madhuranthakar was lying in the fields or in the dead of the forest drenched in rain and mud? What if he is dying? Then too will you say that it’s none of our business?”

“You are imagining too much. These things will not happen. Anirudhar will take care of it.”

“Prime Minister Anirudhar? What does he know about this?”

“Aha! How can you say that? Anirudhar knows everything that happens in this Kingdom.”

“Then... he also knows what happened in Kadambur Palace.”

“Do you remember we both stood by the road in Kadambur, while Pazhuvur queen’s palanquin passed us by?”

“Of course. I also remember how excited and restless you got, when the veils of the Palanquin opened and you asked me to give her a message.”

“And you thought that I intended to send some ‘love message’ to the Pazhuvur queen and admonished me saying, ‘How dare I ask you to do this sort of work?’ My message had no such love. Instead, I wished to warn Madhuranthakar, not to be taken in by the words of these rebel lords.”

“You knew even then, that it was Prince Madhuranthakar, inside the palanquin.”

“I had a doubt and it got confirmed when the Prince peeked outside. You are a close-mouthed fellow. No matter how much I tried, you never revealed to me that it was not Nandini but the Prince inside the palanquin.”

“You too are close-mouthed. Did you tell me where you were going when I asked you so many times in the afternoon?”

“If I had told you, you would have interfered in that matter as well. As such, you courted so much trouble. Henceforth...”

“Does the Prime Minister know about the meeting that the Kalamugars had and the impending arrival of Prince Madhuranthakar?”

“Of course, he knew! That’s why he sent me to attend the meeting. At the same time, he also would have sent somebody else to ensure that the Prince does not attend the meeting. You said that some servant held the fire torch and that had frightened the horse; he was probably Anirudhar’s man. If the horse had thrown the prince somewhere in the forest, be rest assured he would have been rescued by the Prime Minister's men soon enough. By now, the

Prince would be on his way to Thanjavur, in a palanquin or a chariot. Come! Let us go.”

“Vaishnavarey! I can’t come.”

“What is this? What about our mission? I heard the news that the Prince has already left Kanchi. Shouldn’t we be hurrying along, to intercept him before he reaches Kadambur...”

“You can give the message that Princess Kundavai has sent for her brother. Prince Karikalar is not like Madhuranthakar. He won’t be travelling by palanquin in the night, it wouldn’t be that difficult to meet him...”

“And what do you plan to do instead?”

“To tell the truth, I didn’t follow Madhuranthakar into the forest. I was following somebody else and I came upon the Prince by a coincidence.”

“I know a bit of astrology; shall I test it on you? The person that you were following was a woman, wasn’t it?”

“You truly have a wicked tongue and one of these days I am going to break that head of yours...”

“You can’t do that. I have already pledged this head of mine to a Kalamugan. Now you tell me who is this woman that you were following from Kudanthai?”

“Kodumbalur Princess Vanathi came to Kudanthai Jodhidar’s house. She left his house on her palanquin. I too left the Jodhidar’s house after some time. I had no intention of following that crazy girl anywhere, but the direction of our path was the same and I could see her palanquin being carried at a distance. That’s when, I saw her being attacked by a group of men. They tied her companion to the

tree and bore the palanquin away. Vaishnavarey! I am very worried about that girl. I want to find out what happened to her?”

“Why are you so worried about that girl?”

“How can you say that? She is after all the only daughter of Kodumbalur Siriya Vellar – the great warrior, who lay down his life for the honour of Cholas. She is also the cherished companion of Princess Kundavai and there was also the rumour that she is the chosen bride of Ponniyin Selvar...”

“Ponniyin Selvar is dead and drowned in the sea... what is the point of discussing about his marriage?”

“There is nothing to prove that he is dead... it’s just a rumour.”

“Then, you know for sure that he is alive?”

“*Vaishnavarey!* If you think that I will blurt out secrets to you, then you better forget it.”

“Alright! Alright! I will not ask you anything. Don’t worry about Vanathi. Princess Kundavai loves her very much...”

“That’s exactly why I am worried. Princess Kundavai doesn’t know that Vanathi is in such a danger.”

“If not today, she will know it tomorrow.”

“What’s the point? What if the Kalamugars sacrifice this girl at their altar?”

“You said that Kalamugars took Vanathi along?”

“That’s how it looked. Vanathi’s companion also described them as Kalamugars.”

“If that is true, then you don’t have to worry about it at all. Kodumbalur clan are great patrons of Kalamugars. If they come to know that Vanathi is the Kodumbalur Princess, they will accord royal treatment to her and offer her protection.”

“Really! I didn’t know that?”

“That’s why Kalamugars are strongly protesting against Prince Madhuranthakar, as the next heir.”

“Who cares if these skull bearing Sanyasis protests against the Prince?”

“That’s all you know. In this kingdom, many influential and prominent clans and lords are patrons of Kalamugars. Many army commanders belong to their sect. That’s why Pazhuvetarayar is courting their support for Madhuranthakar’s claim but that got foiled, thanks to a horse. Now then, are you going to come with me or not?”

Vandiya Devan hesitantly got up and untied his horse from the nearby tree and followed Azhwarkadiyan through the dense forest path. After a long while, they came out of the forest and found their way to the King’s road. Azhwarkadiyan looked up and pointed at the sky to Vandiya Devan. They could see the entire length and breadth of the comet that had stretched from one end of the sky to the other. As they gazed at it, a cold wind blew across them and they could see a lone dog howling and crying at some distance.



Chapter 38: What happened to Vanathi?

Vanathi, the Kodumbalur Princess was travelling towards Thiruvavoor, even when the sun had begun to set. As she started on her journey, she found herself confused. She wished to go to Nagapattinam Choodamani Viharam and nurse Prince Arulmozhi, who was ailing but there were many hurdles to pass through. Firstly, she wondered whether she would be allowed inside the Viharam. Secondly, the thought that she had to go to Nagapattinam alone scared her. She tried to build courage by reasoning with her heart....

To accomplish even small things, people need to cross hurdles... everybody is struggling to fulfil their aspirations and dreams. I just need to build courage in my heart and must not get disheartened. Imagine, how courageous that fisherwoman must be to ply her boat through the sea, day and night. One can only imagine the courage that she must have possessed to save the Prince from the stormy seas, where the waves rise as high as the mountains. And I am scared of undertaking a small journey alone!

It doesn't matter if I am not allowed to meet the Prince. I can find lodgings to stay near the Prince and if I can meet that fisherwoman, then through her I will find a way to meet him. I need to convince him somehow that I am not interested in becoming a queen and that my love is pure, devoid of any such ambitions. After that, I can happily give up my life or I can join the Viharam and become a Bikshuni...

Vanathi wished to know at what time they would be arriving in Nagapattinam, from the palanquin bearers. She, therefore, opened

the veils and stuck her head out. She could see several dark figures hiding behind a large tree on the road. They were Kalamuga Saivars. She was not worried about them. They were frequent guests of her uncle, at their palace in Kodumbalur. They would speak to her uncle, conduct pujas and then demand whatever they needed and leave. Once the head of Kalamugars himself had stayed at their palace. Her uncle was their patron and had donated much wealth to temples and to village chieftains to provide food and shelter for these wandering mendicants. She knew that they wouldn't harm her in any way. They might help protect her on the journey. She knew that they were all headed towards the Maha Sangam congregated at the Kollidam River and had surmised that that's why so many of them were seen walking on the roads.

Despite knowing all this, Vanathi, in her heart of hearts, wondered why this particular group of Kalamugars, were hiding behind the tree.

Do they intend to harm me? What if they don't know that I am Kodumbalur Princess?

Even while she was wondering thus, the Kalamugars emerged from the shadows and came running towards the Palanquin and surrounded them. Then too she was not scared. She assumed that they would leave her alone, once they knew, who she was but before she could open her mouth, they had tied her companion to the tree. This elicited a scream from her mouth, but Kalamugars were unfazed. One of them turned towards her and held up his trident and said, "Woman! Don't shout. If you come with us quietly, we will not harm you or else you will fall prey to this trident."

Vanathi tried to speak to him courageously and said, "Do you know who I am? I am the daughter of Kodumbalur Vellar. If you touch me, you will be destroyed."

But the Kalamugan was unfazed by her revelation. He said, "We know who you are. We have been waiting for you in this forest, for a

long time. Do not make a sound or else we will be forced to silence you.”

At the same time, Vanathi could hear the Kalamugars whipping her palanquin bearers and their screams of pain. She tried to get down from the palanquin but before she could move, the Kalamugars took the Palanquin and started running towards the dense forest path. As they ran, they screamed with a peculiar sound that would have drowned any pleas of help from her. It was impossible to jump out of the palanquin, as the entire gang of Kalamugars had surrounded it from all sides. Vanathi decided to wait out and see what would happen.

For about half-hour, they ran with the palanquin and in the dense forest, there was a clearing, where an old Durga temple was situated. They placed the palanquin near the entrance. By then, darkness had enveloped and nothing could be seen clearly. One of them went inside the temple and came out with a burning lamp. He held it near Vanathi’s face and said, “Woman! We have a few questions for you. If you tell us the truth, we will not harm you. We will escort you to your destination safely.”

“What questions? What do you wish to ask me?”

“Woman! You left Pazhaiaarai alone to meet someone in secret. Who were you planning to meet and where were you going?”

“What do you care, who I am planning to meet? What is it to you? I will not tell you anything about it.”

The Kalamugan laughed and said, “You don’t have to say anything. We know that you had plans to meet Prince Arulmozhivarman. Tell us where he is hiding and we will not harm you.”

“You are free to harm me in any way, you want but I will not tell you anything.” Said Vanathi with determination.

“So, we are free to harm you, is it? I doubt if you would say this if you knew what’s in store for you.”

“Go ahead! Tell me.”

“First, we will take one of your beautiful soft arms and burn it in the fire. Next, we will roast your other arm and then we will unravel that long hair of yours and burn that as well...”

“Is that so? Here is my arm. Bring the fire log here and go ahead!”

Vanathi was well aware of the conspiracies that the rebel lords were hatching against the royal family. She surmised that these Kalamugars must be their men and they are trying to find out where the Prince was hiding.

If I underwent torture to save the Prince from these murderous rogues, then what more could I ask from life?

It was this thought that gave Vanathi the courage and determination to talk fearlessly to her captors.

“Woman! Don’t be foolish. Answer our questions, or else you will regret your silence when you roam around like a sightless beggar.”

“You are free to torture me in any manner you wish. Go ahead and burn my arms... hack me to pieces and kill me, but I will not tell you anything.”

“Alright. I think it is time that we make good on our promises. You! Get that firelight close here...”

Just then, Vanathi’s attention was diverted when she saw a procession of palanquin, elephants and horsemen appearing at a distance. It looked as though the procession was coming towards them. Heaving a sigh of relief, she realized that she would soon be rescued.

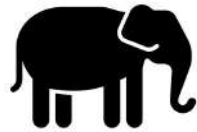
“There! Be careful now! Someone is coming.” She said to their leader.

Instead of being scared, they laughed outright and asked her mockingly, “Do you know who is coming?”

“It looks like Prime Minister Anirudhar. If I scream, they will be able to hear me. Save yourself. Run away from here before they catch you or else....”

“Yes! The Prime Minister is on his way here. It was on his orders that we kidnapped and brought you here.”

Now Vanathi was not only shocked but also afraid. A scream almost escaped from her mouth!



Chapter 39: Gajendra motcham

Vanathi got down from the palanquin and watched the procession arrive near the temple. Her kidnappers, the Kalamugars too stood next to her silently. The silence was so absolute that she could hear the croaking of a lone frog at a distance.

She didn't think she could run and escape the approaching party or her captors. She knew the Prime Minister's reputation. She might probably escape the Kalamugars with schemes and tricks but the same may not work on Anbil Brahmarayar. His political acumen and brilliant statesmanship were well known even among the sheltered womenfolk of Pazhaiaarai. In the innermost chambers of anthapuram at Pazhaiaarai, womenfolk and servants freely discussed the affairs of the Kingdom and the private lives of every nobleman. But no one spoke a word about Anirudhar, ill or otherwise, because they feared that he might learn about it somehow. It was a well-known fact that the Emperor who was known for his benevolence in other matters, would never tolerate disrespect towards his dear childhood friend.

Vanathi knew all this and more. She knew that Princess Kundavai had great respect towards the Prime Minister, therefore, she hoped to get assistance and protection from him but the Kalamugars' revelation came as a shock to her.

Why would the Prime Minister send these Kalamugars to capture her, of all people? Could they be lying?

Though she was confused about the turn of events, she was, however, sure of one thing.

Irrespective of who came here to question her, be it the Pazhuvur brothers, Prince Madhuranthakan or even the Prime Minister, I must not reveal any information about the Prince.

This decision bolstered her heart and gave her new determination.

Let them come... I will let them see how brave the people of Kodumbalur clan can be.

The procession stopped at some distance and a palanquin came forward borne by bearers. After it neared Vanathi, the bearers kept it down and Prime Minister Anirudhar got down from it. At his signal, the bearers and the Kalamugars withdrew to a respectful distance and waited.

“How strange? Is this perchance a dream? You are Kodumbalur Princess, aren’t you? You are the daughter of Kodumbalur Siriya Vellar who sacrificed his life for the honour of the Chola Kingdom in Ilangai.”

“Yes. I am the Kodumbalur Princess. Ayya! I hope I too am not dreaming about standing in front of the most respected Prime Minister of this Kingdom and the cherished childhood friend of our emperor.”

“Good. I am happy to learn that you know who I am. It will make my task easier and I need not give you too much trouble.”

“I wish you wouldn’t worry about giving me trouble, as I wouldn’t consider it as one.”

“I am glad to see that we understand each other perfectly well. I do not wish to trouble you overtly. I have a few questions to ask you, and if you answer them to my satisfaction, I will...”

“Ayya! Before you question me, might I ask a few questions of my own?”

“Go ahead and ask. You are like my daughter. A few days ago, I met your uncle Budhivikrama Kesari in Ilangai and he requested me to take care of you as my own daughter, during his absence and I promised to oblige him...”

“Is that so? Then let me offer my salutations to you! A few years ago, when I met the Emperor, he had promised to be a ‘father’ to me and now I have the most powerful Prime Minister too wanting to adopt me as his daughter. I think I am truly blessed.”

“Child! Ask whatever you wish of me quickly. It looks like it is going to rain.”

“Father! Was it you who ordered these Kalamugars to kidnap and bring me to this isolated temple? Was it you who ordered them to mutilate me, if I failed to answer questions? These scoundrels are saying so, but I refused to believe them...”

“Child, they speak the truth. It was ‘I’ who ordered them to bring you here. If that is a crime...”

“Ayya! Your statement shocks me. You are the most powerful Prime Minister of this Kingdom and yet you have no idea whether an action such as this is a crime or not? You know the law of this land and you are in a position to question the Emperor himself if he committed a crime. It is indeed strange that you do not know, whether kidnapping a lone woman and threatening her with mutilation, is a crime or not? If ‘you’ do not know this simple fact that what will happen to the rest of the women in this Kingdom?”

The Prime Minister was speechless for a short while, and he found it impossible to get a word in between. His voice hardened with anger when he said, “Princess! Stop, please. Your eloquence is a wasted

effort, I assure you. There are enough and more reasons for me to wonder whether it was a 'crime or not' because it solely depends on the answer that you would give to my questions. I learned that a woman who knew a very important secret about the Kingdom was travelling on the Nagapattinam road and I asked my men to stop this woman and bring her to me. They might have made a mistake. They might have kidnapped the wrong woman who had been to Kudanthai Jodhidar's house. Tell me the truth, daughter! Did you intend to return to Pazhaiaarai from Kudanthai? Did your palanquin bearers take you on the Nagapattinam road, by mistake? Tell me that it was never your intent to meet someone who had plotted against this kingdom? If you can prove that these allegations are wrong, then my men have indeed committed a crime and I too am complicit in it. What do you say? Shall I speak plainly? Did you start on this journey to meet Prince Arulmozhivarmar?"

The Kodumbalur Princess was shaken to the core by the Prime Minister's questions and she was also very angry. She knew that there was no point in showing her anger on this man. At that moment somehow, she transformed from being an innocent maiden to a woman, who would weigh each word she spoke, lest she reveals something important.

"Ayya! What is this that you are saying? How can Prince Arulmozhivarmar plot against his own kingdom? Isn't it a crime to speak about the most darling Prince of the Kingdom thusly? I think I should report this to Princess Kundavai immediately."

"Go ahead and report anything you wish, Princess. You need not tarry here for a minute longer after you have answered my questions. I will escort you myself to Princess Kundavai."

"And if I don't answer your questions... then?"

"You can't escape without answering the questions from this old man, Princess. You will have no choice but to answer me."

“Ayya! You are the most powerful man in this Kingdom but you will not learn anything from me. I might be a poor orphan girl, without any protection in this kingdom but I will not answer your questions. Your men promised to burn my fingers in the fire a little while ago, maybe you should do good on that promise.”

“Princess! I commend your brave heart and steadfastness. You are indeed the daughter of the brave Velir, who lay down his life for this Kingdom. You say that you will not answer my question... that is wrong because you have already answered several of my questions. There is but one more question for you to answer, which will make all things simpler...”

Vanathi was shocked into silence. She wondered whether she inadvertently say something without her knowledge. Then she took heart and reined in her courage.

No! I didn't say anything. This old man is trying to trap me into answering his questions.

“Ayya! You are known to be the most learned man in this world. I am sure you recite the Vedas every day therefore, it is not right for you to lie thus. How can you say this? I haven't said anything about the Prince, then how could you claim that I did?”

“Think carefully, Princess. You may be surprised to know that one need not open their mouth, to answer a question. Your very silence about my question has indeed answered them. Let me tell you what you revealed then. The entire Kingdom is right now under turmoil because Prince Arulmozhivarmar is presumed to be dead. The citizens of this Kingdom right from noble families to the poor beggar are mourning his death, yet you are standing here telling me that ‘you don't know anything about him’. What does that reveal? That shows that you know for a fact that the Prince is ‘well and alive’. I asked you whether you were on your way to Nagapattinam but you didn't refute that either. You didn't tell me ‘No I am not going to Nagapattinam... I am going elsewhere’ and nor did you counter me

saying, 'How can I meet a Prince, who is already dead?' This essentially means that you know that he is alive and you are on your way to meet him. Now, there are just two more questions that you need to answer. Where in Nagapattinam, is the Prince hiding and I need to know how you learned this information? Once you give this information, you need not worry about anything else, I will escort you safely anywhere you wish to go."

Vanathi plunged into despair. She knew now that she had doomed the Prince's fate through her foolishness.

Is there any way that I can redeem myself from this blunder? No, that's not possible. The only way out is to give up my life!

"Ayya! You claimed that you are a friend of my uncle's and that you consider me as your daughter. I beseech you... I do not wish to go to Nagapattinam and nor do I wish to go to Pazhaiaarai..."

"You wish to go back to Kodumbalur... I would be happy to escort you there."

"No. I don't want to go there...I wish to leave this world. Please ask your men to sacrifice me at the temple's altar. I am ready."

"Princess! I told you that I would fulfil your wish, whatever that would be. Therefore, if it is your wish to leave this world, then so be it, but before that, you will need to answer my question."

"Ayya! There is no use asking me any question, as I will not be answering you. If you truly consider me as your daughter..."

"Princess! I do consider you as mine own daughter. I have known your family for many years. I had great admiration for your father. Your uncle and I have been friends, for the past forty years now. However, I never endeavour to mix friendship and politics. Where the welfare of the Kingdom and its people are concerned, we have to set aside these relationships. I can't turn a blind eye to your crimes, just

because I consider you as my daughter. Just look at the Emperor's actions. Did he stop to consider his relationship with his son? No. When he learned that the Prince had indeed plotted against him, didn't he send his men to imprison him?"

"Ayya! You are saying so many things about the Prince. In what way did the Prince plot against the Emperor and the Kingdom?"

"Ah! So, you don't know about it. That might be the reason, why you are refusing to answer my question. Let me enlighten you. Ponniyin Selvan went to Ilangai on the pretext of fighting the war. When our armies defeated the Ilangai King, he saw an opportunity to grab the Kingdom for his own. Isn't that treason against the Emperor and his Kingdom? When the Chakravarthy knew about this plot, he sent two ships full of soldiers to imprison the Prince but he foiled their attempts, by deliberately jumping into the sea. The rumours of his death are false because I am sure he must have escaped somehow to some secret place. You are an innocent girl, that's why you don't know anything about the Prince's ulterior motives. If you try to hide his secret, you too will be complicit in this plot, against the Kingdom and will be treated as one. Therefore, tell me the truth, where is the Prince?"

Vanathi's anger broke all bounds. She couldn't stand there and listen to the falsehoods and lies that the Prime Minister was speaking about her Prince. Her anger transformed her from a calm gentle creature into a ferocious roaring tiger.

"Ayya! You are peddling malicious lies. All your accusations against the Prince are false. In Ilangai, when our army was disheartened, the Prince took over the command and gave our war campaign, a new life. They fought and defeated the enemy, thanks to the Prince's presence and his war tactics. When the people of Ilangai came to know about the Prince's grace, goodness and benevolence they wanted him to rule as their King. The Buddha Mahasangam offered the throne of Ilangai to him but he refused. I can't believe that you would say such things about him! When the Prince learned that the

Emperor had sent his men to imprison him, he hastened to meet them on his own. He didn't jump into the sea deliberately. He was trying to save his dear friend's life. The Prince never plotted against the Emperor or the Kingdom. I am an unfortunate creature, indeed, who had to listen to such falsehoods."

Anirudhar responded to her tirade, with a slightly mocking smile, "Princess! If someone were to hear you talk thusly about the Prince, they would conclude that you both were lovers."

"Ayya! What you just said is half true. I have indeed lost my heart to the Prince, but I doubt if there is any room in his heart for the likes of me. Even the smallest of the birds in this world can fall in love with the moon but the moon does not know that the bird exists."

"Ah! I didn't know that my dear friend's niece had such an appreciation of poetry. But then, that's probably why Princess Kundavai cherishes your friendship so much."

"Enough! I want no praises from you of all people. Either you let me go free or else command your men to sacrifice me."

"Princess! You seem to know too many things about Ponniyin Selvar, I am sure you also know where he is hiding right now. Tell me where he is and I will take you to your uncle. He has returned from Ilangai now and would have reached Madurai by now."

"Ayya! My uncle is not a person who would be friends with people who have poison in their hearts. I am an orphan. I have no parents, no relatives or family to speak of. I know nothing about the Prince and even if did, I will not be revealing it to you. Do not waste time..."

"Yes. We can't tarry anymore. It looks like it's going to rain anytime now..."

"Where there are people like you, thunder and lightning too would fall..."

Nature seemed to acknowledge Vanathi's words because even as she said it, a flash of lightning streaked across the sky.

"Woman! Will, you not tell me where Prince Arulmozhivarman is?"

"No."

"My guess is correct then. You are indeed on your way to meet him with a secret message. Is that true or not?"

"Ayya! You are wasting time. I am not going to answer any of your questions."

"Alright. Then prepare yourself. You will be punished in a manner that befits those who collude with criminals who conspire against the Kingdom."

"I am ready for whatever punishment you wish to mete out. Lead the way. I will lay my head on the sacrificial altar."

"No. You are the daughter of Kodumbalur Velir. You deserve a punishment that befits your station in life. Look at that elephant!"

Vanathi looked at the elephant that was in the forefront of his entourage. It was a huge beast dark and massive. In the enveloping darkness and the drizzling rain, she could discern only the pearly white ivory of the elephant's tusk.

"Princess! Have you heard of Gajendra Motchan? When a crocodile caught the elephant's foot, it cried for help and Lord Vishnu came all the way from Vaikuntam to save his devotee and slew the crocodile and sent it to the nether world. This elephant too has punished many people for their crimes and have sent them to the nether world. You said that you wished to leave this world... this elephant would fulfil your wish within a second. It will wound your body within its trunk and throw you away."

After saying this, the Prime Minister laughed which sounded terribly sinister to Vanathi. She was sure that he was a demon hiding within the skin of a human.

“Princess! Let me ask you for the last time. Will you tell me where the Prince is hiding or would you prefer a terrible death through this elephant?”

“Ayya! Will you ask the elephant to come towards me or shall I go to him?”

Anirudhar signalled with his hands for the elephant to come closer and then he said something incomprehensible in a language that Vanathi didn't understand. The elephant came forward and entwined its huge trunk around Vanathi's slender form and lifted her from the ground.

During that moment, many thousand thoughts came to Vanathi's mind. She was shocked and surprised by the fact that she was so brave and courageous while facing the Prime Minister.

Didn't Princess Kundavai mock me all the time for being timid and meek? If she had only seen me now what would she think? Will she ever know what happened to me? No...She will know one day and will tell Ponniyin Selvar how bravely I gave up my life to safeguard his secret. What will the Prince think then? Will he realise that I was braver than that fisherwoman?

The elephant's trunk moved upwards and Vanathi too moved up.

Yes! That Brahma Rakshashar was right. This elephant is going to throw me. God knows where I will fall but I will be dead soon.

The elephant was ready to throw her. Its trunk was above the head. Vanathi closed her eyes and waited for the inevitable to happen. Thankfully, she also lost consciousness at the same moment.

Chapter 40: Aanaimangalam

We know that one of our heroines Vanathi has the annoying habit of fainting at the end of momentous chapters. We hope that you would excuse her this one time because she would soon be cured of this habit.

When Vanathi gained consciousness again, she felt as though she was swaying in the sky. Drops of rain fell all around her and she could smell the rain and the freshness of the earth and the drip-drop sound of the rainwater. Though it was dark all over she could still make out flashes of lightning on the sky and the cold wind blew all over her.

She remembered the Prime Minister's words about going to the nether world and the elephant lifting her in its trunk.

Anirudhar's words came true. My life in this world has ended and I am travelling towards the nether world. I will probably see Gods and Goddesses in this world. But he wouldn't be there. The one person whom she had enshrined within her heart as God will not be there. So what's the use of going to the nether world?

Why am I swaying thus? Why is my mount shaking? But the place where I am sleeping is so comfortable and soft just like a mother's lap. No... more than my mother's lap it reminds of Princess Kundavai's lap who loves me just like a mother.

Ah! I wonder what she is doing in Pazhaiaarai right now? When would she learn of the terrible fate that befell me?

Alright! I am travelling to the heavens through the clouds but what kind of vehicle am I on? Could it be Pushpaka Vimanam that comes in Ramayana or would it be Airavatham – Indra's magnificent white elephant? My God! Why am I thinking about an elephant now? That life is over and done now.

Though she tried to convince herself about her death, Vanathi's curiosity got better of her and she tried to find out where she was lying. She touched the place where her head was placed and found it as soft as silk. Someone was touching her cheek and her eyes and was calling her...

"Vanathi! Vanathi!"

"Akka! Is that you?"

"Yes. It's me. Who else?"

"Are you travelling with me to the heavens?"

"Why do you wish to go to the heavens, my girl? Are you so tired of this world now?"

"Then... where are we going?"

"You have forgotten about it so soon? Don't you remember that we are going to Aanaimangalam?"

"Where? Where are we going?"

"Great! We are going to Aanaimangalam perched atop an elephant no less."

“Ayyo! An elephant!”

“Are you afraid of elephants now? Why are you shivering?”

“Akka! Did I fall asleep?”

“Yes, you did. You were cherishing the joy of travelling in an elephant and fell asleep happily.”

“Fell asleep happily! There was nothing happy about it. I had the most frightful dreams.”

“I thought so as well. You were blabbering many things in your sleep.”

“What did I blabber?”

“You spoke about Kalamugars... sacrifice and then Gajendra Motcham and then Elephant’s trunk! After that, you abused our poor Prime Minister Anirudhar and called him names! I do say that he totally deserves being abused thus... though if he had heard it, I doubt if he would sleep peacefully for days.”

“I can’t believe that it was all a dream, Akka.”

“What was the dream... tell me that?”

“I dreamt that the Kalamugars kidnapped me and took me to the Prime Minister who asked many questions about the Prince. I refused to answer his questions and he got irked by my refusal and commanded the elephant to throw me to death. I wish you had seen me then, akka. I didn’t flinch away from the danger and nor did I give away to despair. I remembered you then... I wished you were there to see me stand up to that man bravely.”

“Well... I am glad that at least in your dreams you turn out to be brave.”

Vanathi remained silent for a while and then said, “I still can’t believe it.”

“What can’t you believe?”

“All that can’t just be a dream...”

“Sometimes dreams can be that realistic too...I have had many such dreams that seem so real that I can’t believe it when I wake up.”

“What dreams are these? Tell me.”

“Why? I dream of my brother all the time. It’s been so long since he went to Ilangai but in my dreams, he is there with me.”

“You are lucky akka!”

“Lucky, am I? What do you know of my heart that has been in pain ever since he disappeared in the sea?”

“What if that too had been dream and never happened?”

“If only it were so Vanathi, but it is true. The Prince did jump into the sea and people who saw it have come back to tell us about it.”

“You are talking about the Vandiya Devan aren’t you? Didn’t he say something else about the Prince and the boat girl and mention Choodamani Viharam as well?”

“It must be one of your dreams then. Now that I recall, you did blabber something about the boat girl Poonguzhali and Choodamani Viharam in Nagapattinam. You also said that you would become a Buddha Bikshuni! Have you lost interest in this world that you wish to give up its pleasures?”

“Akka! Don’t you know my heart? I have no wish to live now that he is no more! I truly wish that the elephant had thrown me to death.”

“Wretched girl! You would die and leave me alone!”

“You are different akka!”

“True! You bear more love and affection towards my brother, than I do, perhaps?”

“Akka! I didn’t mean that. I was about to say that you have a strong heart that has the forbearance to weather through dark times... whereas I don’t have such fortitude and I have no wish to live on after he is gone...”

“Stop! Why do you say that he is dead? Why should we believe such a thing? Do you know for sure? Did you see? Pazhuvur brothers and their queen and that poor Madhuranthakan might mourn my brother in the public and feel happy about it privately, but why should we do it?”

“What are you saying then? What do you think happened to him after he jumped into the sea during the fierce storm? If he had escaped, don’t you think he would have come back home by now?”

“Foolish girl! When someone jumps into the sea, should we just assume that they died?”

“If he had escaped, then why didn’t he come back home?”

“Vanathi! Do you know what happened to my father when he was young? For many months in a row, he was missing and no one knew where he was. They searched for him high and low in the seas and then brought him back to the kingdom and made him the heir apparent to King Gandaradithar. My own grandfather Aringzha Cholar went missing after the Thakkolam war and returned after many years. Listen to me Vanathi! My beloved Ponni River saved my

brother and gave him back to me years ago... in the same manner, Samudhra Raja^[70] too would give him back to me. There are many small islands dotting the coast of Ilangai, it is possible that the Prince might have taken shelter there. I started on this journey just to ensure that no effort is spared in searching for the Prince. Don't you remember I told you all this just before we started? I can't fault you though... you have been in a state ever since the news about the Prince came."

Vanathi remained silent for a while and then asked, "Akka! What's the name of the place where we are going?"

"Aanaimangalam."

"Where is it?"

"It is near Nagapattinam. In your dreams, you had blabbered about Choodamani Viharam that too is near Aanaimangalam. If you truly wish to become a Buddha Bikshuni, it would be very convenient for us. But don't be in a tearing hurry to give up this world and don ochre robes... you can decide about it after we get more news about Ponniyin Selvan." Said Kundavai and laughed.

"Akka... you are laughing. How can you? Are you so sure that the Prince has escaped?"

"If I am not sure, then would I be like this Vanathi? The astrologer's predictions have certainly come true. The divine couch and the Sudarshana Chakra mark in his hands will come true... so far whatever was predicted about him has come true."

"I don't know how you can believe all that..."

"You have not been yourself ever since you heard the news. Almost all the astrologers that I had consulted told me that Arulmozhi would have to pass through many dangers to his life and that has come

true. I am sure the rest of the predictions about his life too would come to pass...”

“What were the rest of the predictions?”

“I have told you so many times...why do you want me to repeat it now? Sleep now... we will talk about it later.”

Vanathi remained silent for a while and then said, “Why are we travelling in the night that too on the elephant, akka?”

“You don’t remember? If we travel in the day, people from nearby villages would come to us with questions about the Prince... It would be impossible to answer them... and they, in turn, would curse the Pazhuvur brothers of conspiracies and abuse the Pazhuvur queen in our hearing. Why should we hear all that? The Pazhuvur brothers might even go to the length of accusing me of inciting the public against them. That’s why we are travelling in the night. I told you all this when we left Pazhaiaarai but you seem to have forgotten. I hope we find some cure for you at Choodamani Viharam... Now go to sleep... even I am feeling sleepy. There is nothing else to do on this moving mountain...”

Vanathi resolved to remain silent from now on and thought back to the day’s events... they seemed real to her now.

I am not dreaming and nor am I imagining things as Princess Kundavai seems to believe... she concluded.

She wondered what might have happened to her after the elephant had lifted her with its trunks but she couldn’t remember anything. One possibility was that Princess Kundavai might have arrived there on time, to save her...

She imagined how the Prime Minister must have felt after seeing Kundavai but the elephant had lifted her in its trunk to throw... how could Kundavai save her from this danger?

What if this is the same elephant that had lifted me with its trunk?
She could faintly remember seeing a hooded seat on top of the elephant.

What if Kundavai had been sitting in the hooded seat all the while when the Prime Minister was talking to me? The elephant might have placed me in the hooded seat, instead of, throwing me to death!

Vanathi had seen elephants do that feat many a time. She wondered whether Kundavai and the Prime Minister had concocted this plan just to stop her journey or maybe they wished to check how brave she was?

Didn't Kundavai do a similar thing by arranging a dead crocodile to frighten me?

Be that as it may...travelling to Nagapattinam alone, was a stupid plan in the first place. It is so comforting to be with Princess Kundavai and sleep on her lap instead. She wondered whether to believe in Kundavai's optimism or not? She now knew for sure that the Princess wouldn't be so cheerful unless she knew for sure that the Prince is alive and well.

Will I meet the Prince at the end of this journey?

When she thought about the meeting, her heart bounded with love and anticipation.

The elephant walked on and on through the night. The royal guards accompanied it guarding its front and rear. The rain had stopped after a while and the stars came out.

Vanathi looked at them and wondered whether they can truly influence the lives of countless people who live in this world.

For many years now, she had heard astrologers comparing Ponniyin Selvar's stars and hers as a perfect match.

Is there any truth in all that? Kudanthai Jodhidar had predicted that the son born to her would rule the world! Would it come true?

They also say that the appearance of a comet on the sky indicates grave danger ... if so what danger would it be?

Is the danger averted now that the Ponniyin Selvar jumped into the sea or could it be something else... something more fatal?

Will he truly return just as Kundavai believes?

With these and many other thoughts swirling through her mind, Vanathi slept for a while. When she woke again, it was early in the morning.

Kundavai too was up and she parted the veils of their hood and looked out and said, "We have reached Aanaimangalam. We have arrived at the Chola palace..."

They both ascended from the elephant hood and entered the palace. The palace retainers welcomed the Princesses warmly and showed them the place. In the end, they went to the rear of the Palace, which was at the backwaters of a canal that joined the sea.

"Akka! You said that you would be making arrangements to search for the Prince.

"Yes, Vanathi... the arrangements have been made. See there... do you see a boat? The people in the boat might bring us some information."

Vanathi saw that there were two people in the distant boat. "Akka! Who is coming in the boat?"

“The boat is rowed by Senthana Amuthan... remember him? We released him from the Thanjavur Dungeon prison and the other person in the boat must be Poonguzhali, his cousin.”

Goose pimples rose on Vanathi's body and she said, “Akka! I do not wish to meet that woman; I will go inside.”

“What is this? Why are you so afraid of that girl now? Stay where you are and don't say anything.”

The boat neared the palace even as both the women waited for it.

.....

How did Vanathi escape from the elephant? Her guess proved to be right in this case. The elephant, as she had anticipated did not throw her to death. Instead, it had handed her over to the hood, where Princess Kundavai caught the unconscious girl and laid her down.

After that, the Prime Minister had looked up and said, “Devi... I will take my leave now. May your journey be successful and fruitful,”

“Ayya! I thank you for your help.”

“You said that the Kodumbalur Princess was a coward? I haven't seen a braver girl than her...”

“She was a faint-hearted girl before but off late she has become braver...”

“That must be because of you Princess... She must think that I am the worst demon in the three worlds... but then many people think about me in that manner and I am not bothered about other people's opinions... I will take your leave now.”

Saying thus, the Prime Minister got into his palanquin and headed west, while the elephant and its guards turned south.

Right after the Prime Minister's journey began, it started raining but the bearers and the guards didn't stop for respite anywhere. In a little while, the rain too stopped and that's when the Palanquin stopped.

"Why have you stopped?" asked the Prime Minister.

"Master... it looks as though someone is lying under the tree there."

The Prime Minister looked out and at that time, a bolt of lightning flashed through and he could see a figure lying on the ground.

"Yes... It looks as though someone is there." said the Prime Minister and got down from the palanquin and then walked towards the tree.

He could hear someone moaning in pain...

"Who is there?"

"Is that the Prime Minister?" asked the person who was lying there.

"Yes. This is the Prime Minister. Who are you?"

"Ayya! Don't you recognize me? I am Madhuranthakan."

"Prince! What is this? What happened to you? How did you end up thus?" said the Prime Minister and hurried towards him.



Chapter 41 – Madhuranthakan’s gratitude

When the Prime Minister tried to lift the Prince, he wailed in pain.

“Ayyo! I am dead! Don’t touch my legs.... they are broken.”

Anirudhar asked him, “Prince! What happened to you? How did this mishap occur?”

“My legs are broken. I can’t walk... nor can I stand.”

The Prime Minister called out his men to bring the palanquin nearby and then turned towards the Prince and said, “Ayya! What happened to you? How did you end up alone in the forest, hurt and broken? Where is your entourage? Where are your royal guards and servants? How dare they leave you alone in the forest, in this rain? I can’t think of a punishment that would be just enough for such scoundrels!”

“Prime Minister! There is no need to punish anyone. I came on my own here alone on a horse. I was going by the riverbank when it started raining heavily and then the lightning struck. My horse bolted and started galloping wildly. I couldn’t control it. Then I fell near this tree, that’s when my legs either broke or I might have sprained them. I can’t get up without any aid. Thankfully, you came in the dead of the night, to help me.”

“It was your father King Gandaradithar’s blessings and good deeds that saved you, today Prince, that’s what sent me this way towards you. Bear the pain for a little while, my men and I will carry you to the

Palanquin. We will discuss the other details while on the way to my house, near Nadan Kovil.”

Anirudhar’s men brought the palanquin nearby and kept it down and then they helped Madhuranthakar up on his feet and placed him inside, amidst many painful groans from the Prince.

After that, the bearers lifted the palanquin and walked slowly so that the Prince didn’t get jostled during the journey. The Prime Minister walked alongside the palanquin.

After a while, they reached Nadan Kovil village, where the Prime Minister had a house near the temple. Anirudhar and his men took the Prince inside and laid him down on a bed. Next, they lit a lot of lamps and proceeded to check the Prince’s leg and found that he had indeed sprained his leg and that they were not broken. This relieved the Prince and his panic subsided.

The Prime Minister’s servants got food from the temple that he partook along with the Prince.

“My Prince! Sleep well tonight. In the morning, I will make arrangements for you to go, wherever you wish. I am on my way to Thanjavur, if you wish, I can accompany you there.”

“Ayya! You have harmed me many times all these years but your actions today, negate all that. I will never forget the help that you rendered me. If I become the Emperor of Chola Kingdom tomorrow, I will retain you as my Prime Minister.”

“Prince! I am indebted to the Chola dynasty. It is my duty to guide and offer apt suggestions and render help to all those who belong to your dynasty. Therefore, there is no need for you to thank me. I was merely doing my duty. I am, however, intrigued by your other statement. You said that I have harmed you many times. I do not understand that. To my knowledge, I don’t think I have harmed you,

in any way, but if I have, I would like you to tell me how to redeem myself.”

“Ayya! Your reputation in this Kingdom is great. You are well known for your political acumen; intelligence and brilliance in strategic affairs, therefore, please do not use your superior skills on me. You very well know, what harm you have caused me but I am willing to forgive and forget all about it only because of the help that you rendered me today. In return, if you need any help from me, I would be happy to give it.”

Anirudhar smiled at him and said, “Yes, my Prince. There is something that this old man wishes from you. I wish that you detest from going anywhere, alone on a horse. It would be best for you to travel in a palanquin, with your entourage and soldiers. People of this Kingdom are very angry, due to various reasons. You saw how people came together and protested in Pazhaiaarai. I am of the opinion, that instead of an open palanquin, a veiled palanquin would be much safer for you and if we can get Pazhuvur Queen palanquin for the same, it would be much easier. No one would suspect that you are travelling.”

Madhuranthakan was flabbergasted. He didn’t think that the Prime Minister knew anything about his journey to Kadambur. Beads of perspiration formed on his forehead, as he tried to gather his thoughts and respond to the old man. “Prime Minister! What are you saying? Are you, intentionally, trying to humiliate me? Why would I travel in Pazhuvur Queen’s palanquin?”

“My Prince! I didn’t know that you found it humiliating to travel in the Pazhuvur Queen’s palanquin! You were going all over the Kingdom in her palanquin and the last journey that you made was to Kadambur Palace, wasn’t it?”

Madhuranthakan looked truly scared now.

“Prime Minister! I... I went to Kadambur...”

“Yes, Prince! You went to Kadambar on the month of Aadi, on the 18th Aadi Peruku day. On that day, even Periya Pazhuvetarayar had accompanied you. You were taken there on the Pazhuvur Queen’s palanquin. To tell the truth, I didn’t like it much. Travelling in a palanquin is recommended for old men like myself. For young men like yourself, travelling on an elephant or a horse is more appropriate, however, you do need appropriate training to do that. Once you regain your health and the use of your legs, I will arrange for the same...”

“Anirudharey! Careful! You have been humiliating me with your words ever since you brought me here. Just because I fell today, do not conclude that I know not how to control a horse. You can’t be more wrong to conclude that I use Pazhuvur Queen’s palanquin, all the time. I am patient only because you are an old man who helped me today...”

“My Prince! I am happy about the fact that you are patient. There is a saying that goes, ‘Those who are patient, rule the earth.’ Do you know what great poet Valluvar said once? He said that there is none more patient than our Mother Earth. It bears the wounds that we men visit upon it. We dig the Earth deep but in return, we are gifted with water. I believe that those who wish to rule too must have the self-same patience that Mother Earth has. Therefore, if this old man talks something inappropriate, kindly bear it with patience.”

“Ayya! What are you saying? Are you accusing me of trying to covet this Kingdom?” Madhuranthakan’s face had by then become red with anger, his lips were trembling and his eyebrows were knitted together in fury.

The Prime Minister was unperturbed by the Prince’s anger. He said, “My Prince! Why would I accuse you of anything? If you wish to rule this Kingdom, how would it be wrong? You are the young scion of King Vijayalaya Chola’s dynasty and the son of King Gandaradithar Chola. You have all the rights to ascend the throne and no one can

accuse you of trying to covet anything when it belongs to you, by rights. However, if someone is advising you to the contrary, and saying that what you wish for is wrong and that you need to indulge in conspiracies against the Kingdom, to attain your wishes, then I beseech that you do not believe these people.

Prince! Please listen to this old man. Your parents didn't wish that you rule over this Kingdom and you listened to them for a while, but now your wishes and desires have changed. No one can fault you or accuse you of trying to covet the Kingdom that should have come to you, by rights. You can march up to the Emperor and openly state your wish to ascend the throne as his heir, instead of trying to garner the support of the Kalamugars and joining hands with the Pazhuvur brothers, to claim the backing of the noblemen. Those who are giving you such ideas are doing a great disservice to your reputation and you must consider them as your enemies."

Madhuranthakan was confused. Firstly, he didn't anticipate the fact that the Prime Minister knew everything about his activities.

"Ayya! How do you know so much about my activities? Who is that traitor who has been acting as my friend and telling on me behind my back?"

"My Prince! It is futile trying to learn my sources. I have eyes and ears all over this Kingdom. Be rest assured, nothing can happen in any part of the Kingdom, without my knowledge."

"If that is so, then does the Emperor also know about all this?"

"No. I haven't seen it fit to inform him about all this, yet. I bear many and more secrets than I care to reveal, My Prince. I reveal them only when the time and circumstances are right."

"True. Your heart bears many dangerous secrets and if by some chance, they get revealed won't it shake the very foundation of this

Kingdom?” said Madhuranthakan with his voice dipped in irony and malice.

The Prime Minister however continued and said, “The Emperor is my friend but there are many secrets that even he doesn’t know. His illness is the biggest source of pain and torment, and his heart is wounded. I don’t wish to burden him more with the conspiracy that the noblemen are hatching, at the behest of the Pazhuvur brothers. My Prince! Be rest assured, I will never inform the Emperor about your involvement or activities, in this regard.”

“Ayya! I wonder why this sudden love for me that too, now of all times?” said Madhuranthakan and laughed derisively.

“My Prince! I have no ‘sudden love’ for you. Whatever respect and love that I bear for the sons of Sundara Chola are also yours to claim. I have always had utmost respect and love for you, since your birth though, there was no occasion to reveal the extent of it to you before...”

“Until today, when you helped me after the mishap with the horse. But if this mishap had happened a couple of days earlier, you wouldn’t have hesitated to kill and leave me to the wolves in the forest, wouldn’t you?”

“Narayana! What are you saying, Prince?”

“Ayya! I am not a fool, who would believe anything that is told to me and neither am I a simpleton who doesn’t know anything. You have been conspiring against me ever since I was but a babe in my mother’s womb. You tried to kill me on the day, I was born... there you are looking surprised. You thought that I didn’t know? Do not be under the wrong impression that you alone know all dark secrets about this Kingdom.”

Anirudhar did indeed look surprised and shocked by the Prince’s words but he soon gained his composure and said, “My Prince, you

are right. There have been many times when I have been vain enough to believe that, I alone, knew the secrets of this Kingdom. Today, however, my pride is broken. Now that you knew all about my plans to kill you at birth, how did you escape my murderous clutches? If you would tell me, I would be much obliged.”

“You wish to know how much I know about everything. All right, I will tell you. You sent murderers to kill me right after I was born and they snatched the child without even checking whether it was a ‘girl’ or a ‘boy’ and when they learned that it was a girl they came and told you. You allowed the girl child to live and gave her off to some priest and asked them to bring her up. A half hour later, my mother gave birth to me and since my horoscope and stars seemed to be fine, you allowed me to live. Since you failed to kill me at birth, you have been determined to stop me from ascending the throne. You tried to influence my mother and asked her to bring me up as a Shiva devotee so that I would willingly refuse the throne. You failed in that too. I didn’t turn out to be the mad Shiva devotee who would renounce the kingdom. Ayya! Why are you looking so stunned? Won’t you argue that all that I am saying is a blatant lie?”

The Prime Minister was indeed looking stunned and it took him great effort to think of a reply. “Prince! There is indeed no point in refuting all this, especially when you know so much about everything.”

“Yes. There is indeed no use. I also know why you saved me. You have no love or regard for Aditya Karikalan. You wished to crown Arulmozhivarmar instead, but now that he has drowned in the sea, you have developed a sudden love for me. Despite all the wrongs that you have done to me, let me tell you this. I will forget the past because of the help that you rendered me today. I will also retain you as my Prime Minister, once I become the Emperor of this kingdom.”

“My Prince! Your words are a great source of happiness for me.”
Said the Prime Minister.



Chapter 42 – Fever subsided

In the meanwhile, at Nagapattinam Choodamani Viharam, Prince Arulmozhivarman lay on a wooden cot, in one of the chambers allotted for the head of the Viharam. He battled through three days of high fever. For the most part, he lay unconscious under the grip of the fever and the old Bikshu sat next to him monitoring his progress.

The Prince woke up sometimes from his fever and wondered incessantly, where he was lying. He kept looking at a painting on the wall by which he lay and was fascinated by its details. There were Devas, Yakshas^[71] and Gandharvas^[72] in that painting playing many musical instruments. Some were present with a hand fan hilted in gold and some held gilded umbrellas. The others bore coloured flowers placed on an ornamental plate in their hands. To the Prince's fevered mind, this painting seemed so vivid that he thought that they were literally standing, in front of him. Whenever he woke from his fevered dreams, he thought that he had travelled to the heaven and that these Devas, Yakshas and Gandarvas were welcoming him to their world. He often wondered, how he had come to the heaven. His last memory of the living world was travelling on a boat, through a beautiful canal steered by a handsome youth and a beautiful girl.

The handsome youth seemed to be utterly devoted to Lord Shiva because he sang many Devaram songs and hymns. The beautiful girl didn't sing. She sat down silently listening to the youth singing and speaking but a few words. To the Prince, these few words seemed like the most beautiful melody he had ever heard. Where did they go?

In the heavens, apart from the Devas, Yakshas and Gandharvas, there seemed to be a special place for Buddha Bikshus too! Maybe, it is they who guard the 'nectar of life' in the heavens. He also noted that an old Bikshu came near him at varying intervals and fed him some nectar. Though heaven seems to be fine and nice, the Prince suffered from unbearable thirst during his stay there.

Why is that old Bikshu being so stingy with nectar? Why can't he give me more and slake my thirst?

Maybe one is not allowed to imbibe more than one's share of nectar! Is this really nectar? Or could it be wine? No! No! Would a Buddha Bikshu willingly touch wine and why would they feed it to him? If that was not wine, then why am I feeling so sleepy? Why do I lose consciousness?

For three days, the Prince lingered between heavens and the black void of fevered unconsciousness. On the fourth day, the Prince woke up completely, shaking off the dredges of unconsciousness that the fever had brought on. Though he felt weak and tired, he was fully conscious and aware of his surroundings.

Now when he looked at the wall, he knew that it was just a painting where Devas, Yakshas and Gandharvas were welcoming Lord Buddha to the land of the heavens and not him. He saw the rest of the paintings in the room, where Buddha was travelling through the skies to reach the heavens. He surmised that he was lying in a Buddha Viharam but couldn't figure where?

He tried to remember everything that had happened since he left Ilangai. He remembered the burning ship and the night that he spent with Vandiya Devan battling the sea waves. He didn't remember much after that.

A young Bikshu came into the room holding a bowl.

Ah! The bowl of nectar!

The Prince took it from his hands and peered into it. It was not nectar. It was just milk probably with some medicine mixed into it. He looked back at the Bikshu and asked, “Swami! Where am I? Who are you? How long have I been here?”

The Bikshu didn’t reply, instead, he withdrew silently to the adjoining chamber and said, “Acharyarey! The fever has completely subsided and he is fully conscious now.”

Sometime later, an old Bikshu entered the Prince’s chamber and checked him. He stood near the cot and looked intently at the Prince’s face. He looked happy when he addressed him and said, “Ponniyin Selva! You are staying at Nagapatinam Choodamani Viharam. You came here, three days ago, in the grips of a shivering fever. We were fortunate enough to lend our roof and assistance, to serve and protect you.”

“I think I am the one who was indeed fortunate. For many years, I have wanted to visit this Viharam. Once I came close to the shores of Nagapattinam but couldn’t come inside. Thankfully, I was lucky enough this time around, to stay here. Swami! Do you know how I came here? Who brought me?”

“My Prince! Please drink the bowl of medicine that you have in your hands and then I will tell you details that I know.”

The Prince drank the medicine and said, “Ayya! This is no medicine but nectar. You have nursed me through my fever and taken care of me with such dedication but I am not going to thank you for it...”

The old Bikshu smiled at the Prince and said, “Prince! There is no need to thank me. Our Lord Buddha has decreed that it is our prime duty to look after those, who are sick and maimed. There is nothing special about healing you. It was our duty. We are indebted to the Chola dynasty. Your father the Emperor and your sister Princess Kundavai have done much and more for us. You have helped our

brethren in Ilangai by rebuilding our monasteries. What we have done, doesn't compare with what you and your family have given us."

"Acharyarey! That's not what I meant. I am aware of how deadly this shivering fever is. I have seen hundreds of my own soldiers dying because of it. I should be dead by now and must be travelling to the heavens, being welcomed by Devas, Yakshas and Gandharvas who would bring me nectar and flowers and play divine music. Instead, I am sitting here, drinking medicine. You brought me back right from the doorstep of heaven, to a world that is filled with sickness, sadness and heartache. That's why I am not thankful to you..."

The old Bikshu's face flushed with joy when he heard the Prince's words.

"Ponniyin Selva! When it is time for you to go to the heavens, the King of the Gods, Devendran himself, would come down and take you with him. But now is not the time. There is much and more that you have to achieve before you could even think about leaving this world."

The Prince sat up after hearing the Bikshu's words and said, "Acharyarey! You are right. There are many things that I wish to achieve before I leave this world. I want to rebuild this Choodamani Viharam and make it as imposing and grand, as the many Viharams that I have seen in Ilangai. I want to sculpt huge Buddha stupas and statues just like the ones in Ilangai. I want to rebuild all the Shiva Temples in our Kingdom in stone. After seeing the huge statues of Buddha in Ilangai, I feel ashamed by our pitiful attempts at sculpting Gods, who are mightier than anything else in this world. I will build a huge temple for Lord Shiva in Thanjavur, and its Gopuram would be stand out as a marvel of our architectural ingenuity and skill. In time, all the temple and Buddha Viharam will compete with each other in stature and size, and it would be a glorious sight to see for our future generations..."

After speaking thus with passion, the Prince reclined again, tired and sore. The Old Bikshu held the Prince by his shoulders and slowly lowered him onto the cot and said, "My Prince! All your dreams and intentions will bear fruit in time, but right now you need to regain your strength and health. Please take rest."



Chapter 43 – Nandi Mandapam

The next day, a younger Bikshu came to the Prince's chamber. The Prince was awaiting the arrival of someone or anyone, who could answer his questions but the Bikshu didn't give him any answers. He listened to him patiently and said, "Ayya! Our Gurudeva will answer all your questions."

The old Bikshu finally came to the chambers and asked, "Prince, how are you feeling now?"

"Ayya! I am feeling so fine that my body is questioning me. It is asking, 'why are you sitting quietly? Get up and run, mount a horse and race him or wrestle with an elephant! Don't lie down like an invalid'. My appetite is voracious today. Whatever food your Bikshus gave me today, wasn't enough, by any measure. I can't believe that I was unconscious and delirious with fever for three days! I feel as if I was never ill in the first place! Your medicines are very potent indeed!"

"Ayya! You shouldn't listen to the dictates of your body now. After the fever subsides, it is but natural for you to wish to get up and go around so, but if you do so, your body will weaken and god forbid, if the fever strikes again, your life will be in danger."

"Gurudeva! I am not worried about the dangers that I face in life."

"You are not worried indeed but lakhs and lakhs of people, who live in your Kingdom are out of their mind, worrying about you. People

are shedding tears and praying against hope for a miracle that would rescue you.”

“Ayya! I do not understand your meaning. Why are people so worried? Don’t they know that I am in excellent hands, undergoing treatment here? Are they worried about my shivering fever?”

“My Prince! People don’t know that you were suffering from fever and nor do they know that you are living here. If they knew that, wouldn’t they assemble in front of the Viharam? I doubt if this Viharam can withstand such an assault! You should have seen the state of the people when the rumour spread that you were lost in the sea. Why... even I stood in front of the Viharam, mourning your death.”

Ponniyin Selvar sat up on the cot and said, “Gurudeva! I can’t understand what you are saying. Who brought this news to this town? When did it come? Who would spread such malicious lies?”

“Prince! I know not who brought the news but, on that morning, everyone hereabouts had heard the rumour and was mourning your death. We heard that one of the ships that you were travelling was struck by lightning and had sunk and that you tried to save someone in that ship and were lost to the sea. We heard that Lord Treasurer Periya Pazhuvetarayar searched for you, high and low, along the coast and came back saying that you were lost to the sea. We at the Viharam too had heard this and were in deep mourning. That’s when one of my bikshus came to me with the news that someone had brought a patient in a boat through the canal that connects the Viharam. And that patient was you. Since then, you have been here under my care.”

“Gurudeva! Do you know who brought me here?”

“A young man and a young woman.”

“Yes... I can remember them faintly. I thought it was all a dream. Do you know who they are? Is the young man Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan?”

“No Ayya! He called himself Senthana Amuthan. He looked like an ardent devotee of Lord Shiva. I didn't learn the young woman's name. She seemed robust and courageous.”

“I can guess who that is. It must be the fisherwoman Poonguzhali, daughter of Tyaga Vida Karayar, the guardian of the lighthouse at Kodi Karai. Did they tell you, why they brought me here?”

“No, My Prince! I didn't ask them about it.”

“Did you inform anyone about the fact that I am safe here?”

“No Ayya! The people who brought you here asked me not to inform anyone that you are safe here. When I saw your health condition, I too felt that it would be better not to inform anyone. You needed all the rest you can get and if people knew that you were here, they would have razed the Viharam to the dust.”

“Gurudeva! Something is wrong. I came back from Ilangai because, my father, the Emperor had ordered me to be imprisoned for treason. On the way, many untoward incidents happened. I suspect that I have been brought here in secret, just so, that they can blame me later, for not accepting my father's commands. That's why they have started these rumours that I am lost in the sea. Gurudeva! By giving me sanctuary here, you too have committed treason... I think you should send me to Thanjavur, immediately.”

“Prince! If by giving you sanctuary here, I have committed royal treason, then I would happily accept any punishment for the same.”

“Ayya! I am grateful for these kind words, yet I am surprised that you accepted me under your care, without interrogating the people who brought me here.”

“There was no need to ask anything, of anyone, Prince. I am duty-bound to serve all those who are sick, ill or maimed. Moreover, the last time I met your sister, Princess Kundavai had hinted that you might be staying here.”

“Is that so? Did my sister say that? When did she say this?”

“She said this, just a few days before you came to us. And the young man who brought you said the same.”

“Gurudeva! That young man and woman, did they leave immediately after they left me here? Is there any way, I can meet them? I wish to speak to them.”

“Ayya! Don’t be impatient. Both of them are staying in this town and they come here every day, to know the state of your health. Though, I don’t know why they haven’t come here still...”

Right at that moment, a young Bikshu came inside with a message. The old Bikshu nodded his head and said, “I will come there.” and exited the room. The Prince waited impatiently until he returned.

“Gurudeva! I do not wish to stay here, any longer. I don’t want to be known as the Prince who tried to escape his father’s commands. I don’t want any harm to befall this Viharam, just because I have been given sanctuary here.”

The Bikshu acceded to the Prince’s request and said, “In truth, we too do not wish to take on that responsibility and nor do we wish to stop you from leaving. You are free to leave right now. There is a boat waiting for at the canal.”

“To go where?”

“That’s for you to decide. The people who brought you here, have come with a boat to take you back.”

The Prince hesitated despite his wish to leave. A mysterious smile bloomed on the Bikshu's face, making him wonder, what was happening around him.

"They have returned? Did they tell you why?"

"They did. At an hour's journey through the canal, there is a place called Nandi Mandapam. They said that two women are waiting to meet you there."

When Prince heard this, he immediately bounded out of the cot and said, "Gurudeva! Take me to the boat immediately!"

The Bikshu took the Prince to the canal that was situated at the back of the Viharam. When Senthana Amuthan and Poonguzhali saw him walking on his own, hale and hearty, their faces became animated with joy.

After the Prince got in the boat, the old Bikshu folded his hand in salutation and said, "Ayya! We consider it our good fortune for helping you through this ordeal and our doors are open to you, all times. I wish that you come back here, for another week, so that you completely recover your health."

"Gurudeva! I think I will be coming back here or else, I wouldn't leave this place without bidding farewell to the other bikshus."

When the boat started moving, the Prince looked at Senthana Amuthan and Poonguzhali and said, "When you last brought me through this canal, I thought that you were divine beings who were tasked to take me to heaven. Instead, you tricked me and took me to a monastery of all places! I need to know what happened after you rescued Vandiya Devan and myself. But before that, tell me who is waiting at Nandi Mandapam?"

Though the Prince had asked the question to both of them, Poonguzhali maintained a studied silence and left Senthana Amuthan to answer him. When the Prince learned that Princess Kundavai and Vanathi had come to meet him, he said, "Why did my sister bring that faint-hearted girl who swoons at every turn?"

Senthana Amuthan then said, "Ayya! Something strange is happening to all the girls in our Kingdom. They wish to abandon the faith they are born in and join the faith of Buddha instead."

"Who is saying this?"

"I believe that Kodumbalur Princess has been saying so, and so is my cousin here."

"Just these two Amudha! I don't think it would be a big loss if we lose these girls to the faith of Buddha. I know of many monasteries in Ilangai, where women live as Buddha Bikshunis. I can personally escort them to one of these monasteries if they so wish." Said the Prince and laughed along with Senthana Amuthan.

Later, Senthana Amuthan related all that had happened ever since Poonguzhali rescued them in the middle of the sea. Ponniyin Selvan listened to him intently and compared the events with many of the memories that he remembered.

Finally, Poonguzhali pointed to someplace in the middle of the canal and said, "There is Nandi Mandapam" and the Prince turned around to see where she was pointing.



Chapter 44 – And the Nandi Grew!

The boat sped through the narrow canal that had thick vegetation shielding them from prying eyes, on both the sides of the bank. The place where Poonguzhali pointed out was an isolated corner with the statue of huge Nandi (the divine bull who guards Lord Shiva) that had given the place its name ‘Nandi Mandapam’.

The Mandapam was used by the Shiva Temple at Nagapattinam where once a year, Lord Shiva and his consort Devi Parvathi were brought there to give darshan to their devotees. During this annual festival, scores of people would visit the Nandi Mandapam and spend the entire day, on the banks of the canal. Since it was near the outskirts of the town, not many people ventured out on other days.

As the boat neared the mandapam, the Prince saw the women who were waiting for him and after that, he didn’t look anywhere else. When the boat stopped near the banks of the mandapam, Princess Kundavai came down the steps to receive her brother. Vanathi stood behind the pillar of the mandapam, watching him with anxious eyes.

Senthan Amuthan and Kundavai helped the Prince to get down from the boat. After he got down, Senthan Amuthan and Poonguzhali took the boat around the Mandapam and waited for him to return.

“Thambi! You have become so frail and lean!” cried Kundavai her voice was laced with sorrow, while tears threatened to escape her eyes.

Ponniyin Selvan said, “Forget about my health, why is your face so gaunt and drawn? Why are you looking so worried? I know that many things have occurred that have pained your heart, that’s why you sent me that Olai summoning me immediately back home.”

“Yes. There are many things for us to discuss and talk. Come here... the prince who refused the golden throne of Ilangai, would you sit beside me on this stone seat?”

Ponniyin Selvan bent down and sought the blessings of his sister, instead. Kundavai lifted him up and breathed the scent of his hair, while tears streamed from her eyes.

After they sat, Kundavai said, “Thambi, I shouldn’t have summoned you here today. The head of Choodamani Viharam told me that you have recovered from the shivering fever, but I can see that you have not, but I couldn’t sit quietly, I had to see you.”

“Akka! Don’t fret. If you had not summoned me here and sent the boat, I might have started for Pazhaiaarai. Even when I was suffering from the fever, all that I could think of was your message, asking me to return home. And the messenger, who brought your Olai, let me tell you, I haven’t seen a more valorous warrior than Vandiya Devar. I tested him in many ways but he passed them all... where is he?”

Kundavai’s face lit up when the Prince spoke of Vandiya Devan, and she smiled when she said, “Thambi! Don’t we have many other things to discuss? Why are you worried about him?”

“Why do you talk thus? Has he courted your displeasure in some way?”

“No! No! Why would I be displeased? He promised me to bring you back home and he kept it...”

“And the tricks that he employed to achieve his ends... My God! I can’t describe them enough. Where is he Akka? When I heard that you have come here, I thought he would have escorted you? Instead, you brought this faint-hearted princess, who swoons all the time.”

“Thambi! You don’t know how brave my friend has become in the time you have been away. Yesterday, our Prime Minister’s elephant wrapped her in its trunk and threw her. She didn’t know that I would catch her atop the elephant. You should have seen how brave she was, when she faced the Prime Minister...”

“Enough with your friend’s praise... give me news about my friend.”

“What’s there to tell about him? He has accomplished his mission and has now gone back to our brother Aditya Karikalan.”

“If that is so, then he has broken his word. He told me that he would not go back to Kanchi and that he would stay in the Chola Kingdom.”

“How is that possible? We, who are living in the Chola Kingdom have no inkling of what our fate would be tomorrow? If you have so much love for him, then why don’t you speak to the Emperor and return his ancestral kingdom.”

“What will he do with that?”

“He will do whatever the rest of the noblemen in our father’s court do. You went ahead and rejected the throne of Ilangai, do you think he too would reject it?”

The Prince smiled at his sister and said, “Akka, I rejected the throne of Ilangai in the presence of witnesses and despite that, I was

accused of treason and soldiers and ships were sent to imprison me.”

“Thambi! If you had accepted the throne, no one would have dared to imprison you. You would have been an independent king, who is beholden to none.”

“Do you think that I should have grabbed the throne, disrespecting the wishes of our father?”

“Ponniyin Selva! If you had accepted the throne of Ilangai, our father would have been pleased. He would have divided the rest of the Kingdom between your brother and Madhuranthakan and would have achieved a measure of peace in his heart. Even now, efforts are being made to divide the kingdom. The north of Kollidam will be one-half of the and south would be another. Father believes that if you come here, you would help with the division of land and wealth. Earlier, when he had sent word, you didn’t heed them, that’s why, he sent soldiers to imprison you. Father is aware of the fact that you have refused the throne of Ilangai.”

“I will never agree to divide the kingdom, instead we can hand it over to our uncle, intact.”

“If that is so, then you and the Prime Minister are of one mind, in this matter.”

“Yes. Prime Minister agrees with me on this. His journey to Ilangai was for the sole purpose of discussing this with me. Akka! Shall I tell you the real reason, why I rejected the throne of Ilangai?”

“Who would you tell, if not me?”

“Yes. I have no one else to share my innermost thoughts with. When I first went to Ilangai, I thought it was a land of great wonders but it was only after I went there that I learned that it was a very small

kingdom. If you have a horse, you can travel from the west coast to the east within a single day.”

“Thambi! Is the Chola Kingdom that big? Can’t someone journey through our lands within one day?”

“The Chola Kingdom is also very small and if someone were to offer me the throne, I would refuse to accept it. I blame those who divided this divine Tamizhnadu as Chola, Pandya and Chera kingdom. That’s why, no matter how many brave courageous kings are born in this land, they did not achieve greatness, of any measure. At the same time, look at the northern land, which was united under the rule of great kings like Chandragupta, Samudra Gupta, Harshavardanar... they were able to unite many kingdoms under one umbrella. Is there any king or emperor in the South, who was able to do that? Only two kings of note have appeared in our history, Kanchi Pallava kings, Mahendra Varma and Narasimha Varma. Now even that dynasty has but disappeared. Akka! If ever I rule any kingdom, I will not be happy with a small tiny kingdom. I would want to rule a kingdom that is vast and large, all the way from Ilangai to the Ganga River in the North. I would like to conquer all the lands and island kingdoms that lie past Ilangai and hoist our tiger flag there. That’s the kingdom that I want to carve.... What are you looking at? Do you think I have become mad?”

“No Arul Varma. I am happy that there is one more person, just like me, who delights in building castles in the air. If you are mad, then I too am mad... and to a larger degree than you are. Do you know our grandfather King Paranthakar too had many dreams just like this? During his lifetime, none of these dreams came to pass, but I am convinced that I would see them become a reality, during mine. I know it in my bones that I would not die before seeing our kingdom spread out vast and large from Ilangai to River Ganga. For a time, I had believed that our brother Aditya Karikalan would achieve this dream of mine, but now I have no such aspirations of him. Aditya Karikalan is a great warrior but he lacks self-control over his mind and heart. Such a person can never achieve great deeds but I still

believe that you can fulfil my dreams. But if you too, are unable to achieve this dream of mine, I will not be disappointed because I am sure your son would not fail me. I will cherish and nurture your son, as my own, right from the time he is born. I will shape him into a warrior that the world has never seen before and he will be the one, who will fulfil all my dreams. I will tutor and teach him about world politics and the art of ruling and he will be the greatest king that the world has ever seen.”

“Akka! Now I am sure, you are indeed madder than I am. I have no intention of getting married and you are sitting here and talking about the son that would be born to me. If any of your companions are dreaming of marrying me and ruling the kingdom beside me as the queen, then please ask them not to indulge in it, as it will never come to pass. That’s my final word on the subject.” Said Arulmozhivarmar and for a second, he glanced pointedly at Vanathi who was listening to their conversation from behind the pillar.

Next, he glanced at the Nandi statue and said, “I have some news for you Akka. Though Ilangai is a very small kingdom, the kings who ruled it was indeed great. They planned great things and accomplished them. You should see the Buddha stupas that they have built there... it almost touches the clouds. They have built Buddha Viharams that had thousand or two thousand rooms! I have seen mandapams that were built with 11,000 pillars! They wanted the people to know the extent of Buddha’s greatness and they showed that with the sheer size of his statue. You know, I have seen statues that are as tall as that coconut tree over there. Just look at this Nandi statue... so small. In Kailasham, the hoards of Lord Shiva trouble him incessantly and it is Nandi’s duty to control them. Would anybody build the divine bull Nandi as a tiny puny statue? Look there, akka! The Nandi is growing right in front of me and it is hitting the roof of the mandapam. The hoards of Lord Shiva stand puny in front of him, wanting to meet their divine lord. If Nandi is so huge, how large would the statue of Lord Shiva be indeed, I wonder? We might have to build a mandapam that would be called as Southern Meru and its gopuram will touch the very clouds. Today, in our

kingdom, all the temples that have been built are just large enough for Agastya Peruma^[73]. Their stature does not match the greatness of Lord Shiva, by any measure. I do not want to rule this Kingdom, however, whoever rules it, I would request them to make me responsible for temple renovation work.”

“Thambi! I think we need to have a contest, as to, who is indeed mad here. The kingdom is under a great threat, thanks to the conspiracies of the noblemen who act, as though, they are our friends. And if that were not enough, we have people who are waiting to start a civil war. I have been seeing a dreadful dream for many nights now. A murderous sword of glistening steel flashes like a lightning and I know not on whom, it will fall. Either, it will claim the flesh of someone dear to us or it will shatter this kingdom into pieces. We need to work together and avert this danger somehow.”

“Yes akka, I was able to understand these dangers from what Vandiya Devan told me. You do know who poses the greatest danger to the Kingdom, don’t you?”

“You are referring to Pazhvur Queen Nandini Devi, aren’t you?”

“Yes Akka, I hope you do know, who she is?”

“From the details that Vandiya Devan told me, I was able to piece it together. That’s why I wanted to talk to you desperately.”



Chapter 45 – Vanathi in danger!

“Akka! Do you remember how I almost drowned, when I was five years of age? Do you remember how Kaveri Amman rescued me and took me back to the boat?”

“How can you ask me this question, thambi? How can I forget that? Don’t we call you ‘Ponniyin Selvan’ because of that incident?”

“I met ‘Kaveri Amman’ who saved my life in Ilangai... Akka why are you silent? Aren’t you surprised?”

“I am not surprised, nor am I shocked but I do have an ardent interest to learn more about her. Tell me everything you know.”

“It is difficult. There is so much to tell... a day wouldn’t be enough, for sure. She saved my life, all those years ago and that’s not all, in Ilangai she has saved me countless times. Akka! I am not beholden to her just for saving me... it’s the great affection that she bears for me that has me enslaved. There is no substitute for that kind of love... why, even the love that bears for me would be secondary.”

“You don’t have to hesitate to tell me that. I would be the first to admit that my love for you isn’t pure. It comes along with many strings, desires, ambitions and dreams that I hope to fulfil through you. Let me be frank with you. My life is tied to this Kingdom and anyone who would be instrumental in making this land ‘great’ will find a place in my heart. I love you all the more, because I believe that under your rule, this beautiful kingdom would flourish. But if you or

anyone, would strive to crush this dream of mine, I might turn against them too. But the love of this deaf and mute woman has no such selfish motives. She showers on 'you' the love that she bore for our father, twenty years ago. There cannot be any comparison for love, such as that."

"When did you learn this?"

"What are you referring to?"

"That she is our step mother?"

"I guessed it from what father told me, and later from Vandiya Devar too. Does she think you are her own son or another woman's son?"

"Neither she and nor I have entertained such thoughts, ever. Why do you differentiate thus?"

"Our mother became the queen of this kingdom, in her stead and despite knowing that, she showers you with love and affection... you who is the son of her rival. Isn't that special?"

"I am sure she knows that I am not her son. If not anything else, the difference in our age,s is quite obvious. She can't talk... can't express anything. She draws pictures and whatever we can understand from that is what we can learn from her. Apart from the love that she bears for me... if you but knew the extent of love that she bears for our father, it breaks my heart to pieces. Akka! Did father look exactly like me, when he was my age?"

"No! Father was as handsome of Manmathan, when he was your age. Our clan was well known for bravery and glorious deeds in war, but not for beauty. Our grandfather, Aringhza Chola married Kalyani Devi who belonged to the Vaithumbarayar clan after being enamoured by her beauty. I have heard that when they married, her complexion was that of gold and her beauty could only be compared to that of a full moon. Even today, after so many years, she still looks

beautiful and that's how our father ended up being the most handsome king in the Chola dynasty, so much so, that his own given name 'Paranthakan' is rarely used. Our brother, you and I, have taken after our mother, in appearance. The Thirukovalur clan hates beauty in any form, and they believe that bravery and beauty can't go hand in hand."

"I know not whether bravery and beauty can go hand in hand, but I do know one thing for sure, there is no connection between affection and beauty. Otherwise..."

"Otherwise, why is this girl Vanathi looking at you, without blinking her eyes? Why are Senthana Amuthan and Poonguzhali, looking at you from over the boat?"

The Prince smiled at her and said, "Akka! You have strayed away from the subject of our conversation. I was talking about the love that Kaveri Amman bore for me. Leave that aside... do you think it's possible for one person to look exactly like another?"

"Why not? If they are twins by birth, it is very much possible. Mother and daughter, can look the same, when they are of the same age. That apart, there has been many instances where two people, who are not related by birth to look the same. It is one of the mysteries of nature."

"I am wondering whether Pazhuvur queen and our stepmother can resemble each other as Vandiya Devar claims. I have seen Nandini when she was very young. I haven't had the opportunity to meet her properly, after she became Pazhuvetarayar's wife. What do you think?"

"I have met Nandini, but I haven't seen our stepmother but I believe Vandiya Devar because what he told me, also matches with what our father related about his past."

"Father spoke to you? When?"

“Few days ago, Vanathi and I went to Thanjavur and that’s when, he narrated many of the past events that had happened, when he was of your age. He told me how he was marooned in an island near Ilangai and how he met a deaf and mute girl and their love for each other. He was found and brought back to the Kingdom by one of the searching party that his grandfather had sent out for him. The day he was anointed as the crown prince of the Kingdom, he saw her in the crowd that was standing outside the palace. She vanished, soon after that and he sent Prime Minister Anirudhar to find her but he learned that she had fallen to her death, from the lighthouse of Kodi Karai. Her death had a dreadful impact on him and ever since, the guilt is eating through him. He is reliving her death and it has taken a serious toll on his health. He believes that she has died because of him.

Leave aside our dreams, ambitions and aspiration for our clan and dynasty... our first duty is to our father. We should find relief for the torment he suffers every day. You will need to somehow bring Kaveri Amman here and we need to prove to him that she is well and alive and by no means dead. Unless we do this, he will not know peace, neither in this life or the next.”

“Akka! Off late I have been at the death’s door many times and each time I had only one regret about my life... that I am dying without uniting Kaveri Amman with my father. Whenever I think about her, my heart bursts with sorrow. Those with the gift of speech can speak and express themselves and those who can hear, can at least ,listen to words of solace but she can do neither. Just imagine her plight! All these years, she has buried, love, affection, sorrows and regrets deep within her heart... I am not surprised that she is roaming through the jungles of Ilangai, like a mad woman. I do wish to reunite her with our father, but do you think he would want that?”

“Whether he wishes it or not, I believe it is our duty to bring her to him. Do you know that for the past 20 years, he believes that he is seeing the ghost of this woman, wanting to avenge for him for her

death? It is this guilt, fear and shame that torment him day and night. That's why, his health is not improving by any measure."

"How did you know this? Did father tell you?"

"Yes, father told me... and so did Vanathi."

"Vanathi... What's this got to do with her? Did you tell about this?"

"No, I didn't. I will let her tell you everything that happened one night when we were in Thanjavur. I think you are being very rude and ungracious. You haven't spoken a word to the Kodumbalur Princess and nor have you enquired after her health? Is this the way, you would greet the daughter of noble Siringu Vellar, who gave up his life for the glory of Cholas?"

"Akka! Why should I enquire after her specially, when you are looking after her?"

"Is that so? Now keep that mouth of yours shut and be gracious. Vanathi! Come here my sweet... the Prince wishes to greet you properly."

Vanathi came near them but didn't look at the Prince. Instead she looked at Kundavai and said, "Akka, why do you speak such lies? Your brother doesn't wish to meet me, his gaze is on the boat, at all times. It is obvious that he wishes to go back ." Obviously she meant Poonguzhali when she spoke about the boat!

The Prince laughed out aloud and said, "Akka! Your friend can speak! And here I was wondering whether she too is deaf and mute, among the others in our family."

"Akka! I do become mute when I am in his presence. Sometimes I wonder, whether I have really been struck mute."

“That’s good I say! In Kodi Karai, there is this man, Poonguzhali’s brother. With others, he manages to speak somehow but when he is in the presence of his wife, he becomes mute. Therefore, his family calls him ‘mute’ despite the contrary.”

“This Princess too is like that. When she first came to us, she used to chatter constantly but ever since, you went to Ilangai the first time, she has changed completely. She doesn’t talk to anyone and strays away to daydream. Vanathi! I want you to tell the Prince about what happened that night at the Thanjavur palace.”

“Let the Kodumbalur Princess sit and narrate her story. If her uncle sees her standing for so long, he would get worried for her health. When I was in Ilangai, he used to enquire about her health whenever he happened to meet me. You never used to send me any message about her and I used to wonder what I could tell him.”

“I had sent a message with Vandiya Devar, didn’t he give it to you?”

“He would have given the message, akka but your brother might not pay any heed to it. He must have been too busy thinking about other things.”

“That’s very true. After seeing your Olai, I have been very preoccupied indeed. I feel as if this fever has affected my ears as well, ask your friend to speak a bit louder.”

Then with Kundavai’s skilful coaxing, Vanathi narrated all that had happened that night when she had tried to find her way to the palace terrace and the King’s wails. She also described whom she saw at the King’s chambers that night when she overlooked the room from the balcony. Many a time, she would glance up and meet the Prince’s eyes and would forget what she had been saying. Kundavai would then prompt and remind her to finish her tale much to the enjoyment of the Prince.

The Prince listened to her with avid interest and then finally said, "Akka! Your friend has forgotten one important thing. After seeing and hearing all these things, I am sure she must have swooned!"

Vanathi bent her head shyly, while Kundavai and the Prince, laughed out aloud.

Kundavai then told her, "Vanathi! Why don't you roam around the banks of the canal? Or if you want, you can go and wait with our entourage in the palanquin. Arul Varman will be here for a few days; we will meet again."

"Alright akka! I will roam around the banks and wait for you." Said Vanathi and left with an enthusiastic gait.

Arul Varman waited until she left and then turned towards his sister, "Akka, I can understand the reason behind father's wails but what do you think about what he saw in his room? If whatever he saw, was his own vision born of guilt then how could your friend see it?"

"Our father didn't see a vision and nor did Vanathi imagine things. Whatever happened that night, was a midnight drama enacted by Pazhuvur Queen Nandini Devi. I guessed the truth even then, and now I know for sure, why she must have done, thanks to you and Vandiya Devar."

"What was the purpose of this drama? What did she hope to learn?"

"Nandini has always been suspicious about the secret of her birth. She also knows that the Emperor swooned the first time he time he saw her. After that incident, she never graced his presence publicly but she must have been curious and wanted to glean as much truth of as possible from him. By enacting this sort of drama, she hoped to learn the truth from him."

"Do you think she has learned the truth?"

“I know not, Arul Varma. Not even the Lord Brahma can hope to understand what lies beneath her heart. When I think about Periya Pazhuvetarayar’s plight in her hands, I feel sorry for him. We spoke about beauty, a few moments ago. If you were to ask who is the most beautiful woman among all, then I would name Nandini. We can’t compete nor compare with her beauty. Hers is a kind of beauty, that enslaves men and makes them her devoted slaves for life. Pazhuvetarayar, Thirumalaiappan, Kandanmaran and now Parthibendran... Our Prime Minister is scared to go near her, lest she influences him. Aditya Karikalan doesn’t come to Thanjavur, for the same reason. There was only one man, who has braved her mesmerizing beauty and is not affected by it...”

“You are talking about Vandiya Devan, aren’t you?”

“Yes. Him. That’s why I have sent him to Kanchi, to guard Aditya Karikalan.”

“Why?”

“Pazhuvur Queen has issued an invitation to Karikalan, asking him to meet her at Kadambur Palace. I sent him there to stop him from going there and if that’s not possible, then I have asked him not to allow them to meet alone. Karikalan doesn’t know that Nandini is our sister and I do not know, whether she knows, this truth or not.”

“Are you sure about this, that she is our sister?”

“I have no doubt about it. And ever since, I learnt it my heart has undergone a transformation. When we were young, I hated her, I was jealous of her beauty. I planned and schemed to humiliate her, I tried my utmost, for you and Kariklan to hate her too. Even after she left for Pandya Kingdom, my hate and envy, for her remained the same. When she came to Thanjavur, as the bride of the old man, I mocked her many times and have insulted her to the face. I have decided to atone for these sins...”

“How?”

“The next time I meet her, I am going to fall at her feet and beg forgiveness and I will happily accept any punishment that she deems appropriate for my sins.”

“If you are planning to do any such thing, I will not allow you in her presence, ever. There is no need for you to beg anybody’s forgiveness and there is no one in this world with power enough to punish you. You didn’t envy Nandini’s beauty; it was she who was jealous of you. It was ‘she’ who hated you with every breath she took.”

“You told me that your heart is filled with sorrow for our stepmother who is roaming through the jungles of Ilangai but have you ever thought about Nandini and what she has undergone in her life. When I think about her, my heart bleeds. She became the ultimate victim of other people’s blunders. My sister, who was born before me, is now the wife of an old man...”

“Akka... Do you know anything about how all this happened? Why did our father think that Kaveri Amman is dead? How did Nandini end up in some priest’s house, brought up by strangers?”

“I have been thinking about this for a long time but I am able to guess very few details, for sure. There are only two people who can shed some light on these secrets. Our grandmother Sembiyanmadevi, must know these secrets and the second is Anirudhar, who probably knows everything. I don’t think we can learn anything from these two people, not unless, they choose to reveal. Anirudhar’s disciple Thirumalai must know everything as well, but he is more close-mouthed than his guru and will never reveal anything. But I don’t think it is important to know these secrets now. What we need to do right now is to ensure that Nandini does not endanger her own family and clan. Vandiya Devar told me that she has a sword in her possession that is engraved with the royal emblem of Pandyas - a fish. He told me that she worships that sword every day, and is

planning to use it to fulfil her oath. Ever since I heard that, fear and anxiety has filled my heart. I am terrified that she would seek vengeance on her own blood...”

“What if we tell the truth to Nandini?”

“I doubt if that would help. Her anger and wrath would surely increase but we need to do what is right and appropriate.”

“You have sent Vandiya Devan to guard our brother. That’s the right move but what about our father? Why should he drown in guilt? Shouldn’t we tell him everything? Shall we start for Thanjavur right away?”

“No. I will leave for Thanjavur in two days, but you need to stay at Choodamani Viharam for some more time.”

“Why do you say that? Do you want me to hide myself away, just to escape from our father’s orders?”

“Yes. If you come to Thanjavur, the entire kingdom will be in turmoil. People are already furious with the Pazhuvur brothers and with Madhuranthakan. Some people are also angry with the Emperor, for trying to imprison you. If the people come to know that you are well and alive, the tide of their emotions will turn and the outcome of it would be catastrophic for the Kingdom. They might demand that the Emperor abdicate the throne and crown you as the King immediately. They will lay siege to the palace and to the capital and make demands that can’t be fulfilled. I called you home from Ilangai to avert the many dangers that we are facing but now I wish you could go back there, for the same reason.”

“I am not going anywhere, without meeting our father. If revealing myself to the public will cause problems, then I will go to Thanjavur in disguise and meet him. I need to meet him somehow, and tell him all about Kaveri Amman.”

“I can tell all this to our father... you don’t need to travel there just for this reason.”

“I have seen her in flesh and if I tell him about it, he will believe me. I am sure. And when I meet him, I can seek his permission to bring her here.”

“Arul Varma, I will not dissuade you, if you feel that you need to meet him but stay at the Viharam for another week. I will go to Thanjavur and tell him that you are alive and then send word to you. I came here to meet you for one more purpose. I want you to grant me a boon. You have courted great danger to your life in these few days, and there is aught that I can do to help you. I want you to achieve greatness and before any other danger befalls you. If you would but grant me this I would never ask anything else from you, ever.

“Why so formal, akka? When have I refused any request from you?”

“No, you have never refused me, that’s why, I am asking this of you. Aditya Karikalan didn’t marry and nor does it seem like, he would. Our father’s line can continue only through you. That is my request to you.”

“If I agree to your request, will you allow me to wed a woman, of my choice?”

“Why do you ask thus? For twenty years, our likes and dislikes have been the same. Why would it change now?”

“Akka! The woman that I marry must stand by me, and help me fulfil the dreams that I have.”

“Thambi! Truly! You wish to fulfil your dreams with the help of a woman?”

At the same moment they heard Vanathi shout, “Ayyo! Ayyo! Akka! Help me.”



Chapter 46 – And Vanathi laughed!

While the Prince and Kundavai were speaking in the Nandi Mandapam, Senthan Amuthan and Poonguzhali too were have a serious conversation, while waiting in the boat.

“Amudha! If I ask you something, will you tell the truth?”

“It is difficult for me to speak anything other than the truth Poonguzhali. That’s why I haven’t seen or spoken to anyone for the past four days!”

“There are some, who can’t speak the truth, ever. Your friend Vandiya Devan is like that.”

“Still, he is a good man. He never lies to cause harm to anyone.”

“He told me something about you. I wish to know whether that is true or not.”

“There is no reason for Vandiya Devan to lie about me. What did he tell you?”

“He told me that you praised me a lot.”

“That’s true.”

“He told me that you love me very much and that you wished to wed me.”

“Did he truly say that to you?”

“Yes, Amudha. He did.”

“I will have to thank him the next time I meet him.”

“Why?”

“I don’t think I would have ever revealed, what’s in my heart. Instead, he told you of my desires and laid my heart bare to you. I am thankful to him for that.”

“Then, whatever, he told me is true?”

“Yes Poonguzhali. It is true.”

“Why do you love me Amudha?”

“Can one reason with the heart? How can anyone tell why love happens?”

“Try. I am sure if you think carefully, you will know the reason.”

“One can’t really know how affection, love and care are born in our heart.”

“Don’t people look at each other’s beauty and fall in love?”

“Yes, they do. We do find other people beautiful and fall in love, some fall in lust but that’s not true love and nor does it last. You spoke about Vandiya Devan now, do you know he became friends with me, the minute we met, and I dared Thanjavur’s underground prison just so that he can escape Pazhuvur soldiers. Do you think, he fell in love with my beauty and became my friend?”

“But your friend waxed eloquent about my beauty and praised it to the sky?”

“Yes he admired your beauty but didn’t fall in love with you. He described Pazhuvur Queen’s beauty, a hundred times over, but didn’t fall in love with her.”

“I know the reason for that.”

“What is that?”

“That’s because, he has lost his heart to Princess Kundavai.”

“Don’t you agree then there is no connection between love and beauty?”

“Do you then mean to say, that I am beautiful than Princess Kundavai?”

“Have no doubts about that Poonguzhali. You are indeed more beautiful than Kundavai or Vanathi. Even Nandini, who everyone claims to be a seductress, can’t possibly be more beautiful than you. It is this divine beauty of yours, that is swaying me away from my Lord. Fear clouds my mind all the time, when I think about you. Surely a beauty like you, wouldn’t want a man like me.”

Poonguzhali looked thoughtful for a while, and then said, “Amudha! If I tell you that I do not love you, what would you do?”

“I will wait for a while with patience and hope that you change your mind.”

“How will it change?”

“Mind is a strange being. It changes all the time. Many people remain unaware of what they really want for a long time. That’s

because things that they choose to believe, cloud their mind and reason. It is an illusion. When this illusion vanishes, the truth of what they want is laid bare.”

“Alright. You will wait patiently for me to change my mind. But if my decision is final, what will you do?”

“Then, I will try to change my mind and my desires.”

“Would that be possible?”

“Yes, if I try it would be possible. I will try to focus my attention on Lord Shiva and try to forget my heart’s desire. Our elders have done the same with great results, I will emulate their example, and try to forget you.”

“Amudha! I don’t think your love for me is true. by any measure.”

“Why do you think so? What do you think makes ‘true love’?”

“If you truly love me, you would be angry enough to kill me just for rejecting you. And if you knew that my love and affections are forfeit to somebody else, you would be angry enough to kill that person too.”

“Poonguzhali! My love for you is true, pure and honourable, while the love that you just described is bestial and cruel.”

“I know not what is honourable or bestial. I know only of human nature. I believe that love should only give happiness and pleasure, not heart wrenching sadness or sorrow. If we truly love someone but they do not reciprocate it, then it is but natural to hate them, isn’t it? Shouldn’t one avenge them, for not accepting our love?”

“No. It is not natural. It isn’t human nature. It is the nature of a demon to avenge one’s self. If we truly love someone, we will cherish them and their happiness will become ours. If they reject our love, I agree

it will be difficult to accept at first. But the hurt and sadness that we feel will fade in time, when we see our loved one happy.”

“What you described is not human nature and nor is it possible for men to act so nobly. Along with Vandiya Devan, that physician’s son came to Kodi Karai. He fell in love with me, the minute he saw me and desired to wed me. When I rejected him, he thought that I was in love with Vandiya Devan and he became so angry with his so-called friend that he tried to betray him to Pazhuvur soldiers. I am sure, he might have killed me too, if he had the opportunity.”

“If that is so, then he is not a human being. He must be a demon.”

“There, do you see that Kodumbalur Princess? It is obvious that she has lost her heart to the Prince. If the Prince rejects her, won’t she try to poison him? And if she learns that the Prince desires some other woman, wouldn’t she try to kill her too?”

“Never! Gentle Vanathi would never do anything like that.”

“Maybe you are right. But if I was in her place, I would do that.”

“I will pray to God so that he forgives you.”

“Who is this God who thinks he is great enough to forgive me? It is ‘I’ who should forgive the God instead.”

“God will forgive even these blasphemous words.”

“Amudha! You are truly a good man. You are more like our older aunt, in character.”

“What is this you are saying suddenly?”

“You know our aunt, the one that our family claims to have died long back?”

“Who? My mother’s twin sister?”

“Yes. She is not dead.”

“I have heard rumours about her.”

“She is roaming through the forests of Ilangai like a mad woman.”

“A family curse! What can anybody do?”

“Her plight today is not only because of the family curse. A Chola Prince’s deceit and rejection is the sole reason for her madness.”

“What?”

“When our aunt was young, she lived in an island near Ilangai. A young Prince, who got marooned there, told her that he loved her. She believed his words but he rejected her once he became the King.”

“How do you know all this Poonguzhali?”

“I spoke to my aunt with the help of sign language. That’s how, I learned all this. There is more Amudha. Some time ago, I happened to meet many Pandya soldiers who wanted to seek vengeance against the Cholas. I was itching to join them. I wanted to avenge my aunt and bring down the King who rejected her love and drove her to madness. But my aunt didn’t seek vengeance. There is no room for hatred or revenge in her heart. She had not only forgiven the man who had wronged her but had also saved his son’s life in Ilangai. The love that you describe is what I have seen in her. But I am not my aunt and nor will I ever be like her.”

“Then what will you do?”

“If any Prince rejects me and my love, then I will turn against him and murder him. I will also murder the woman for whom he has rejected

me. And then I will kill myself and die happily.”

“My God! Why are you talking thus?”

“Amudha! You know not the torment that I have been undergoing for the past two years, that’s why, you are giving me all this Godly advice.”

“Why can’t you be more like our aunt?”

“I am not my aunt and this is my affair and I choose to conduct it in whatever way, I think is appropriate.”

“What are you saying, Poonguzhali?”

“Amudha! If you take some of my blood and some of Vanathi’s blood, would there be any difference?”

“There won’t be any difference.”

“Is she superior than me in beauty, brains or talent?”

“No, she isn’t. You were born in the sea, while she is palace born and bred. You will kill a wild animal and will not blink an eye. You will ply a boat in storms and save those who are lost in the sea. Vanathi will be terrified of waves, even while standing on the shores. Even a bold tom cat can scare her to bits and if she hears some unfortunate news, she would swoon away.”

“Then why does Kundavai have such a low opinion about me, while she pours out all her love on that meek girl?”

“Poonguzhali! You are being unfair to Princess Kundavai. Vanathi has been her companion and friend for many years now, while she has met you only now. Didn’t she express her heart-felt gratitude for saving the Prince’s life?”

“Ah! Who wants the gratitude of that Princess? She can keep it with her. Amudha! When the Prince returns, please ply the boat alone. I might just capsize the boat, if I take on the oars. I am that angry.”

“You won’t do that Poonguzhali! What has the Prince ever done to you?”

“Amudha! My mind is not under my control. I can only think of the wrong that his father did to our aunt. What if I lose my mind and try to avenge her by killing the Prince? It would be best if you row the boat.”

“Alright! I will take the Prince back to the Viharam. What will you do in the meanwhile?”

“I will follow that Vanathi and throw a stone on her blessed head.”

Saying thus, she took a rock that lay on the bed of the bank. At the same moment from among the grove of coconut trees, a well-built bull came out and walked towards the bank with a languorous gait. Poonguzhali threw the rock on the bull instead and it immediately turned and started racing.

“Ayyo! What have you done? Why did you throw the stone on the bull?”

“So what?”

“So, what! Poor animal. It can’t defend itself and you are throwing stones at it.”

“I know a deaf and mute woman who was born in my family. She too couldn’t defend herself and a Prince wronged her for life. What do you think she should do instead?”

“You are throwing a stone on this bull so that you can avenge our aunt. Your logic makes perfect sense indeed!”

“This bull isn’t all that defenseless. Doesn’t it have sharp horns? What did my aunt have? She couldn’t do anything but become mad and roam through the forests. If any Prince dared to wrong me like that, I will make his life miserable.”

“Of course, you will. You will throw a stone at a bull. That too, while sitting safely in a boat in the middle of the canal! The bull can’t come and attack you here.”

“Let it go and gore anyone to death, for all I care.”

“Of course. Just as you showed your anger on a poor defenseless animal, you wouldn’t care would you?”

The bull didn’t hear any of this conversation but it did exactly what Poonguzhali had predicted (or rather wished for). It couldn’t get near the boat from where the stone was thrown so instead it raced through the coconut grove. At that moment, Vanathi who was walking towards the palanquin that was waiting with their entourage encountered the bull. First when she saw the racing bull, she felt exhilarated but as it neared her with its head bowed and its gleaming horns poised to attack, she panicked. She started running toward the banks of the canal. There was no place to run but to the edge of canal bank – a small cliff overlooking the canal.

That’s when she shouted, “Ayyo! Ayyo! Akka! Akka!”

Startled to hear her cries Kundavai and Arulmozhi looked for Vanathi. They spotted her on top of the bank, looking at something with a horrified expression. It was soon apparent, as to what had terrified her so, because they could see the bull that was racing towards her. The Prince immediately ran towards the canal bank and caught her, as she fell down the cliff.

Kundavai who was at first terrified for her friend, was happy to see her brother saving the her friend.

“Akka! Here is your friend. Take her. I know not how this girl was born in the brave Velir clan of Kodumbalur.”

“Thambi! How could you do this? How can you touch an unmarried maiden, like Vanathi?”

“Now is that a crime? What should I have done, then? Watch her fall headlong into the canal? Thank God! She didn’t know that I caught her. She must have swooned before she fell into my hands. Here, take her.”

Vanathi laughed gaily and jumped out of Arul Varma’s hands.

“Sneaky girl! You were conscious all this while.”

“Ask her why she pretended to be unconscious, akka.”

“I didn’t pretend or anything. I felt shy when he caught me, so I closed my eyes that’s all.”

“Now how would I know that? Your friend has the habit of fainting away all the time.”

“I will never faint again and even if I did, it won’t be anywhere near him. I just hope he remembers the help that I rendered him today and stays grateful to me.”

“What? What? Is she really saying that she helped me today?”

Kundavai looked at Vanathi and asked, “What are you saying Vanathi? Are you saying that you are grateful to him for saving you?”

“No akka, it was ‘I’ who helped him today, so he should be grateful to me.”

“So ‘I’ have to be grateful to ‘her’ for saving ‘her’ from falling headlong into the canal. Akka, is your friend of sound mind?”

“I am of sound mind thank you. Let me explain akka. When your brother was young, he fell into the river and a woman came to his rescue. And a few days ago, when he was lost in the sea, again a woman came to his rescue. Your brother has gotten into the habit of being rescued by woman, all the time. Thanks to me, he can now claim that he happened to rescue a woman who was about to fall head-long into the canal. That’s why he should thank me.”

Saying thus, Vanathi laughed gaily and Kundavai and the Prince joined her. Hearing them laugh, on the other end of the canal, Poonguzhali and Senthana Amuthan looked in their direction.

“Amutha! Why are these people laughing like this?” said Poonguzhali and laughed.

With the banks of the canal echoing with the laughter, the bull too threw its head out and let out a grunt.

Dear Readers, I hope you enjoyed Ponni's Beloved: The Sword.
Here is an excerpt from Volume 4, which will soon be released.

An Excerpt....

**Ponni's Beloved Volume 4 - The Crown
Chapter 1 – Banks of Kedilam**

Kedilam is one of the rivers that made the Kingdom of Thirumunaipadi fertile and green. Along the banks of this river is a Shiva Temple much celebrated by Appar Perumal. Further down this river is yet another temple of Lord Shiva where Sundaramurthy Nayar had composed many of his poems in Thirunavalur. Situated betwixt these two places lay the king's road that led one from Thondai Mandalam to the Chola Kingdom. The banks of Kedilam were always busy, thanks to the many pilgrims who bathed in the river before visiting the temples.

That year in the month of Aipasi (October to November) there were many people gathered near the banks and the water flow was heavy. Drowning the sounds that these pilgrims made, yet another noise was heard on the King's road. Startled by it, many went up the trees to see what's happening. At first, they could only see the dust of the road rising up and soon, they could see an entourage of elephants, horses, royal chariots and palanquins, royal heralds, flag holders, drum beaters marched at the head of the procession.

The clear voice of the herald soon cleared the people's doubt about who was approaching.

"A warrior born and bred on the battle-field! A Prince who became a seasoned warrior at the tender age of 12 years! The lion from whose shadow, the Rashtrakutas flee! Noble Lord of Erattai Mandalam! The Crown Prince of Chola Empire! The Eldest Son of Emperor Sundara Chola! Prince Aditya Karikalar arrives!"

The thunderous voice of the herald caused a busy flurry of activity at the banks of the river. Those who were half way across the river came back to the banks to watch and cheer for the Prince. Those who were bathing, hurriedly dried and dressed themselves to watch and gawk at the royalty, who would soon arrive.

After the herald and the flag holders, there came three warhorses bearing three warriors. Even when they were at a distance, people pointed towards and started talking.

“You see the one in the middle, that is Aditya Karikalar. Don’t you see the golden crown that he is wearing? See how it glows in the sun!”

“This crown is not as glorious as Karikala Valavan’s crown. You should see that. They say that it glows with the radiance of over thousands of suns.”

“The one that you are referring is not the crown of Karikala Valavan. Though they call it the same, for tradition’s sake, it was made during the time of Parthaka Chakravarthy. That’s the crown that was given to Sundara Cholar, during his coronation. Though, we don’t know how long he would wear it.”

“People have been saying that for a very long time... but the Emperor is still lingering.”

“I hope that he does. So long as he is alive, there won’t be any confusion or chaos in the Kingdom.”

“That too is not certain. Ever since the news about Ponniiyin Selvar came, the entire Kingdom is troubled. Who knows when there will be a civil war?”

“Who is going to fight whom?”

“They are expecting a fight to erupt between the Kodumbalur clan and the Pazhuvur clan. To avoid this, they have organized for peace talks at Kadambur Sambuverayar’s palace. Aditya Karikalar is also on his way there.”

“The horses are coming near, talk softly...”

As the horses neared them by, they said, “Why is Prince Aditya Karikalar looking so grim and upset?”

“Isn’t it natural? His brother is lost in the sea and no one has any news about him. Everyone knows how much he loved his brother and his father has become an invalid.”

“That’s not the reason why the Prince is looking grim. He is upset because his plans of invasion against the Eratai Mandalam have been foiled.”

“Who foiled his plans?”

“Who else but the Pazhuvur brothers. I heard that they refused to give the Prince the supplies that are needed for an invasion.”

“You people don’t know the real truth, that’s why you are carrying on with such lies. The real reason as to why the Prince is upset is not known to all...”

“Really! So it is you who knows everything. Why don’t you tell us then?”

“I have heard that the Prince was in love with some woman from Pandya Kingdom. When the Prince was battling with the Pandya army, Periya Pazhuvetarayar swooped in and married her. Now she has become the Pazhuvur Queen and is literally ruling over the Kingdom. I have heard that the Prince has lost his mental balance, since then.”

“It’s possible... our elders say that women are the sole reason for most wars.”

“Who are these elders who say such absurd things? This is sheer madness and I haven’t heard a more malicious lie than what you just told. So what if the Prince had loved a woman? What possessed her to go and marry an old man instead? I can’t believe that people are peddling such lies...”

“If that is so, then why is the Prince still unmarried? Tell us if you know everything.”

“Be quiet! The horses are coming closer. The one on the right side of the Prince is Parthibendra Pallavan. Who is the warrior on the left? Is it Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan?”

“No! No! It is Kandan Maran, noble Sambuverayar’s son. Instead of sending a message, Sambuverayar sent his son instead, to invite the Prince to Kadambur Palace.”

“That shows that something important is going to be decided at Kadambur Palace.”

“They probably want to decide who would succeed the throne next. And until Karikalan is unmarried and single, all these noblemen will try to get him as their groom. He is the heir apparent and the crown prince, after all. And the woman who marries him first, will become the queen!”

Such were the conversation and conjectures that the people debated upon. The three horses went all the way to the banks of the river and stopped. Aditya Karikalan got down and went towards the chariot that had followed them behind.

Chapter 2 – Grandsire and Grandson

The chariot stopped and Thirukovallur Malaimaan who was seated on it, said, “Child! Karikala! I will take your leave and go to Thirukovallur. Before I leave, I wish to speak to you about a few things. Will you sit with me for a while, under that tree.”

“Alright Thatha!”

The Prince and his Grandsire walked towards the tree and sat under it.

Watching them, Parthibendran looked at Kandanmaran and said, “Thank the Gods! I was worried that the old man would come with to Kadambur Palace.”

“If he had, I would have drowned him in the floods of Kollidam River.”

Both men then laughed, mighty pleased with their humour.

In the meanwhile, Thirukovallur Malaimaan looked at his grandson and said, “Aditha! You were born on this day, 24 years ago in Thirukovallur in my palace. I remember the festivities that we had then, like it happened yesterday. Many noblemen of your clan, my clan and that of Thondai Mandalam had gathered there to celebrate the birth of the royal heir. Along with all these noblemen over 30,000 soldiers had come as an entourage. The festive gaiety that followed your birth, can’t be described in one day. Even your father’s coronation paled in comparison, to the celebration that we had, after you were born. Whatever treasure my ancestors had hoarded in over hundred years, was spent on that one single day!

Did you know, your great grandfather Paranthaka came to Thirukovallur along with the King Gandarathidhar and your father? You can’t imagine their happiness when they learned that a male

heir has been born to the royal dynasty. Your great grandfather's sons died without siring an heir and of all the sons only Aringzha Chola had a child, your father. He was the most handsome prince to be born in your family. Poor man! He was subjected to many inconveniences because of that. When he was young, the palace womenfolk enjoyed dressing him up as a woman and engaged in games about how beautiful he would be, if only he was a woman! When he grew up, scores and scores of noblemen fell over their feet trying to offer their daughters' hand in marriage to him. He was ripe for plucking indeed! He was not only handsome but also the heir to the Chola throne. I was fortunate when he accepted my daughter's hand in marriage and he became my son-in-law.

Our clan is well known for bravery and not for beauty, be it men or women. We consider battle scars to be symbols of beauty among the men and for women virtue, honour and duty are the qualities that make them truly beautiful. When it was decided that Sundara Chola would wed my daughter, the people of my kingdom rejoiced and I became the object of envy among the other noblemen who had been vying for the Emperor's hand in marriage. I didn't let it bother me. Their marriage was solemnized in Thanjavur and the celebrations that followed were in accordance to royal nuptials in any kingdom, yet they can't be compared to the celebrations that followed your birth. There arose a huge argument about what name you should bear. Some of your relatives wanted you named after the most famous king born in your clan – Karikala Valavan, while I wanted you to be named after your grandfather Rajadhithar. Finally, we named you Adithya Karikalan and satisfied the wishes of all concerned.

There! Adhitha! Do you see the temple tower of Thirunavalloor Temple? That's where Sundaramurthy Nayanaar was born. That's where, your grandfather Prince Rajadhithar had camped when he went on to fight his last war. I have seen many warriors in my life and have heard of many more in stories, legends and myths but I am yet to meet another man who can compare with Rajadhithar's might and skill. Those of us, who were fortunate enough to fight along with him, will attest to that.

Rajadhithar had camped here to invade north. He wanted to conquer Eratai Mandalam and defeat King Kannara Devan. Centuries ago, Narasimha Pallavar destroyed Vatapi and the Chalukya stronghold along with it, Rajadhithar wished to do something similar and win a glorious name for himself. To amass an army for invasion is no mean feat. It took Narasimha Pallavar, seven long years to build an army and hoard the supplies needed for the same but Rajadhithar accomplished it within four years. He built an army, trained them in the art of warfare and established barracks for them here.

Adhitha! You were not fortunate enough to see the sights that I had seen when Prince Rajadhithan had camped here. Those of us, who saw it, will never forget it. Rajadhithar stayed at Thirukovaloor with 30,000 soldiers and the Chera King Vellan Kumaran came there with 20,000 soldiers. Your grandfather Aringzhan was also with me at Thiruvkovaloor and he was helping me train 50,000 soldiers. Many noble clans including Kodumbaloor Vellar, Kadambur Sambuverayar and these pesky Pazhuvetrayers too had come and camped near the banks of this river. The Prince used to organize mock battles among us to train the soldiers. Elephants, horses and foot soldiers bearing blunt weapons would test their battle readiness in many games.

The people Thirumunaipadi were very good. They hosted a vast garrison of soldiers in their midst and didn't complain. Farmers hereabouts couldn't sow grains and harvest their fields because of the war preparation, yet they didn't complain and rendered all help that was possible to the army. The Prince felt indebted to them and that's why he commissioned his soldiers to build dams and reservoirs to help them. The dam that he built at Veeranarayanapuram is a fine example of how much he cared for the people. Kadambur Sambureyan benefited a lot from that dam. I have seen him bowing low and eloquently thanking the Prince for his great work. Look at him today... his rise to power has been swift indeed."

Adithya Karikalan then interjected and said, “Thatha! Who cares about his power today? Tell me about the Thakollam war. When did the army leave these banks? Despite preparations and training that was given to our soldiers, how did we lose this war? How did we lose Prince Rajadhithan? You fought along with them didn’t you? Only you can tell me what happened there.”

“Yes. I will tell you about it.”

“Rajadhithar had gathered vast armies here to invade the north but due to various reasons, he couldn’t start the invasion. A war erupted again in Elangai and the Prince had to send one portion of his army there. The Emperor didn’t allow the army to proceed towards north, especially when Elangai was up in arms again. He didn’t want his army generals and commanders to march up north to invade when one part of his kingdom was in trouble. He asked the Prince to wait until the war in Elangai had a successful conclusion before starting on the invasion plans. The Prince acceded to his father’s wise request and waited patiently. In the meanwhile, the Erattai Mandalam King Kannara Devan too was gathering an army to counter the massive forces that Rajadhithar had amassed. When the Ganga King Boothakan joined his forces with Kannara Devan, they started proceeding towards our Kingdom. Their armies came towards us like a sea that has broken bounds to engulf the land. Our spies came rushing to us with information about the army that was coming towards us.

But the Emperor was unfazed by the approaching danger. He felt that it was a good thing that the enemy was marching towards us. His reasoning was sound. Instead of us marching towards the enemy kingdom along with fatigued soldiers and burdened with food and water supplies, wouldn’t it be better to wait for the enemy to come to us, where we can have the upper hand. It was only after the enemy forces came near Venkatam, that the Emperor ordered our army to start marching.

But the Prince didn't wait for the Emperor's approval. He led his army to meet the invading enemy with three lakh foot soldiers, 50,000 horse soldiers, 16,000 war elephants, two thousand chariot warriors, 350 generals and 32 kings. I was fortunate to be one among the kings, who was led by this prince but I was also unfortunate to be one among the survivors.

After marching for three days, we met the enemy forces at Thakollam. In myths and legends, we have heard of great wars that have been fought between Indra and Virata. Who can forget the Great War that Rama and Ravana fought on the last day? And Mahabharata is full of such battles and wars between the Pandavas and the Kauravas. After seeing the gory battle that happened in Thakkollam, I don't have to imagine how these legendary battles might have been fought. The enemy forces had twice the size of our army. They had five lakh foot soldiers and 30,000 war elephants but we faced them undaunted because we had a huge advantage that none of their superior numbers could match. We had Prince Rajadhithar and that made all the difference. That's why the Goddess of war favoured us right from the beginning.

For ten days, the war went on. It was impossible to count the dead on both the sides. I can still see the pile of dead elephants looking like a small mountain in the battlefield. Though both the sides suffered huge losses, the enemy forces had weakened to a larger degree. They were in awe of Prince Rajadhithar's skill in battle and war tactics and knew that until he led our forces, a Chola victory was imminent. Whenever our soldiers became exhausted, he would take his elephant there and when they saw the Prince, their exhaustion vanished and they fought with great vigour. Our enemies noted all this and soon they knew that unless they brought down the Prince, they stood no chance. They came up with a treacherous plan of which we were totally unaware. It was the Ganga King who planned and executed it.

In the thick of the battle, Ganga King Boodhakan approached Prince Rajadhithan screaming for mercy and with a hoisted peace flag on

his elephant. The Prince who first thought that it was the Eratai Mandala King who was calling for the peace, allowed this swine to approach him.

Boothakan came near Rajathidhan with his eyes streaming with tears and his hands folded in salutation and his head bowed low. The Prince felt sorry for the king, so he coaxed his elephant to go near his.

I wish that the Prince had remembered wise Valluvar's words about the enemy who approaches with devious tears. But Rajadhithar had no such misgivings. He genuinely felt sorry for the king. When he neared the king, he asked him, 'What news do you bear?' and the Ganga King's answer made the Prince squirm with revulsion. He said that since the armies of Erratai Mandalam were poised to be defeated, he wished to defect from the losing side and enter an alliance with the winning side. The Prince cursed the Ganga King's decision with many harsh words.

He told Boothakan that he would never allow a cowardly worm like him to fight along with their brave forces and advised him to leave the battlefield, along with his army. That's when, he did the unthinkable. He took the bow and arrow that he had readied way before the parley and shot a poisoned arrow at the Prince. The Prince fell down and confusion and chaos reigned for a while. No one around knew what exactly happened though most of them could hear the Prince asking the Ganga King to leave. Immediately after the Prince fell, the Ganga King too turned his elephant and fled from the scene.

Our army became disorganized after the fall of Rajadhithar. Commanders and Generals started fleeing with their battalions. I too was among the many Kings who fled the battlefield that day. And the enemy forces drove us like cattle herds, as we tried to flee for our life. It was only after we came to this Kedilam River, that we regained our senses. We took a stand again and stopped the enemy forces from advancing. I went to my mountain fort and brought a fresh army

to attack the enemy. Our army was scattered and had captured many parts of these regions. It took me few years, to get rid of them in the hereabouts. They still held the city of Kanchi and it was only three years ago, that you threw them out and captured it back.”

Adithya Karikalan interjected again and said, “Thatha you have narrated this tale many times, yet I can’t help wanting to hear it again and again.”

“Child! Rajadhithar wanted to expand the Chola Kingdom, all the way from Elangai to Ganga River but he died without fulfilling that dream. People say that you are the very embodiment of bravery, just like him and that only you have the capacity to fulfil Rajadhithar’s dream but I fear that you too might fall for treason. That’s why, I narrated this sad tale of this brave Prince.”

“Thatha! My grandfather died in war because of the enemy’s treasonous plans. Why would you remind me that now of all times? I am not going to a war. I am going to meet my father’s noble friends. Why would they harm me in any way?”

“Karikala! You should never fear the enemy who stands before you with his sword unsheathed but it is the friends who extends one hand in greeting, while hiding a sword in his back that you should fear. You are going amidst friends, who are in truth your enemies. They are calling you there with many false reasons saying that they wish to stop a civil war in the Kingdom. They want to foist one of Sambuverayar’s daughter on your head but I still can’t fathom the real reason as to why you were invited there. Noble families and Kings will fall over their feet to give their daughters’ hand in marriage to you. You don’t need to marry this girl, anyway. I also heard that they wish to divide the kingdom and give one half to you and the other half to your uncle. But something doesn’t seem right here, and I fear there is some treason at work. That’s why, I am going to Thirukovallur to bring my army. I will garrison it near the banks of Kollidam. While you are at Kadambur Palace, if you scent even a hint of danger, I want you to send word to me.”

It took some while for the old man to see that the Prince was not paying any attention to his words. He was instead looking at something and pointed it to his grandfather, “Thatha! Look at that.”

[1] **Kaveri Pattinam:** Poompuhar in Nagapattinam district, was earlier known as Kaveri Pattinam. This was an ancient port city of the Cholas and most of it was destroyed by a tsunami in 300 BC. Today, National Institute of Oceanography is excavating the ruins underwater.

- [2] **Viharam:** Buddhist Monastery
- [3] **Vengai:** The Vengi (or Venginadu) is a region spread over the mandals of Godavari and Krishna districts.
- [4] **Kalingam:** Kalinga is a historical [region of India](#) defined as the eastern coastal region between the Mahanadi and the Godavari rivers. The core territory of Kalinga now encompasses a large part of Odisha and northern part of Andhra Pradesh. At its widest extent, the Kalinga region also included a part of present-day Chhattisgarh.
- [5] **Nadha:** Means my lord, master, leader, etc.
- [6] **Puranic:** The word Purana literally means "ancient, old", and it is a vast genre of Indian literature about a wide range of topics, particularly myths, legends and other traditional lore. The Puranas are known for their intricate layers of symbolism depicted within the stories.
- [7] **Mohini:** Female avatar of Maha Vishnu who slays Bhasmasura and acquires the pot of nectar from the asuras and gives it to devas thus providing them with immortality.
- [8] **Asuras:** Asuras are described in Indian texts as powerful superhuman demigods with good or bad qualities.
- [9] **Apsara Menaka:** A beautiful apsara sent by God Indra to lure Rishi Vishwamitra from his penance.
- [10] **Vishwamitra:** A powerful Brahmarishi who tried to create a heaven of his own.
- [11] **Kovalan:** Husband of Kannagi from Silapadhigaram.
- [12] **Madhavi:** A courtesan who lures Kovalan away from Kannagi.
- [13] **Dasaratha:** Father of Prince Rama and the Emperor of Ayodhya
- [14] **Rama:** Crown Prince of Ayodhya
- [15] **Kaikeyi:** Favourite queen of Dasaratha and mother of Prince Bharatha
- [16] **Egypt's queen:** Queen Cleopatra of Egypt
- [17] **Chi! Chi:** An expression of disgust used in Tamil.
- [18] **Mammalapuram:** A UNESCO heritage site today, it was a port city of Pallavas named after Pallava king Narasimhavarman I. The site is famous for its beautiful rock carvings and temples.
- [19] **Sanjeevini:** A magical herb that Lord Hanuman brings from the Himalayas to cure Lakshmana's wounds in Ramayana.
- [20] **Meru:** Also known as Sumeru, this five-peaked mountain is sacred in Hindu, Buddhist and Jain mythology.
- [21] **Palmistry:** The art of reading the lines of one's palm and predicting their future.
- [22] **Kuzhagar:** One of the many names of Shiva.
- [23] **Prasadam:** Prasada, is a material substance of vegetarian food that is a religious offering in both Hinduism and Sikhism. It is normally consumed by worshippers after worship.
- [24] **Anointed milk:** In Hinduism, offering raw milk to Shiva to seek his divine blessings is a form of worship. According to legends, the objective of pouring milk on the linga is an act of purification of one's soul.
- [25] **Battarey:** Temple priests are called Battars or Pattars in Tamil.
- [26] **Chakravarthy:** Emperor
- [27] **Athaan:** Literally it means son of 'Athai' (aunt). Since it was traditional to marry the aunt's son, the term athaan is also a term of endearment to call one's husband.
- [28] **Sundarar:** Sundara murthy Nayanar was an eighth-century Poet-Saint and was one of the most prominent Nayanmars
- [29] **Ragam:** Raga that is normally sung in the dawn is Bilahari
- [30] **Poompugar:** An ancient port town situated in Nagapattinam district known as Kaveri Poompattinam. It was also the capital of early Chola Kings. Located at the end of Kaveri river beside the sea coast, this ancient

city is mentioned in many ancient texts. According to legends Poompugar was destroyed by sea around 300 BC by sea erosion and tsunami

[31] **Guru Bhagawan:** Represented by Planet Jupiter, Brhaspati appears in ancient Hindu literature as a vedic era sage who counsels the gods.

[32] **Plaques of Anaimangalam:** One of the most important copper plates of Raja Raja Chola (985-1014 A.D) is from Anaimangalam near Nagapattinam. They are called Leiden plates because they are housed in the Leiden Museum, Holland. They record the gift of the Anaimangalam village to a Buddha vihara built by the king, Sri Mara Vijayatunga Varman, of Java in the name of his father, Sri Chudamani Varman. The plates are an interesting example of how a Saivite king helped in building a Buddha vihara. Sundara Chola, Raja Raja Chola's father, issued the Anbil plates. (Courtesy The Hindu)

[33] **Shenbagam:** Magnolia champaca also known as champak in Hindi

[34] **King Ashoka:** Indian emperor of Maurya dynasty who ruled from 268 BC to 232 BC. Ashoka waged a destructive war against the state of [Kalinga](#) (modern [Odisha](#)), which he conquered in about 260 BCE. In about 263 BCE, he converted to Buddhism after witnessing the mass deaths of the [Kalinga War](#), which he had waged out of a desire for conquest and which reportedly directly resulted in more than 100,000 deaths and 150,000 deportations. He is remembered for the Ashoka pillars and edicts, for sending Buddhist monks to [Sri Lanka](#) and [Central Asia](#), and for establishing monuments marking several significant sites in the life of [Gautama Buddha](#). (Courtesy Wikipedia)

[35] **Ashoka stupa near Kanchi:** According to historical texts Emperor Ashoka had erected a Buddhist stupa in the present-day Kanchipuram but the site has not been located so far.

[36] **Yama:** God of death in Hindu mythology.

[37] **Chitragupta:** Chitragupta is a [Hindu](#) god assigned with the task of keeping complete records of actions of human beings on the earth and punish or reward them according to their Karmas. He is god of justice therefore known as Dharmaraja. Upon their death, Chitragupta has the task of deciding [heaven](#) or the [hell](#) for the humans, depending on their actions on the earth. (Courtesy Wikipedia)

[38] **Kumbhakarna:** Younger brother of Ravana, the King of Lanka who kidnapped Lord Rama's wife Seetha. Because of a boon gone wrong, Kumbhakarna used to sleep for six months.

[39] **Dingambara Jain Saints:** The word Digambara means "sky-clad", refers to their traditional monastic practice of neither possessing nor wearing any clothes. (Courtesy Wikipedia)

[40] **Abathuthavigal:** Bodyguards of the slain Pandya King who wish to avenge his death.

[41] **Kumbakarna:** Giant brother of King Ravana in Ramayana who sleeps for six months. Those who sleep a lot are also teased to be like Kumbakarna.

[42] **Manmathan:** Hindu God of love known for his handsome mien.

[43] **Parakesari Uttama Chola:** Ascended throne after Emperor Sundara Chola's reign in 970 AD according to Tiruvalangadu plates of Rajendra Chola.

[44] **Devaram:** Devaram or Thevaram is devotional poetry sung on Lord Shiva.

[45] **Krishna's Janmashtami:** Annual Hindu festival that celebrates the birth of Krishna

[46] **Olai Suvadi:** Palm leaves manuscripts

[47] **Gyanasamandar:** A young saiva poet-saint of 7th Century and one of the most prominent nayanmars of Lord Shiva.

[48] **Queen Mangaikarasiyar:** Revered as a Nayanmar, Queen Mangaikarasi was the wife of Pandya King Koon Pandyan whose hunchback and ailment were cured by Sambandar.

[49] **Shiva Yogam:** A rare placement of houses in one's horoscope which blesses the person with spiritual wisdom

[50] **Raja Yogam:** An auspicious placement of houses in one's horoscope that bestows power, title and financial prosperity.

[51] In Mahabharata, Mayasura built a wonderous palace for the Pandaas in Indraprastha, where the Pandavas performed their Rajasuya Yagna.

[52] **Kaikeyi:** King Dasaratha's third wife and favourite queen in Ramayana who demands that Prince Rama be sent to the forest for 14 years.

[53] **Mantarai:** Queen Kaikeyi's maid who poisons her mind against Prince Rama.

[54] **Mazhapadi** Thiru Mazhapadi is about 28 kms south of Ariyalore on the banks of River Kollidam.

[55] **Kailasam:** The abode of Lord Shiva

[56] **Rudraksha:** A seed that is used as a prayer bead in Hinduism, especially in Shaivism. (Courtesy Wikipedia)

[57] **Haaram:** A long bejewelled chain

[58] **Nadaswaram:** A double reed wind instrument

[59] **Savitri:** Savitri, goddess in Hindu mythology, the daughter of the solar deity Savitr and the wife of the creator god Brahma. The Mahabharata recounts how Savitri used the power of her dedication to her husband Satyavan to prevent Yama, the god of the dead, from taking him when he was fated to die. **Courtesy:** Britannica

[60] Kunti Devi: Mother of Pandavas who conceived her sons through a mantra that would attract any God to grant her a son. In Mahabharata she gave birth to six sons. Karna born through Sun God, Yudhishtra born through Yama (God of death), Bheema born through Vayu (God of wind) and Arjuna born through Indra (King of Gods)

[61] **Iravatham:** The glorious white elephant of Lord Indra (King of Gods)

[62] **Garuda:** The vehicle mount of Maha Vishnu (Preserver of the Universe in Hindu Mythology).

[63] **Yamalagam:** Abode of death

[64] **Aipasi:** Spans from mid-october to mid-november in Tamil calendar

[65] **Vaikuntam:** Celestial abode of Hindu God, Maha Vishnu – the preserver.

[66] **Thandavam:** Cosmic dance of Shiva – the Hindu God of Destruction.

[67] A Brahma Rakshasa is actually the spirit of a Brahmin, a dead scholar of high birth, who has done evil things in his life or has misused his knowledge, who has to suffer as a Brahma Rakshasa after his or her death. (Courtesy: Wikipedia)

[68] **Raja Guru:** Spiritual head of Kings

[69] **Thopukaranam:** A practice that is performed before Ganesha wherein you hold both your ear lobes by cross your hands over your chest and then do repetitive squats. This is an ancient yogic practice that enervates and activates your brain cells. It is also used as a punishment for lethargy, laziness and to improve brain power.

[70] Samudhra Raja: King of Seas

[71] **Yakshas:** Yaksha is the name of a broad class of nature-spirits, usually benevolent, who are caretakers of the natural treasures hidden in the earth and tree roots. They appear in Hindu mythology, Jain and Buddhist mythology.

[72] **Gandharvas:** Heavenly beings in the legends of Hinduism, Buddhism and Jainism. Gandharvas were known for their musical knowledge and dramatic skills.

[73] Agastya: A revered Vedic sage who was short in stature.